Gold Man

Lori Hodgkinson



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ISBN 978-1-998206-52-0 (*paperback*)
ISBN 978-1-998206-52-0 (*e-book*)
First Edition

Published by RE:BOOKS Publishing
www.rebooks.ca

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Cover design by Chloe Faith Robinson
Interior design and typesetting by Élite Publishing

For Mom and Dad. Your love and confidence encouraged me to take risks.
And to ~~Bob—Your~~ vibrant spirit, love and support will always be my inspiration.

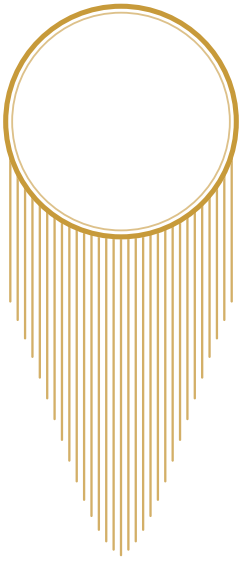
AUTHOR'S NOTE

The character Pookmis (Wild Man of the Sea) draws from the powerful masks of Kwakwaka'wakw Hereditary Chief and master carver Beau Dick (1955–2017) and from the rich mythology of supernatural beings in British Columbia Indigenous oral traditions.

With the greatest respect, I have taken poetic license in reimagining this figure for the novel. Pookmis in this story is not presented as a traditional teaching or an exact retelling of any specific folklore or dance.

All details, behaviours, and narrative roles are my own inventions.

I thank Indigenous Peoples for sharing their vibrant, inspirational customs and cultures.



PROLOGUE

SEPTEMBER, HECATE STRAIT

As the early morning sun burned a path through the fog, Benji Johnson killed the motor on his thirty-two-foot trawler, *Gull*. He'd shoved off from Hartley Bay the previous evening, ~~reaching~~ his destination: the southern end of the Hecate Strait. The open waters were unpredictable, but he was willing to take the chance. Sleep-deprived, he drew in a deep breath ~~with a long exhale~~. A purge of sorts. The season had not been generous. He needed a turn in his luck. It was time to gear up and get on with the day.

Benji, like ~~generations of his Kwakiutl uncles and cousins~~, was a fisherman, a custodian of the ocean. The men had one spoken rule: take only what you need. He understood.

Seagulls swooped past, chasing a run of salmon migrating to their spawning grounds in the Great Bear Rainforest fjords. Benji reacted and tossed his net overboard. Within minutes, the salmon hit. He peeled off his grubby raincoat and hustled for the next four hours, pulling in a heavy haul.

"Epic," he hollered, loud and echoing.

By noon, the trawler's hold was brimming. He wiped his face with his flannel sleeve and admired the salmon's golden scales. A treasure chest.

The flock of seagulls returned, thicker than usual, circling, squawking with unusual urgency. As he scarfed down his second cheese sandwich, he knew he'd maxed out his quota. He couldn't stop hearing his Aunt April's voice: "Ocean spirits don't tolerate greed. Disrespect them, and the harmful spirits will claim you as Pookmis, the Wild Man of the Sea." Her folklore fables were never lectures, though he'd heard them a thousand times.

But in Benji's forty years, neither he nor anyone he knew had encountered any kind of ghost. He laughed off the thought. *Pure nonsense.*

He stared at his catch. There was no guilt. He deserved it, just this once, and life felt damn good.

The south winds pushed in a cluster of dark clouds. It was time to head home. As Benji packed up the nets, he realized he had a problem. Because of the boat's unexpected weight, he wouldn't have enough gas to reach Hartley Bay. He made

a quick calculation. Klemtu was closer. He'd dump the fish, get paid, and gas up there—problem solved. He settled into the wheelhouse, and the motor roared to life as he was on his way.

Gull chugged along. Half an hour later, unease set in. The birds had disappeared—an unwelcome sign of change. The westerly winds moved in, bringing stormy skies and rain. The downpour bounced off *Gull's* deck.

Minutes later, reality hit fast. Long rolling waves slowed the trawler's pace to a painful crawl. The distinctive whistle of the gusty squalls warned him to find safe harbour. He tightened his red ball cap bearing his hometown name, Alert Bay, over his salt-and-pepper buzz cut and pulled on his rain gear. Every couple of minutes, he checked his fuel, cursing as the needle kept dropping.

Klemtu was no longer a possibility.

He scanned the coastline. There was Aristazabal Island, and tucked behind it was Princess Royal Island. Both were uninhabited, but once he got closer, he would radio one of his buddies with his exact location and get help after the storm passed. That was the plan.

A crack of lightning snapped across the strait. He tried to gun the engine, pointing the bow toward Princess Royal Island, but he was running on fumes.

His heart sank.

A fifteen-foot wave slammed the port side. The trawler leaned within degrees of capsizing, then righted itself. A second wave broke over the craft and ripped the nets into the ocean.

The Hecate rumbled. The violent waters rushed from all directions. He gripped the steering wheel, trying to keep himself and *Gull* afloat.

But the chaotic fight for survival was short-lived. He froze. In the distance, an eight-story wall of water barrelled toward him. Since childhood, being on the ocean had given him freedom, independence, and a sense of security. That comfort vanished as the rogue wave closed in on him.

His life had been filled with disappointments and rejection, but that morning, for once, he dared to imagine his future would be better.

Luck, again, was no longer on his side.

The eighty-foot crested wave was colossal; that, oddly, seduced Benji into a perverse sense of peace. With a deafening roar, the water's powerful force crushed the cab, ejecting him into the frigid strait.

An anchor, he drifted down to the ocean floor. His ball cap floated past him. A memory of his past. He snatched it and squeezed his eyes shut, choking on the seawater, understanding the meaning of slow death.

A strange tug pulled him not down, but up. When Benji opened his eyes, a smoky, scorched forest replaced the icy sea. He stood trembling. His torn clothes had bits of fishing net hanging from his limbs. Blood from his slashed bare feet pooled into his rubber boots.

Before him stood an imposing figure.

"Welcome, Benji," the being said with a deep voice. "Or should I say Pookmis?"

"Who are you?"

"Bukwis is my name."

Benji remembered Aunt April's tale of Bukwis, the Wild Man of the Woods and the ruler of the afterworld. His stone-like face and hollow eye sockets were mesmerizing. Bukwis loomed naked, human-like, stroking his waist-length dark hair tied with eagle feathers, sizing up Benji like a hatchet man.

"P-Pookmis?" Benji asked. "No, I'm Benji. I deserved that catch. I meant no harm to anyone."

"You knew your limits, and you didn't care." Bukwis pointed and snarled. "Welcome to the afterlife."

Benji, numb, digested another wrong decision, but this time the consequences were irreparable. "What do you want from me?"

"You will return to the mortal world as one of us—an enforcer of ill omens."

"An enforcer?"

"Yes. Find someone worthy of soul destruction. Ruination. Do you have someone in mind?"

Benji shivered. A strange urge, a desperate desire to be accepted by Bukwis, overwhelmed him. But his choice was decisive. "Yes, I do," he said, lips quivering.

"Perfect." Bukwis motioned for other spirits staring from a distance to join him. "And if you don't follow my rules, there will be dire consequences."

Immersed in a supernatural world riddled with spirits, they rejoiced as Benji declared his new identity—Pookmis—and pledged to his sinister purpose. The celebration began as they danced and howled, scheming the fate of their prey.

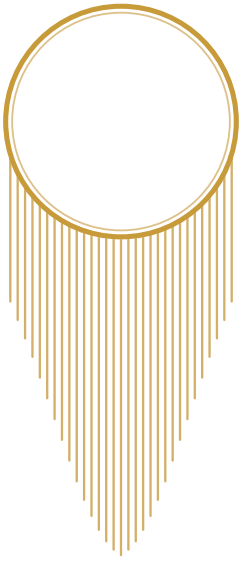
Days later, Pookmis, after arriving on Princess Royal Island, hid in shame in the ancient rainforest near the beach. To his

surprise, two Gitga'at Guardians from Hartley Bay were combing the shoreline when they discovered a large piece of aluminum buried in the sand. The painted letters GUL were visible.

Pookmis snaked through the moss-draped trees, close enough to catch their conversation.

After further investigation, one of the men turned to the other and said, "Never thought this would happen to Benji. He knew the waters better than anyone."

His friend couldn't take his eyes off the mangled wreck. "Buddy, something bad happened."



CHAPTER 1

ONE MONTH LATER, NEAR STEWART

Harry Howitzer flipped through the dog-eared analysis. The report confirmed potential high-grade gold in the first rock samples collected late last spring from their prospect in the glacier fields near Atlin. Gold ran through Harry Howitzer's veins. That was his reputation, at least. He wasn't sure he agreed. Maybe bourbon. But at sixty years old, Harry needed to prove himself, to find a new trophy for the family legacy, and their company, Sceptre Gold.

Close to fifty years ago, his grandfather, Easton, discovered Sceptre's first gold claim. The remote area was near the small

town of Stewart in British Columbia's Golden Triangle, a hub of gold mining activity. His father, Wallace, built the company, and Harry had been CEO for the past ten years. Then there was Mac, the hotshot fourth-generation geologist. His son was brilliant; Harry would humbly admit it. He picked up a picture frame on his desk. The photo was from Mac's university graduation, showing him at the podium in his black gown, smiling with pride. The only Howitzer who'd earned a full-ride scholarship.

For the Howitzers, mining was their religion.

But Harry faced challenges. As CEO, he was managing a company in transition. Sceptre Gold had been a performer for decades, but the past five years had proved tough. Reserves and revenues had fallen, and gold prices were volatile. The mine's shutdown was imminent. It wouldn't be tomorrow, but within the decade. He dreaded the day he would have to announce it was over to the hundreds of townspeople of Stewart, Sceptre's employees who had made shareholders and the Howitzers a fortune.

The Howitzers owed their employees something more than a golden handshake. He scratched on his notepad. "Stewart staff job transition plan."

Harry closed the Atlin report. It was an early-stage, confidential summary, but Sceptre Gold could be on the verge of discovering its next motherlode. That was what he needed to maintain the Howitzers' reputation and prosperity for the next generation. The second report, which would provide a deeper analysis of the data, was to be finished within a few months. A high-grade

sample showing gold at thirty-five grams per tonne would be a strong message to shareholders.

A guy can dream.

~~What~~ if the results didn't confirm the high-level findings of the document he was holding in his hand? Then he was screwed. Sceptre didn't have a backup plan.

Why Atlin? Harry never understood how and why Wallace had staked the property years ago. When questioned, his father never gave him a straight answer. Harry guessed it didn't matter. For the past three years, Mac and Wallace devoted countless hours analyzing the geology. But as promising as the property was, Atlin was six hundred miles north of Stewart. Harry would need to see through a complete transition of Sceptre operations. If Stewart had to be shut down before Atlin could be built, it could be a disaster. It would take years of financing, approvals, and diligence to build a new mine.

One step at a time.

His Friday afternoon was stacked with appointments. First, ~~he had~~ lined up a call with the geologist ~~who had~~ authored the Atlin report. He needed comfort—to understand there were no errors in the analysis and to discuss potential drill target sites. Then, at two o'clock, he had another call with a potential merger candidate, a small gold producer close to Sceptre. Any extra revenue would be helpful, but Harry was cautious. He wasn't prepared to overpay for anything or take on someone else's problems, which was usually the case with most offers.

The office door rattled from a fast-rapping knock. It flew open before Harry got out of his chair.

"April," he said, hanging his black-framed readers in his jean shirt pocket. "Nice to see you."

The visitor was five feet tall, maybe a hundred pounds, with camouflage rain gear draped over her narrow shoulders. A knapsack half her size was hung low over her back. She grabbed the straps and threw the sack on the floor. "Whoever did this is sick. Sick in the head."

"What's the matter?" Harry pushed the Atlin report under a pile of files. April was scowling, something he'd rarely seen in the four decades he'd known her.

"Harry, look inside my bag. I can't believe this."

At eighty, April could have been mistaken for twenty years younger—a super-ager. The lines on her glowing face reflected experience, not age. Her brown eyes were oval and soft, and her dark hair was streaked with silver strands.

She was an Elder who lived in Stewart. When Harry had started working at the mine in his twenties, they would run into each other at the local diner. The stories April shared over a cup of coffee about the area's history intrigued Harry. A friendship began.

April was a loner and highly respected in her community. She grew up in Alert Bay with her sister Spring, never married or had children, and moved to Stewart as a young woman for work in reforestation. The two friends hiked through the woods around Stewart. April's Indigenous perspectives about nature made Harry a better geologist. But she was also tough with her opinions and advice. Most times, Harry agreed. And

as the years went by, she told Harry he was family to her. The feeling was mutual.

He placed April's bag on the long pine map table next to his desk. A foul stench wafted up. "Whoa, what's in here?"

"Look inside the garbage bag, Harry."

Harry untied and opened the plastic. Inside were two dead salmon. They were a strange colour, coal black. "What the hell is this?" He poked at the whitish slime on their mushy flesh.

"No, Harry, the question is, who did this? I found them in the stream at Hemlock."

"Hemlock? You're kidding?"

"Not kidding."

Hemlock was a bust for Harry from its start. About five years ago, Sceptre ~~had~~ claimed a section of land about three miles from the mine. The purchase and the name were Harry's ideas. He was in search of new reserves. Sampling attempts were made, but not a speck of gold was found after two years.

Mac and Wallace had disagreed with Harry's idea up front. Wallace had called the patch moose pasture. Their analysis was correct. Three generations of Irish geologists in the family, all with sizeable egos, caused lively discussions and humbling moments.

"What were you doing up there?" Harry asked.

"It's October. Last of the chanterelle season." She studied the contents of the bag. "Harry, that stream is full of dead salmon. Hundreds of fish."

April's words made Harry's heart skip a beat. "Hundreds?"

"Hundreds of them. I'm not exaggerating."

April was a clever, no-nonsense woman. The type of woman he wished he'd married instead of his ex-wife, Martha Prigger. Why had Martha even come to his mind? Because every major problem ~~he had~~ encountered in his adult life was usually from or about Martha. He tried to recall whether there had been any issues with the stream in previous spawning seasons. Nothing came to mind. And Harry insisted Hemlock return to an intact forest after his prospecting shut down. "Sceptre didn't do this."

"Sceptre wasn't responsible. It's sabotage. Smell it. That's chlorine." Her delicately featured face was pensive. "Whoever did this should be hanged by their," she said, raising her voice, "their, you-know-whats."

After a second sniff, it was evident to Harry that the scent was chlorine. A dead salmon didn't smell pungent unless it had been poisoned. But anything dead found on company property, not due to natural causes, was a problem for a miner because it suggested a leak or some kind of chemical discharge.

Company negligence.

"I need to see the stream." Harry had to find facts. "Have you told anyone else?"

"Of course not." April tucked her toque over her ears and took a moment ~~and gave~~ Harry her usual once-over. Her eyes narrowed. "That ginger hair of yours is starting to get greyer. You're wiser, I hope." She stepped closer and looked up at Harry. "Good. Those green eyes are still sharp."

There were never any illusions with April. "I'll take that as a compliment."

"It's not a compliment, Harry. I'm suggesting you better be on your game. No time to dawdle," she ordered. "Get your coat on and let's go."

Harry tied up the bag and dropped it on the floor. "I'll get rid of this later."

He handed April back her knapsack and pulled on his Cowichan sweater. A multitude of worst-case scenarios ran through his head about how the salmon could have died.

April shrugged on her pack and waited at the door. "Who did the Howitzers piss off? Excuse my colourful language. This act was intentional." She shook her head. "Harry, can you imagine the mine being shut down? Our people's lives would be devastated. What would we do?"

Those were tough words to hear. If April only knew what the future held for the town and the mine.

"April, everything'll be okay." Harry searched his briefcase for the truck keys. "Mining is a tough business. But our security is solid. How could someone poison those fish?" He found his keys next to his phone, right where he always put them.

"Harry, people talk about rich people like you. The things I've heard. You'd be embarrassed."

"April, come on." Harry had heard it all, every plain lie about the Howitzers. "We're good guys. What you see is what you get."

"No, Harry. ~~There is~~ someone darn angry about something."

April was wrong. Nothing unusual had happened in the last couple of months, or years for that matter, to provoke anyone. And no one knew about the plan to shut down the mine except Wallace and Mac. There were always issues with

shareholders complaining about a lacklustre stock price or the odd disgruntled employee. But poisoned fish? This wasn't the work of a stockholder *or* a former employee.

"Let's see what we've got before we jump to conclusions. Maybe it was from natural causes."

"You remember who ~~you are~~ talking to?"

Of course he did. "Let's go, before anyone else finds those fish."

"Harry, you don't understand." April pointed to a photo of him receiving the Order of British Columbia a year ago. "Life has been pretty good for your sixty years. Too good, in fact, Harry."

It was April who didn't understand the world he lived in. His entire life had been Sceptre, and it came with myriad personal sacrifices. "I understand."

"No, you don't."

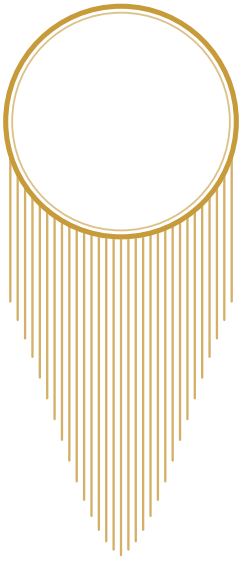
"April, where are you going with this conversation?"

"Money. Everyone wants money. And you have lots of it." She pulled at his arm. "Let's go."

His friend's comments were sharp, but Harry wasn't offended. As he watched April's short legs hustle down the head office hallway~~,~~ dodging Sceptre staff, he hollered to his PA out of his office door. "Sky, I'm heading to Hemlock with April. Can you please cancel my afternoon meetings?" From her office ~~across from~~ Harry's, she peered around her workstation and gave a thumbs-up.

Back in the corner of his office was an oversized bookcase. He pushed the wood cabinet door. It popped open, exposing

a gun safe. The dial turned right, then left, then right, and clicked open. The black metal door rattled as he took his .44 Magnum pistol from the top shelf. He buckled his leather holster snugly around his waist and adjusted his thick sweater coat to conceal the weapon.



CHAPTER 2

April bushwhacked through the mossy branches and waist-high ferns with her small-handled axe. Harry was right behind her, feeling the familiar crisp fall air. It was a fast-paced trek through Hemlock's old-growth forest until he heard the familiar babbling stream.

"Look at this disaster." She led Harry around an ancient Sitka spruce to the narrow, glacier-clear water. Piles of dead salmon littered the shallow edges of the gravel stream.

"Unbelievable." Harry's heart pounded as he snapped dozens of photos and filmed videos of the black and burnt-red carcasses. Each time he lowered the cellphone, the sight of the rotting

flesh reminded him how vulnerable Sceptre was. The stench of death and the swarms of black flies made for a grisly scene. "There are hundreds of them."

"And that smell. Chlorine," April said, kneeling and examining the decaying slabs downstream. "Harry, look at this." She pointed to the pools of dead fish corralled by a suspiciously piled logjam. "Trying to make a point. Harry, what have the Howitzers done? Tell me."

Harry swallowed, not yet ready to admit April might be right, or that he didn't have a clue what the hell could have prompted sabotage of this nature.

"As I said before, there's nothing. Please, April, ~~no~~ more questions."

"You're wrong." April shook her head. "History, Harry. The Howitzers have that too."

"Maybe it's some eco kook group," he said.

"Harry, come on. Killing these beautiful fish? No way." She walked into the shallow water and picked up a white plastic lid. "Accu-Tab. You use ~~those~~ chemicals on site, don't you?"

"Yes, for potable water." Harry acknowledged the tabs were chlorine-based and highly concentrated, but they were a mainstream industrial product. "~~But t~~hat doesn't implicate Sceptre." ~~But it~~ didn't matter at this point who owned the tabs; the environmental impact was serious. "This wasn't done by a sophisticated group."

Harry's mind went into overdrive. He had to be the first to announce the incident. Sceptre could face massive fines, daily penalties, and even criminal liability if he couldn't prove the

sabotage, the crime. It was critical that he fly back to Vancouver ASAP to deal with the fallout.

Like aliens in a bad horror movie, hundreds of cloudy salmon eyes seemed to watch him as he calculated the damage and the risk to Sceptre.

April continued to scan the old-growth forest. "Let's go upstream."

As the two hiked around the large rocks and stumps along the water's edge, April said, "Harry, those salmon are the lifeblood of our ocean and forests. All our animals and birds need these fish. I'm spitting angry."

"I know, I know." Harry was struggling to come up with an answer that would assuage her anger when he heard twigs snap. April stopped and motioned to him to do the same. Across the water, about forty feet to their left, was a light brown grizzly bear. Its nose was pointy and long, and its perky ears were round and fluffy—a thin grizzly for the size of its big bones.

Harry's hand moved to his holster.

"Don't you dare," April said. "We're friends. It's her first season without Mom. Three-year-old. Not old enough to breed." They stood still, watching her watch them. "She is hiding from those horny old boars," April whispered, then she grinned. "Can't blame her." She clapped her hands. "Fern, away you go."

The spooked bear galloped into the dense forest.

Only April would name a grizzly bear. She never liked Harry carrying his pistol. But he had to protect himself and April, not only from grizzlies but from all predators. For all he knew, the

idiots who killed the salmon were roaming the woods, looking to do more damage.

Harry climbed over fallen trees and pushed away dense underbrush. He recollected his last-quarter meeting with Kirk, the head of security. ~~They had~~ discussed the completion of the new camera installations and the repair of the fencing. Kirk ~~had~~ requested drones, but Harry ~~had~~ decided it wasn't necessary.

Wrong decision.

They followed the stream and witnessed more poisoned fish stacked up on rocks. "I need to ask you something, Harry."

"Yes, what's on your mind?"

April held on to a branch. She squinted, trying to find her words. "To heck with it. Are you shutting down Sceptre? Is your grande dame past her prime?"

"What?" *How could she know*? "April, we are running at full capacity. That's what I'm focused on."

"The locals are worried. Rumours are that production is down." The look she gave Harry was one of trust. "You would tell me, right?"

"April." He was trying to find the words without revealing anything. "Things have a way of working out. Let's go."

They both stopped. Their eyes locked. April gave him a wary look.

"I understand, Harry."

Of course she did. "This way."

Through a cluster of leafless birch trees, they stumbled upon what Harry was searching for. Four deep tire tracks in the mud and piles of stones tossed to the side for access.

"Morons," he said.

"Moron, Harry. One set of footprints."

Harry took close-ups of more dead fish, the access point, and the tire tracks. They followed the tracks on the makeshift road that ~~he had~~ built for the unsuccessful exploration program.

"How could security not notice someone, or at least a vehicle?" Something was niggling him. "And the tire tracks. They're too wide."

April stopped and examined the ground. "Agree. Very odd."

The first course of action was to call the RCMP to initiate the criminal investigation, and he had to inform the Ministry of Environment and Parks to obtain their support. If the authorities weren't on board, the government could shut down the mine immediately.

"My first call is Officer Hunt."

"No, Harry, Hunt is a total dimwit. Call someone else. He's a lazy man and frankly not bright."

Hunt, the only officer in the region, was known to be counting down the days until retirement. "Who else can I call? That's the chain of command up here. This is a crime scene."

"I'm sorry to disagree with you, but the man is a bad apple. When he speaks, he never looks anyone in the eye. Get someone else to help you figure this out." April checked the sky. "You're flying home this afternoon, aren't you? Back to your father, ~~and~~ tell him this shocking news? He's going to explode, Harry."

"April, come on. Stop." Her attitude was fierce, and she had never said a good word about Wallace. In a few small moments—like when she was pressing him about the slow

production at the mine—he felt impatient with her. He didn't like being short with her, but the circumstances he was dealing with were severe. "I'm in a hell of a mess here."

April rolled her eyes, as if Harry was focusing on his and others' livelihoods but missing the sacredness of the salmon and the sacrilege of the crime.

But only by protecting Sceptre could he protect the salmon stream. She was missing the point. They trudged the last half mile down a muddy road to their vehicles without any words. Harry wasn't sure whether April was upset only with the situation or with him, too.

"Call me when you land. I hate small planes in this weather."

"I always do," he said, softening his tone and taking her hand. "Thank you. If anybody was going to find this disaster, I'm glad it was you."

The Elder checked the darkening skies and let out an exasperated breath. "You'd better get going. Those fast-moving clouds are bringing in a storm. Take care. And eat something, will you? You're thin."

"It's all muscle." He smiled. "Promise." Harry leaned down to give her a hug, still feeling her anger thrumming through her rain jacket. He slammed shut her rusty white Dodge truck door. ~~That~~ truck was a piece of junk. ~~He had~~ offered to buy her a new one for years, but she'd refused.

April rolled down her window. "I'm doing my own research and ~~not waiting~~ for Hunt. And what about Chief Joe?"

"Can you talk to him, please? Tell him I'll call in the morning." The local Nation's support was critical with an incident of this nature.

"I'll make sure he's on side. Safe travels, Harry."

Harry reassured April that he would fly safely and watched the old beater bump down the road. He turned his attention to organizing his photos and videos into an album for evidence. The pine trees stirred. He touched his holster. Was that the idiot who ~~had~~ poisoned the stream—waiting to take Harry Howitzer out? He unsnapped his pistol case. The bushes parted, and a baseball-sized paw emerged. With a snort and huff, April's grizzly bear's dark eyes locked with Harry's.

"Fern, get lost," Harry snapped. "I'm not in the mood."



As Harry sped up the driveway to the head office, the storm clouds crept in. The mountain peaks weren't visible, and the gauge inside his truck cab showed the temperature was dropping. A system was on the way. He screeched to a stop. Through the rear-view mirror, he saw Sky racing toward the vehicle. Her baby blue eyes were saucer-sized. He stepped out of the truck.

"Sky, where's Kurt? What's the matter?"

"~~Kurt is~~ on his way back from Rupert. Still driving. He's home tonight."

That was not good news. Kurt was out of cell range.

Sky's face was pale. She raked her fingers through her pixie-cut blonde hair. "Crikey, Harry, where were you?"

Harry recognized that her nasal Australian accent sharpened when she was stressed. "I told you, Hemlock."

"Is that where the dead salmon are?"

"What are you talking about, Sky?" *A leak? How?* "Yes, we have a problem. There's dead salmon~~, poisoned by some jerk, at Hemlock. How the hell did that happen?~~ And someone got into our facility without us knowing?" Harry's voice grew loud. "This doesn't happen to a company like Sceptre."

"That's ~~terrible news~~." Her hands moved as fast as her voice, explaining her past hour. "The stock dropped over a dollar in the last half hour before the close. The phone lines are on fire, and my email is exploding with angry shareholder inquiries about what they read on the message boards."

"What?" Harry hated those message boards. The posters were a bunch of losers sitting in front of their home computer screens, never getting out of their pyjamas and Crocs, making up crap so that they could day trade their Sceptre stock.

"Yes, the message boards are going crazy with terrible allegations about the Howitzers and Sceptre."

It didn't take long to remind Harry there was no such thing as a secret in the mining business.

"Not what I needed to hear. I'm flying out within the hour."

Harry bolted into his office, which reeked like a five-day-old tuna sandwich. The plastic garbage bag was still on the floor. He pitched it into the hallway, and then returned to his

desk. Hundreds of emails filled his inbox. His screen showed Sceptre's stock plummeting from over $5.00 to $4.20 in less than an hour. The volume of shares traded was in the millions. Fortunately, the market was now closed for the day.

Sky stood at his office door. Her right foot was tapping on the wooden floor. "Harry."

Harry looked up at her. "Mac landed in Vancouver?"

"In an hour. The plane was late leaving Whitehorse. Apparently, his drive from Atlin was brutal. Winter has arrived." She peeked at his screen. "~~How can I help~~?"

Security was Harry's next issue. "Get a hold of Kurt as soon as ~~he is~~ in cell range. Update him on what I found at Hemlock, and you can tell him I said his ass is on the line. I want a report regarding access for the past forty-eight hours by the time I land, and I want to move to Level Three." A first for Sceptre. For all Harry knew, someone had plans to blow up the mine.

"Don't you want to talk to Kurt yourself?"

"He'll get the message. First call when I land. Please, Sky." His desk phone rang. The call display showed it was Wallace. "Hey, Dad."

"Where is this environmental accident?" Wallace sounded jittery and aged. But his father was still connected to the street, and this was an example.

"Hemlock."

"Why didn't you call me?"

"I wanted to see it for myself." ~~Typical Wallace response.~~ "What's your source?"

"Source? Rumours and stories are spreading like wildfire on the internet."

Harry scanned his stock trade screen again, listening to Wallace rant. He saw that an aggressive buyer, labelled Anonymous, had scooped up all the cheap stock. *Odd.*

"Bloggers are writing that Sceptre poisoned a salmon-spawning stream—a carcinogenic leak. Those greenies will have a field day. And the governments. The consequences go on and on. As Mac ~~says, this shocking news has gone viral.~~"

"It was an intentional act. I saw the evidence." Wallace still thought he was the CEO. Ornery as ever, and he wasn't going to change at eighty-five years old. Though socially, he could be a charmer. Harry picked up his pen and tapped it on his desk. "April found the site."

"She's always got her nose in our business. Harry, may I remind you of White Fox Silver?"

"Dad. Knock it off." He remembered what had happened to White Fox Silver. An environmental disaster in Alaska three years ago ~~had~~ decimated the company. They couldn't prove they ~~hadn't been~~ responsible for contaminated aquifers. The company's stock price ~~had~~ dropped from $10.00 to $0.10. Then bankruptcy. "I'm flying out within the hour. ~~See you at six o'clock at your place.~~ Make sure Mac is there too."

"Best decision you've made on this file. We need you back home. And I want to hear your plan, something that makes sense."

"Gotta go, Dad. See you tonight." Sky ran back into his office, appearing ~~as if she needed~~ to deliver more unwelcome news.

"The Toronto Stock Exchange wants to talk to you. And this woman, Cinnamon, called you twice in the past half hour. Is she a new girlfriend?"

"Not that new." Cinnamon would have to wait. Sky was always snooping around about his love life. She assumed it was much juicier than it was. "If she calls back, tell her I'll call her tomorrow morning." He sat down. "Line?" He leaned on the desk, anticipating the phone call.

"Line three. It's James, you know him."

"Can you stay, please, Sky? I need to show you where the location is." James. Mr. Senior TSX Jerk. "Hello, James, how can I help?" Harry updated the compliance officer and denied any wrongdoing by Sceptre. "No, the stock should not be halted Monday morning." The last thing Harry needed. It would draw more unnecessary attention to the incident. He had the weekend to figure this out. "I'll be back to you before the opening on Monday with a statement to release, and I will answer all your questions. Bye for now."

"That guy is such a wanker," Sky said.

"Lots of wankers in this world, Sky." He found Hunt's number and dialed it. Voice-mail. "Hunt, Harry Howitzer. I need to speak to you. I'll call you within the hour. Make yourself available, please. I have a major incident on the Hemlock site. I need your help. Talk soon."

Harry hopped out of his chair. On an oversized map of the mine on the back wall, Harry circled the area of the incident

with a red felt-tip pen. "Here's the location. Get one of Kurt's guys to escort Hunt when he comes."

"Got it."

Harry moved back to his desk and, still standing, typed with his two forefingers. "I've got to file my flight plan."

"What else can I do?"

"These photos on my phone. I need to back them up on my cloud." Harry passed Sky the phone, and she swiped through photos and videos.

"This is ugly, Harry. Look at all those dead salmon." Sky checked the weather through the long office window and the time. "You've got to get going. Back up the photos on your computer when you're in flight. You'll be fine."

"I can do that." He glanced outside. Snowflakes drifted through the air, and the clouds were moving in the wrong direction. If he didn't get out of Stewart before the storm hit, he could be stuck on site for days. "I have to finish up here."

Sky gave Harry a sad smile and left, grabbing the stinking garbage bag in the hallway.

According to the weather forecast, the first major winter storm was on its way. Harry decided his best route would be through Prince Rupert. It was the safest. He could land at the airport if he encountered any weather problems. He filed the flight plan. He packed his briefcase with the Atlin report, the working papers for the shutdown of the Stewart mine, his laptop, and his cell.

"I'm out of here," he called out to Sky.

Sky ran up to him. "I told CBC you weren't available for an interview. Get going. The weather."

"Ambulance chasers. People love to hear about a good tragedy, don't they?"

"That they do. I've told security to implement Level Three."

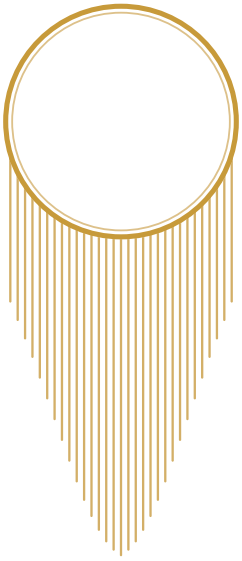
"Thank you. ~~I'm going to~~ call Hunt again after takeoff. Wait for him, please." He turned to Sky, who was following his steps out the front door to the truck. He settled into the driver's seat. "And whoever asks, your answer is either no comment or Sceptre didn't kill those salmon."

"Fly safe, Harry." She squeezed his arm and hip-checked his truck door closed.

Harry manoeuvred the black Ford F-150 down the mountain road, taking the switchbacks at maximum speed. Sceptre and the Howitzers had been set up. The company was on the brink of a major crisis, and it fell on him to fix it. His mind was filled with questions and no answers.

How much worse would the situation get? *It won't*, he tried to reassure himself.

It just can't.



CHAPTER 3

Harry loved the freedom of flying. With over 3,500 hours of experience, he had flown his Pilatus PC-6 hundreds of times in and out of the Stewart airfield. Located at the head of the Portland Canal near the Alaska Panhandle, the unmanned airport was tucked in a narrow valley surrounded by towering mountains and a coastal inlet.

Still, after decades, takeoffs and landings gave him butterflies. This 550-mile flight to Vancouver would be his last until ~~the~~ spring. ~~The~~ Stewart airport closed at the end of October.

It was about three in the afternoon. His first task was the visual inspection. It had only been three days since he'd arrived

in Stewart, but it didn't matter. He wouldn't assume anything, given what he witnessed at Hemlock. He unloaded and locked his gun in the metal pistol safe tucked in the cargo cubby.

The inspection started with the propeller—no concerns. The brake pads were free of foreign material, and the tires weren't skinned. He assessed the tail and the flaps and then stepped back and eyed the fifty-two-foot wingspan. They appeared balanced. He ran his hand across the cold, black metal body of the seven-passenger plane. There was no indication of cracks, warps, or bends. The fluid levels and the hoses were the last items he checked.

The Pilatus was ready for takeoff.

Harry hoisted himself into the snug cockpit, tossed his briefcase and duffel bag onto the co-pilot seat, and strapped himself in. The dashboard housed the high-resolution nav system and a state-of-the-art cockpit portal. Power on. Immediately, he noticed the blue patterns on the weather radar, indicating that the snowstorm was moving in faster than forecasted.

Clouds clung to the left side of the valley, and the ceiling had dropped close to a no-fly situation. He tightened his shoulder harness, positioned his headset, and fired up his plane. The surface winds registered nearly twenty miles an hour. He noted the speed and pulled out his plasticized pre-flight checklist. Fuel pump—on. Ignition—on. Oil pressure—green. Radio—on. Avionics—on. He cranked his neck and scanned the sky.

Good news. The intense winds opened a small passage through the thick ceiling. Nav lights—on. His liver-spotted fingers squeezed the yoke while taxiing to the hash marks. Harry

shut his eyes for a moment. Before each takeoff, he visualized a perfect execution.

With his right hand, Harry hammered the throttle. The plane shot down the airstrip. The gusts fought him fiercely. He accelerated the turboprop engine, kept the nose down, and fine-tuned the flaps to a twenty-degree angle. The Pilatus took flight.

That was one hell of a takeoff.

With precision, the aircraft rocketed between the sharply peaked mountains and into the parting clouds. Harry altered his wings ten degrees and gained altitude into the layers of cloud cover. With the assistance of his instruments, he took a wide turn to the south and soared to his recommended altitude.

The knot in his neck loosened.

The Pilatus was a remarkable aircraft.

After getting comfortable in his seat, he radioed the Prince Rupert tower. NAV CANADA advised him on his position and that he should beat the snowstorm before landing in Vancouver. The gauges indicated the plane was in working order. He could call Hunt.

"Hunt, it's Howitzer."

"Hello? Hello?"

What's with this guy? "Hunt, it's Howitzer."

"You sound far away. Hello?"

"I'm on my satellite phone in my plane. Hunt, are you there?"

"Why are you calling me from your plane?"

"Didn't you get my message?"

"No."

April was right. He was a bit of a dimwit. “Listen to your message. Some kook has sabotaged Sceptre’s Hemlock site. Please, head up to the mine’s offices and see Sky. She has all the information for you. You need to see this stream. It’s full of poisoned salmon.” He could feel the tension in his voice. “It’s a disaster and a storm’s on its way. You need to see it and gather the evidence. It’s a crime scene.”

“Harry, you’re not making sense. Call me when you land.”

“Hunt. This is time sensitive. Someone intentionally poisoned the stream. There are hundreds of dead fish.”

“How do you know it wasn’t a natural event?”

“Hunt, fish don’t die like that. We found oversized tire tracks leading in from the road, and the streambed had been disturbed to gain access to the water. ~~And this~~ idiot left behind evidence—an Accu-Tab plastic lid.”

“What do you mean we?”

“April and I. The chlorine from the tabs poisoned those fish. It’s bloody rude. You’ll see it for yourself. Sky is waiting for you.”

He could hear Hunt’s heavy breaths. “Hunt, you there?”

“I’m here.”

“It’s critical to get this investigation going now and show Sceptre is not responsible for the poisoning. This news is all over the internet. It’s brutal. My stock, my shareholders. It’s a mess. You seem to be the last guy to know, and Stewart is your town.”

“The situation sounds severe. Need to go by the book on this one. I’ll see what I can do.”

Harry heard a clicking noise. “Hunt, are you heading up there? I need your help.”

“I said I would help. I’ve got another call coming in. I’m busy.” Hunt’s line disconnected.

“And this isn’t important?” Harry said to an empty plane. *The attitude*. He’d deal with Hunt when he landed, but his worry intensified. Every hour the crime scene was left unattended could jeopardize Sceptre’s innocence.

Thirty minutes had already passed since takeoff, and the radar showed he was about ten minutes away from Prince Rupert. Once he passed Rupert, he would head southwest toward the Hecate Strait. He engaged the autopilot and opened his computer on the co-pilot seat. He connected his phone to transfer the photos. It was a good plan to have a backup. He reached to turn on his flight music. No, not this flight, he had too much on his mind. The cockpit remained quiet.

Minutes later, air traffic control directed him to lower his altitude to ten thousand feet. After settling into position, he called Mac. “Son, good ~~you are~~ home. ~~We are~~ in a real predicament.”

“Dad, Granddad is hot.”

“He let me have it.” Harry provided a blow-by-blow account of the afternoon to Mac. “Honestly, I did not see this one coming.” The plane bounced. It was a strange thud, an unfamiliar sound. That wasn’t turbulence. His eyes locked onto his instruments. “Got to go. See you at Wallace’s.”

“Dad?”

An alarm sounded. “See you soon.” He was about to hang up. “Love you, son.” The situation wasn’t okay. The fuel warning

light illuminated. His satellite phone rang. And rang again. But he had three tanks full of fuel.

"Fuck, there's water in my fuel."

And as Harry had anticipated, the engine sputtered and then stopped. He quickly fine-tuned the flaps to twenty degrees to maintain his speed. The plane descended through the clouds. The strong coastal winds shook the plane. His shoulders and arms locked as he wrestled with the yoke, attempting to stay airborne and alive.

Based on his location, an emergency landing in Prince Rupert was not an option. He calculated he had about five miles of gliding distance at his current speed. "Prepare for a crash landing, Howitzer."

Harry grabbed his radio and contacted Prince Rupert. "Mayday, Mayday, Mayday. Charlie, Alpha, Uniform, Four, Four, Four. Engine failure."

The tower repeated. "Mayday. Charlie, Alpha, Uniform, Four, Four, Four. Engine failure. Please confirm."

"Confirmed." Harry referred to his nav system. "Deadstick. Princess Royal Island is my best chance."

"Confirmation. Deadstick. Destination: North fjord, Princess Royal Island."

There was a fjord at the north entrance of the island. He could belly land on the elongated sandspit if the tide was out. What were the chances of that? "Wish me luck. I'm going to need it." He hung up his radio. The satellite phone buzzed again. "Mac, not now."

Harry turned his flaps to ten degrees. The plane floated down from ten thousand feet to a low altitude, drifting above the heart

of the Great Bear Rainforest. He had a visual of Princess Royal Island as he glided through the Douglas Channel, identifying his familiar Pacific coastal landmarks.

The silent engine evoked a sense of eeriness and unreality. He could be a dead man within minutes. Could there be a fishing boat in the area? He checked, but there was no life on the ocean. It was too late in the day. "Mayday. Charlie, Alpha, Uniform, Four, Four, Four. Deadstick Princess Royal Island."

"Confirmation. Charlie, Alpha, Uniform, Four, Four, Four. Search and Rescue has been informed."

"Confirmation. Over and out."

Harry tightened his seat belt, prepared for some kind of landing. "It better be a rescue, not a recovery mission." The Pilatus was lined up with the target. The tide was out, exposing the long sand spit. That beach would be his runway.

"Good news," he muttered, focused on keeping himself alive. He could make it to the fjord if he kept the plane to the right of the six-hundred-foot granite escarpment. "Here we go."

But the plane's speed slowed, and the tail's pitch dropped toward the ocean. Pilots called this event a "change in attitude," and this situation could be his death sentence. The strong tailwinds didn't help. His years of flying and numerous hours of training prompted him to immediately adjust his flaps to twenty degrees and push the nose down.

Sweat dripped down the sides of his forehead as he fought like hell to level the wings. The plane began to respond.

"That's it. A little more. Yes." That curveball was not part of his crash-landing plan. He survived, but he wouldn't a second time.

He braced himself as he glided feet above the ocean. The makeshift landing strip was close, less than a quarter mile away, but there was no guarantee he'd be able to maintain his elevation.

He strong-armed the plane to keep it horizontal as he drifted into the fjord's entrance. "Do this, Howitzer." The sandbar was in sight, and the glide held longer than expected.

Touchdown.

The plane plowed into the rocky sand, coming to an abrupt, whiplash-like stop.

Moments later, Harry heard a high-pitched cry and, out of the corner of his eye, saw a golden eagle land on the wreck. It peered through the split windshield.

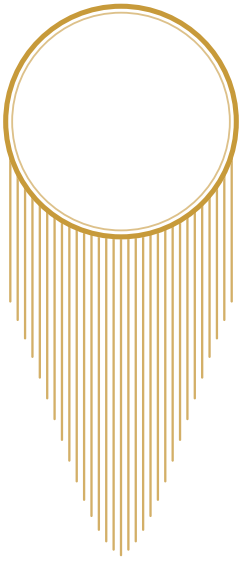
Eyeball to eyeball, the bird crouched down and sounded another sharp *wip* call. Its mild musky scent pervaded the busted-up cockpit.

Sparks of light, like falling stars, flashed in front of Harry's eyes. Dazed, he digested his reality. Would there be a chance to share his story with Mac, how he had fought like hell and survived an epic crash landing?

A strange pain shot through his chest.

No, Mac will never know.

Everything went black.



CHAPTER 4

PRINCESS ROYAL ISLAND

Harry pried open his swollen eyes and pinched his frozen cheeks, which was how he realized his ten fingers still worked. He wiggled his toes. His forefinger ran across a long, deep, bloody gash along his forehead. The good news: he was alive, but not unscathed.

As he cleared his foggy brain, he tried to gather his bearings. The storm was a whiteout. At least six inches of snow had fallen on the island, and it didn't appear to be slowing down.

His Pilatus had saved his life, though it was a crushed wreck. He sniffed for gas. The tanks were intact. "A miracle—a miracle

I'm alive," he said, shaking the shrapnel off his lap, and then noticing his laptop and cellphone were destroyed. There was no point crying over the proverbial spilt milk when right now his goal was to stay alive. He threw the devices into his bag.

The plan. He'd been unconscious for just about an hour. And it would be dark by six. Search and Rescue couldn't be on site until dawn, and only then if the weather cleared. That was the best scenario he could hope for. Sheltering in the plane wasn't an option. He'd be frozen to death by the morning or worse. He remembered a story: a helicopter pilot had experienced mechanical problems last summer in the Great Bear. After landing on a remote forestry road, he'd thought he'd be safe overnight in his chopper. The man ~~had been~~ found dead the next day. A grizzly had ripped off the doors and finished the pilot. A lesson Harry could not forget.

He stared at the old-growth trees, covered with clumps of wet snow, that lined the ocean's edge. The longhouse. Inland, there was a longhouse he'd flown over. It was at sea level, below the granite escarpment. Though the weather was socked in, he was aware of his approximate location.

Dusk was inching in, but he was certain he could find it. It was his only chance for survival.

Both of the plane's front doors were damaged, but the one behind him appeared operable. An exit. He stuffed his briefcase into his duffel bag and threw it onto the second row of seats. As he crawled his way out, he chose to ignore the sharp pains shooting down his back.

After the third shoulder push on the metal door handle, it opened. Once outside the plane, the snow stung like needles pricking his face. It was bloody cold. He gripped the cargo door handle and pried it open.

The survival kit was intact.

The first bottle of water quenched his dry throat. The second one went down just as fast. The energy bar tasted like dust. Dizziness continued as the blood dripped down his face. He wiped it with his arm. His sweater felt rough on the tender cut. He needed a better solution. A pair of navy cotton boxers in his duffel bag could do the trick. He ripped the garment apart, wiped his face, and wrapped the rest around his forehead to staunch the blood.

Harry threw a silver blanket, water, and more rations into his bag. He retrieved and loaded his gun. The harness fit tight around his waist. He turned on his flashlight, hung it around his neck, and put on his toque and gloves.

Destination: longhouse.

After a quick survey of the fjord, it appeared walking the ocean's edge was the fastest way. The tide was still out. Looping his arms around the bag's straps, he threw it on his back. After half a dozen steps, his knees wobbled. Maybe he wasn't in as good shape as he thought. The wet mud flats were scattered with an array of snowy cedar branches. He found a piece of wood with a skinny top to grip. As a walking stick, it worked.

Making his way around the fjord was a slow, hard grind of slogging through the snowy mud and sand. The complete silence

of the wilderness made him wonder what kind of animal had its eyes on him. As an intruder, he knew he wasn't welcome.

The snowflakes accumulated and his heavy-knit sheep's wool sweater was a lifesaver. It kept him dry, but the wind was cutting. After a twenty-minute hike, he should have been near the longhouse, but he'd found nothing. Then he turned a sharp corner, and the beach ended at a small entrance into the forest. This might have been the access point to the longhouse, but hiking through the twisty trail was not an inviting idea. Night was encroaching.

The trail appeared to be a grizzly alley. Cedar and mossy hemlock trees formed a low canopy. Dimples in the thick bog path indicated bear traffic. April had educated Harry on grizzly alleys decades ago. When bears were adolescents, they cleared a track through the forest to the ocean in search of food, and for their lifetime, they hunted along the same route. More evidence: at the entrance to the trail, black fur stuck to the bark of a two-foot-wide tree trunk.

"Keep your distance," he shouted, focusing his flashlight on the path. Time was moving fast, and he wasn't. "Here goes nothing."

The walking stick helped him stay upright, but his legs soon cramped as he climbed over stumps and logs. What if the path didn't lead to the longhouse? That was an easy answer.

With each step, he became colder and stiffer.

Could he die at sixty years old?

No. Although he had decades of experience with Sceptre, he had to prove himself as a notable miner. And then there was

Mac. He couldn't leave his son. The two of them had lots to accomplish—like finding the next motherlode and fixing the Hemlock disaster. Wallace was too old and miserable to run the company, and Mac was too young. They'd have to hire an outsider. No way. Sceptre belonged to the Howitzers.

Survival was the only option.

A dark shadow flashed across the trail. Harry directed the light toward where it disappeared. Too fast to be a bear. A wolf? He scanned the path. Nothing. He snapped open the leather cover of his pistol. A strange odour, like rotten fish, drifted along the path. The shadow zipped by again.

"What is that?" With that kind of speed, it had to be a wolf. Oddly, the snow appeared undisturbed in the fading light. He stopped and turned to ensure a grizzly hadn't caught his scent.

Desperation crept into his mind. "Harry Howitzer isn't going to fucking die." He started to sing his favourite Stones song, "Angie." It was a good distraction and brought back years of good memories.

His mind immediately ~~thought about~~ Mac. Harry had loved raising that kid. The Whistler weekends teaching him to snowboard when he was a tyke, and the endless, competitive father-son tennis matches—with a running tally. To watch Mac grow up to be such a smart, good human was the biggest prize of his life.

And as much of a curmudgeon as Wallace had become, one of his favourite times with his own father was when they took a trip to Chile, fly fishing in Patagonia and catching the biggest brown trout he'd ever seen.

~~Though~~ he hated to admit it, there were one or two good times with Martha, such as cruising their Chris-Craft up to Desolation Sound and anchoring for a week in the marine park ~~in the hot July sun~~. But just when he had hope they would work as a couple, she pulled a manoeuvre that reminded him she was a certified narcissist.

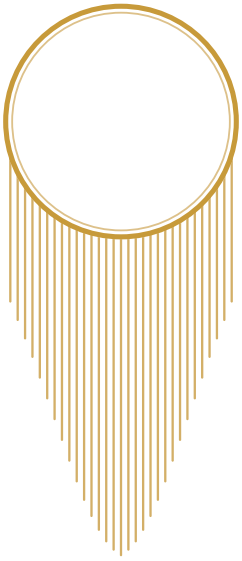
~~There~~ were the parties, known as shakers back then, he and his best friend Trudy had thrown for friends and neighbours. In their early twenties, whenever Wallace was out of town, the Howitzer house was party central. The dancing, the champagne, the bourbon, and the debauchery were electric. By early morning, after Trudy ~~had made~~ breakfast for dozens of their guests, the epic party was over. There were times when he and Trudy crossed the line from friendship into something more, even now. Could he and Trudy be a couple? Hard to say. But she was a good lady.

~~But if~~ he didn't make it to the longhouse, Harry Howitzer had lived a blessed life. Family, friends, wanting for nothing—the good life.

His out-of-tune voice continued to echo through the eerie woods.

He kept moving. The trees in the rainforest grew smaller and farther apart, and the path widened. He picked up his pace and plowed through snow-filled deer ferns and blueberry bush thickets. His light swept across a gap in the temperate rainforest. To his right, the beam caught the top of a small-peaked structure.

Harry collapsed.



CHAPTER 5

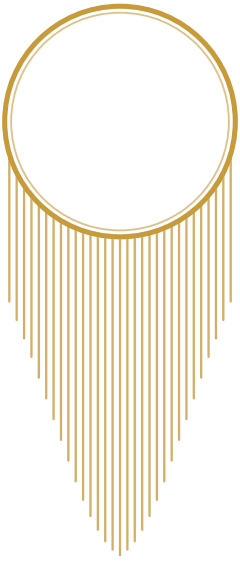
"Keep going, Harry Howitzer," Pookmis whispered to himself. He crept through the towering cedar trees, stalking the mortal stumbling toward the longhouse, Pookmis's shelter since succumbing to the afterworld.

The Howitzers had been an easy choice for Pookmis—arrogant and entitled.

"Get up, you bastard. You're just about there."

The haunt waited and watched Harry, who managed to right himself with another burst of energy. He staggered to the bottom of the stairs and crawled up to the longhouse front door.

"Finally," Pookmis growled, "we will meet, Gold Man."



CHAPTER 6

A sense of wonder—a feat—was how Harry felt finding his oasis. He pulled himself up, tossed his walking stick, and crawled up the six steep steps to the front entrance of the cedar plank structure. It took a strong push, but the wooden front door swung open.

"Hello?"

The door slammed behind him. *It must have caught the wind.*

The cedar-scented room provided an immediate sense of comfort. His light led him to one of the six short benches lining the perimeter of the open space. He plunked onto the

wooden seat and held his bloodied head in his hands, trying to settle his nerves.

What a hell of a day.

The longhouse was an impressive work of art. The flashlight shone on a massive wooden mural depicting a symbolic white bear shielded by two red-and-black orcas. Two five-foot totem poles guarded the carving. In the centre of the room was a fire pit filled with river rock and charcoal wood. He respected that he was a guest in this spiritual sanctuary.

It felt damn good to be inside and safe.

He found the firebox on the other side of the room. It was stuffed with kindling and dried bark. Perfect. He had matches. The small fire was easy to start, but the room filled with smoke. His mind was not working.

After he struggled to open the smoke hole, the room's chill evaporated, and the flames provided dim light. He pulled off his wet sweater, socks, and boots and placed them and himself on the bench close to the fire. The thaw began. He found the thermal blanket and spread it over his legs. A bourbon would be the perfect remedy to dull the pain, but that night it was bottled water.

His mind moved to Mac and Wallace. Search and Rescue would have called Mac and informed him that the plane had gone down. But Mac would have figured that out, given their untimely conversation. Harry knew his son. He would stay positive. Wallace would be strong-minded. Together, grandfather and grandson, two best friends, would support each other.

The emergency beacon should be functioning. Harry wished he'd had the presence of mind to leave a note in the plane about heading to the longhouse. Once the snow stopped, he'd mark his location with an SOS.

A shadow flew by Harry's face. A bat? His light searched the ceiling. Nothing. He was dog-tired. He added more wood and poked the fire. It should keep him warm. He stretched out on the floor under the thermal blanket, with his eyes closed, rehashing the last moments of his crash landing. *Unbelievable*.

The gun holster dug into his hip. *Leave it on*, he reminded himself. Grizzlies can bust up a door. He moved his bony body to try to find a comfortable position.

As he was dozing off, the reek of rotten fish flooded the longhouse, followed by the sounds of gasping and grunting.

"~~Hello?~~" Harry sat up, gagging from the stench.

"It's me." The voice was gritty, strong, and resonating. It seemed both close to his ear and everywhere at once.

"What?" The fire cast a shadow on an outline of a man about six feet tall.

"Hello, Harry." ~~But~~ the figure he'd taken for a man was . . . a ghost? His face was chalky, scaled like a fish with deep, scarring wounds, and the eyes, pupilless and white, swirled. Lumps of seaweed dripped from his shoulders, concealing a black, ripped undershirt. A tattered red ball cap with two words, Alert Bay, covered the top of his wild, shoulder-length, coal-black hair.

Harry trembled, trying to focus on what he was seeing. No, for sure, the thing in front of him was not human.

"How do you know my name? Who are you?"

"Pookmis." The creature's right rubber boot squeaked as he took a step across the wooden floor. "You know me, I'm the drowned fisherman."

"Drowned fisherman? No idea what ~~you are~~ talking about."

Pookmis continued to rasp with each breath. "The ocean spirits punished me."

"What are you talking about?" *The thing was repulsive and bizarre.*

"I made bad choices and paid the price. Now you will join me."

The cryptic words caused Harry to gasp. The vision hovered close to Harry, staring into his eyes. The putrid smell grew stronger, and Harry shivered as the room ~~grew~~ frigid and inhospitable. The beast's red lips quivered when he spoke the next words to Harry.

"Brother, I can't wait for what's coming next." Pookmis leaned toward Harry. "The omen."

Omen was not a good word. Harry would try to appease the thing. "Hey, relax. Tomorrow, I'm sure I'll be rescued, and you can have your longhouse back."

Pookmis waved his gnarled finger in front of his mouth. "I'm not welcome here. I brought shame on myself. I'm leaving." He pointed. "With you."

"Look, Pook, whatever your name is. I'm definitely not your brother. Get the fuck out of here. And you are not coming home with me."

"The name is Pookmis," the vision snapped, "Gold Man."

"I'm losing my mind," Harry whispered to himself.

"No, you're not, Gold Man, I'm real."

Harry touched the cut on his forehead. The bump was hot and still dripped blood. The head trauma had to be playing with his mind.

The walls in the room started to tilt. The paralyzing pain in his head caused him to retch and empty his stomach across the wooden floor. He crumbled onto the cold floor and lay still, with his eyes squeezed shut, hoping he'd be ignored.

The echoes of Pookmis's thumps kept Harry awake for what seemed like hours, his heart pounding, as he listened to the haunt rant and mumble. Then, Pookmis turned quiet. Without the commotion, the longhouse became more petrifying.

It appeared his life was ending for the second time in one day.



About twelve hours later, Harry awoke to the thumping beat of rotor blades. The helicopter was outside the longhouse. He tried to get up, but toppled onto the floor.

"Help." That faint call wouldn't have been heard by anyone. "Goddamn it. Come and get me," he tried to shout without success.

Seconds later, the wooden door flew open. “Harry Howitzer, call out.”

“I’m here,” Harry croaked.

Two athletic men arrived at his side. “Good call, dude,” the younger one said, pulling out his two-way radio. The static cleared. “Captain, we’ve got him.”

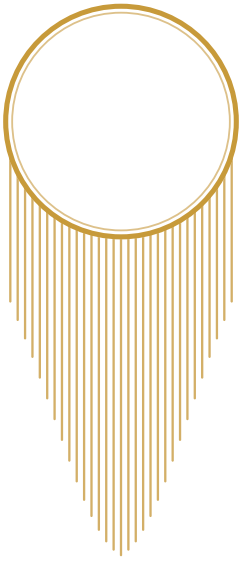
“Talk about a lucky guy,” said the older officer, trying to help Harry roll over and sit. “We got you, Mr. Howitzer.” The rescuers lifted him by the shoulders and propped him up.

Harry held tight to one of the young man’s arms. “Get me out of here. Now.”

“You bet. The chopper is waiting.” The rescuer’s boyish face dropped. “Wow, you’re in rough shape.”

“Don’t let that thing come with us.” Harry squinted as the sunlight peeked through the door, exposing a blue winter sky. The rescuers shone their survival lights around the room, then exchanged confused looks.

“No one is here except you, Mr. Howitzer,” the veteran said and rubbed Harry’s back. “You’re safe now.”



CHAPTER 7

~~A YEAR AGO,~~ GUANGZHOU

Scooters with their high-pitched whine and pint-sized electric cars barrelled down Linjiang Avenue, one of Guangzhou's main thoroughfares. Out for his daily afternoon walk, Zi Liu paused for a moment. The sun warmed his back as he leaned against the metal railing and watched the container ships slip through the cluttered lanes of the Pearl River.

The walk was therapeutic. For decades, he'd taken an hour each day to explore the city, using the time to ponder and stay lean and fit, even in his early seventies. Today, he reflected on his life journey. He'd grown up in the country as a farmer.

There was never much money. It was a humiliating existence to be penniless. Zi had made it his mission to avoid poverty. After his stint in the army, ~~he had~~ been trained as a pharmacist.

That education ~~had been~~ a turning point. Over five decades, he built a successful pharmaceutical company and grew wealthy by buying other small pharmaceutical factories. His firm had become a multimillion-dollar enterprise~~. His~~ business circles considered him a takeover guru.

Zi was proud of his reputation.

He turned the street corner. The boulevard beds were filled with early-May pink-and-purple tulips, his late wife Lin's favourite flowers. They'd worked for decades on the recipe for success and achieved it. Then, after a short illness, she was gone. He slipped his Ray-Bans into his black sports jacket and headed back toward his office, cherishing the lovely life ~~she had~~ given him. He was fortunate to have had her, even if the time was cut short.

The heavy glass door shut and locked automatically behind him.

"Hello, Jing," Zi greeted his administrator, whose eyes were glued to her computer screen. She refocused on her boss and offered him a warm smile.

"Hello, Mr. Liu. How was the walk?"

"Needed, thank you." ~~She~~ was lovely, a bright young woman and the daughter of his best friend, Chen, from his army days. Zi was more than happy to give her a chance after she'd graduated from university. And she was trustworthy.

"Wei is waiting for you in your office." She passed him a stack of reports.

"Perfect. Thank you." Down the hallway was his sister Genji's office. The lights were off, and the door was shut. ~~She~~ had been the CFO at his company but ~~had~~ died with no warning from a heart attack in her sleep a couple of months before. ~~She'd been healthy at sixty-eight years old. She was his only sibling and unmarried.~~ It was a tragedy that she passed.

His executive-sized office was appointed with black leather furnishings and a custom walnut desk. The L-shaped desk was ideally situated by the window, so he could open his heavy curtains and view the state-of-the-art production line. On the feature wall, photos of *Sunspot* hung, his superyacht, currently docked in Monaco. The other walls showcased collectible Chinese art, and the shelves held porcelain vases. Collecting art was a passion for him.

"Zi, did you get your steps in?" Wei asked, sitting on the guest chair at her father's desk.

"Wei, please call me Father."

He hated his daughter calling him by his first name, which started when she was ten. Wei's personality was strong and ~~confident~~, unlike her twin, Dashi. His son was the life of the party; his daughter, the quiet observer. ~~And~~ she was ambitious—nothing scared her. Both twins were genetically blessed and had graduated from Ivy League business schools; Wei with top honours in finance, while Dashi was more of a computer kid. They had spent five years in London with top-tier consulting

firms before returning home because of their mother's death. They were also both very single.

Wei had endured years of bullying in her local elementary school because of her unorthodox appearance. Zi understood why. She was born with noticeably lighter-coloured skin and was a head taller than her classmates. The reason was a closely guarded family secret. Her maternal grandfather was a Russian army sergeant. Lin, who was visibly distraught when asked to share the story, wouldn't reveal the full truth about the circumstances to Zi. Over time, he'd learned he had to respect her privacy.

Because of Lin's family trauma, Zi had internalized anger toward any Russian. But after the first time he had held his baby girl, the prejudice had disappeared. Now, as an adult, his daughter was striking. That Russian heritage had given her distinct Eurasian features, a six-foot height, and waist-length black hair with blond streaks. And she was a superb athlete.

"I like *Zi*. Sit down. I want to show you something. It's good." Wei's eyes were keen and playful. "I've analyzed the latest revenues. Sales are on target with our distributors and wholesalers. There is a huge opportunity for expansion. I've got new ideas to make a fortune."

"We already are making a fortune, my dear," Zi said. Wei was Zi's COO, and she'd been pushing to take his business to the next level. "We're comfortable where we are, and as the saying goes, let's not rock the boat—for now. Speaking of boats, I want to enjoy *Sunspot* for the summer. We'll look at the idea in the fall."

Wei let out a long sigh. "Zi."

Jing interrupted the meeting with a phone call. "Yes, bring them in."

"All right. We'll wait until fall. Who are these guys?" Wei adjusted her dress and crossed her ankles.

"Friends of Jaw Long's son." Zi had accepted this meeting request as a favour to an old army mate. "They have a business proposition."

"You said no to my idea. Why are you meeting them?"

"A favour, that's what friends do for each other."

"You don't need me here." Wei started to gather her papers. "I've got a pile of stuff to do."

"Wei, please, don't be stubborn. Don't you want to run the company one day?"

"You know I do." Wei made a funny face at her father.

Jing escorted ~~the~~ two muscular men in their early thirties into the office. They were dressed in the finest Gucci but appeared to have led a harsh life. Their youthful faces were scarred and pocked. Zi didn't trust anyone who wore a Louis Vuitton man bag. The four exchanged quick greetings.

"Gentlemen, please sit. How do you know Jaw Long?" Zi asked. He continued to size up the men. They were from the other side of town. He was certain. And not the good side.

"His son is our friend," the shorter and bulkier man answered.

The other man appeared distracted and continued to check his phone. Zi recalled that Jaw Long's son had gotten involved in underground criminal activity. It didn't appear he'd changed, judging by the quality of his friends.

"Gentlemen, make this quick, will you? My daughter and I have a busy day." Zi caught Wei giving the men a dirty look.

"Sir, your chemical business has a lot of potential opportunities."

"And who do you work for?" Zi asked.

"It's a consortium. Global." The two men exchanged glances. "I'll get to the point. Mr. Liu, have you considered expansion? We have a pipeline with the Russian gang's dealers. Since Guangzhou is a port, it's a perfect set-up to ship chemicals to North America's ports for fentanyl production."

~~*The* conversation *was* absolute nonsense.~~ "I am a businessman with a flawless reputation and plan to remain that way." Zi stood up. "What nerve you have coming into my office with ~~those~~ suggestions! Get out."

"Oh~~,~~ my God," Wei laughed. "Time for you to leave."

The men tried to apologize for overstepping their welcome. Zi chased them out the front door, calling them thugs and ordering Jing never to take another call from the men again.

"Idiots. Can you imagine?" Zi sat back down at his desk. "Apologies, dear."

"That fentanyl is big business, but not for us," Wei said. The office door opened again. "Hey."

"Dashi, what are you doing here?" Zi asked.

Dashi, in his late thirties, was tall and lean, with a distinctive long Roman nose—a younger-looking version of Zi. But that was where ~~it~~ ended. Dashi insisted on keeping his silky hair at shoulder length, like a lion's mane. Fashion was his son's thing. His leather moto jacket was unzipped, showing his ~~perfectly~~

~~pressed~~ white T-shirt. A pair of fashionable jeans hung loosely on his hips. He was wearing those black biker boots that Zi believed were unsuitable for anyone but motorcycle riders.

"This is the last box from Aunty Genji's." He placed the brown water-stained carton on the nearby coffee table.

"What's in it?" Zi asked and wandered over to join his son.

"It's your father's belongings. It was shipped from Vancouver to Năi Nai after he passed away." He pointed to the faded return address on the lid. "I didn't want to throw ~~this~~ out."

"Ahh. I've never seen this before." The return address label read 144 Keefer Street, Vancouver. Inside, he pulled out his father's mouldy field coat and notes written to his mother. ~~His dad, Sying, had moved to Vancouver in the late 1950s at thirty-five. He had been a geologist for a small company that staked gold claims in the forests of British Columbia.~~

"Let's see here." Wei nudged into the sofa between Dashi and her father. "Oh, these notes are sweet. He ~~says~~ he misses your mom but had to stay in Canada because his work was important and he wanted the family to be wealthy one day."

"Very nice. I could never get a clear picture of my father's life. My mother never wanted to talk about him." Zi caught the funky smell of his father's coat. "Dashi, we have to get rid of that, please."

"Will do. Hold on." Dashi pulled out one last piece of yellowed, folded paper. "What is this? A death certificate. It's Yeye's." He squinted, reading the details, and turned to his father, his face flushed. "Baba, you won't believe this—the cause of death states homicide."

"Homicide? No, Dashi, he died from an accident." But thinking about that comment, Zi realized his mother was vague when discussing his father's death.

"No, Baba, read for yourself." He passed his father the official document.

"Someone killed my father, and I'm the last to know about it?" Zi stared at the paper. "This is shocking. Absolutely shocking."

The twins fell silent, waiting for any response from their father. Dashi moved his grandfather's jacket, and the sleeve clunked against the glass tabletop. "What's in here?"

Inside one of the pockets was a patch with something sewn into it. He pulled out the thin threads and discovered a shiny yellow chunk of gold about an inch long and wide.

"~~Wow,~~ that's one chunk of gold. Hold on." Dashi squeezed a crunchy section of the sleeve, then ripped it apart to find a tattered, faded page listing an official government mineral claim under the name Sying Liu. It was attached to a second paper: a map with a red circle indicating a location.

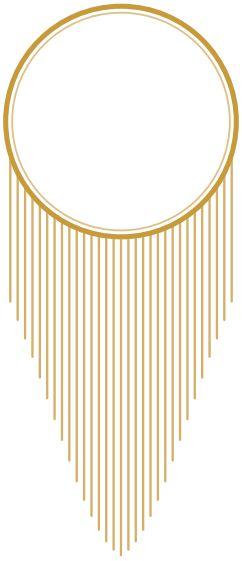
"Let me see that." Wei examined the torn paper. "North of Vancouver, toward Alaska. In the boonies. What's this all about, Zi?"

"I don't have a clue." He reread the death certificate. "The Chinese were discriminated against in Canada ~~in~~ those decades. My father was murdered, and no one cared?"

"Wei, what does it say on the back of that map?" Dashi asked, his head cocked.

"It's hard to read. Easton." She studied it further, her eyes narrowed. "Easton Howitzer?"

"~~What does that mean~~?" Dashi asked.



CHAPTER 8

PRESENT DAY, VANCOUVER

A two-night stay in the Prince Rupert Hospital had been enough for Harry. He ~~had~~ checked himself out against the attending doctor's wishes on Monday morning, and ~~had~~ asked Wallace to organize a private flight home. He didn't care how much it cost. Sceptre business was his number one priority.

The air ambulance was scheduled to land at Vancouver International Airport at ten in the morning. Harry slept until the plane encountered turbulence as they flew over the Seymour Narrows. His pounding heartbeat woke him. It took a minute to piece together the past few days.

"How are you doing, Mr. Howitzer?" the paramedic asked. "Would you like some water?"

"No, thanks. I'm fine."

"Surviving a plane crash and finding a safe place to stay until you were rescued. That's unheard of." The paramedic kept staring at Harry.

"It's been the worst three days of my life." Small talk was the last thing on his mind. He adjusted himself, pretending to be interested in the scenery out the window.

The paramedic shifted back into his seat. "Got it. Get your rest. You'll be better in no time."

The two female pilots handled the plane with ease upon their approach. The captain announced that the four-seater Beechcraft King Air 200 would land in ten minutes.

The wheels screeched, and the plane bumped along the runway. It taxied up to the private airstrip at the South Terminal. Harry spotted Wallace~~. He donned~~ his green newsboy cap and well-used Barbour field coat~~, and there was Mac~~ next to his grandfather, bundled up in his red puffer parka. Even from a distance, they looked like two lost souls. Harry ~~had~~ briefly spoke~~n~~ to them in the hospital, but ~~they had~~ refused to discuss business. He snapped open his seat belt.

The pilot parked the plane, then gave Harry a flirty smile as she pushed open the cabin door and released the airstairs.

"Nice flight," Harry said, pushing himself up and returning the friendly smile.

"My pleasure, Mr. Howitzer. Heard you're no slouch either. That was a stellar landing you made."

"A little talent and a lot of luck."

"You can be my right seat anytime." She tipped her captain's hat, showing her youthful sapphire eyes.

"Someday, I might need extra work." Harry winked. He picked up the small white paper bag the nurse had given him. The Tylenol No. 3s would dull the sharp pains he was trying to ignore.

The paramedic handed Harry a sealed box that Search and Rescue had dropped off at the hospital, labelled PROPERTY OF HARRY HOWITZER.

Out the exit door, he hobbled down the stairs. Drops of rain spattered off the runway as Harry watched Mac hurry to meet him.

"Dad."

"Hey, my man."

Mac's six-foot husky frame was the result of years ~~of~~ playing rep hockey and being a true outdoorsman. His mop of ginger hair was frizzy from the wet October weather. Tears welled in his hazel-green eyes.

"Dad, that call we had when you were crashing. I lost it when you didn't answer."

"I knew you'd take care of Sceptre and Granddad." Harry recognized the maturity and resilience in his son's face.

"I did. And you're here. That's all I care about." Mac stepped back. "Wow. Your head."

Harry's forehead was tender, with stitches under the bandages. The hospital had diagnosed a slight concussion, ~~explaining~~ why his concentration wasn't great.

"Looks worse than it is." That was a ~~misstatement~~: ~~his forehead~~ felt like a knife was stuck in his skull. "Bruises here and there, but I'm here. Better than ever. Take this box, will you?"

Harry put his arm around his son's broad shoulder and walked to the end of the tarmac to meet Wallace.

"Harry, look at you. I worried you wouldn't return to us." Wallace's voice cracked.

"Don't worry." Even accounting for the circumstances, his father looked withdrawn and pale. "Dad, are you okay?"

"Yes, I am. Kept you warm, didn't it?" Wallace tugged at the Cowichan sweater coat ~~that~~ he'd given Harry for Christmas years ago.

"Lifesaver." Harry gave his father a quick hug. Though he saw his father all the time, they rarely embraced. His dad felt frail. "Are you sure, Dad? Feeling good?"

"I am, Harry." The three generations of Howitzers climbed into Mac's spotless black Jeep.

"Dad, hold on." Mac opened his glove box and handed Harry a new cellphone and a set of keys for his house and office.

"Thank you." As usual, Mac was prepared. "Laptop?"

"On your kitchen counter." Mac put his Jeep in gear and wheeled out of the airport. Harry turned his attention to Mac and Wallace as he powered up his cellphone. "Now tell me. What the hell is going on?"

"Hold on, Harry," Wallace said, "what caused the crash? You're a hell of a pilot. It couldn't be your error."

Harry recalled his last hours in the longhouse. If Pookmis had been real—whatever that meant—and not ~~a~~ hallucination,

could the accident have been some kind of mystical takedown? *No. Nonsense.*

"Dirty gas. That's the only thing it could be. The plane was in perfect shape from stem to stern before takeoff."

"That Stewart airport is effin' random. The tanks had probably rusted out, and water seeped." Mac slapped the steering wheel.

"I agree with Mac. And Harry, at my request, Search and Rescue didn't release your name to anyone in the press when there was a report of a small plane missing." Wallace's tone was gruff. "We didn't need that media coverage, either."

"But Granddad, the rumours are out. People know." Mac eyed Wallace in the rear-view mirror.

"It doesn't matter now, I'm alive," Harry said. If he hadn't been found, that would have been a different story. From a legal perspective, because he was the CEO of a publicly listed company, Wallace shouldn't have kept the accident quiet, but he wouldn't ruffle his father's feathers.

"Harry, the board distributed a press release before the market opened this morning."

"And the release stated Sceptre was cooperating with the RCMP's case, and the company had nothing to do with the incident?" Harry asked. But Mac and Wallace's silence indicated something wasn't right. "What?"

"Yes, that was the release," Wallace said. "But Mac and I got off the phone half an hour ago. Hunt said he made a quick stop."

"Did security take him to the site?" Harry asked.

"No, he went on his own." Wallace continued. "Sky said he insisted." He shrugged. "But here's the problem. He didn't get

a chance to take photos or make notes for the case because he had to respond to a serious traffic accident as soon as he got on site. Now, with a foot of snow on the ground, he said the evidence can't be found or used." Wallace let out a long breath. "It's ridiculous. He's telling us, without evidence, that he can't open a criminal case. Now Sceptre appears to be the criminal."

"What? No investigation. Hunt saw the destruction first-hand. Did my photos sync?" Harry turned to Mac, who shook his head. "What about security? No photos of the intruder inside the property?"

"Nothing. I've asked security to go through, frame by frame, for the four days before the fish were found," Mac said.

"That's impossible—how could no one be detected?" The update was not what Harry had expected. No evidence and no case. His mixed-up mind tried to gather the facts. "April is a third-party witness. She can verify the Accu-Tab lid stuffed underneath the dead carcasses if Hunt didn't see that evidence. Let me call him."

Harry dialed the RCMP's number while pings from unseen texts and emails assailed him. He listened to it ring several times before going to voicemail. He tried again. "Hunt, it's Harry Howitzer. I'm in Vancouver. In one piece. You've put us in a hell of a position by not opening a case. Please call me." He threw his phone on the dashboard. "Hunt can't do this. This is Sceptre Gold he's dealing with, not some pick-and-shovel amateur outfit."

With his foot on the accelerator, Mac swerved through the heavy traffic on Granville Street. "The Ministry of Environment called. They've started their initial investigation."

"And?" Harry hated dealing with the government. The department was a nightmare—too much red tape and bureaucracy.

"I told them to hold off and speak to you when you got back. Those guys are dicks. The last time I dealt with them on that spotted owl issue, I wanted to choke them." Mac was at a stoplight and threw up his hands. "There wasn't a nest in that red cedar. I would never endanger those birds. It took me months to convince them."

Mac was promoted to director of exploration a year ago after the retirement of Sceptre's senior operations manager. At thirty-five, he was considered young, but he understood the company's operations better than anyone. Newer board members had begun voicing their concerns—nepotism was becoming an issue with their publicly traded company.

Wallace leaned forward toward the front seat and held on to the headrest. "And Harry, the stock price is down miserably. What do you want to do about this morning's press release? Retract it? You are the CEO."

Harry knew where Wallace was going. It was his responsibility to inform shareholders about all news. "Not until I speak to Hunt myself. ~~We have~~ had no formal notice from him."

Wallace gave him a disapproving look and flopped into his seat with his arms crossed. "Your choice. I don't approve."

"Dad. Give me a break. Sceptre is and will always be run by the book." His father's hypocrisy threw him off. About forty-

eight hours ago, Wallace had chosen to avoid full disclosure of the plane accident.

He grabbed his phone and checked his stock app. It flashed Sceptre's dismal stock price. Three fifty. Hundreds of thousands of shares traded at rock-bottom prices. "Somebody did this. Who?" His voice was firm. The cab turned quiet. "Nobody comes to mind?"

"I talked to the site managers and a couple of my buddies," Mac said. "It wasn't a local. No one wants to see those salmon dead or mess with their employer."

"Gentlemen," Wallace said with a curt tone, "someone wants to create serious havoc for us. Maybe take us out. Every offer is snapped up. Millions of shares are being accumulated."

"Could it be Atlin?" Mac asked. "If the word got out?"

"No, Mac. That's nonsense," Wallace said. "We don't even know the potential of that site."

"My biggest worry is that there will be more sabotage," Harry said. "At the mine, or to our employees, or to us. I'm at a loss right now."

"That's obvious, Harry. Think about this. In three days, you crashed your plane and your company," Wallace said with a huff and an exaggerated exhale. "That's quite an accomplishment. Get some sleep. Six o'clock. Dinner at the Tudor. We need a plan for Sceptre and our shareholders."

Harry refused to respond to his father's cutting~~, totally rude~~ comments.

Mac turned onto Harry's street and pulled into the driveway of his modernist-style house. Before Harry climbed out of the truck, he turned to Wallace. "Dad, I'll get to the bottom of this."

"Six sharp, Harry."

With no further criticism, Harry was relieved that his father's inquisition had ended.

"Dad, everyone is on edge." Mac walked with Harry to the front door. "~~And~~ Granddad. What's up with him? We're family."

"He built the company into a powerhouse. He's pissed." Harry patted his son's back. "I need some sleep, see you soon." ~~He~~ watched ~~the Jeep~~ drive toward Wallace's house, four blocks away.

The front door ~~deadbolt~~ flipped open, and he entered his alarm code. ~~As he pulled off his sweater, the~~ wool smelled like the smouldering cedar fire from the longhouse. He threw it on the bench. He wanted to toss it, but no, he couldn't. It was a gift.

It was good to be home. Each room was finished with mid-century Scandinavian furniture and accented with collectible photography pieces. The house was in perfect order. In the kitchen, he saw his new laptop on the counter. ~~He opened his email. The~~ messages dumped into his inbox. He skimmed the messages. Important shareholders threatened to unload their positions. They wanted answers. So did he. "Enough." He shut his screen.

The doctor told ~~him~~ he'd have nausea, and he was right. His stomach flip-flopped, but no one needed to know he was in such rough shape. In the living room liquor cabinet, he took out a bottle of Knob Creek and brought it back to the kitchen.

After a three-finger pour and a long sip, the liquor began to coat his scratchy throat and settle his stomach. He glanced out his kitchen window at the wet lawn in his backyard. Dried leaves covered the ground, and the bushes and trees were bare. Winter was on its way.

In more ways than one.

Whoever carried out the poisoning did enough damage to put Sceptre in the spotlight for being socially irresponsible and then immediately alerted the social media and press. That was their plan, and they had succeeded.

He topped up his glass, headed down the hall to his bedroom, and placed his phone on his bedside table. Hunt should call soon. After tossing the mud-crusted hiking boots and the hospital hand-me-downs in the garbage, he turned the shower temperature to the right. The steam and pulsating showerhead relieved his achy body.

Half an hour later, he towelled off, swiped the fog off the mirror, and saw a guy who looked like he needed a few meals and sleep. The shaver sheared off the grey-ginger beard, but left his skin feeling like sandpaper. He peeled off the wet Band-Aid and for the first time saw a close-up of the gash in his head. It was deep and about three inches long. The stitches criss-crossed the cut. It was not the work of a plastic surgeon. The nurse had given him a package of butterfly bandages in the bag with his T3s. For now, he'd let the air heal it. He combed his hair back and was about to add a little gel. No, time for a change. He'd grow out his short, slick style. He parted it in the middle and brushed it back, exposing his forgotten cowlick.

Harry closed the blackout blinds and flopped onto his cushy mattress. The thick duvet felt as good as the bourbon. His mind scrambled back to the longhouse. Until three days ago, no one could convince him that the afterlife existed.

And he still didn't believe it. The plane crash ~~had~~ caused him to be delusional and hallucinate. That was what had happened.

He reached for his phone. No ~~voice mail~~ from Hunt, but there was a text from Cinnamon sent on the weekend. He loved her suggestion—an afternoon in bed with a bottle of champagne.

No way would he admit to her, in the shape he was in, that that wasn't going to happen anytime soon.

RAIN CHECK ☺

Cinnamon had recently become a new member of the tennis club. ~~He had~~ noticed her right away and introduced himself to her at a tournament they ~~had~~ both played in late spring. They ~~had~~ hit it off immediately. Not only was she a superb player, but she was intriguing. Tall and blondish—confident. Her business savvy made her more attractive. But her age was a problem. Thirty-eight. ~~A~~ little older than Mac. He told her up front that he wasn't looking for anything serious, but she said she didn't mind. Her response suited him fine. She said she was from somewhere in the New York area. It was better for Harry that she wasn't a Vancouverite. The local gossip about who he was dating drove him crazy.

Dinner at Wallace's was in four hours. After half an hour of tossing around in his bed, he wrapped himself in his robe and headed back to the kitchen. He listened to three voicemails from April. She knew he was in one piece. He returned her

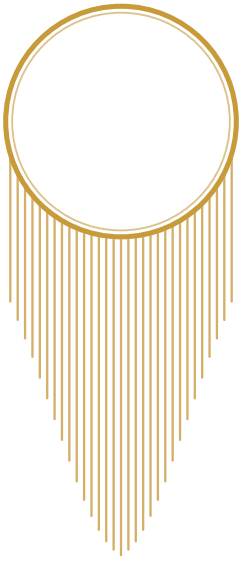
call. Her old-fashioned answering machine kicked in. "April, I'm in Vancouver. I'll call you after dinner. I'm good, but Hunt isn't. Talk soon."

He tore off the packing tape from the Search and Rescue box and flipped through the Atlin report. The only good news for Sceptre. He locked his pistol and harness in the broom closet gun safe.

He reflected on April's comment: *some people didn't like the Howitzers*. Their reputation as tough, shrewd negotiators was a given. They were miners. How else would they have been so successful for decades?

April was wrong. The Howitzers were hard-working and honest.

The real deal.



CHAPTER 9

~~A YEAR AGO~~, VANCOUVER

Zi began plotting; not only was he angry, but he couldn't lose face. His father's death was a tragedy, and no one could ever know about the circumstances and the truth of his unnatural demise. Murder was taboo, an untouchable topic in his culture. His father's honour had to be restored.

Zi applied for a travel visa. He'd spent the past few days absorbing the reality of his father's fate, but he could find nothing about the history of Vancouver mining on the Chinese internet. A one- to two-month wait was too long. But he contacted an

army friend who worked in the government to fast-track his paperwork.

A week later, he flew to Vancouver—his first trip to Canada—to learn the real story of his father.

Despite the jet lag, Zi started his search. First up, he asked the taxi driver to pass by 144 Keefer Street, the rooming house where his father had lived. The white-brick-with-redwood-trim structure had been redeveloped into condominiums and a street-level cocktail bar, a small island of gentrification.

What had it been like for his father to live here in the 1950s? ~~He had~~ learned that immigrants and the youth lived in humble Chinatown boarding homes during those times. The night before, a well-to-do businessman in the Fairmont Hotel lounge had informed him that wealthy Westside families used to love visiting the community to enjoy its ethnic food and vibrant culture.

No longer. Chinatown had lost its charm. Graffiti scarred the storefronts, which were now protected with steel-reinforced gates and doors. The area felt abused and unsafe.

Zi had seen enough. "Can you take me to the police station?"

"Yeah, sure, no problem."

The taxi turned down Hastings Street and waited at the red light, where a scatter of gaunt men and women stumbled across the ~~crosswalk~~. A city garbage truck crawled down the street. Sanitation workers were shovelling piles of trash accumulated by tents set up along the sidewalks.

"What's happening here?" Zi asked.

"Nowhere to live. Addicts steal anything they can ~~and~~ then sell the goods on the street for drugs. Fentanyl. Big business here." The driver turned left. "Can you imagine? And that's okay? Idiots run this country. Crazy."

Zi remembered the two enthusiastic thugs in his office excited about the drug trade opportunity in North America—now he understood the filthy game. He leaned back in his seat and admired the magnificent North Shore Mountains. The bright red and purple rhododendrons in full bloom caught his attention as the cab manoeuvred through the back streets. Vancouver was a strange city, beautiful but troubled.

He paid the taxi driver and walked into the Vancouver Police Department~~, and he~~ waited, but not for long. The receptionist motioned him over to the kiosk.

"I'm Officer Munro. How can I help you?" asked the youthful man. His short blond hair was nicely combed, but his skin was red with acne. He straightened himself in his office chair, positioned in front of a computer.

"Nice to meet you. My name is Zi Liu. I have a question. I believe my father was murdered in Vancouver years ago. Here are the details." Zi passed him a paper. The man typed on his keyboard but had no immediate answers. Zi became curious. "And?"

"Yes, ~~he is~~ on our cold case website. I guess you haven't seen it?"

Zi wasn't sure what the man was referring to. "Could you show me?"

The officer turned his computer screen. "This is his case. He was stabbed at the Hotel Vancouver. Yes, it's a cold case. Decades old. But the department never closes a case until it's solved." With a tone of certainty, he said, "Evidence eventually shows up."

Zi read the web page. There was a picture of his father he'd never seen before. He was bundled up in a winter coat, wearing a fedora. But his father's warm smile was familiar. Zi swallowed hard: it was the wrong time to show his emotions. "Yes. But there have been no findings, is that right?"

"Correct. You could add a reward if you like? That sometimes gets the wheels turning again." The young man handed him the paperwork. "Email me these forms, and I'll process them for you. Sorry for your loss, Mr. Liu."

"Yes, me too."

Zi stood outside the police station. His heart tugged at the thought of his father's fate. What rotten person would do such an act? An officer with her German shepherd passed him and stopped.

"Need some help?" she asked.

"No, thank you." But he did need help. It was a sad moment to process. A reward made sense. Ten thousand dollars. The dollars could jog someone's memory.

A yellow cab turned the corner. Zi flagged him and hopped in. Next stop: a mining claim company that advertised its advisory services. He hoped someone in the firm would help him interpret his father's papers. Ten minutes later, the taxi stopped at the street corner.

"It's to your right. Eight dollars, fifty cents."

Zi handed him a twenty. "That's fine." The driver thanked him for his generosity. As Zi stepped out of the taxi, the fresh ocean air inspired his quest.

The company, Mineral Experts, claimed to be a top-tier consulting firm. But once inside, the untidy office was not promising. File boxes were piled against the wall, and hundreds of rolled maps were stacked in pyramids on do-it-yourself shelving. A scrawny man with a shiny bald head sat behind his metal desk.

"Can I help you?" the man asked.

"Yes, I hope so. I would like to pay you for your time." Zi handed him a hundred-dollar bill and the mineral claim. "This was my father's. Does he still own it?"

"Let me have a look." The man's eyebrows furrowed when he keyed in Zi's information on his desktop computer. "Your father? You're sure?"

"Yes, is it still under his name?" Zi gripped his father's map while the man entered additional information.

"This claim turned into one of the best-known junior mining companies in British Columbia. Sceptre Gold. It's a public company, but the Howitzers are the major shareholders." He shook his head. "One of the wealthiest families in Vancouver. They made a fortune."

"Please explain." Zi didn't understand what he'd heard. "Can you write this company name for me?" On a scrap of paper, the man wrote the symbol of Sceptre on the Exchange: SCEP-T. "The family name?"

"Howitzer."

"Howitzer, did you say?" The second time he'd heard that name. "My father never owned the land?" He intended to go nowhere until he got answers. He sat down on a cracked faux-leather chair and waved three hundred-dollar bills.

"Let me look." The man began rapping his knuckles against the desk. "Someone owned the land first. Sying Liu. Then Easton Howitzer scooped up the claim a week after it expired."

"Easton Howitzer. Is that right? A week later?" Zi asked.

"Yup, that's all I can help you with." The man pushed himself out from behind his desk, opened the front office door, and, with his cash in hand, he said, "Best to leave that alone. I'm going for lunch."

After being tossed out of the office, Zi stood on the sidewalk and watched the man lock the door. He needed a moment. His father was murdered in 1960. ~~The~~ same year, he had made the claim. Zi had to be ten years old at that time. A kid.

The pieces of the puzzle were starting to fit together. The name on the back of the map. Zi's father knew Easton was up to no good. But was the murder a coincidence or intended? Easton Howitzer owned the staked land within days of its expiration. ~~Years~~ later, his father's claim became Sceptre Gold, a money-making machine.

The heartbreaking situation needed further investigation.

At this stage of life, he wasn't expecting to discover this misfortune. ~~He had~~ achieved so much—money, success, and family. And yet his father had bled out in the back alley of a

glamorous hotel, alone, without ever knowing the triumph of his discovery.

Zi walked a dozen blocks back to his hotel and nursed a pot of black tea in the lounge. What a tragedy. He couldn't go home yet. He had only half the answers he needed. Perhaps he wasn't even asking the right questions.

Cui bono? Easton would be long dead, so who was still profiting off his father's death? He searched for Sceptre's website on his phone. ~~There was~~ a contact number for the Vancouver office. He dialed it, and someone answered on the fourth ring. He would be discreet.

"Yes, hello. My name is Jimmy Zhang. I'm a fund manager from Hong Kong. Who am I speaking with?"

"Who are you?" The rough voice sounded like that of an older person.

"Jimmy Zhang. And you are?"

"Wallace Howitzer. Jimmy, I can direct you to our investor relations firm."

Perfect. Based on the website, he was speaking to the eldest of the Howitzers, Easton's son and the retired CEO.

"I've got a twenty-million-dollar fund, looking for a resource deal in Canada. Your company fits our profile. Interested?"

"Tell me what you're talking about, again? We aren't doing a financing right now." The man paused. "Twenty million did you say?"

"Yes."

"You can buy a lot of stock with that kind of money, can't you? I can spare ten minutes," Wallace said. "My office. Three, two, one Water Street. Two thirty."

"Very good. See you then." *That was a good move.*



Twenty minutes later, the taxi dropped Zi off in Gastown. The area appeared seedy, with litter on the sidewalks and people wandering aimlessly. Why wouldn't the Howitzers be in a high-end office tower downtown? He entered the building only to find that the fourth floor was locked to the public. The intercom granted him access, and after the elevator moved swiftly up the low-rise brick building, the door slid open into the office.

It was a vast open space. Three oversized light-oak desks and a long board table stacked with maps furnished the room. The red-brick walls showcased framed maps and dozens of photographs. Various antique mining tools were displayed. It was an impressive set-up.

"Hello. I'm Wallace Howitzer. Jimmy—you said?"

The senior Howitzer wasn't short, but he didn't match Zi's height of six feet either. The father toddled over to greet him. He had to be in his mid-eighties, but his green eyes were

discerning. ~~But~~ Zi noticed Wallace's interest in his Italian shoes and his gold-rimmed Patek Philippe watch.

"Yes, Jimmy Zhang. Thank you for seeing me." Zi bristled at the lack of welcome. Wallace hadn't invited him to sit on the sofa or offered tea. "This is Sceptre's head office?"

"It's our family office. Our operations are in Stewart, as is our staff. Terrific group. We run the business side from here, but one of us is usually on-site. It's an impressive operation."

"I see." It didn't take long for Zi to get bad vibes. "My fund doesn't invest in anyone until we do our due diligence. Tell me. Your father founded the company?"

"That's right. Easton Howitzer was a hell of a geologist. And today, I can proudly say that the Howitzers own twenty-four percent of Sceptre. We are the largest shareholders." Wallace pointed over to a brick wall that paid homage to his father. "That's Easton. Stellar man. He founded our company in the middle of nowhere."

"By himself? Did he have a team working with him? Other geologists?"

"You're talking about his mule, aren't you?" Wallace laughed.

"Mule?" Zi didn't understand the reference.

Was that a disrespectful name ~~that~~ they called ~~his~~ baba?

"Easton was the kind of guy who always had people around, but he was a pioneer—the founder. He staked the claims. After university, I joined him. He died unexpectedly, and, as a young man, I built Sceptre. Took me years, but Easton knocked out a home run at Stewart—he discovered a monster motherlode."

Zi stared up at Easton's ego-sized portrait. The obese crook was dressed in a grey herringbone three-piece suit, leaning his tall frame against a wingback chair. His face was bloated probably from rich food and too much alcohol. But it was the smarmy smile that irked Zi the most. He'd heard and seen enough.

"I need to discuss your information further with my colleagues," Zi said, focused on keeping calm. "Is there anything else you can share about Sceptre?"

"The Howitzers are a success. If you've got cash to invest, you won't go wrong. I can't tell you anything more without an NDA, except that I forecast the Howitzers will be flush for generations." Wallace nodded and called up the elevator.

"I see. I see." The picture of the Howitzers became clear to Zi.

"Willy, give me your card. I'll have my grandson, Mac, add you to our investor list. That boy is the best geologist, probably in the country. He's the captain of the Howitzer rocket ship."

"It's Jimmy." ~~But Zi was still curious about the man who was currently running the company, since the old goat had retired.~~ "And what about your son, Harry? Where does he fit in?" He noticed Wallace took a moment to ~~form~~ his thoughts.

"There's a saying that the first generation creates the wealth, the second stewards it, and the third consumes it. Harry's number three." Wallace shrugged. "I'm too old to deal with him anymore. He's got a fantastic life thanks to me."

What a terrible thing to say to a stranger.

"You've told me what I ~~wanted~~ to hear." Zi turned his back on Wallace and stared at the elevator, waiting for it to arrive,

and an awkward minute of silence ensued. He refused to say goodbye.

The elevator delivered him to the lobby. He slammed open the polished brass and glass door, stood on the sidewalk, and glanced up to the top floor. Wallace Howitzer stood at the window, peering down ~~at~~ him.

Zi's emotions boiled. But his mission became clear. *Sceptre ~~should~~ return to its rightful owners.*

An electric scooter zipped by. The scooter driver, his face obscured by his oversized helmet and sunglasses, wore a pair of expensive running shoes, like Dashi's. He stopped to meet a dishevelled couple slumped over on the sidewalk. Drug paraphernalia was scattered around them and their mangy mutt, which needed food and a bath. The three briefly spoke. A police car drove by, ignoring the lawbreaker.

In broad daylight, he handed over a palm-sized tinfoil package in return for a fistful of dollars. Zi had witnessed a drug deal. After the exchange, the scooter driver went on his way. It appeared nobody cared about his ill deed.

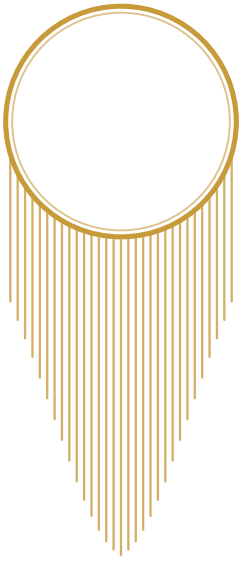
He understood how difficult it would be to take down the Howitzers. The family had money and power. But he had an advantage: his years of takeover business expertise. He had to somehow put those skills to work in a Canadian public-company environment. It would be a challenge, and he would need to learn fast. His first issue, though, was access to money in Canada. He couldn't transfer his millions from China due to government regulations. It was prohibited. He'd be starting at zero.

The thugs' visit to his office promised new markets for pharmaceutical products in North America. When Wei spoke about the offer, her enthusiastic comments confirmed it was a profitable opportunity.

All options needed to be explored.

Eyes fixed on the building he'd just left, Zi fantasized about storming into the fourth floor, ripping down Easton's painting, replacing it with his father's portrait, and throwing the Howitzers out of the family office.

~~Because the Lius were~~ the new majority shareholders of Sceptre.



CHAPTER 10

PRESENT DAY, VANCOUVER

The century-old mansions in Harry's childhood neighbourhood were in transition. Dozens of the estates were dark. Some of the character homes were torn down to make room for mega mansions, and others were neglected. But as the old guard died, foreigners snapped up the grand properties as trophies, rather than forever family homes. Friends of his who had cashed out their parents' homes considered the lucrative deals to be brilliant moves. Harry disagreed. What about their traditions, their legacy?

But right now, who was he to judge? The Howitzer legacy was at risk.

The short walk to Wallace's front gate wore him out. He took a minute to catch his breath and walked along the paved stone driveway to the black-and-white Tudor, designed by a renowned English architect in 1912 and built by a Canadian Pacific Railway executive. Harry's grandfather, Easton, had bought it eighteen years later after the owner had lost his life savings in the crash of 1929. "For pennies on the dollar," Wallace quoted Easton with a chuckle. Generations of the Howitzers have lived there since.

For Harry, Easton was a man of mystery: he was gone by the time Harry was around twelve years old.

His key chain rattled when he pushed open the heavy wooden front door. "Hello?" Harry called out. Wallace's Westie, Osler, greeted him with a tail wag. "Hello, my friend," he said, and hung his jacket.

Harry treasured his family home. The ten-foot-high ceilings in the foyer carried the familiar scent of spicy white lilies. Wallace's notable Canadian art collection, mostly from the Group of Seven, lined the oak-panelled walls. In his thirties, Harry hadn't understood his father's passion for acquiring artworks. But thirty years later, he now realized the risk was worthwhile, and the collection had become a substantial part of the Howitzers' financial portfolio. To his right, he noticed the painting *Wood Interior* by Emily Carr was askew. He adjusted the frame half an inch. Carr's work was one of Wallace's best investment choices.

The oil piece captured a moody brown-and-green forest canopy. It reminded Harry of Princess Royal Island.

A sharp and unexpected shiver rippled through him.

In the kitchen, Mac and Wallace were preparing a welcome-home dinner. The family had spent years cooking meals and watching sports on the old-fashioned leather sofas in the adjoining family room overlooking the backyard. The acre-sized garden had been Wallace's pastime since he had retired. Since then, the trees and bushes always appeared precisely manicured, and the gardens were stuffed with perennials and colourful summer annuals.

"Sorry I'm late," Harry said.

"Hey, Dad, we were wondering where you were," Mac said.

"I'm here. Dad, I noticed a few paintings in the hallway were off-kilter. Was there someone working on the Tudor?" Harry asked.

"Just me and Osler. Feeling better?" Wallace asked.

"A little." Harry didn't want to share the truth. He felt like a bus had hit him.

Mac was rubbing the steak with salt and pepper. He topped each of the two-inch slabs with a drizzle of olive oil and started grating Parmesan over the Caesar salad. "Mom called—something about purchasing the Howitzer collection. She has a buyer."

Martha. That woman lived in a perpetual delusion. "Mac, nothing is for sale," Harry said.

"The collection is the Howitzers'. I spent my lifetime building it," Wallace said, stirring the julienne carrots on the gas stovetop,

banging the wooden spatula against the pan. “Is she back in Vancouver? Keep her out of my sight.”

“She moved back here with Madeline, her girlfriend, about six months ago. They set up an art gallery down in Railtown,” Mac said.

“There’s plenty of good art for sale in the city. Mac, tell your mother our collection is a private matter, please,” Harry said. He wondered what Martha was scheming. “Let’s get down to business.” There was an open Chambertin on the kitchen counter. He poured himself a small glass of the Grand Cru and sat on a barstool. A scent of berries wafted up from the glass. “Mac, what’s the status with security?”

“No one was spotted in that area for the past week.”

“That’s impossible,” Wallace said. “The jerks didn’t magically fly in there.”

“Agree.” Harry grabbed his glass of wine when his phone rang. “Hey, April. What’s up?” He moved to the edge of the sofa and sat down. The news wasn’t good. Five minutes later, he’d heard enough. But before he could hang up, April questioned him about the longhouse, asking him if anything strange had happened. There was no need to rehash that night. “No, nothing unusual. Thanks for the update. Bye for now.”

He downed the wine but needed something stronger.

“What now, Harry?” Wallace asked.

“April said she wanted to meet with Hunt to ask him about the status of the case. But there was no sign of him in town. She caught up with Layla, Hunt’s girlfriend, who shared in

confidence that ~~he had~~ left this afternoon on a special assignment, and she didn't know when he'd return."

"What on earth?" Wallace shook his head.

"He didn't mention anything about going on a special assignment to us today," Mac said, tapping his grandfather's hand for affirmation.

"For whatever reason, he's not going to help to us." At least Harry had clarity. "But the rumour mill in town is buzzing about who did it ~~and~~ that ~~the Howitzers~~ haven't been forthright with information. Can you believe that?"

"Absolute nonsense. Harry, Sceptre has been a stellar, forthright~~,~~ gold miner for decades under my helm." Wallace reached and grasped the counter. His voice grew louder, but shakier. "Shareholders don't expect an event this amateur to happen to a company like ours. It's sloppy. And now a dinky little stream with dead salmon is completely blown out of proportion."

"No, Granddad. Killing salmon that are spawning is a big deal."

"That's your generation, Mac, not mine." Wallace slammed down the pot lid on the counter. "I can't believe this is happening to us."

"Dad, stop. This is not even a conversation." Harry didn't want to listen to his father trying to argue that Sceptre should be exempt from their legal responsibility. His father's logic was ludicrous. "I'll be right back."

In the living room, he helped himself to a short, small batch bourbon from the liquor cabinet. He brought the bottle back

with him and set it on the marble counter, wondering about the oversized tire tracks at the stream.

"Those tire tracks I saw. They were wider than normal. Whoever did this entered the Hemlock stream with some kind of special vehicle under the radar. But how?" The liquor took the edge off his headache. He topped up the glass. Wallace was watching his consumption. ~~He~~ didn't care. "Thoughts?"

Mac was looking something up on his phone.

"You can customize an F-150 with wide-track axles. That idea fits the bill, but how would they get on site? None of our employees own anything like that," Mac said. "Doesn't make any sense."

"No, it doesn't." Harry glanced over to the smoky barbecue outside and pointed to Mac. "Let's go. Time to eat."

Dinner was ready. The dining room was fitted with a table for twelve and adorned with two crystal chandeliers. Watercolours by Franklin Carmichael hung on the wall. It was a grand room. Decades of dinners had been enjoyed there, celebrating birthdays, entertaining special guests, and revelling in Sceptre's success.

"Bon appétit." Harry's first bite of the medium-rare steak tasted juicy and tender. "Nice job, son."

"Yes, good job, Mac." Wallace placed his knife and fork down. His high forehead crinkled with frustration. "Mac, you know we don't have our phones at the table."

Mac glanced at his phone and put it back in his pocket. "I've got news, and it's not good. I just got a text from the Taku Chief confirming the conversation I had with him this afternoon. He had questions I couldn't answer about the salmon sabotage."

Mac pulled his hair off his face and sighed. “Didn’t matter what I said. I tried to talk him down all day. They’re stopping any further activity on Atlin until we clear our name. Even if the sampling report is as good as we forecast.”

~~That~~ news was a punch in the stomach for Harry. He and Mac had worked hard to build ~~their~~ relationship for the past five years.

“Why?” Harry asked.

“It wasn’t the Chief’s decision,” Mac said. “The nation doesn’t want to be associated with a mining company with environmental issues. From their perspective, we weren’t taking care of our lands. They’re concerned about how we manage our operations. He used the word *reckless*.”

“What nonsense. I spent forty years building Sceptre. You two have no idea what I inherited from my father. It was a struggle from day one to start up a mine. Now this? Being told how to run our company?” Spit hung from Wallace’s lip. “This Taku issue goes no further than this table. Not a word to anyone. Do you two hear me? No more bad press. Mac, I expect you to fix this.”

“I’m on it.” Mac turned to his father. “This screws up the program at Atlin—big time.”

“I don’t get it. Things are deteriorating—fast.” But for Harry, April’s comments stuck with him: *It’s not local. It’s about the Howitzers*.

Maybe she was onto something. Harry remembered that Thursday night, decades ago, in The Vancouver Club. ~~After~~ graduating from Queen’s, ~~he had~~ joined Sceptre as the vice

president of geology. After work, he'd go to the club and play billiards, hoping to one day be a part of the old boys' network. Since 1889, the men's club had provided a safe haven for members to socialize with associates, tell tall tales, and sometimes tattle on each other.

That evening, Harry was meeting his university buddy Neil Nakazawa. He ~~had~~ wandered through the buzz of regulars. Industrialists from the logging and mining sector ~~had~~ joined politicians, judges, and influential friends at cocktail tables, drinking Scotch and pontificating. A young page boy dressed in a fine suit ~~had~~ tapped Harry, who was peering over the top of the staircase, searching for Neil. "For you, Mr. Howitzer, sir."

"Thank you."

Neil had been forced to work late, typical for a newly graduated accountant's life. Harry ~~had~~ tried to find another game. Unsuccessful, he~~'d~~ packed the pool cues back into the locker he only had thanks to his father, ~~and~~ beelined to the family liquor locker in the next room. With his bottle of bourbon in hand, he~~'d~~ acknowledged a table of club patriarchs.

"Where's Wallace?" one had asked.

"Argentina." Harry ~~had been~~ nervous speaking to Wallace's friends, wanting to appear like a grown-up Howitzer. "Chasing those fat brown trout." He ~~had~~ waved before heading off. "Nice to see you, gentlemen."

But he'd forgotten ice. ~~As he'd turned the corner back into the bar, he'd heard the name Easton. He'd eavesdropped.~~

"Easton Howitzer was a rogue. Rumour has it he didn't even find the gold mine himself. One of his juniors did."

"Hell," another old codger had chimed in. "My daddy told me Easton came from some shithole in Saskatchewan with a grade-five education. All that bastard did was swindle anyone who got in his way. There was nothing blue in his blood." The table had chuckled.

Harry had lost his appetite and gone home early. He had dismissed the conversation as jealousy, but he'd never forgotten the nasty gossip.

That gossip prompted Harry. "Question. Has something happened that I should be aware of? You know, bad blood? Or a secret? Because someone is sabotaging us. And it doesn't make sense why." The table was quiet. Wallace's face soured at Harry.

"Let me start," Harry began. "Kind of a secret. This has nothing to do with our business, but I've been dating a thirty-eight-year-old for a while now. Nothing serious."

Mac burst out laughing. "Kind of old for you, isn't she?"

"What's with this bullshit, Harry?" Wallace pounded his hand on the table. "You're acting like a child. Did that head injury scramble your brain?"

"Granddad, hey, ease up," Mac said.

"We are on the verge of a major crisis with our company," Wallace shouted, "and Harry's talking about who he's screwing. If I were ten years younger, I would go to the board tomorrow morning and tell them I'm going to replace you as CEO."

"Dad," Harry said, backtracking. "We've made loads of money, and nothing has gone wrong until now. Do we have any secrets? Because if you do, tell me." He paused. "I don't have any."

Would it be the right time to bring up what he'd overheard about Easton at the club all those years ago? Though he'd always doubted the gossip, maybe there was some truth to it. But seeing his father's seething, blotched face, he couldn't add to the patriarch's stress level.

"No secrets," Wallace snapped. "~~I'm concerned it's~~ going to be tough for Sceptre to recover its reputation after this mess. Harry, find out how this happened. It's critical and damn serious. Do you hear me?"

"Dad, come on, just settle down. Nothing is more important to me than fixing this disaster. Pronto."

A door slammed upstairs. The Westie let out a series of relentless howls. "Osler, stop it," Wallace shouted. "Mac, pick me up on your way to the office. Eight a.m. I ~~can't~~ sit around this house and wait for answers."

Mac gave Harry a side glance, wanting approval.

"Whatever you want to do, Dad." Harry didn't want his father breathing down his neck all day, but he wouldn't upset his father any further. "Hunt is out. Tomorrow morning, my first call is to the RCMP in Prince Rupert to speak to his supervisor, make a formal complaint, give a statement about the incident, and include April as a witness. Mac, for sure, there are no photos?"

"No, it's because of the spotty coverage up there."

"That was a mistake. I've got to move on. I'm going to insist on a complete investigation to clear us of any responsibility. I'll get legal to release a statement for a safeguard."

The only reaction Harry got was from Osler, who raced into the room and snapped his teeth in the air.

Wallace threw his napkin on the table. "Harry, shareholders aren't stupid. Smoke and mirrors won't cut it. Get a real plan." He pushed his chair back. "I'm going to bed. Mac, eight o'clock sharp."

"Dad, don't talk to me like I'm a child. What do you want me to do? Lie?" Harry asked, his voice loud, demanding. "Have respect, will you? How could I have prevented this?"

"Both of you are pretty salty," Mac said. "Stop this."

"Salty? I don't even know what you're talking about, Mac." Wallace stood at the doorway, a little hunched over. "Dead fish, no investigation, Atlin program iced." He shook his head. "And Harry's answer is to make a phone call. Our company is in peril. Pathetic, Harry."

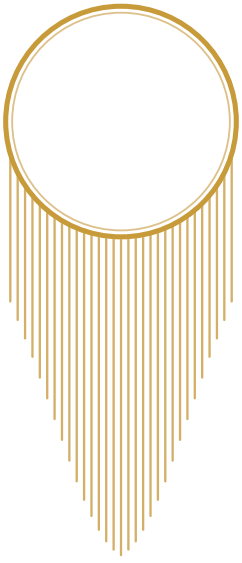
"Dad, quit ~~being~~ so—"

"So what? Acting like a real CEO should?"

The insult hit Harry hard. ~~The exchange of those words was difficult.~~ They'd never spoken to each other that way—ever.

Wallace turned, cursing under his breath and shuffled toward the staircase leading to his bedroom. "Osler, bedtime," he shouted.

The family dinner had imploded into a full-blown Howitzer natural disaster.



CHAPTER 11

PRESENT DAY, VANCOUVER

The capitulation of the Howitzer legacy was underway.

The Lius had arrived in Vancouver a year ago with one goal: to take over Sceptre Gold. They had put Jaw Long's Russian contacts to beneficial use to set up a fentanyl venture. Within six months, Zi and Wei had established production facilities in Richmond. Chemicals had arrived from Guangzhou, in mislabelled containers. Thousands of fentanyl pills had been pressed into greenies and funnelled through a Russian dealer network with a fifty-fifty split.

The business had made fast money. The proceeds had seeded the launch of Keefer Gold, a shell company Zi and Dashi had created and listed on the TSX Venture Exchange. Three directors with obscure backgrounds, friends of the Russians, fronted the company. Keefer Gold was the perfect facade.

But the first few months had brought disappointment. There wasn't much Sceptre stock available for purchase until Zi and Dashi had devised a brilliant plan of attack.

Sunny November days were scarce in Vancouver, but not that Monday. The sky was bright, and the air had a hint of warmth. Zi inspected the yard of his new home on the city's Westside, finished with magazine-worthy renovations. The eight-thousand-square-foot mid-century modern home was nestled in an acre of lush landscaping. And having Dashi live in the coach house was a bonus. But predictably, Wei wanted to be in the downtown scene. She chose to live in a luxury condo in a hotel complex.

Zi headed back inside to his living room. The twelve-foot-high glass windows and walnut panelling provided natural light and an airy feel. It was his favourite place. He would spend hours sitting on his leather chair with a snifter of cognac, admiring the Burrard Inlet and the Salish Sea view and contemplating his Howitzer coup.

A six-foot-high acrylic painting hung over the brick fireplace. It was his first Canadian art acquisition. He had bid on the piece at a fundraising auction the previous week. The work was by an Indigenous artist, Lawrence Paul Yuxweluptun. Zi liked the name of the painting: *Portrait of a One Percenter*. It was a

unique interpretation of a businessman sporting a black suit and blue tie. But his head was a colourful carved Indigenous mask representing a sinister, drooling character. Zi recognized the message wasn't flattering and understood the artist was making a statement about privilege. Zi disagreed.

Privilege provided worth and lifestyle.

The purchase was a good start, and the artist had a global following. He had decided he'd like to build a Canadian collection.

Zi continued down the long, empty hallway. It would be an excellent area for his new gallery. Further down the corridor, he found Dashi in their home office pounding away on his keyboard. "Good morning. What's happening?" Zi asked.

"Still picking up stock. Those Howitzers have holding power."

"Don't remind me." Zi bent down to get a better look at Dashi's screen. Red-and-green numbers flashed, making it challenging for Zi to understand. "What's Keefer's position?"

"Close to eight percent." He handed his father a printout. "Long way to owning this thing, Baba."

"When ~~do~~ we expect ~~this~~ report from Hunt?"

The report was the second phase of their salmon sabotage event. Stage one was a stellar success—dead salmon with lots of bad press. When Zi ~~had~~ decided to pursue Sceptre, he'd taken it upon himself to study the mining business. A mine had to be responsible for the environment, and if not, the consequences were severe. An RCMP report implicating Sceptre in the stream chemical poisoning would create further havoc. Zi forecasted a second lucrative opportunity to buy more cheap stock once the report was released.

"He said within the next few days. All good. Baba, it was a fluke when Serge and I met Hunt, and he could be bought off—total luck."

"Did you pay Hunt already?"

"Crypto sent. For the poisoning and the report."

"Why pay before it was released, Dashi?"

"He's a cop. He's good for it."

"Too late now." His son's idea was flawed—never give money with only a promise. The door opened. "Hello, Wei."

"Hey, Cinnamon." The siblings broke into a fit of laughter.

"The name is Red on the street." Wei flicked Dashi's ball cap. Jet-black tights clung to her lanky figure. She unzipped her coat and black hoodie, and pulled off a long red wig.

"That look, sis, it's you." Dashi shook his head. "You're badass."

"Keeping on the down low in the Downtown Eastside." Wei peeled off a small prosthetic hooked nose and a burn scar that covered the right side of her face. "Got to keep incognito." She turned. "Morning, Zi. Are we winning?"

"Not yet," Zi said. "Why do you have that getup? Do you trust the Russians?"

"I do, but I like to see for myself." Wei smiled. "A personal audit."

"I don't like you going to that neighbourhood. It's a war zone. Do you have to do this?" Zi waited for an answer. Her stubborn attitude wouldn't calm his concern. "Be careful, please. Tell me about Howitzer."

"No luck this weekend. I sent him a text to grab a coffee but no response." Wei leaned on the back of the sofa in the office.

"Just a coffee? No booty call?" Dashi laughed, but was the only one in the room who enjoyed his joke.

"Dashi, don't be ~~rude~~. Wei wouldn't do that." His daughter was her own boss. But that was how he'd raised her. Her intimidating personality was probably why her marriage had ended a ~~year ago,~~ and ~~she~~ had few female friends. ~~She~~ and Dashi were like glue. "Wei's mission is strictly to seek out insider information from Harry Howitzer."

"Will you two chill out? I'm on it." Wei poked her brother's shoulder. "Don't be juvenile."

"Enough nonsense, you two. I'm going with Serge to Richmond to check the operations. Dashi?"

"Yes, Baba. I will let you know when I hear from Hunt and when the report will be released."

"Good. I'm gone for the day." Zi found Serge waiting outside. He was the Russian gang's front man for the Lius and Zi's right-hand guy. It had taken time for Zi to warm up to him. But ~~he had~~ earned his value and was trustworthy.

Serge wasn't a handsome man. Not tall, but not short. His broad nose had a deep scar across it. Maybe a knife wound. One day, Zi would ask. For days, Serge had worn the same ill-fitting, cheap black suit with a wrinkly blue dress shirt. It was time to take him to a tailor. "Serge, how's *Sunspot*?"

"Perfect order. The Coal Harbour Marina has never seen a yacht like yours."

"My beauty." Zi's superyacht had arrived in Vancouver later than he had anticipated. His showpiece would be used for pure

pleasure. “We’ll go see her after our visit to Richmond.” Next to the SUV was a black Porsche 911. “Whose is this?”

“Wei’s.” Serge touched Zi’s shoulder. “Your daughter is a woman with her own mind.”

They climbed into the Escalade.

“That she is.” About ten minutes into their drive, after small talk about living in Vancouver, Zi said, “I’m worried about when we own Sceptre. What do we do with it? The company doesn’t appear to be in great shape long term.”

Zi appreciated Serge’s background and opinions. ~~He had~~ grown up in Moscow and was a geologist. His family was in the inner political circle~~. They had been~~ high-profile players in the Russian mining industry for decades.

“Depends on what the outcome is with the sabotage event. Many possibilities there—even bankruptcy if Hunt’s report is good. But if not, and they get out of the mess you’ve put them in, the reserves are nearing their end, possibly exhausted in five years or so. The company has been operating for a long time. Not sure it can continue its success,” Serge said.

“That’s what I thought.”

“Those miners are sharp. I imagine they have another plan. A merger, or any new project.” Serge tapped the wheel. “But boss, there is risk. They do have a new project further north. Atlin. Early stage. Could be something there.”

“When I ~~met Wallace Howitzer, he was~~ keen on that project. Now it is in early-stage testing.” The more Zi learned, the more he realized he didn’t know. “~~Waiting~~ for the results from what the news release states.”

–Hit or miss at this point. If the results are good, a drilling program would be next. That takes time. They don't have the money for something that big, as far as I can tell. It's millions."

That was what Zi understood. "Serge, if this Atlin project doesn't go forward?"

"It's going to be a struggle." Serge shrugged. "You could lose your investment, boss. Millions."

"This mission is not about my money. I want the Howitzers exposed for who they are. Something will break in our favour."

The Escalade idled at a stoplight. The jam-packed strip mall caught Zi's attention. Patrons hustled in and out of local beaneries. He looked up at the sign, No. 5 Road. Richmond was a bustling suburb of Vancouver with residences and low-rise commercial buildings. A low-flying jumbo jet roared above them.

"How are things going at this facility?" Zi asked.

"Pretty good, but we have a power problem." He turned left and merged into the right lane. The driver of a BMW sports car behind him leaned on the horn. "Too much use. The utilities could flag us."

"Ahh, I see." Power usage wasn't something Zi had considered. "The answer?"

"Need to buy more land around us. Tap into their lines."

"I'll make that a priority." There were more problems than he had anticipated, but nothing he couldn't handle at the moment.

It took money, like everything else important in his life.

Ten minutes later, they drove into the farm community from the suburbs. Serge pointed out nondescript properties

that would be good candidates for purchase. He continued to check his rear-view mirror.

"Something wrong?" Zi asked and made a shoulder check. There was no one in his sight line.

"Just being cautious." Serge turned right down a dirt driveway with no visible street address.

The first-class operation, concealed in a cranberry farm, had a perfect front. Out of sight from the road, they arrived at an eight-foot armed gate buried in tall, thick cedar trees. Heavy security was evident around the property. The guards, disguised as workers, drove the tractors in the fields. Other farm equipment filled the yard. Even two horses were corralled in the grassy part of the property. They pulled up to two large galvanized-steel warehouses. A rundown 1970s ranch-style home was at the back of the property.

Serge parked and pointed to the warehouse to their right. "Vehicles first?"

"Sure, let's go." Zi zipped up his lambskin leather jacket. They greeted the guard, who tugged at the heavy door and motioned the men inside.

Screeches from electric saws and the toxic whiff of car paint greeted the visitors. Dozens of men fussed about prepping the German and British sports cars and sedans.

"Nice ride," Serge said, nodding to a hunter-green Range Rover. The workers removed the original vehicle identification numbers and replaced them with fake plates. They had paid off a local insurance agent to register the new numbers. The cars were cleaned and repainted at the paint booth in the back

corner of the building. A sporty black Rolls-Royce convertible caught Zi's eye. He checked out the ruby-red leather interior.

"Where did you find this beauty?" he asked the worker polishing the chrome.

"West Vancouver," the man said in broken English.

"Ah." The car would be an excellent addition to his new garage, but he reconsidered. No need to bring attention to himself right now. "Serge, how many cars per container right now?"

"Five to six."

"How many containers are we sending this week?"

"Eight, but more containers are available in the next few months."

"Going to China?" Zi made his calculations.

"And Saudi. This lot is worth twelve million dollars, laundered. Plans to ramp up, don't worry, boss."

Zi liked this business. It was simple. The Russian gang members stole the cars and shipped them overseas through their port contacts. Everyone involved received cash payments from the buyers through underground banks.

"Very good. Let's go next door." In the next warehouse, a man emerged wearing a hazmat suit.

"Do you want to suit up?" Serge asked.

"No, I'll peek in the front door."

Serge called over the worker, who returned with transparent plastic face masks. Inside, the operation whizzed like a beehive, reminding Zi of his lab in Guangzhou. The walls were white, and the porcelain floors were dull grey. Dozens of personnel stood at workstations, combining the chemicals Zi had shipped

and adding green dye. That compound was then pressed into greenies. Zi rubbed a ring on his right hand that he had custom-designed from the gold nugget he had found in his father's jacket. The chunk of gold was ostentatious, something he would not usually wear, but it was a reminder of his purpose.

"Excellent, Serge. Let's go inside the house."

An armed man nodded and opened the front door of the house. A rapid clicking sound resonated in the hallway. To his right, in what should be a living room, were six women, kept warm by spot heaters. They sat at card tables, tending to their money counters. They gave a slight wave to the visitors as they banded and stacked the currency from drug sales.

"Expansion—for casino laundering." Serge explained how Wei had organized a larger team of nondescript casino players. With the drug proceeds, the gamblers would spend hours winning and losing. "The banks are still taking the counter cheques—no questions asked. But the government officials are rumoured to be clamping down."

"Yes, that's the rumour." The money laundering game also had its risks.

"The real estate holdings are better for the long term, boss," Serge said and smiled. His long, yellow teeth reminded Zi of a moray eel.

"Yes," Zi said. "The twins have made good contacts. I like what they've bought so far."

"Agree." Serge motioned. "Come on. The vault is finished."

They passed three bedrooms. Serge opened a coat closet that led to a locked door. After punching a code on the electronic

lock, he escorted Zi down a narrow, makeshift staircase. The lights automatically turned on, revealing a newly constructed basement that resembled a bank vault.

Fireproof ceramic panelling lined the walls and the six-foot-high ceilings. Bundles of cash and firearms filled the shelves. Zi stooped to fit into the cement tomb-like structure.

"Look at this." Serge led him through the maze of money. "Millions stashed. And I love the hardware." He pulled out a semi-automatic rifle and showed it to Zi.

"Ah. That is more interesting to you." Zi was still adapting to the life of a gangster. He wasn't a fan of guns.

"Good update today, Serge. Let's go to *Sunspot*. Then I'm meeting this woman I met to discuss art—Martha." Martha, an art dealer, was very friendly with Zi and attractive.

"Like your recent purchase?" Serge asked with sarcasm. Serge shared Wei and Dashi's opinion of the piece. He was another art neophyte.

"I met Martha at the art auction last weekend. She has contacts to help me build a Canadian collection."

"I understand, boss." They climbed into the vehicle and headed down the driveway onto the road. Seconds later, a thumping noise filled the Escalade cab. Above them was a black and white helicopter swooshing back and forth across the swaths of agricultural lands. Serge grumbled in Russian. "Mr. Zi, we need to take the long way home."

"The police?" Zi stretched his neck to get a better look. That helicopter was not good news.

"I can't tell what's going on, but we're not giving them any reason to pull us over." Serge turned onto the main road and kept his speed to the limit.

The gangsters put on their sunglasses and tucked into their seats. They continued to be followed at a distance for the next ten minutes, but for Zi, it felt like an hour. The helicopter dipsy-doodled back and forth in the direction they were driving. Zi ground his back teeth, and his jaw cracked.

Sirens started to wail. Both men searched for the source. Three RCMP cars raced toward the Escalade. Multiple red lights flashed, and the whooping sound grew uncomfortably louder.

"Serge, what do we do?"

"Let me handle this." Serge continued to drive down the road, and as the cars approached, he pulled to the edge of the broken pavement. "If you are asked anything, nod. No English."

The RCMP vehicles flew by the Escalade, and the helicopter followed. They watched the convoy fly at high speed for about a quarter of a mile. The cars turned into a property that appeared to be in the greenhouse business.

Serge pumped his fist. The target was infested with law enforcement. The Escalade made a U-turn, and Serge booted it.

"We've got to sharpen our game, Mr. Zi."

After those stressful fifteen minutes, that was an understatement. The Escalade drove down the winding road, and as they passed their operations, Zi mused on the day's events. A good word to describe it: revealing.

Years of life had taught him that nothing would turn out as planned.

"Those cars," Zi said. "When are they ready to ship?"

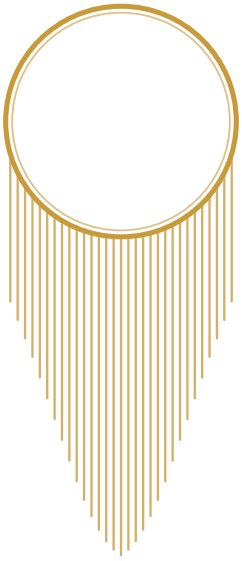
"Last ship would be early January. To Saudi." He gulped from his water bottle and dried the trickle running down the side of his mouth with his calloused hand.

"After that shipment, shut down that operation. Short term. Power problem fixed."

"Done. You and I will find a new location for the cars." Serge checked his rear-view mirror one more time.

The helicopter and the RCMP takedown on the neighbouring property spooked Zi. He reminded himself to tread carefully. Canada was a new country, and he didn't have the influence or the knowledge the Howitzers did. If the underground drug operations exposed him, the consequences could be tragic—jail or deportation.

"Serge, we can't make mistakes. I will not shame the Liu family."



CHAPTER 12

Pookmis crept through the Tudor's basement. Knots of cobwebs and decades of dust coated the exposed timber beams. Somewhere in the maze, filled with heaps of junk, he would find his refuge. There was a door. A possible hiding place. Inside, the wine cellar was stocked with hundreds, maybe thousands, of bottles. The excess confirmed his assumption. Wallace was a glutton. Pookmis moved deeper down a narrow hallway past dozens of stacked boxes and antique leather trunks. The cracked cement floor needed repair. Wallace had neglected the foundation. *Typical.*

Deep in the crawl space, Pookmis found the root cellar. The shelves were lined with mouldy mason jars and rusted

canning pots. It was vault-like, perfect. He tucked into the cement corner and savoured the chance to fulfill his afterlife duties according to Bukwis.

Yes, he would deliver on his promise—with pleasure.

Heavy footsteps ricocheted down from the first floor. Wallace was awake before the sun rose, alone except for Osler. The dreaded dog wouldn't shut up last night, after he'd chased Pookmis out of the hallway while Pookmis tried to eavesdrop on the dinner conversation.

It was time.

Pookmis crept through the main floor and found Wallace in his library upstairs, sitting in a fancy chair next to the roaring fireplace, reading a newspaper and drinking from a mug.

"Hello, Wallace."

The cup fell on the carpet. Wallace stood up. "Dear Lord, who?"

"Hello, Wallace." The anticipation caused him to smack and lick his lips. "Or should I say—Father."

"Father?" Wallace's chin trembled. The whites in his eyes grew wider. His wrinkled hands gripped the top of his wingback chair.

"You remember Benji? The son you rejected. What about my mother, Spring Johnson? You never acknowledged her. Mom tried to keep you a secret, but when you visited, I knew what you were doing."

"Spring?" Wallace shook his head as if he were trying to wake himself.

"Yes, my mother. She died from a broken heart years ago. My beautiful ~~mom~~ loved you." Pookmis watched his father's body begin to shudder.

"Get out of here, whatever you are."

"~~No,~~ not going anywhere. With all your money, you never gave her or me anything. Your neglect killed her. I'd find her in bed, wrapped in her blanket, in tears, so sad about how you treated her."

"That's nonsense." Wallace's tired eyes squinted as he tried to move closer to Pookmis. "~~But w~~hat are you?"

"Don't look at me that way." Pookmis wasn't proud of his appearance. "You and your son Harry will understand soon enough."

"~~You're talking~~ nonsense. Spring had so many issues, the poor girl. I didn't do anything she didn't want me to." Wallace spoke with conviction.

"Wrong. We have unfinished business. ~~And y~~ou knew about me, and you ignored me. All my life, I have never had anything except *Gull*. I made a few bad choices, but my failure was not my fault. It was yours, Father. I needed help, and you ignored me. I paid my price. Now the Howitzers will pay theirs." Pookmis wasn't clear if Wallace understood his message.

"You're not a Howitzer."

"I am. And I despise you."

Wallace tried to swat at Pookmis but lost his balance, knocking over a small carved wooden figurine of a grizzly bear.

"Nice try. You're going to need more than that to get rid of me."

Wallace took a step toward the ghost, reaching out as if he expected Pookmis to help him. For a moment, Pookmis wanted to help—his dad finally needed him. Hard to believe, but it was too late. He took a step back and watched Wallace tumble face first onto the Persian carpet.

Pookmis leaned down and hissed to the back of Wallace's head. "See what it's like when someone doesn't help you, rich man—it's called desperation."

But the dying man got a second wind. He rolled over, grabbed at the right side of his chest and gasped. "I don't want to die."

"Neither did I, Father."

The door chimed, and then the front door thumped shut.

"Granddad, let's go."

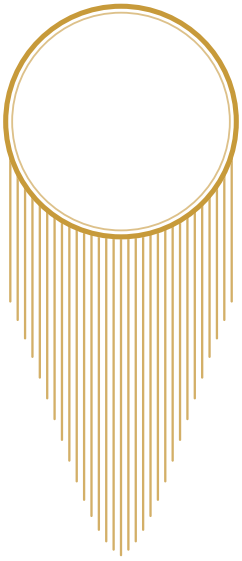
Pookmis slipped into the living room and watched Mac race to his grandfather.

"Granddad, what's wrong?" He leaned down to try to understand the undetectable words.

"Stay still, I'll get help!" Mac shouted. He dug into his coat pocket, pulled out his phone, and dialed 911. "There's been an emergency—my grandfather, he's collapsed."

The haunt sucked through his broken teeth, tucking himself behind the heavy navy curtains, waiting for the next turn of events.

"Nice work, Pookmis," he whispered.



CHAPTER 13

It was close to eight in the morning, but Harry had been up since five. A hot shower and three strong cups of coffee had primed him for the day. His dad ~~had been~~ miserable last night, and so ~~had~~ he. Harry needed to apologize. His father had grown fragile as he ~~had~~ aged, and Harry needed to recognize and respect the new reality.

By the end of the day, Harry would get answers and show his father that he could manage Sceptre through a crisis. At sixty years old, he still lived in the shadow of Wallace E. Howitzer, and that was not a good place to be.

A quick check on the stock was depressing. It was trading under three dollars. All Harry could do was watch the trainwreck. The years his family had spent building the mine, the Sceptre name, and proudly generating stellar revenues had been lost in days. Their success had been stolen by whoever had sabotaged the stream.

The search for Hunt's sergeant took time. The online directories weren't helpful, so he had called the Prince Rupert detachment and sweet-talked the receptionist. The man's name was Nightingale. Harry left a detailed voicemail and a request to call him. Then Mac called.

"Morning, son. I'm heading out."

"Dad." Mac's voice cracked, and his phone dropped.

"Son, what's the matter?" He could hear some kind of rustling. "Mac?" There was more commotion. He could hear Mac saying something like *Granddad*. "Son, talk to me!"

Mac picked up the phone and stuttered out a message.

"Son, I don't understand what you're saying. Start again."

"Dad, I'm at the Tudor. I found Granddad on the floor in the library. I think he might have had a stroke." He tried to catch his breath. "The ambulance is here."

"But he's alive, right?" There was only one answer Harry wanted.

"I can feel his pulse—sort of. He's pale and sweaty. He isn't making any sense. We're leaving. Meet me at the hospital."

"Right behind you." Harry grabbed his keys and coat.

There was an old saying that things happened in threes. Harry considered it an old wives' tale, but he was living it. Vancouver

General was blocks away. He fired up his vintage black Ferrari California, flew through the neighbourhood, and after double-parking in front of the hospital, ran into the emergency ward.

Mac was sitting in the empty back corner of the waiting room with his head buried in his hands. Harry touched his son's shoulder. "Son, what's going on?"

"The paramedics weren't hopeful." Mac's bloodshot eyes told the story. He wiped his hand over his face. "He was in and out of consciousness. He kept saying 'be careful.'"

"Careful?" That comment made sense given the circumstances they'd been dealing with. "Did he say anything else?" Mac shook his head, trying to keep his emotions intact. "Wallace is a fighter. Where's Osler?"

"Yvonne."

Yvonne, Wallace's closest neighbour, was practically family. Harry liked how she'd kept Wallace company. ~~He was a widower and she was a widow, and~~ they were lethal duplicate-bridge players at the club.

Though it hadn't been long since Wallace was brought into emergency, Harry couldn't wait. "I'm going to see if I can find the doctor."

He asked the admittance attendant about Wallace's condition. The guy wearing blue scrubs dotted with cartoon penguins said, "Just a sec." He got out of his chair and went into the back room. He returned. "They're still running tests. You're going to ~~have to chill.~~ A couple of hours."

Harry rejoined Mac. "More tests. I think that's good news. But we're going to have to wait."

An hour later, after worrying about everything possible without finding any solutions, Harry got up. He walked the hallways and asked any doctor who would speak to him if they knew about Wallace's condition. No answers. He returned to the waiting room. The two men sat silently, exchanging reassuring glances, answering emails, and scrolling.

It had been close to another hour.

"I can't stand this," Harry said and tugged at Mac's arm. "Come on. Howitzers don't wait." He noticed a petite female doctor, in her late fifties, enter the waiting room. "Are you Mr. Howitzer?"

"Yes." Harry could tell she was checking his battered face. "I'm okay." He flattened down his hair. "If you can believe it, I survived a plane crash."

"Oh dear, when it rains, it pours." The doctor's serious expression behind her thick black glasses was not reassuring. "Come with me."

Harry knew something was wrong. Good news was not shared in a private room. "Are we going to see Wallace?"

"This way." She led them into a closet-sized, white-walled room. Two chairs and a table were shoved in a corner. She closed the door and put her glasses on her head. "We ran every test and thought we had Wallace going in the right direction."

Harry's stomach dropped. "But what?"

"He had a stroke. It was bad timing."

"Timing?" *What in the world was she talking about*?

"Wallace didn't tell you?"

"Tell me what?" Harry asked.

"I spoke to his doctor. Dr. Bradley informed me that Wallace had been diagnosed with an eighty-percent blocked artery in his neck. He was put on blood thinners. A stent was planned to be inserted in a couple of weeks. He mentioned November 16."

Harry turned to Mac. "Did you know about this?"

"No." Mac wiped his cheeks. "What the eff?"

"He's on life support, Harry," the doctor said. "He's in a deep coma."

"No chance for recovery?" Harry asked.

"No, unfortunately. Do you have his living will? You need to review it."

"Living will?" Harry asked. He remembered that Wallace had updated his estate plans about five years ago. The legal document dictated medical and end-of-life care if someone was incapacitated. "I'll find it. But can we see him?" He glanced over to Mac, who was trying to temper his emotions. "Hang in there, son."

"Give us half an hour. We are moving him to a more comfortable room." The doctor opened the door. "Your father is lovely. Such a respected man in the community. And so generous to the hospital."

"Thank you," Harry said. Wallace's efforts and donations to the Vancouver General Hospital were in memory of his mom, Barbara, who had died from cancer years ago. In the main building, his generosity had led to the creation of a dedicated Howitzer hallway.

The doctor shut the door behind her. Harry and Mac shared a deep look of sorrow and grabbed each other. Harry wiped his

son's eyes, rubbed his back, and felt his body shaking. "Hey, buddy. It's okay. At least he's not in any pain."

"But if I'd been there earlier, maybe I could have saved him."

"Don't go there. You did your best." There was nothing Harry could say to make Mac feel better. The family legacy was about to transition to a new era. "He was clear with his direction, but I need to get the document. Do you want to come to the house with me?"

Mac broke down. In a shaky voice, he said, "No, I want to be with Granddad."

"I'll be quick." As Harry drove to the Tudor, he tried to organize his thoughts and the reality of what was happening. Wallace needed a stent. Why didn't he tell anyone? Those were his father's old-school ways—keep matters personal, private. *~~Could his health condition have~~ caused him to become so miserable?*

Bad things do happen in threes.

Back at the Tudor, he jumped out of the car, raced down the driveway, and, once inside, headed straight for the library, where Wallace kept his personal documents. He searched through files in the bottom drawer of the desk. Nothing. The safe. That was where it was. The safe was hidden in the wall, like Sceptre's office in Stewart~~. The~~ bookcase ~~was~~ on rails. Harry slid it over and popped open the door. The code. Yes, ~~one, nine, three, nine.~~ The year Wallace was born.

The ~~case~~ was meticulously organized, as any good geologist would have done. After looking through dozens of documents, he found nothing. He fished further to the top shelf and pulled out three envelopes. The top one was titled:

WALLACE EASTON HOWITZER. LAST WILL.

A second envelope attached was titled:

PRIVATE AND CONFIDENTIAL FOR HARRY HOWITZER ONLY. TO BE OPENED FOLLOWING MY DEATH.

What was that about? Later.

The third envelope:

WALLACE EASTON HOWITZER. LIVING WILL.

The other two documents were returned to the safe. When Harry sat in the wingback chair, he smelled a faint scent of Wallace's cologne. Musky with a nose of nutmeg spice. The document outlined his wishes. Harry was to be appointed the trustee. Wallace had no desire to live on any type of life support. He'd had a good life and wanted to die with dignity.

The decision had been made. Harry took a moment to relive late nights sitting in the regal room by the fire with his dad, having lively, opinionated conversations about the gold business and life according to Wallace. Harry reflected again on Wallace's behaviour the night before. The father Harry had admired and looked to for advice and support had slowly faded.

Age had caught up with Wallace, and he ~~had been~~ trying to remain a relevant contributor to Sceptre. Harry shook his head, disappointed in himself.

~~The Tudor was locked, and Harry~~ raced back to his car. He hustled to the hospital, running through stop signs and red lights. Ten minutes later, the Ferrari roared up to the parking lot and manoeuvred into an open spot. He waved off the parking attendant. "Give me a ticket."

The hospital hallway smelled like antiseptic and urine. Mac had texted him Wallace's room number. Harry stood at the door, holding the living will. To see his father's frail body hooked up to a machine hit him hard. "Damn it."

Mac sat next to his granddad, gripping his bony white hand. "Granddad, I'll carry on, and I will find the next motherlode."

Harry pulled up and sat down in a cold metal chair next to Wallace's hospital bed. The white sheets and blue blanket were tucked up to his neck. His father was pale, deathly white. "So?"

"Granddad doesn't seem to be responding. Did you find it?"

"I did. His directives were clear. And I spoke to the doctor." He tapped Mac's knee. "She got all the results from the tests. No options."

"Are you sure? Should we get another opinion?"

"That's what I've asked her to do. She said she'd consult a colleague. But I'm not hopeful. Still, we do have time with him."

Mac and Harry tried to keep a positive tone for the next few hours, taking turns sharing stories with Wallace. Harry chatted about their fly-fishing trips to exotic locations and lodges. Mac shared his stories about being in the field, rock hunting. He reminisced about one of their trips to the Atlin site, where they were being stalked by a cougar. Mac recalled,

detail by detail, how frightened he had been. His voice rose as he described how brave and cool Wallace was when he had yelled and stared the cat in the eyes, scaring the cougar off. "You were savage, Granddad."

Wallace lay still.

The doctor knocked on the door. Her face was grim. No words were required.

"I can't watch him die. I'm outta here." Mac leaned over and kissed him on the cheek. "Love you, Granddad." As he left the room, he turned to Harry. His youthful energy had dissipated. "I'll be outside."

"I guess this is it?" Harry asked.

"Yes," the doctor confirmed. "He can't breathe on his own. There's nothing else we can do. I'll give you a minute."

At that moment, the reality of the frantic morning hit home. There would not be a tomorrow with his father. He leaned toward the still body and lowered his voice.

"Dad, thank you for giving Mac and me an amazing life. Listen, you can count on me. And when you take a break from your fly-fishing stream, I want you to send me a sign that you recognize that I've made Sceptre a success, because I'm going to. I'm going to get out of this mess. Mac and I are going to turn Sceptre around and make another fortune." There was nothing else he could say except, "Love you. See you on the other side, but not for a long while."

He touched the soft, wrinkled skin on his father's face and kissed his forehead. He squeezed his hand tight for the last time and signalled to the doctor, who had given him his privacy.

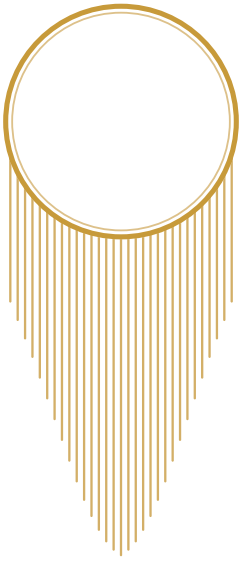
"Okay, he's ready."

In the hallway, he watched the machine lights fade to black. Wallace Easton Howitzer's legacy was finished.

But then a wave passed—a strange guilty sense of relief for Harry.

No, that was the wrong word.

The word was freedom.



CHAPTER 14

The cavernous Tudor seemed different. Gutted. In a single moment, Wallace's commanding presence had vanished. Osler raced through the rooms, searching for his roommate. Mac stood at the library door and remained quiet.

"I'm sorry this day is tough for you, son."

"I'll be okay," Mac said, shutting the door. "Two ~~o'clock.~~ I don't care. I'm going to take a nap." He started to head upstairs to the room he'd slept in since he was a tyke.

"You go, but come here first." Harry hugged his son's vibrating body. "Get some sleep. We have our hands full with Sceptre, but today is about Wallace."

A clanging sound resonated from downstairs.

"~~Is that~~ from the wine cellar?" Mac asked and turned his attention to the noise.

"It must be the hot water pipes. I'll go check it out."

"Okay. Wake me up at cocktail hour."

"Will do." Mac's hollow voice hit Harry hard. "It's going to take some time."

"~~All good.~~" Mac grabbed Osler, nestled him under his arm, and headed upstairs.

Harry opened the door to the basement and turned on the dim light.

The narrow wooden stairs led him to the cooled room that kept Wallace's wine collection organized by country, region, and year. There were no pipe leaks, but the recognizable musty damp smell was present. Beside the cellar were two brand-new hot water tanks humming quietly. No issues.

A piercing jab stabbed his forehead. The electrifying pain shot through his body.

"Father is gone?" a raspy voice asked.

Harry jumped. "Father? What the hell are you doing here?" Sweat started to bead from the nape of his neck.

"My Howitzer plan is working," Pookmis said, puckering and licking his lips.

"You can't be in this house." Pookmis's presence in the Tudor dragged Harry back to the terrifying night in the longhouse.

"Wrong. Don't tell me what to do."

The ghost flung the wine cellar door open and slammed it shut repeatedly. The banging echoed through the Tudor.

"Stop, listen to me," Harry ordered. "Calm down."

"I am calm, Gold Man."

There was only one thing in Harry's life he couldn't replace. "Whatever you are trying to do, you leave my son out of your bullshit."

"He suffered today," Pookmis said with a quick, devious smile. "I have more important things to do."

"Meaning what?"

"You'll see."

Harry ran up the stairs, slammed the basement door, and beelined into the living room. His hand trembled as he shot back a glass of bourbon. The thing was real. And it was living in the Tudor. His phone rang.

"This is Harry Howitzer," he said in a jittery voice.

"Mr. Howitzer. This is Sergeant Nightingale. You were calling me earlier this morning."

"Yes, are you familiar with my situation, Sceptre Gold? That stream on our property has been sabotaged. By whom, I have no idea. And Hunt is on a special assignment? How do I get action here? I need to inform my shareholders." He stopped, realizing he sounded unhinged—because he was.

"Slow down, Mr. Howitzer. Let's start over. I'm familiar with the case."

"Yes, let me start over. You must open a criminal case. Hunt is avoiding us and the incident."

"I understand your concern. Officer Hunt has numerous responsibilities; as the only officer in the Stewart area, he faces life-or-death situations at any time. Mr. Howitzer, as important

as your mining incident is, it had to take a back seat for other reasons. He has priorities to manage."

What kind of answer was that? "Officer Nightingale, by law, I need to publicly disclose the company's status on this situation in a timely fashion." By this time, the markets were closed, but he needed to get the information out before they opened in the morning. "Sergeant? Will you help me out here?"

"I'm fine with you putting out a release. Keep it simple, stating the RCMP is investigating it as a criminal case."

"That's terrific news because we put that statement out yesterday. Then Hunt told Mac and my father he changed his mind." *It was the only good news of the day*. "But can you tell me what's going on? Hunt isn't around, according to my sources."

"Mr. Howitzer, let me reassure you we will deal with your concerns."

"I'm confused about how this is being managed. I'm under a hell of a lot of pressure for answers."

"I'm taking full responsibility. I understand the importance Sceptre holds for our northern residents' livelihood. I know you have an independent witness."

"You do?"

"Yes, April Johnson. She was in my office a couple of hours ago. I obtained all the necessary details. ~~Based~~ on her recall of the evidence, there's no doubt it's sabotage. ~~And h~~er information will be our starting point."

"Thank you. It's been a week. And this morning, my father died unexpectedly. I'll need a couple days to get ~~it~~ together."

"Sorry for your loss."

"Thank you." Harry realized he'd be hearing those words often. "Can you send me a case file for my records for legal?" He threw his head back. *Thank God for April.*

"I didn't know your father, but his reputation was legendary. Yes, ~~I will~~ send ~~this~~ to you by the end of the day. Please get back to me soon, and we can discuss the next steps. I'll take care of this."

"Thank you." It sounded like April wouldn't take no for an answer, but he'd take the excellent news. The cell rang again. "Now what?"

"Mr. Howitzer, Jeffrey McIntosh. McIntosh Funeral Services. ~~Sorry~~ for your loss. My father knew Wallace. The hospital called. ~~Your~~ father will arrive here by five tonight. There is paperwork for you to prepare."

"~~Jeffrey, tomorrow morning, I'll be at your office at eight o'clock to start the work~~ and make the announcements. Bye for now."

"See you then. Take care, Harry. Cherish the memories."

"You bet, bye for now."

Bit of an odd guy. What kind of family owns a funeral home? To own a gold mine was crazy enough. Harry checked his texts. There was a message from Cinnamon.

DINNER, ETC. TONIGHT? ☺

Sex was the last thing on his mind.

SOUNDS FUN. I'LL CALL YOU IN A WEEK. SOMETHING MAJOR HAS COME UP. THANKS FOR THINKING OF ME! H

He grabbed his glass and ~~the~~ bottle and went to the library. The air was chilly; he made a roaring fire and sat down in ~~his~~ chair.

Now, Harry Howitzer was the go-to guy, and he knew he wasn't close to ~~100~~ percent. He had to get it together and start making a mental list of to-dos for tomorrow. His eyes drifted to the bookcase. The letter. It was probably instructions from Wallace about what he wanted for his funeral service. That would be a good start.

The safe cracked open, and he found what he was looking for. PRIVATE AND CONFIDENTIAL FOR HARRY HOWITZER ONLY. TO BE OPENED FOLLOWING MY DEATH.

He tore open the top of the sealed envelope and discovered a multiple-page letter in his father's handwriting, along with an old photo and a yellowed piece of paper folded in four. Curiosity set in. He sat down by the fire and began to read his father's message.

Dear Harry,

I've lived a blessed life.

I don't know how many years I have left, but my conscience has been wearing on me. The truth about the Howitzers should be known.

One February morning, my life changed after your grandfather, Easton, died. He turned out to be a fraud and a murderer.

"What the hell?" Wallace's letter was written five years ago. *What was he talking about?* Harry quickly turned the page. He remembered when Easton had died. The~~re were~~ closed-door

conversations between his parents. Wallace turned miserable, and his mother, Barbara, drank more gin. Harry continued to read.

In the ~~1960~~s, Easton was a struggling gold prospector. He was a womanizer and a drinker who hung out at the wild Howe Street water holes. Sceptre was listed on the Vancouver Stock Exchange, generating little interest due to dismal results. Easton was an over-promise, never-deliver kind of man.

Harry reread the first lines. The gossip at the club was true.

Easton hired a brilliant geologist from China named Sying Liu, who arrived in Canada in search of a better life.

The following is my understanding of how a series of tragic incidents happened.

Easton sent Sying to Stewart to evaluate his claims for Sceptre. Sying spent months up there and concluded the properties Easton had staked were worthless. My father refused his analysis and told him to rework the plan. But during his time up north, Sying discovered an area he thought had better potential and shared his findings with Easton. With a twist, though: he wanted to be Easton's partner. But Easton, whose ego was bigger than his oversized waistline, wasn't interested in any partnership.

Sying went north for the second time and a month later showed up in Vancouver with a bag of rocks and nuggets the size of golf balls. Those rocks were from Sying's claim and loaded with veins of gold. Easton heard the news and recognized a motherlode. He promptly offered Sying money for the property. Sying refused.

Weeks later, the young Chinese prospector was found dead in the alley behind the Hotel Vancouver, stabbed to death.

The police quickly closed the unsolved murder case. Easton claimed the properties a week after the claims expired from Sying's ownership.

Harry leaned back in his chair and stared at the ceiling. "Is this a joke?" He needed to finish the letter.

About ten years after the murder, Easton died. It was a heart attack—no doubt from too much excess. In the library safe, he left a letter to me, like the one I'm leaving you, revealing he murdered Sying and appropriated the claim for Sceptre. I guess Easton had some kind of conscience. By then, we had completed the plan for the mine with financing in hand. We ~~had~~ worked for years securing the necessary permits, approvals, and financiers. I shamefully admit that I continued to develop Sying's claim under the Sceptre name, which made our family's fortune. Sceptre's mine was rightfully never ours.

Harry turned to the last page.

Sceptre needs a restart without the ghost of Easton and me. At times, I wasn't a good man or husband, but the dream of success drove me, and if I could admit it boldly, I loved the limelight that Sceptre brought to my family and me. I'm not sure that's a justification for living the lies I did.

Now it's up to you and Mac to discover the next motherlode. Make a difference, make the Howitzers whole and proud.

Easy on your bourbon, but more importantly, don't be like your grandfather and me. Be true to yourself. And take care of my grandson, the best geologist and my best friend.

With love,

Your Father

Harry inspected the photo from the envelope. A man he assumed was Sying was holding a pick next to a stream. He was husky and tall, with thin lips and a broad nose. Long black bangs hung over his distinctive furrowed brow and deep-set dark eyes. His weathered appearance suggested he'd lived a tough life.

The tattered piece of paper Harry pulled out from the envelope was Easton's letter. After reading it, he sat motionless. For fifty-odd years, Wallace Howitzer had lived a life of lies. He logged on to the desk computer and googled Sceptre. After about ten minutes, he found nothing to support Wallace's story. That was what he'd expected, but he'd had to check. Easton's sordid history went too far back to be documented online. There was the BC government website where he could search the history of Sceptre's claims. He found the website. It was inoperative for another three days due to upgrades. Last, he typed in "Sying Liu murder Vancouver"—there it was. A Vancouver Police Department cold case.

In his mind, his father had always been a straight-up man—that was the standard Wallace preached, and the one he'd told Harry to live by. But the truth was, Wallace and Easton were crooks.

After putting the envelope stuffed with the letters and photo back in the safe, he walked across the yard to the front gate and tried April's cell number.

"Hello?"

"Where are you, April?"

"Prince Rupert. Did you talk to Sergeant Nightingale?"

"I did. Thank you. He's thrown me and Sceptre a lifeline." The sharp winds started to blow. Harry contemplated how to deliver the news to April.

"Hunt is still MIA. That low-life. The sergeant wouldn't tell me anything about his whereabouts. What's the matter, Harry? You sound off."

"Wallace had a stroke and died this morning." He waited for an empathetic response. "April?"

"I feel for you, Harry." Her voice was firm. "With Wallace gone, this is your opportunity to make your life your own—for the first time. It's the best thing that ever happened to you."

That was a twist of advice Harry hadn't expected. He wanted sympathy. "April, he was my father."

"Wallace lived his privileged life without any guilt or conscience. That man was wretched."

Harry wanted to agree with April, but a wave of guilt hit him. He'd lied to April about Stewart shutting down. And he couldn't tell her about Wallace's confession ~~because it was a~~ mind-blowing scandal. The truth about Sceptre would have to remain a Howitzer secret. But there was something else to share.

"April, at the longhouse . . ."

"Yes? Tell me."

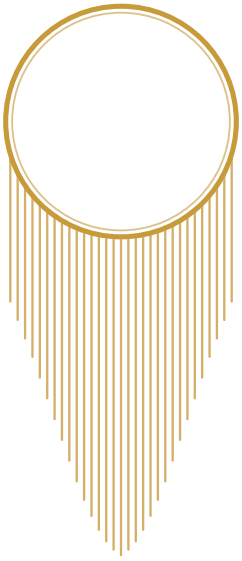
"~~This thing called Pookmis~~ showed up and went wild on me until I was rescued. A total lunatic. April—~~a~~ ghost. He told me he carried an omen. And I would suffer." His scar started to throb. "Scariest thing in my life. Even more than crashing my plane. But it gets worse. ~~He's~~ in ~~the basement.~~ And he's

not leaving." He cleared the frog in his throat. "Am I losing my mind?"

"I only know of the legend of Pookmis and his harm. I need to talk to other Elders. I'll call you back. Goodbye."

April's cold response was not what he wanted to hear. Once again, he was waiting for her help.

The day delivered devastating revelations. The moral decay of Easton and Wallace was staggering. The Howitzers' grand life was built on nothing but deceit and lies.



CHAPTER 15

SATURDAY

Harry awoke, startled by the sounds of a choking rasp. When he opened his eyes, Pookmis's chalky white figure floated above the chair beside his bed.

He became mesmerized by the ghost's bulging, pupilless eyes.

"What are you going to say at Father's service? It's today."

"What?" Harry asked, shaking his head to wake himself. "Father?"

"Yes, Father."

The ghost's cryptic message made no sense. Harry waited a moment, then rolled out of bed, and peered around the door.

After the phantom left his room, he glided up the staircase to the third floor, leaving a trail of eagle feathers that had fallen from his messy hair.

Harry thought he smelled bad, but he had nothing on Pookmis. The bedroom reeked of the phantom's rotten fish odour. He opened the window and sucked in the fall air. At least the rain stayed away for the dreaded day.

It was Saturday, four days after Wallace had died. There would be no pomp or party. It was an early afternoon burial at the Howitzers' family plot. There were questions about why the service was so soon. But it was because his father was a phony, and Harry didn't want to pretend anymore. The service would give Harry and Mac closure and the opportunity to drive on—Wallace-free.

The unresolved debacle with Sceptre continued. He hadn't heard a thing from Hunt or Nightingale. The market had not forgotten the incident. Sceptre's stock had stopped free-falling, but languished around an abysmal $2.75 at Friday's close, and Mac had made no progress with convincing the Taku Nation that Sceptre was a responsible corporate citizen.

After a hot shower, he took a moment to check himself out. The bathroom mirror showed a haggard man. The tender, puffy stitch marks didn't help. He had no intention of discussing the incident with anyone. He covered the cut with a bandage and combed his hair to cover it. He leaned further into the mirror. No, there were no quick fixes for his deep crow's feet.

He dressed in a conservative black suit, a navy-blue tie, and black leather lace-up shoes.

It was noon, and he couldn't wait for the day to be over. Mac would be here any minute. In the library, he found Osler curled up in Wallace's chair. "Hey, guy."

He joined the Westie for a moment to gather his thoughts about what to say at the service. Best to keep his words simple—*a long-time successful businessman whose life was built on myriad lies*. No, he would have to lie. He wrote down half a dozen points and stuffed the paper in his pants pocket.

Osler awoke with the noise of the front door slamming shut. He growled, then wagged his tail.

"Dad?"

"In the library," Harry called out.

Mac's skin was pasty, but his green eyes were strangely fiery as he tucked his thick, auburn hair behind his ears. The dark wool coat over his navy suit gave him the appearance of a fine-looking adult. His Queen's University tie was knotted like Harry had taught him on his first day of private school. Mac had a newspaper in his fist.

"Look at this." He handed his father the paper. "When is this going to end?"

In the *Vancouver Sun*'s business section, the front page ran an article by a business journalist known for his jaded outlook on the major local players in the stock market. The title read, "THE LAST NUGGETS OF THE HOWITZER LEGACY."

Harry read the article aloud.

"The Howitzers have had a run of bad luck, and the markets are wondering how long the ~~mining's~~ golden reputation will last." The short, sharp opinion piece examined the mystery of

salmon poisoning at the mine site and Wallace's sudden death. The article questioned whether the next generations could bring Sceptre back to life.

Harry continued with the last paragraph. "Harry and Mac Howitzer's mountain of gold is a daunting climb now that the family icon is gone—the brains of Sceptre."

Harry threw the paper on the desk. "That idiot has some nerve talking about us like that. ~~He hides~~ behind his pen and paper, hurling insults without any facts. The guy knows nothing about mining or you and me, Mac."

"Like, why would he write this? What's the point? It's wrong."

"To sell papers. Gossip. I'd call him and tell him off, but that would provoke more bad press for us. Such a dick. Forget him, Mac." His phone rang. "Son, I have to get this. Our ride should be here. I'll see you outside in a minute."

"We can't be late, Dad."

"We won't." Harry watched Mac, with his head down, walk toward the road. "April, good to hear from you. How are you?"

"Harry, I'm worried. We need to talk about Pookmis."

"This morning, ~~he~~ was in my bedroom calling Wallace—get this—Father."

"Harry, Wallace was his father."

"April, come on, what are you talking about?" Harry sat back down on the chair. Osler jumped off and left the room with another growl.

"You remember Benji, my nephew, ~~who recently died in a fishing accident?~~"

"Yes." Harry had never met him.

"Benji died in a commercial fishing accident, violently, on the Hecate. The only thing left of him, or his boat, was a couple of pieces of metal washed up on Princess Royal Island."

"Princess Royal Island?" *That* was an odd coincidence. He held his forehead, feeling the ache. "Tell me more."

"Wallace was Benji's father. He and Spring were lovers and had Benji together over forty years ago."

"His father? Are you kidding me?" Harry gripped his cellphone. At that time, Harry was in his early twenties. His mom and dad seemed fine, but they always tried to feign being the perfect upper-crust couple. "~~Spring Johnson, your sister, was Benji's mom and Wallace's girlfriend~~?"

"Yes, until Spring died twenty years ago. And Wallace never gave either of them a dime. They lived penniless, and he didn't care, that cheapskate."

"My God." Harry's voice cracked. Wallace was a tough ass, but, in his mind, never a womanizer. "I don't need to hear anything more about my dad."

"You *need* to hear the truth. Spring was sweet, but a troubled woman. She loved Wallace, and he took advantage of it."

"April, since Wallace died, I've discovered he was a man I never really knew. And I don't like him." Now he understood the acrimonious relationship between April and Wallace. "But ~~then how does Benji become this~~ Pookmis thing?"

"Benji was in debt his whole life." April's voice started to break up. "Big talker, big plans, but nothing ever worked out for him. Let me start by giving you his background. A fisherman

must respect the ocean and live by the principle 'take only what you need.'"

"Okay? What am I missing, April?"

"We have to assume Benji encountered a run of salmon and took more than his limit. A wrongdoing. So, the spirits punished him for his greediness: they dragged him to the afterlife and cast him as Pookmis, a malevolent, drowned spirit. That is the legend."

"You're saying Pookmis *is* Benji. In some kind of weird afterlife?" ~~*The story sounded*~~ *bloody absurd.*

"Yes. Not weird, Harry. Ominous." Her tone sharpened. "The omen he carries is deadly."

"This must be superstition." Even as he said the words, he couldn't ignore the unsettling encounters he'd had with the ghost. His phone pinged—it was Mac.

WE ARE LATE

"I've got to go. We'll finish this tomorrow."

"Harry, you don't understand how serious this is. He's already moved into your house. I have to call the Shaman right away."

"A Shaman? Please explain."

"He's a healer and our spiritual leader. You need help, Harry. If I don't fully understand these spirits myself . . . how could you?"

"April." She hung up before Harry could respond. ~~That conversation~~ was staggering. Wallace Howitzer had an illegitimate child.

Before he closed the front door, he called out to Osler. The Westie did not come, but ~~an~~ eagle feather drifted by his head and settled on the hardwood floor.

Harry locked up and walked quickly to the SUV. "~~Hello, son.~~"

"Dad, we are going to be late." He looked his father in the eye. "You aren't yourself these days." Mac opened the back door.

"I'm fine." Harry patted his son on the back. They settled into their ride.

It was time to get this service over with.



The limo wove through the large crowd, drifting along the narrow lane toward the hill at the Mountain View Cemetery. Game on. Harry had anticipated the affair would be small, but it wasn't. There had to be at least a hundred people, maybe more. Wallace was quite the operator—ruthless, but disguised as charming.

The service was an odd sense of personal exposure. Harry didn't like being the centre of attention. Death was private to him, not a celebration or recognition. But it was what his father had requested.

Both father and son exited the vehicle. A tall man wearing an ankle-length, tan raincoat passed by Harry with his head down. He tried to get a look at the hooded man, but the visitor's quick pace made it impossible. The guy seemed out of place.

The Howitzers were greeted by dozens of well-wishers as they made their way to the burial site. People attempted to ask about the plane crash, but Harry's response was "Today's about Wallace."

People filled the rows of wooden chairs, and the overflow of attendees stood behind them. Bouquets of giant white lilies were piled and draped over Wallace's polished black coffin. The podium next to the casket was flanked by tall vases of white orchids sitting on five-foot-tall wrought-iron stands. Wallace's admirers shared sad smiles and whispered compliments as they waited for the service to begin.

Harry scanned the crowd. Politicians, business leaders, neighbours, club members, and shareholders waited to pay their respects. Reverend Sullivan stepped up to the podium. The clergyman described Wallace as a respected man and citizen in a ringing Irish accent. Harry wondered if the reverend knew the truth about the Howitzers. He and Wallace had spent years pontificating over bottles of whiskey in the library. Could it be that the two closest people to Wallace were the only ones who didn't know the truth?

The reverend introduced Mac. The tall, strong grandson latched onto the sides of the podium as he spoke about his camping trips with his Granddad. All day long, they'd scout for rocks. "Gold rocks," he laughed and described how his grandfather had taught him real-world geology. "I hope one day to be as good as Granddad." He continued his speech, sharing amusing incidents about their competitive nature on the tennis

court and their perpetual game of gin rummy. "Rest in peace, Granddad." Mac's emotional tribute touched the crowd.

Harry stepped up and patted his son's back affectionately. He recognized and thanked the guests for attending. He dug out his notes.

"Wallace created a legacy for the Howitzers. As a young geologist, he built one of the best junior gold-producing mines in British Columbia," Harry said. A flash of fear interrupted his train of thought. *What if the entire town of Stewart knew Wallace had an illegitimate son with Spring*? He stopped, took a moment, and then continued.

"But business aside, his motto was that the truth could never be as bad as the lie," Harry continued, feeding the crowd untruths about his father until the rain began spitting. The drops smudged Harry's notes. He'd have to wing the rest of his speech, so, rather than more flattery, he stuck to what was actually true.

Harry looked directly into the crowd. "There was a generous side to Wallace. For decades, Dad donated hundreds of thousands of dollars to the Vancouver Chinatown Foundation, Dr. Sun Yat-Sen Gardens, and S.U.C.C.E.S.S. Wallace believed charitable giving was part of the Howitzer legacy." It was guilt money, but he couldn't tell that part of the story. "Mac and I will ensure that generosity continues."

Harry scanned the crowd. There was that hooded guy in the raincoat again, standing in the back. His arms were crossed, fists clenched. *Who ~~was he~~?*

"Thank you for coming today and being with Mac and me to say goodbye to Wallace Easton Howitzer."

The five attendants lowered the black lacquer coffin into the cold ground with a heavy clunk. The Howitzers tossed a couple of shovels of dirt each into the pit while a sombre-faced bagpipe player piped "Danny Boy." It was a perfect tribute to an imperfect man.

After the Lord's Prayer, Reverend Sullivan ended the service. The drizzle stopped, and the crowd broke up. The skies darkened, and the air continued to chill.

Trudy was the first person to find Harry. Her shoulder-length grey hair was wildly curly, and her squinty blue eyes complemented her creamy olive skin. Their friendship began when they were kids. They were cottage neighbours on Bowen Island. On summer vacations, they'd build tree forts and cruise the shores in their little runabouts. Her family, the Hamiltons, were generations of Vancouver developers who owned large swaths of Westside property. Trudy never had to worry about money. They embraced in a long hug.

"Look at you. So colourful. I've missed you," Harry said.

"Oh, Harry. How are you?" she asked. "I can't believe what you've gone through."

"Me neither," he said. Trudy's friendship meant a great deal to him. They spoke daily, and he shared his troubles and chaos: the plane crash, Wallace's death, and the mess he was in with Sceptre. But he couldn't tell her the complete truth, especially about Pookmis. She would have thought he had lost his mind. That burden he left for April.

"You're going to be okay. You're a Howitzer." As she gripped his hand, she said, "The service was perfect. Like Wallace." Her calculated laugh had meaning. "You know, all our dads were."

"They sure were." Harry rolled his eyes.

Trudy grabbed his pinky. "Come by the café Monday morning before the market opens. And get some sleep."

"See you soon."

On her way out, Trudy stopped to greet Mac and gave him a big hug. He knew she was giving his son encouraging words. It was time to go. He turned when he heard his name.

"Cinnamon?"

"Hi, I came to pay my respects, even though I didn't know your dad. I didn't want to interrupt your conversation with that woman." Cinnamon glanced over at Mac and Trudy. She tightened her burgundy scarf that matched her long wool coat. "I guess you're busy for the rest of the day?" Her eyes widened. "What happened to you?"

"Long story. I don't want to talk about it." Harry didn't have the energy to deal with Cinnamon today.

"Are you all right? Were you in an accident?" she asked, her eyes still big and round, staring at his face.

"You could say that—my plane."

"What?" She grabbed Harry's arm. "Are you kidding me?"

"No, I'm not. I'm sorry, ~~we will~~ talk later."

"I'm feeling that me being here is awkward." She checked out Trudy again. "When can I see you?"

"Soon, Cinnamon."

She continued to hold on to his arm. "I'm glad you're okay."

"Kind of okay." Harry shook off her hand. "I have to go." Cinnamon attending the service was inappropriate. They were too new. She left as fast as she'd arrived. He waved over Mac.

"Dad, I want to leave."

"You and me both. Let's go."

"Harry."

~~But not yet. There was one last obstacle.~~

Harry knew that distinct husky, gruff voice. He'd gone out of his way to stay clear of Rock Weston. But Rock was a business-first kind of guy, being the chairman of Sceptre, and impossible to dodge.

"Hey, Rock."

"I'm going to miss Wallace." Rock shook Mac's and Harry's hand. His salt-and-pepper eyebrows rose as he directed his attention to Mac. "Got those Atlin test results, Mac?"

"Let me check." Mac fussed with his dress coat pocket and pulled out his phone. After a quick scroll, he said, "No, but soon."

"It's the only thing that's going to save Sceptre. But you know that, don't you, Mac and Harry?"

"Understand. Thanks for coming today. Dad, I'll be in the limo."

Like a wolf, Rock was never still, and when it was the right time, he pounced. Harry understood his son's angst, but that was the mining business, and Mac had better get used to it.

"That salmon thing is a distraction and a problem for us, Harry. Any update on that?" Rock sized up Harry. "You look like you've had a tough time. Skinny and tired, like a drowned rat. The plane crash did you no favours." Rock buttoned up his

heavy coat and flipped up his collar. Someone in the distance caught his eye for a moment, and then his gaze returned to a laser focus on Harry. "Now that nasty article in the *Vancouver Sun* today."

"That idiot is a sensationalist." The last thing Harry wanted to do was have this conversation.

"Uh-huh. I'm coming over tomorrow afternoon—four o'clock for a glass of wine or two. Time for a chat. Let's drink a couple of Wallace's best bottles."

"Sure, see you at four tomorrow." *What the hell did Rock want*?

Harry was done. He had no interest in talking to one more person. ~~He shut the limo door.~~ Mac sat slumped, a blank look on his face, staring out the back-seat window. "Son?" Mac turned to his father with bloodshot eyes. "Hey, it's the life we live. You need to stand up and deal with it."

"I know, having a moment." Mac shook himself. "I'm good."

"Your Granddad would have been proud." It was time for his son to refocus and set aside his emotions. "Let's move on."

"Dad, the Atlin results will make or break us. The pressure is tough to deal with, especially now that Granddad isn't here."

"And you are going to deliver." Mac's grieving for Wallace wasn't deserved. "Let's go out for dinner. Italian?"

"I'd like that." Mac sat up straight and gave his father a grateful smile. "Thanks, Dad."



Harry was up early, took a long walk with Osler, and tried to connect with April. No luck. The conversation about Benji and Pookmis was confusing. But for once, even April didn't have all the answers.

After filing more Wallace estate paperwork, ~~it was early Sunday afternoon,~~ and Rock would be arriving soon. Harry knew he'd have to perform as CEO, because Rock would have no problem firing his ass if he didn't. That was his reputation—loyal but formidable. And his résumé read like one of the best miners in the gold business.

The gate buzzed. Harry waited for his guest at the door. "Come on in."

"Hello, Harry." Rock handed him his heavy coat. He was sporting a white starched dress shirt, dark slacks, and tan brogues. "~~Not~~ much sleep last night either?"

"No, but I'm good." Harry didn't want to appear anything but competent. "We haven't talked about my plane crash, and I don't need to. I want you to know I'm in decent shape."

"If you say so," Rock said, tone-deaf to Harry's comments, and turned his attention to the foyer walls, admiring Wallace's art. "Every time I come for a visit, I see something new. I don't know a better collection."

"That was Wallace." The man completely lacked empathy.

Maybe that was why he was so wealthy.

"This house is a beauty. Are you planning to move in?" Rock asked. Harry *had* decided to move into the Tudor and sell his home. He loved the old mansion despite the history.

"Lots of ideas for change, but Sceptre is top of mind." Harry tugged at the neck of his dark wool sweater and scratched himself. Since the accident, his skin had been unbearably irritated. "I opened a 2009 Figeac. Let's go to the living room." He motioned Rock into the tony space and poured the decanted wine into two cut bulbous crystal glasses.

"A 2009 Figeac." Rock sank into the sofa, his knees spread wide. "Wallace knew his wines," he said, looking around the spearmint-coloured living room filled with soft traditional sofas and more of Wallace's fine art. Osler waltzed into the room. "Want to sell the cellar? I'll pay you top dollar."

"Nice try," Harry smirked and tasted the wine. A subtle berry-spice profile was well presented in the Bordeaux. "How's business for you?"

"~~You know, Harry, I can't spend it.~~ Hello, Osler." The Westie greeted the guest by rubbing the side of his face against Rock's pant leg.

The man was never shy about touting his success. Harry settled across from Rock in a velvet club chair.

"I admired Wallace's approach to getting what he wanted for Sceptre. Ruthless when necessary. And a hell of a family man." He laughed loudly. "Unorthodox at times."

"Unorthodox?" Harry waited for the next bomb. ~~*Had Wallace shared his relationship with Spring*~~?

"I never speak ill of the dead." Rock kind of chuckled. "The past couple of weeks in the Howitzer world makes no sense. Do you agree?" Without a response from Harry, Rock continued. "Who the hell would poison a stream other than to gut Sceptre?"

Harry stared down at his glass, swirling his red wine. He had no good response.

"Who have you guys pissed off?" Osler hopped on the couch and rested his head on Rock's lap. The big man softly patted his fluffy back.

"No one. Absolutely no one." Harry leaned forward in his chair. His stomach tightened.

"Harry, being chair of the board, my reputation is at stake. Something else is going to drop, and I don't want it on my watch. And I like that Atlin deal we're working on. It's ours. And it appears it could be our next motherlode."

"Let's hope so. Rock, I'm doing my best with the RCMP." He noticed how Rock leaned further into the sofa, spreading his knees wider, owning the room. The ultimate alpha.

"The RCMP is useless. I'll be dead before they find out anything." He gave the Westie another scratch.

"I'm all over this. I'll get the answers we need, and I'll get the confidence back in the market." Rock's words weren't wrong. Harry didn't have a clue how he was going to fix his problem.

"Millions of shares have been traded. Who's the buyer? It's not me," Rock said. "I have a suggestion. Someone who can help you solve your problem. His name is Cooperhawk."

"Like the bird?" Harry topped up their glasses. The way this conversation was going, the second bottle of wine decanting on the side table was going to be drunk.

"One word. Cooperhawk." Rock's voice lowered, as if he were sharing a secret. "He solved a major problem for me. Fast. Incognito."

"Cooperhawk? Last name?"

"One name. Vietnam vet. PI. He's got access to every source imaginable. You give him your problem. He'll connect the dots. Though he's kind of a kink."

"Why did you need him?" Harry asked.

"Not your business," Rock said. "You can trust him with your life. All confidential. And fast."

This wasn't how Harry expected the afternoon get-together to go, but he was running out of time, and now Rock was getting antsy with him, too.

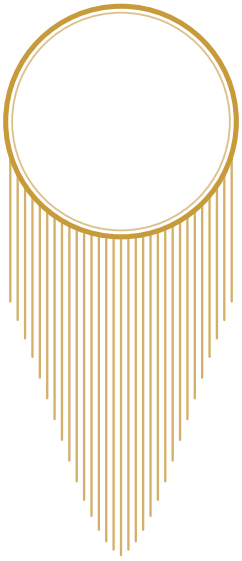
"Harry. Let's get this salmon nonsense closed, get back to business, and make money. I'll get Cooperhawk to call you." He pinged his wine glass. "Nothing drives me crazier than when I'm not in control of the situation. You're going to owe me for this one."

"Rock, whoever did this was some random idiot, a kook."

"Don't be a fool, Harry. Too targeted. I don't want any more surprises, and if there are, I want to be the first to know." Rock's eyes turned dark. "I mean it, Harry. My patience is short. Now, I want to try what you've got in that second decanter."

"Understood."

Harry reached for the second selection. Rock had already outstayed his welcome.



CHAPTER 16

FRIDAY

Pookmis made a habit of watching Gold Man sleep. The previous night, he had been more troubled than usual—tossing his blankets off and on. Every couple of hours, he'd sit up and sip his glass of bourbon set on his bedside table. The liquor didn't appear to be a remedy for his insomnia. After hours of lying awake, he ~~had gotten~~ up and ransacked the library, yanking books from the shelves and rifling through Father's desk drawers. Next, he opened the secret safe. Inside, on the top corner shelf, he pulled down a long, pointed dagger from a purple velvet bag. He appeared puzzled when he'd examined the shiny blade,

then squinted at an inscription on the antler handle. He called Father and Grandfather awful names, slipped the knife back into the bag, returned it to the top shelf of the safe, and locked it. He slammed the library door and went back to bed, without much sleep for the rest of the night.

The morning alarm on his phone startled him; he dragged himself into the shower and dressed. It appeared it was another day at the office for his brother, though ~~he'd~~ felt the sleepless night before—the circles under his eyes were heavy. In the kitchen, sipping his morning espresso, he checked his phone and mumbled about lousy stock prices.

"Osler, let's go." Gold Man grabbed his briefcase. The intercom buzzed. "Now what?" He flipped it on. "Hello?"

"Harry, it's me."

"Martha, what are you doing here?"

Gold Man's face soured. Pookmis dodged out of sight, but kept a clear view of the front door.

"Harry, I have a small gift for you. Condolences for Wallace."

"Busy day, I'm heading to the office." Gold Man made a face. "Another time, Martha."

"Harry, for God's sake, I'm Mac's mother."

"Can't stand this damn woman," Gold Man muttered, and buzzed her in.

A stylish lady in a long leather coat arrived. Her chin-length black hair and long bangs framed her brown, sparkly eyes. The woman tried to give Gold Man a cheek kiss, but he pulled away.

"You're a piece of work, Harry Howitzer," she said, handing him a gift bag. "Your favourite. Fifteen-year-old Pappy Van Winkle. ~~Condolences about your father.~~"

"A Pappy? What's up with you? How did you know I was here?" He pulled out the bottle from the ribboned bag, smiled, and nodded. "Very nice. How generous of you." He set it on the long entryway table, beside a foot-high Inuit soapstone sculpture of a fisherman.

"I knew you moved in. You and your ridiculous Howitzer legacy. Sorry about Wallace."

"No, you're not. You hated him—and you know the feeling was mutual."

"Whatever." Martha stared at his forehead. "That's quite the scar. Plane crash, was it?" Her eyes widened, waiting for a reaction. "Some things don't change—you never ~~liked~~ to answer my questions."

"I tripped and cut my head on the coffee table."

"Liar." Martha snooped around the foyer and stopped in front of a vibrant, coloured painting. "I've always loved this Riopelle. Harry, I didn't go to Wallace's service. I didn't want to draw any attention away from the event." She wiped her drippy nose with a tissue she ~~had~~ pulled out of her snakeskin purse. "It smells in here."

Gold Man's eyes darkened as he scanned the hallway. Pookmis moved to the dining room, still able to watch the divorced couple snipe at each other.

"I was surprised you weren't there. You've always liked a good funeral." Gold Man let out a disingenuous laugh. "It was a wonderful day. And it is time for you to leave."

"Hold on, Harry. I've tried to talk to Mac, but he's always too busy to see me."

"Twenty years later, you're interested?" Gold Man motioned with his hand that he'd had enough. "Where did that fireman boyfriend of yours end up? Run out of my money to spend on him?"

"Ancient history, Howitzer. Madeline is more my style these days. Listen, ~~there is~~ something I need to talk to you about."

"Martha, I don't care who you are sleeping with. I've got a full day. You need to wrap this up. What do you want?"

"Interested in selling Wallace's art?" She gestured to the paintings on the wall. "Any of the Group of Seven stuff. The collection is worth millions. The Carr?" She pointed. "*Wood Interior*?"

Millions? Pookmis took a moment. His father had spent his money on art. *That was his priority*?

"The Carr is not for sale. And never *Wood Interior*."

"~~Maybe~~ need the cash?" An insincere smile crossed her face. "I read that article in the *Sun*. Bad press or what?"

"I have no money issues."

Pookmis watched Gold Man walk to the front door and open it.

"Sure, whatever you say. I have an Asian buyer. A whale. He'll buy Wallace's whole collection. Even those stupid wooden

ducks. Top dollar." Osler trotted into the foyer, ignoring the guest. "Oh, there you are, Osler."

"Time for you to leave, Martha."

"What about that Harris in the living room?" The Westie snubbed her when she tried to pet him. "Give me a break, Osler. Such an attitude. Are you keeping him?"

"I'm keeping Osler and the art. Thanks for the Pappy. You've got to go."

"Dickhead. So glad I left you." After giving Gold Man one more dirty look, Martha left the home without another word.

"That woman has a selective memory, Osler. What a morning. Two intruders." Gold Man shouted up toward the second floor, "Are you listening, Pookmis? Intruder!" He grabbed his gift and tucked it into the living room bar. "Let's go, ~~guy~~."

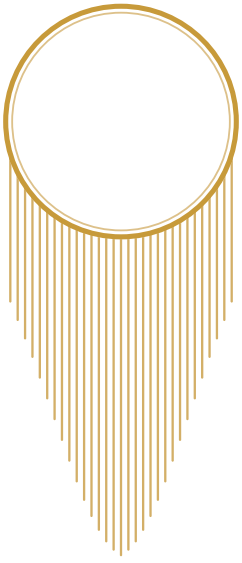
He grabbed his coat, and the two left the house out the back door.

Pookmis drifted back into the foyer. Martha's visit laid bare the brutal reality of his father's real priorities.

Rage. The haunt let out a bloodcurdling howl.

The monolithic fisherman figure on the foyer table reminded him too much of his past. His supernatural energy surged. The sculpture toppled and shattered, sending broken bits of stone across the hardwood floor.

"You arrogant, rich bastard. Brother, ~~don't ever call me an~~ intruder."



CHAPTER 17

FRIDAY

It was the first anniversary of Zi and the twins moving to Vancouver. *Would he own Sceptre by this time next year*? *Yes, he would*.

Sunspot gleamed like a cut and polished diamond in the Coal Harbour Marina. Zi sipped his morning coffee. Last night ~~he had~~ stayed on board. It was wonderful to hear from the captain about the exhilarating journey from Monaco. Zi's vessel proved herself to be an excellent mariner, managing the high winds and ~~the~~ ferocious seas with ease. After his victory over the Howitzers, he would take a long voyage with *Sunspot*.

He stretched out on one of the navy leather sectional sofas in the salon. In the corner was his long mahogany bar, filled with thousand-dollar bottles of whisky and cognac. Next to the bar was a round dining table that seated eight and offered a perfect view of the iconic Stanley Park and Deadman's Island. The yacht was his home away from home.

~~In contrast,~~ Vancouver had been a rough start for Zi. The Canadian stock market was riddled with rules and inspectors. He had to be careful to keep the Lius' anonymity. And he missed his club and army buddies. Serge was a solid wingman. Because he was Russian, Zi had been leery of his loyalty, but Zi ~~had been~~ wrong to doubt him. ~~However,~~ Serge could never be a friend—the relationship was strictly business. And that was how Zi would consider his time in Vancouver—business first, pleasure after the win.

His resentment toward the Howitzers had mushroomed after he had attended Wallace Howitzer's burial. Zi had caught Harry glaring at him suspiciously. The hooded trench coat had been a perfect disguise. But listening to the attendees' stories and the accolades about the so-called fine qualities of the old man had been nauseating.

It was incredible that after so many years no one knew the truth.

Early that morning, he'd contacted the Vancouver Police Department to ensure his reward for information had been posted for his father's death.

In his mind, Easton Howitzer had to have been the murderer. Someone else knew something. The ten-thousand-dollar reward might motivate that person.

There was a knock on the salon door. It opened and Serge peeked into the salon. "Boss?"

"Serge, there you are. What's happening?" The heavy door closed. He checked the wall clock. "Are the twins on their way over?"

"Yes, they have an update for you." Serge sat down. "Boss, I'm worried. Keefer is floundering. Not close to meeting our goals. And there is always risk. The mining business is full of surprises. You need to make something big happen if you want control."

"You've read my mind. We need that report from Hunt. It's critical for the takedown."

Zi sensed there could be issues with Hunt. He was too quiet; the information should have been delivered. He spotted the twins in deep conversation through the long, darkened window as they walked up the gangplank and came on board.

"Come in. Good to see you both. Have a seat. Let's get updated." His daughter sat down next to him on a dining room chair. "Wei, anything with Howitzer? You saw him?"

"I haven't seen him since the funeral. We've been texting, but nothing new."

"Disappointing." Howitzer had to be preoccupied because his daughter's charm was consuming. "Dashi, what about Hunt? You haven't been in contact, have you?"

"The report is supposed to be finished any day." Dashi checked his phone, avoiding any eye contact with his father.

"There's no choice then." It was time for his son to get this done. "Dashi, you need to go to Stewart and find Hunt."

"Baba, are you serious?" Dashi's brows arched, and his eyes blinked rapidly. "The town has like five hundred people. If I roll in looking for him, ~~we are~~ busted."

The first time Serge and Dashi ~~had~~ met Hunt, they had gotten lucky. Dressed as hunters, they had stopped at the local coffee shop in Stewart to gather intel about Sceptre. They had overheard Officer Hunt sharing his money problems with the waitress. He couldn't afford the vet bill for his sick dog. The timing had been pure luck. Serge and Dashi had followed him out to the parking lot and thrown so much money at him that he couldn't refuse the job. Hunt had called the offer "life-changing."

"Dashi, then get an answer. No more waiting."

"I'll call him." Dashi started to pace the room as he waited for Hunt to pick up. "Hey, Hunt, there you are. Where's the report?"

Zi noticed the quick change in Dashi's face. The carefree smile dropped, and the colour of his cheeks turned bright pink. After questions that didn't seem to have answers, he sat down in a dining room chair next to his sister. "What? No, that wasn't the deal. How much more do you want? Tell me." Dashi looked up at his father for confirmation.

Zi leaned in and could hear Hunt murmuring on the line. He motioned to Dashi to up the ante.

"Hunt, name your number. We can do it."

The room waited for Dashi's next move. Instead of further negotiations, he set his phone down. "He bailed. Totally bailed."

The pitch in Wei's voice sharpened. "So now the guy has a conscience after taking our money? Dashi, what the hell? You promised this would happen."

Dashi tried Hunt's number again. And again. ~~This time~~ he threw his phone on the coffee table and turned to his father. "Baba, I'm sorry. How could Hunt do this?"

"Blockhead." Serge scratched at his starter goatee. "This is a problem."

"I trusted you to do this, Dashi," Zi said, pushing himself off the sofa. He gripped the back of a dining room chair. "There is no backup plan. Why did you pay him?"

Dashi dropped his head. "I'm a stupid ass."

"Dashi, ~~we're~~ starting over. It's been a year, let me remind you." Zi squeezed the back of the chair tighter. "I don't have to tell you how angry I am right now."

"I know, Baba. I told you he was on board, ~~but then~~ the guilt set in because his buddies told him that if Sceptre ever shut down, there ~~is~~ no other work up there. They wouldn't be able to take care of their families."

"Who said we would shut down the mine?" Zi realized his mission was not simple. He just wanted control of the company, but hadn't considered the consequences in those terms. As much as he hated the Howitzers, his vengeance shouldn't impact innocent bystanders. But it didn't matter now; the plan was at a dead end.

"Money doesn't buy loyalty, does it, Dashi?" A lesson Zi needed to learn himself.

"Boss, ~~don't raise your voice.~~ We didn't get the report, but the dead salmon drove the stock down," Serge said. "You didn't get your big prize, but no one knows Hunt poisoned the fish. Sceptre is under investigation by all sorts of officials. It's a big deal for them."

"That will take time. Time~~,~~ I don't have." The fury Zi felt toward Dashi's incompetence refused to settle. His son had failed. "Wei, when do you see Howitzer again? We need more information. Something must be happening."

"I'm on it. Maybe this weekend." Wei turned to Dashi. "Tell Zi your idea."

"It's not a game changer, but it's good. We can short Sceptre." Dashi got up and retrieved a file from his bag. "I've lined up three stock influencers who will publish videos on social media, regurgitating everything wrong with Sceptre starting this weekend. We pay for their services—anonymously."

"Who are these people?" The internet was something Zi wasn't that knowledgeable about, and he hated the concept of oversharing publicly.

"Specific influencers. Thousands of day traders follow them," Dashi said, showing Zi an example from his phone. "Watch this."

Zi watched a grainy video of a young guy rambling on about his interpretation of a stock for thirty seconds. It didn't make any sense to him. "This works?" Zi asked. "These people seem amateur. Fools. Serge?"

"Sophisticated investors won't buy it, but they won't be happy. This is day trader stuff, and it causes volatility in the stock." Serge peered down at Dashi's examples. "Shorting is risky."

"I don't agree with you, Serge." Dashi started listing examples of stocks dropping quickly in response to social media posts. "It works. Lots of volume of shares traded."

With a doubtful voice, Serge asked Dashi how many shares he'd like to short.

"Maybe half a million." Dashi referred to a sheet of calculations.

Zi listened to Serge debate Dashi. He considered both sides of the argument. It appeared that the risk was minimal and the upside worthwhile.

"Go ahead, Dashi," Zi said. After the Hunt issue, it was time to try something different.

"Great, Baba. ~~We are~~ using two brokers. Good guys who can keep their mouths shut. We'll be out of the market by next Wednesday at the latest and own more Sceptre stock."

"And after this? We need to create the next event that crushes Sceptre."

"I'll figure it out." Dashi closed his file. "I've got to contact these influencers to get the word out and their videos up. Wei, let's go."

After the twins left, Zi ~~needed to continue the conversation~~. The disappointment stung.

"Serge, this share accumulation is getting complicated," Zi said. "Dashi's idea is small. Not much can happen."

"I don't like shorting. Boss, listen to me. We have lots of cash." Serge grabbed a pen and paper, wrote down his ideas, and showed the paper to Zi. "Have a look. We do a multimillion-dollar private placement. We take our money, and with our inside people, they become investors in Keefer, and we give them a cut to use their name. We tell the Exchange we are seeking a merger to make the infusion of cash into Keefer appear legitimate. Smart money laundering. Give us more opportunities to approach Sceptre if and when there's an opportunity."

"This is going to take time, isn't it?" Serge confirmed the timeline. "And this doesn't have any direct impact on Sceptre. Not like my first idea. It's a maybe something might happen situation, and we'd be ready."

Serge chose his words carefully. "Yes. I understand what you are trying to accomplish, but Sceptre is a well-oiled machine. The family is formidable. It's not as simple as deciding you want it and it's yours." He crossed his arms. "Is it the Howitzers or Sceptre you want to take down?"

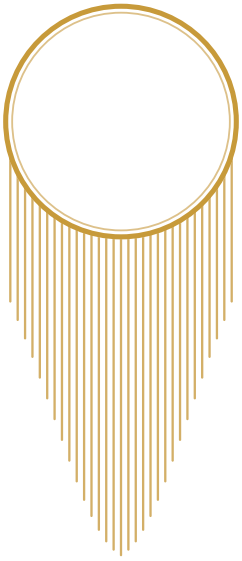
"Both," Zi answered without hesitation.

Serge nodded, recognizing his boss's passion. "Do you really want to be in the mining business? You should consider other paths to get your revenge. Smarter and faster. Not a takeover. I have another idea in mind—a little more aggressive. We have the people."

Zi contemplated Serge's suggestion: a hit on Howitzer. It was an alternative.

His eyes stayed fixed on the Russian. For the first time, he realized Serge showed compassion toward him. “No, Serge. I’m sticking with my original plan. I have my reasons.”

Those words were final, yet for the first time, doubt crept into Zi’s mind. *~~Was his~~ obsession clouding ~~his~~ judgment*?



CHAPTER 18

FRIDAY

~~The week had been a blur—more like a desperate scramble for Harry, dealing with his father's affairs and not getting any closure on Sceptre.~~ Lawyers and accountants peppered him with questions and requests about Wallace. The estate had been left to Harry except for a half-million-dollar donation to various Chinatown foundations. Harry would double the amount—take it out of his own inheritance. But nothing was put aside for the Johnsons. That was a raw point for Harry, but neither Benji nor Spring was alive to experience the painful omission.

Martha's unannounced appearance irked him, arriving with a two-thousand-dollar bottle of Pappy. *Did she believe ~~he~~ could be bought off*? Wallace would roll over in his grave if she even touched his collection. She was relentless—from day one.

August 1985 was the first time they had met. Harry and his tennis buddies had been partying at Kits Beach. ~~They would start real jobs after university, in September,~~ but no one ~~had~~ wanted to grow up. The crowd ~~had been~~ getting high on mushrooms, drinking Mateus, and hooking up.

Martha ~~had~~ arrived uninvited to the beach party, wearing a short blue T-shirt dress that ~~had shown~~ off her long, toned legs. The minute she ~~had~~ spotted Harry, she~~'d~~ made a beeline for him. In retrospect, it seemed as though she'd had a mission that night. Martha had thrown off her electric blue platform shoes. She'd interrupted Harry and his boys and offered them a slug of tequila from a mickey.

All his friends had agreed that she was hot. He loved her long, black hair. And her cat-shaped brown eyes ~~had~~ made her appear mysterious. Their night turned into a wild party.

He and Martha danced by the bonfire. The shots continued. ~~One~~ thing ~~had~~ led to another. Harry ~~had~~ suggested they go for a drive. When they arrived at the car, he realized he was too drunk. Plan B. They made out in the back seat of his fire-red Mustang for a couple of hours and passed out. The warm early morning sun ~~had woken~~ them. It had been a sobering moment. But he'd liked what he'd seen. After his third request, she ~~had given~~ him her phone number.

Four months later, Martha ~~had~~ announced she was pregnant, and Wallace lost it. "That was her plan, Harry." The patriarch had insisted on a paternity test based on the scuttlebutt about Martha's reputation around the tennis club. Mac ~~had~~ arrived five months later.

Martha's interest in being a mother ~~had faded.~~ The complaints about her being tired, bored, and wanting to travel without Mac ~~had~~ turned into endless arguments. Harry needed help. Wallace ~~had~~ grudgingly stepped in. He knew of a fifty-year-old British woman, Gert, looking to care for a new family. Harry hired her on the spot. Their home ~~had~~ no longer ~~been~~ considered a disaster zone, and a professional nanny cared for their son.

When Mac ~~had been~~ about three, it ~~had become~~ apparent that their marriage was over. Martha ~~had~~ wanted more and asked Harry for start-up money for an art gallery. She knew art. He'd given it one last shot to try to make her happy.

However, after her numerous false reports of progress, the business ~~had never taken~~ off, and the cash ~~had~~ disappeared. So ~~had~~ Martha.

A few weeks later, she'd called him. "Harry, it's not going to work. I want out, and now. I'm not cut out for this Howitzer world. And you're boring as hell."

Life was a party for Martha on someone else's dollar. Wallace ~~had given~~ Harry the money to get rid of her on one condition: full custody of Mac.

She ~~had literally taken~~ the money and ~~run.~~

That was the best decision of Harry's life.



Harry sped through the alley in Wallace's ten-year-old green Range Rover and swung into one of their three parking spots behind the family office, next to the Jeep. His son was always the first to arrive. He headed for the Fuel café across the street. A bell tied to the handle clanged as he shut the front door. The small shop had a dozen small tables. The red walls, plastered with eclectic and colourful art Trudy collected on her travels, made the place feel homey and unpretentious.

"Where's the lady of the manor?" The room smelled like hot butter. Good timing—Trudy was baking.

"There he is. How are you?" Trudy stood behind the counter, wiped her hands on her long, floured apron, and mimed hugging him.

"I came for whatever you are serving." Harry knew he looked rough. Trudy's shocked expression validated that.

"Are you growing a beard?" She narrowed her eyes. "That cut on your forehead. Not healing."

"Makes me tough." He rubbed the stubble on his beard, which felt surprisingly coarse.

"No, you look like you did in 1979 after a month of tree planting. A wreck. My God, Harry. Wallace would have a fit."

She laughed and gave him an endearing look. “Sit down. We haven’t talked about the crash. I want to hear all about it.”

“I don’t want to talk about it.” Harry pulled out the wooden chair, the only customer in the restaurant. “The crash isn’t for public knowledge. It’s complicated.”

“I understand. But it must have been scary as hell.” Trudy fired up two double espressos. The machine sounded like a jet engine.

“Life-changing. But that story’s for another time; I only have ten minutes.” After Trudy joined him, he took his first sip. “Perfect. Thank you.” He noticed she kept refolding her napkin. “What’s up?”

“Oh, Harry. After the service, a bunch of us went to the tennis club for a drink.” She moved her coffee cup aside and squeezed his hand. “The gossip about this salmon incident is running rampant in our circles. No one can believe that this would happen to the Howitzers. Rumours about you.”

“Like what?” Harry did not expect this conversation. “We didn’t do it. Some whack job did.”

“That’s what I said, defending you, but it’s juicy gossip. And then that article in the paper stirred the pot, per se.” She got up, returned with a~~nother~~ pastry, and set it in front of him. “I’ve seen this over the years so many times; people love to see rich people fail. They eat it up.” She sipped her coffee. “It’s jealousy.”

“Friends of mine?” he asked. “Saying I’m at fault? Who?”

“Karl,” Trudy confirmed.

“You’re kidding me? I was his best man.” *That was a punch in the heart*. “I don’t get it, but thanks for the reality check.”

He didn't want to hear any more stories. "I've got to find those pirates."

"What?"

"Later." He grabbed his pastry and gave her a peck on the cheek. "Thanks, babe."

"Harry, listen to me. I thought you should know."

"I should. Dinner soon."

"I know you, Harry. Tell me, what's up? What's wrong?"

"Love you." Trudy was correct; he was a mess. Shouldn't that be expected, given the hell he was experiencing? But he wasn't sharing ~~his~~ reality with anyone.

His strides were long and fast as he headed across the cobblestone road. April's words were true the day they found the dead salmon. Life had been pretty easy for him, and now he realized how he hadn't appreciated it. He hoped like hell that he would be able to get it back—even part of it. And now it was his reputation at stake, not only with the markets, but also in his social circles, his so-called friends.

Harry stopped at the red light. Time to call Nightingale. The phone rang eight times. "Answer your bloody phone."

"Sergeant Nightingale."

"It's Harry Howitzer." The clipped greeting told Harry his call wasn't welcome. "I need an update. Hunt?" A city bus rolled by Harry. Its squeaky brakes and hydraulic door opening forced him to start walking. "Can you hear me?"

"I can hear you. I told you he's on assignment."

"And?"

"Mr. Howitzer, I'm not trying to be rude, but your calls are a little too regular. I told you I'll call you when I have an update."

"That's fine for you, but I've got a major problem. What about those tire tracks we talked about? Is there anything there? It's some kind of special vehicle in our area."

"Harry. You know, we all have problems. And some people have worse ones than you if you can believe it. I told you, I'm on it."

"You may think my problems are first-world, but they aren't. I employ a hell of a lot of people, and I need to keep the lights on." *What a rude comment.* "Listen, I need action. By next week at the latest, otherwise, I'm going to your boss. Do you understand?"

"That would be a bad decision, Harry Howitzer." The call was over.

Rock was right: they'd both be dead before Nightingale and the RCMP found out who had poisoned the stream.



The office elevator door opened. Mac stood in the middle of the office, tapping his foot on the oak wood floor and speaking

on the phone. "Monday at the latest? Awesome. Talk then." He fist-pumped. "Yes!"

"What's up?" Harry asked and set his briefcase down on his desk.

"Atlin results. Tomorrow by noon, Monday at the latest." He jumped to his feet and made a quick dance move. "Yes."

"Son, let's wait to see it on paper before cracking the Dom." Harry dropped his briefcase. He hung up his coat, pulled his readers from the inside of his blazer, and placed them on his head—a habit he'd picked up since realizing his reading vision had started to falter slightly with age. "Those results better be stellar. It's our get-out-of-jail-free card."

"Dad, I know. Don't start sounding like Rock."

"And don't insult me." The lack of sleep was becoming apparent; he was curt. He noticed Mac pull out a thick document from a folder. "What's that?"

"The NOBO list. Heard of Keefer Gold? I haven't."

"Who?"

"Keefer Gold. They're buying a ton of our stock."

"Keefer Gold. Never heard of them." Harry had emailed the Toronto Stock Exchange earlier in the week and requested an updated shareholder list to be sent to Mac. Harry thought he knew all the players in the junior gold market, but the name wasn't familiar.

"Weird structure. No CEO, only three directors." Mac rattled off the names from the documents.

"No one I know."

"You're not going to believe this." Mac took a minute and double-checked. "Eff me. Close to eight percent."

"Eight percent?"

The stealth company's ownership didn't make any sense. But the first thing that came to Harry's mind was that they were somehow connected to the poisoning. He'd keep that notion to himself.

Harry searched the company name. No website. The only reference he found was a press release announcing that the company had started trading on the Venture Exchange over six months ago, from a reverse takeover of a shell company. He pulled up Keefer's profile on the TSX website. Few shares had been traded.

"Show me this file." Harry pulled out a chair next to his desk. "Have a seat."

Mac pushed up a long sleeve of his navy wool sweater, exposing his Howitzer artillery tattoo cuff, and sat next to his dad. He pointed to the updated trade list, running his finger to the name Keefer.

"I asked the Exchange, and they sent me this, too," Mac said. The TSX document had a business address.

"Who the hell are these people?" He patted his son's hand. "I've got to go and check out the address."

The building was four blocks away. As Harry made his way up Richards Street, he contemplated why a publicly listed company would buy millions of Sceptre shares. The timing was wrong. Atlin was an unknown.

When he found the address, he had to take a quick break to lower his heart rate. The damn crash's side effects still lingered.

The office space, a business centre, was busier than Harry expected. About two dozen businesses housed the small offices. Keefer Gold's office had a desk and chair, and nothing else. But after one question, the helpful central receptionist told Harry that a guy with a thick Russian accent occasionally came by to pick up their mail.

"Can I ask you for a big favour? I'm in a real quandary about this company, and I need your help. Could you give me his name?" Harry asked with a charming grin. "I'd appreciate it." She was cute.

The blond woman took a minute and smiled. "Sure, give me a sec."

~~Perfect, t~~his was exactly what Harry needed. The old dog still ~~had~~ charm.

"Harry, right?"

"Yes, that's me." He broadened his grin the second time.

"Here it is. Serge Sobakin. He hasn't been around for a while." She printed the name and a phone number on a sticky note and passed it to him. "This is all I have. I shouldn't be giving it to you, but he was a jerk."

"Thank you. Can you call me if you see him?" Harry handed her his card. "I need to meet him."

"Come back anytime if you need anything else." She walked Harry to the door, mentioning she'd heard of the Howitzers. "One more thing. He was a thug."

Harry realized she was flirting, but ignored the signs. “Okay, that’s useful information. Thanks again.”

The man she described sounded like a gangster. *~~Why~~ would a Russian gang be interested in owning* Sceptre? *Nonsense*.

Outside the tower, Harry called the number, which was out of service. At least he got a name. On his way back to the office, his phone rang.

“Hello, Cinnamon.”

“Let’s meet for a drink tonight.”

“Rain check. I’m going to hang out with Osler. I’m beat.”

“It’s Friday night, one drink.”

“One bourbon. See you at five. Pac Rim.” The lounge at the hotel was their regular meeting spot if they weren’t playing tennis. Cinnamon had a gorgeous apartment in the adjoining tower. It was a convenient pied-à-terre. He liked when she asked him out on a date.

The crosswalk light turned red.

“Y’all~~,~~ Harry Howitzer?”

“What’s that?” An imposing man stood in front of him. He appeared to be in his late sixties. He had a narrow, pale, pitted face and was dressed like a toned-down cowboy. “Can I help you?”

“That’s my line,” the man said with a Texan drawl. “Rock said we should talk.”

“Cooperhawk?” *Not what ~~he~~ expected*. Harry tried to look into the man’s eyes, but his dyed brown hair was cut around his face, framing his blue-tinted glasses. “Rock’s friend?”

"Wouldn't say Rock and I are friends." When he spoke, he showed his long, greyish teeth. "I was his handler on a particular issue he couldn't solve." He paused. "Major intervention."

"One of his sons got into trouble, I bet," Harry said. Both Weston boys were entitled idiots even in their forties.

"Private intel. This is about you. What's up?"

"Where do you want me to start?" The man's confidence was both unnerving and reassuring. Harry wanted to learn more about who this mystery man was.

"Let's walk. I told Rock I'm selective these days on any kind of research I do. Had enough of you rich guys. Greasy."

"I'm not greasy. Tell me what you know." They headed east.

"Rock said you've got a poisoning problem. Streams don't kill fish. People do."

"I know that." *Should ~~he~~ tell Cooperhawk the whole story? No, the highlights, if ~~those were the right words~~.*

"I don't have all day," Cooperhawk said. "Who cares if Sceptre goes bust?"

"Shareholders, the employees, the Howitzers—and Rock."

"Uh-huh."

The man's pace was quick. Harry stepped it up. He was elevator-pitching his case to Cooperhawk. For at least ten blocks, Harry recalled the events of the past three weeks. He talked about the salmon crisis, then his horrific plane crash, and his father's death.

Harry described Sceptre's newest problem: a stealth company, Keefer Gold—likely fronted by Russians, maybe gangsters—was scooping up Sceptre stock.

"Odd story." They stopped in the middle of the 100 block of East Hastings Street. "What a tragedy this place is. Vancouver didn't use to be this way. Let's get out of here."

"Agree."

Harry couldn't stand the stench of decaying garbage that littered the street. He tried to get a glimpse of Cooperhawk's eyes for the second time as they headed toward Harry's office, but it was like the man didn't want to connect. For the next ten minutes, Harry continued to explain his losses, the stalled RCMP investigation, and confessed he didn't expect his personal reputation to be affected.

"I'm at a standstill. I need a lot of answers."

Cooperhawk stopped for a moment in front of Harry and craned his neck to look down both sides of the block. "What are you saying, Harry?"

"The plane accident caused me more damage than I'm willing to admit. And Wallace, I can't go there." It was too early to share any more secrets. Cooperhawk needed to take the assignment. *But maybe if ~~he told~~ him the truth, ~~he would~~ take the file? No, that would be stupid.* He didn't know the guy from Adam.

"You got more, don't you?" Cooperhawk nodded.

"~~Doozy,~~ but not now." It was time to shut down the meeting. "So, what could you do for me?"

"I'm not committing to you right now. But the Russian thing intrigues me. Let me tell you, based on what I'm hearing, you, partner, are not going to like what I find out. For good reason, someone really hates your family."

Cooperhawk left Harry standing in the middle of the sidewalk, and those departing words resonated with him as he rode the elevator to the office.

But who?

"Hey, son." He grabbed a chair next to Mac and shared his findings from the business centre. After a search for Sobakin's name, Mac let out a sigh.

"Dead end, is it?" Harry asked.

"I can't figure this out. Random Russian guys? Effin' weird. And where have you been all afternoon?" Mac checked the time on his phone. "~~I was~~ calling you for hours."

"I ran into a friend of Rock's. Don't worry about it."

"I can't stand it when you say that to me. I worry. Since this frigging salmon incident, nothing has been normal, including you. What aren't you telling me?"

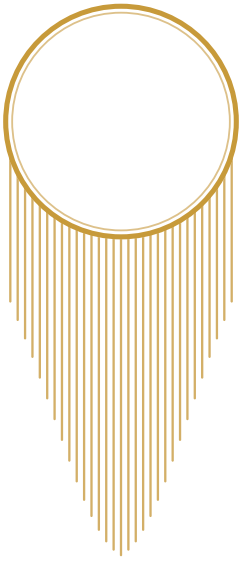
"Settle down." ~~*Should he tell Mac the truth? No, not now, later.* Harry didn't have the facts.~~ "Time for you to get out of here. I can't wait to see those Atlin results."

"Me ~~either.~~" Mac smiled, threw his computer in his courier bag, and grabbed his trench coat. He tapped his father's shoulder. "Sorry, I got angry."

"It's been tough these days. You're a trooper. Have a good night."

Harry checked the stock's closing price. *Dismal*. Keefer *scum*. *Serge whoever*. ~~The Russians circling in on Sceptre were threatening and frankly obscene.~~ *The nerve*.

He hated lying to Mac, but until he had answers, secrets would stay a part of the Howitzer legacy.



CHAPTER 19

Harry skipped the valet and parked on a side street next to the Pacific Rim Hotel. He didn't need the attention of pulling up to the valet at the main entrance. The late November afternoon faded into night. The streetlights cast a dim glow. Tonight, it would be a quick drink with Cinnamon in the lounge, then home. Not that he was looking forward to whatever Pookmis had been up to. The spirit had been causing more trouble.

That morning, Harry had returned to the Tudor after he realized he ~~had~~ left his briefcase on the kitchen counter. When he opened the front door, he stepped into chaos. Pookmis had gone on a rampage that ~~had~~ started with the Inuit soapstone.

It had been smashed into pieces. He had continued on to the library. It looked like a windstorm had barrelled through the room. Books had been tossed on the floor, the art hung askew, and the wingback chairs overturned. Pookmis had overheard too much that morning when Martha carried on about Wallace's millions. The details must have fueled his rage.

It didn't help when Harry had called him an intruder. A lesson learned. Don't disrespect Pookmis and never mention Wallace.

It was still not clear to Harry what kind of power and influence Pookmis possessed. But two things Harry had confirmed: Pookmis had a mean streak, and he was on a mission. Answers only April and her sources could help him with. He checked his phone. *Where was she?*

"Nice to see you, Mr. Howitzer," the chubby bellman said, smiling. He wore a burgundy herringbone vest that matched his pants. "Sorry about your father. We're going to miss him."

"Appreciate that," Harry acknowledged. "Wallace was quite the guy." He cruised into the familiar, chic wood-panelled lounge centred in the mid-century-styled lobby. The bar was a hangout for the local who's who and global five-star travellers.

Harry caught the bartender's attention at the long white marble bar and grabbed a seat. With a Crest-white smile, the black-haired and dark-eyed young man brought Harry a small batch of bourbon.

"Harry, there you are." He offered a handshake.

"Liam, good to see you." The barkeep gave Harry a double take, taking in his haggard face. "I know. I haven't been having much fun these days." He got comfortable on the seat.

"Rumour has it that you crashed your plane. Is that right?" Liam asked with a quiet voice.

"Off the record." Harry couldn't understand why, at times, his scar felt healed, and then other times it throbbed like a fresh wound. He leaned into the bartender. "Life-changing is all I can say."

"You've been jinxed, my man," Liam said, passing Harry a bowl of popcorn.

Jinxed. That's the word. On a second glance at the lounge, he sensed people were staring at him, but avoiding eye contact. He knew he was the topic of gossip. *Those promoters have short memories.* Usually, those types wanted to be in Harry's inner circle and would bring him over a glass of Blanton's for the chance to say hello.

"And a champagne, please. Cinnamon is joining me. What's going on with you, Liam?"

"Writing my last exams. Going to be a corporate securities lawyer soon." Liam's face lit up. "It is awesome." Liam rattled off the details of the firm he was joining, including the outstanding starting salary. "I'm at the top of my class."

"Good for you."

"Thanks, man. Got to go." The bartender hustled back to his chits.

What a great story. He remembered graduating from Queen's and starting at Sceptre. Big dreams and ambitions. Time went by fast. *And what did he have to show for it after thirty-five years*? *A stock under three bucks and a house of cards*. Someone patted his shoulder.

"Hello there, Harry."

He felt a soft kiss on his neck and caught the familiar jasmine flower perfume. "There she is."

He pulled out the stool for Cinnamon, noticing her black knee-length skirt falling into place, revealing her athletic thighs as she settled into the seat. A lace bra peeked out of her white sleeveless V-neck blouse. "Sorry, I haven't seen you in a while. My life has been upside down." He caught himself dwelling on the negative. "And you look wonderful, my dear."

He passed her the champagne glass. Cinnamon's natural beauty captured him. *~~She was~~ a well-put-together woman.*

"Thank you. Sorry to hear things are so tough." She got comfortable, but her eyes focused immediately on his forehead. "That cut of yours—wow. Tell me about your plane crash."

"Not tonight," Harry said, touching the sensitive wound. He'd learned over the years that all bartenders listened to their patrons' conversations. He and Liam traded a knowing glance.

"Is it healing?"

"Kind of. I've got time for one drink. What's happening with you?"

"Busy dealing with family business," Cinnamon said, fixated on Harry's cut, sipping her champagne. She grabbed his hand. "Are you okay, Harry? You don't seem like yourself."

"I'm a little stressed." He stared into his glass and then played with the rim. "Tough couple of weeks."

"I see." Cinnamon moved closer to him. "Your father's service was lovely. I didn't realize what an accomplished man he

was. And generous." She tilted her head. "Wallace discovered the company?"

"No, my grandfather, Easton did, and Wallace built it." *That was a lie.* He wouldn't bring up his thoughts on her showing up at the funeral.

"The woman you were speaking to at the service. Trudy? Why have you never mentioned her to me?" Cinnamon finished her champagne and waved to Liam for a second glass, though Harry had been planning to have his next drink at home.

"Trudy is my best friend. Our fathers were best friends." Harry rubbed her hand, sensing her jealousy. "Friends, Cinnamon, that's it."

"Oh, I see." The lines on her forehead relaxed. "And your son's words were touching. He seems like a great guy. And sharp."

"Great kid and brilliant." Harry didn't want to share anything more about Mac. "After you finish up, I'm heading out."

Harry took another glance at the lounge. It was standing-room-only, including money men and large shareholders in Sceptre. He kissed her soft cheek. She did smell great. "I'm out of here. Good to see you."

"Harry, hold on." Cinnamon stood, downing her glass of bubbly and whispering in his ear. "What I'd like to do right now is see you naked. Do you want to go upstairs? I have something to show you."

"What's that?"

"Me."

Her inviting eyes were compelling. How could he say no? He motioned for the cheque, put down two hundred-dollar

bills, grabbed his coat, and saw Cinnamon waiting for him by the side door.

"My man, have fun. Keep it real," Liam said with a cheeky grin.

"Kick ass on that exam." Harry waved at the bartender as he was leaving. "~~We are~~ going to celebrate your new job." *Great guy.*

"Let's go this way," Cinnamon said. A few steps from the door, they were in the elevator of her apartment. Cinnamon started kissing Harry in the elevator, grabbed his hand, and led him to her front door.

"Welcome," she said.

"~~This~~ is a great spot." He threw off his coat on the sofa.

"Have a seat." Cinnamon poured them both a drink and turned on funky soul music. "You good?"

"Better." He made himself comfortable on the plush leather sofa. The ~~view of the~~ shimmering lights of the panoramic skyline reflected on the Burrard Inlet was mesmerizing.

"I'll be right back. Make yourself at home."

Cinnamon had great taste in furniture and art. A pair of Chinese grey-and-red dragon-motif porcelain vases on a table in the corner of the living room caught his eye. Those were new, and they appeared to be from the Qing dynasty. His mom had collected Chinese porcelain from that period. Wallace loathed her collection~~, and~~ when she ~~had~~ died, ~~he had~~ donated the dozen pieces to a charity auction for tax credits.

After Harry made a quick inspection, the ceramics appeared authentic—big bucks. It was an odd collection for a young person.

"Cinnamon? Where did you get these vases?"

"Harry, I'm over here."

He turned to find her wearing a provocative set of black lace ~~panties and bra.~~ He grabbed her hand.

"Yes?" Cinnamon nibbled his ear.

"Hard to resist. Remember, an hour." Harry wrapped Cinnamon in his arms. She felt incredible. Her kisses were soft. He led her down the hallway into her bedroom, and they fell onto the bed.

"I've missed you, Harry."

"Me too." The couple got carried away.

Harry had lost track of time. After a few hours of romance, the two lovers snuggled on the sofa, wrapped in robes. Cinnamon entwined herself around him and offered a soft smile.

"Harry, you seemed different tonight." She tickled his lower lip. "I loved it."

"Yeah?" *At least something ~~was~~ working right.* "This has been a nice night, but—"

"Harry, you can't leave yet. What's on your mind? I'm a good listener." She tucked into his shoulder. "And a good secret keeper. Tell me what's wrong."

"Tough week. There is this company, Keefer Gold. Today, I learned these idiots, who came out of nowhere, own nearly eight percent of Sceptre." He shook his head. "I don't get it. Like, why?"

"~~What's Keefer~~?" Cinnamon asked.

"Some random Russian guys."

"Russians? I wouldn't be trusting anything Russian from my experience in real estate deals."

"Agree." Cinnamon had read his mind. "I found one contact, Serge, but my research on him was a dead end." The day's findings riled his temper. "I've got to go."

"What about that incident at the mine? The company is getting terrible press." Cinnamon nestled into Harry.

"You're not kidding. The RCMP are pissing me off. I need to prove we didn't have anything to do with those dead fish." Harry stopped himself; he'd shared too much. "I'll figure it out, and I do have to go."

"Ooh, come on. What's up this weekend?"

"I've got to get my sleep. Mac and I have to focus on fixing this mess this weekend."

Harry hopped up and dressed. Cinnamon followed him, trying her best to make him stay, offering breakfast in bed.

"Harry. Before you go. Question. We are exclusive, aren't we?"

"Are we?" *Not tonight.* He didn't have the energy to deal with any more angst. But he did take the time to explain to Cinnamon again that the age gap was a significant issue, and their life priorities differed.

"I don't care how old you are. Come on. You're amazing. We are amazing," Cinnamon said, glowing, and pushing back his hair that hung on his face.

"You should care. I'm an old guy. This is a discussion for another day. But what's happening between us can't be a committed relationship. I have to be honest with you." He gave her a quick kiss, noticing her sulky face. "This was a great night. Talk next week."



After a half-block walk back to the Range Rover, his mind didn't take long to return to figuring out how to haul Sceptre out of the ditch. His cellphone showed no missed calls. *Where ~~was~~ April*? He used the fob to open the SUV door.

"Who's the filly?" someone asked in a deep voice.

Harry stepped back and peered around his Range Rover. The street lamp beamed down on a thin man's outline. It was Cooperhawk. He stepped closer to Harry.

"The filly. You didn't tell me about her." Cooperhawk scanned the block as if he were expecting someone. "I need the whole story."

"She's nothing to worry about." Harry moved closer to speak privately. "Look, I told you what you need to know. Yes, there's more to share, but I'm not an idiot who's going to tell someone I met on the street my life story."

Cooperhawk stood unemotional.

"Are you going to help me out? I don't appreciate you stalking me." The men stared each other down. "I need an answer."

"I'm about done with my homework on you, Harry. I'll let you know." Cooperhawk zigzagged across the street to avoid the traffic and disappeared down the block.

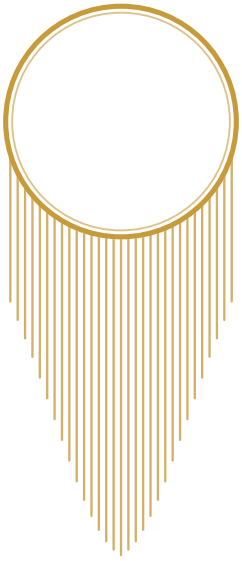
The Cooperhawk thing seemed absurd. *Did he secretly work for Rock?* ~~After~~ that afternoon wine session at the Tudor, Harry wasn't sure whether Rock's true motivation was genuine or self-serving. He was starting to have his doubts.

Harry ~~got~~ into his SUV and fired up the heater. He rubbed his cold hands together.

Dead fish, Cooperhawk, and Keefer Gold.

"Bloody strange." ~~He pulled out of his parking spot and~~ caught a glimpse of a tall woman wearing a ball cap and a long jacket at the corner. She dipped behind an office tower. ~~*Was*~~ *that Cinnamon*? ~~*The street was*~~ *dark*; *that* ~~*couldn't*~~ *be her*.

He made a U-turn.



CHAPTER 20

SATURDAY

A handful of galleries, including Martha Prigger's, dotted the trendy Railtown district. Zi had met her twice before, and his online research had shown she had a long history in the art business. Serge was driving, and they were on their way downtown for his appointment. Zi ~~was~~ a savvy buyer of Asian art ~~and~~ was interested in expanding his collection—privately.

"Is Wei doing a good job with Howitzer?" Zi asked.

"She's a smart woman." Serge glanced at Zi as he manoeuvred through the traffic. "Howitzer isn't going to tell her everything going on over a couple of coffee dates, boss."

"True." It would take Wei time to develop a relationship in which he'd be comfortable sharing business information. Serge's reasoning made sense.

Serge slowed down in front of an address that matched the Escalade's Google Maps location. It was a two-story wood-frame structure. "This is the building."

"~~The~~ place is a dump, Serge."

"It's artsy, boss." He reversed and parked. "I'll be here. Have fun."

"I plan to." Zi brushed the bits of fluff off his coat and checked his gelled hair in the visor mirror. "Looking good?"

"You bet, boss." Serge's smile showed more gums than teeth.

Zi pulled at the heavy metal gallery door. A set of steep cement stairs greeted him. After the climb, he was slightly out of breath. As he entered a long hallway, he discovered an art space with visitors roaming the top floor. Martha was with a young couple in the corner, studying a sculpture that resembled a giant yellow rock. The piece was not to his taste. Three large rooms in the gallery featured photographs, watercolours, acrylic paintings, and wall hangings. She left her guests to greet Zi.

"Welcome to our show, Zi. Wonderful, isn't it? It's mixed media."

Martha, looking sharp in her long navy designer dress, extended her hand to Zi. He found her and her confidence attractive.

"Yes, nice to see you. What do you have to show me?" He didn't want to admit he didn't know what *mixed media* was. *~~Had~~ to be a Canadian thing.*

"Follow me." Martha led him into a small meeting room, then shut the door.

There was a medium-sized oil painting on an easel, which Zi assumed was something special. "Now, did you get me that collection to buy? The special one." That was what he was interested in. Cheap art wouldn't be hung in his new home. "Is this it?"

"That seller changed his mind, but fortunately, I have another client who wants to sell this Emily Carr, *Wood Interior*. It's a lovely piece."

"Tell me more."

"Carr was a pioneer in Canadian art. An icon. ~~This painter~~ had a knack for capturing Indigenous perspectives. Amazing woman. Highly collectible."

"I see."

Zi wasn't sure what to think of the oil painting. It was a vision of green and brown, featuring branchless trees in a forest. The paint appeared thick. He leaned in to look for the artist's signature and was embarrassed; he couldn't spot it.

"Zi, this piece has been in the family for generations. It's precious." She stared at it, nodding her head with enthusiasm. "Goes fabulously with your purchase from the auction."

"How much?" Zi asked. "Why are they selling?"

"This is off-market. The father is aging and doesn't want his sons to manage the collection, so he's quietly liquidating and donating the proceeds. Apparently, the sons are in that entitlement space—what their father owns is theirs, kind of attitude. For that reason, the auction is out. It's a father's private decision."

Zi was grateful the twins didn't have that mindset. "Price?"

"It's in your budget." Her smile widened. "It's a hell of an investment, Zi."

"One painting is not going to work. I have empty walls in my house." Zi didn't understand what she was trying to accomplish. Zi was running out of patience. "Okay, this Carr is fine, but what else?"

"Let's go and have a look at the gallery." Their first stop was ~~at~~ a counter with an ice bucket filled with white wine. "Here." She poured each of them a heavy glass. "Let me show you around."

"I'm going to put my coat in the room." Zi didn't trust hanging his Zegna on a public coat rack. He opened the meeting room door and saw a tall shadow on the white wall. In a flash, it disappeared. *What was that*? He folded his coat, then thought maybe he should hold on to it. Chilly air brushed his neck. A brown-and-white feather drifted and landed on the table beside ~~it.~~ The room had ~~an~~ odd feeling of something present. *No, that ~~was~~ silly*. He shut the door and handed the feather to Martha. "I found this in the room."

"An eagle feather? No idea." She handed him a wine glass and tossed the feather in the garbage. "Let's get down to business."

The first sip of Chablis went down smoothly for Zi. "Yes, show me what you have."

"Let's ~~start~~ over here." Martha led him toward the back room. She pitched the art for the next hour, using words like *emerging*, *timeless*, and *provocative*.

An hour later, Zi, overwhelmed by the information, purchased four acrylic and two watercolour paintings. All works were by new Canadian artists. It was a start.

They finished the bottle of wine and returned to the private room.

"Great selections, Zi."

"Yes, I'm done for today. Can I pick up my art tomorrow?"

"~~Yes~~, but the money?" Martha asked with a broad and fixed smile. "Don't you need time to get a bank wire?"

"Cash deal. I gave you my budget. And this includes all my choices from today, including the oil—the Carr." He'd stashed personal US dollars in *Sunspot* before she'd left Monaco. He watched Martha use her calculator on her phone.

"Yes, ~~I~~ can do that deal, Zi. But the Carr—that's a secret."

"So is my cash payment." Zi reached out and gave her a strong handshake.

They had a deal.



"How was it?" Serge turned off the Russian opera as Zi climbed into the SUV.

"Maybe I'm fussy, Serge, but the building needs better air control and a good cleaning. There was the foulest smell in the meeting room."

"Boss, I meant the art."

"Ah. Spent six figures. More than I planned, but I will be an owner of an Emily Carr. My second investment piece of Canadian art."

"Congrats, boss. I guess."

"Yes, it is exciting. Can you drop me off at Coal Harbour? I'm going to stay on *Sunspot*." But he'd go to the bar at Cardero's first. It was a busy spot on a Saturday afternoon, with good people-watching.

"Done."

Serge drove through the bumper-to-bumper traffic. The visit to the gallery stayed on Zi's mind. The first time he had met Martha at the gala, he had hoped she might be a potential girlfriend, but now she was off his list. He understood. She was being nice to him to sell art. That's it. The minute they did the deal, she couldn't get him out of the gallery fast enough. Something felt off about the transaction. The art, the price, and the easy negotiation. Maybe that was how the business was done here. But Zi had done his homework, and the woman had credentials.

Twenty minutes later, the Escalade pulled up to the marina. Serge stopped the vehicle in front of Cardero's. "Have fun."

"I will. Thank you, Serge."

Zi sat at a table for two, sipping a glass of Scotch, neat. Cardero's was one of Vancouver's most famous pubs. The walls

were lined with wooden planks and model sailboats, and the room was packed with gregarious people. He got comfortable at a small table by the window and observed people comment on *Sunspot*'s beauty.

A dark-haired woman in her sixties caught Zi's eye. She made her way into the pub, manoeuvring through the boozy patrons. She wore camel pants, a high-collared blouse, and a long matching coat. Zi recognized her branded pumps and purse. A classy woman. She continued to search for a seat. *Why not strike up a conversation*?

"I'm by myself. If you need a seat, please." Zi stood up and pulled out the chair.

She appeared startled and continued to check out the bar. "Sure, why not? Sandy."

"Zi," he said as she sat down. "Nice to meet you. Sandy, what would you like?"

"Glass of Pinot Noir would be perfect." She took off her coat and sat down.

Zi noticed her tiny frame. She was cute. He ordered a round of drinks, smiled, and asked if she lived in Vancouver.

"~~Have been~~." She pointed to a high-rise tower close to the seawall. "Over there."

They began to discuss the neighbourhood and agreed it was a wonderful area. "I love the seawall."

"And those beautiful small parks beside the high-rises," Sandy said. "Great green space and so close."

"Yes, I love to walk the seawall and sit in the small park in the corner to have my cigar." He indicated his favourite location.

"Lovely. A cigar man, you say." Sandy chatted about her move to Vancouver six months ago for work. "But I'm done. Going back to Toronto on Monday."

"Ah. I've been here a year. Getting settled."

The two continued to ask each other myriad questions. She was an investor in early-stage companies, and asked Zi what business he was in.

"I'm in the pharmaceutical business. Retired, though." Zi loved a smart woman.

"Tell me more," Sandy asked.

What would he say? There was no need to share the truth with her. He didn't expect that response, and he had to be quick and explain that his twins were busy entrepreneurs and that he had come from Hong Kong to help them.

"Tech?" she asked with engaging eyes.

"No, small land projects." She didn't respond. "Buying houses, making them into multi-unit projects." He had no idea where that had come from. It was time to close that discussion. Enough lies. "Notice that black yacht in the marina."

"Oh, *Sunspot*. I watched it arrive a while ago. Yes, love that ship. It is a ship, isn't it?" Sandy pointed out the window.

"Superyacht. Would you like to see it?" Zi asked.

"You know the owner?"

"I do. Zi. The proud owner. Would you like to join me? We can have dinner tonight. My chef is poaching black cod." He checked his watch. "It's about that time."

"Yes, and fabulous," Sandy said. She opened her purse and pulled out a credit card. The waitress noticed they were ready

to go and brought the bill to the table. "Only if you let me buy our drinks."

"Thank you." *Zi Liu still had it*. Sandy was an excellent catch for a Saturday afternoon.

An hour later, the two were in *Sunspot*'s salon, snuggled on the sofa. They laughed and drank Krug rosé. They were getting loaded. Sandy, giggling, took the initiative to feed Zi the last spoonful of Russian caviar. She licked the mother-of-pearl bowl. Zi couldn't stop laughing at her escapades and her cute quips about how sexy she thought he was.

Sandy unbuttoned her blouse and showed Zi her silk lingerie. He liked what he saw, and she made her intentions obvious.

It was Zi she wanted, not dinner. "Shall we?"

"We shall."

Zi led her to his cozy master stateroom. They popped another bottle of champagne. Sandy continued to take the lead. They disrobed each other and embraced with a string of long, sensual kisses. Their escapades became more risqué.

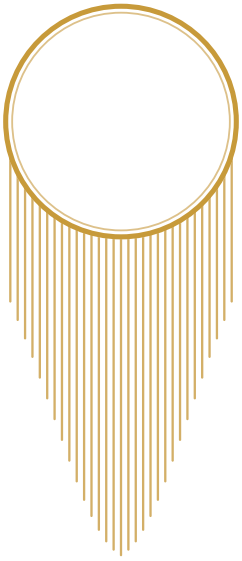
At midnight, Zi woke up. His head was thick, and his tongue felt like fur. He reached over to touch Sandy's arm. She had disappeared.

"Ah." He sat up, turned on his nightstand light, and gulped down a large glass of water.

How perfect. He had been used for a one-night stand.

Zi wasn't a has-been. It felt good to be appreciated. It was time to put the past few frustrating days behind him and be positive about the future.

Vancouver might work out after all.



CHAPTER 21

SATURDAY

The purge was final. Harry spent the morning packing up Wallace's personal belongings for The Salvation Army's pickup. Mac insisted that disposing of the items this soon was insensitive. *Insensitive*? *Hardly*. Harry wouldn't try to justify his actions.

But he set aside Wallace's collection of cufflinks for Mac, who'd wanted the pieces as a memento of his Granddad. Harry understood. He held up Wallace's custom-made, black checkered tone-on-tone tuxedo, the one he wore to accept his humanitarian award from a local charity. *What a joke*. The suit was pitched into the box. *Too bad they didn't have an awards ceremony for*

liars. The carton was sealed, and Harry carried the last box out to the curb. Done.

"Osler," he called for the Westie to join him on the back porch.

He needed air. The sky was misty, and he could smell the earthy fragrance of the late fall. The same dream occurred again last night. The plane crash. He ~~had been~~ guiding his Pilatus to land on Princess Royal Island, but he~~'d~~ missed the beach and torpedoed into the longhouse. The plane ~~had~~ crashed into the wooden building and exploded. Harry ~~had~~ tried to escape from his cockpit, but he couldn't. The smoky fire ~~had~~ surrounded him, and ~~he'd begun~~ to choke. And each time he had the dream, he would wake up at that exact moment, in a cold sweat.

He scratched his dry forearms. Both started to bleed. The real-life landing was a nightmare. It would be Harry Howitzer's last flight. He'd survived and wanted to keep it that way.

He pulled out his phone and opened a new email to send to himself.

CALL MIN TRAN RE: ACCIDENT + FIND NEW PILOT + INSURANCE PLANE PAYOUT

~~The~~ cellphone rang. "Hello, April."

"How are you?"

"Fair. ~~What's up~~?"

She sighed. "Where do I start?"

Harry's stomach did a somersault. ~~*Did he*~~ *even want to know* ~~*the news*~~? "Tell me."

"The Bruce brothers were moose hunting and found Hunt dead about ten miles east of here, in his RCMP vehicle. He shot himself in the head."

"You're kidding me." Harry closed his eyes. "What the hell is going on?"

"This is a humdinger. I was at Layla's. It took me an hour to pry the truth out of her."

"And?"

"Hunt had been on the run, not on a special assignment. He confessed he poisoned the Hemlock stream for money."

"Did he say who put him up to it?" Harry hoped for a clue.

"No, unfortunately. When he realized that if he got caught, he'd lose everything, including his friends, he imploded. Layla said she couldn't settle him down. He left his dog with her and took off. And a couple of hours later, he was found dead."

"Unbelievable." Harry scratched his forearms again. Nightingale had lied to him from the beginning. *Jerk.*

"When I pushed Layla about how he managed to sneak onto Hemlock, she said the RCMP share a rail truck with the northern detachments. He accessed the site through the train tracks. That's why your security cameras never caught him." April continued, "And there was a receipt found in his car. Bitcoin? Is that what you call it?"

"That's correct." That information sparked Harry's mind. Bitcoin wasn't a common currency. Gangsters? Maybe Russians. "April, this is a great start. You're a lifesaver. I've got to call Nightingale."

"Hold on, I have more to share with you."

"Do I need to hear this, April?"

"I know you want to clear up this mess about Hunt, but the Shaman and I ~~have~~ connected and ~~have~~ had some serious conversations. Revealing, in fact."

"One thing at a time, April. I'll call you back."

"Wait!" April insisted. "The Shaman needs to see you. It's not optional."

"Meaning what? I've got to phone Nightingale right now. I'll call you back." It took him a minute to find the number in his phone and make the call. It was a Saturday. *Would he be at his desk*? *Probably, given Hunt's tragedy*.

"Sergeant Nightingale speaking."

"It's Harry Howitzer. Calling about Hunt. I know he's dead, and he confessed to his girlfriend that he poisoned the stream."

"News travels fast in Stewart."

"And you forgot to mention the special rail vehicle he had access to?" Harry waited for a response. "Nightingale."

"I can't comment right now. I need to take another call." Nightingale hung up.

The sergeant couldn't treat Harry Howitzer that way. He was supposed to be working for Sceptre, not protecting a bad cop. Harry called twice before there was an answer. He'd forget the pleasantries this time.

"Nightingale. You're covering up a dirty RCMP officer. Issue a press release clearing Sceptre, stating the case is closed. And there is no evidence to suggest that the company was responsible for the accident. If you don't, I will go to your superiors and

tell them about the Hunt story and your cover-up. You will be fired. What will your family think of you then?"

"Harry Howitzer, do not threaten an officer of the law. Or mention my family. I understand the circumstances clearly. I will not have a civilian tell me what to do."

"What are you going to do about it? I need to know now. You've known this for a while, haven't you? Hunt confessed to you first."

"Do you think I want this incident blowing up in my face? If Hunt's actions go public, I could be investigated, lose my pension~~,~~ and my thirty-year clean record."

"I told you what you need to do," Harry said.

"I will issue a release stating that there was no evidence of Sceptre's involvement and that the company is cleared of any responsibility. And I will include that the evidence wasn't properly logged. Gives me enough reasons to close the case."

"I'll take it." That's the best news Harry could get.

"~~I am~~ processing all the proper internal paperwork for this case for my own career's sake, ~~and~~ if I ever hear about this conversation from anyone, I'll fly to Vancouver and arrest you myself. Do you understand?"

"I do."

Nightingale slammed the phone down. That was an event Harry never expected. It was too early for a bourbon. He made himself a coffee. Sip after sip, he questioned who had paid off Hunt. *The Russian thug and* Keefer Gold ~~*didn't*~~ *make any sense*. *Why*? He thought hard about any recent events or history.

Nothing Russian. And Wallace's bombshell about Sying Liu was decades old. Couldn't be related. Harry was at a loss.

His cell rang again. "Hello?"

"It's Cooperhawk. You checked your email, partner?"

"No."

"In the past half an hour, there has been a flood of spiteful words and vlogs from stock influencers all over social media skewering Sceptre. Someone doesn't like the looks of your shiny boots. I'd like to see you."

Just when Harry thought he was one step ahead with the outing of Hunt, something else came up. Those influencers would cause more havoc with his shareholders. He went to the library and opened his laptop on Wallace's desk.

"Are you working for Rock?"

"Definitely not. You can trust me, Harry. Based on my experience, you've got bigger problems than you thought."

That suggestion confirmed what had been troubling Harry. "I'll see you at five o'clock."

"I have your address. See you then."

What did Cooperhawk have in store for him? He read his first three comments.

@Miningmonster: Howitzer, you're going down. Loser.

@GWB5645: I'm done. Selling.

@BBContracting: Liar.

Next up, he watched a video of an idiot making up lies about Sceptre. *Isn't this illegal?*

The front door echoed through the Tudor when it banged shut. "Dad!"

"In the library."

Mac arrived looking like his true self, a woodsman. He was bundled up in a thick grey sweatsuit and a down vest. His pants were tucked into his well-worn Arc'teryx hiking boots, and his curly ~~red~~ hair poked out of his green wool beanie.

"Hi, son. What a day." Osler greeted Mac, hopped onto Wallace's chair, and gave a long, low growl. "Osler, stop. Great news. We've got the salmon issue closed. I'm waiting for confirmation from Nightingale."

"How?"

"When it's done, I'll share the story." Mac squinted at his father like he didn't understand. "Son, check this out." Harry moved his computer to the end of the desk. Mac leaned in and watched the influencer video.

"Biggest idiots." He shook his head. "That's all they got? It's a rehash of old crap."

"More lies." Harry noticed a knowing grin on his son's face. "You've got the results." Mac waved his binder in front of Harry.

"Dad. GOAT!"

It was difficult keeping up with Mac's lingo. Harry squeezed his eyebrows together. "GOAT?"

"Frickin' unbelievable. Dad, we need to halt the stock for the Monday open. The drill core results are awesome." He showed his father the dog-eared summary page. "Those influencer shorts will get creamed."

Harry read the first page of the results once, then again. They were beyond his expectations. Motherlode material.

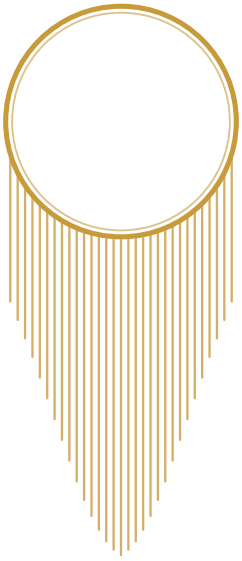
"Congratulations, Mac." The father and son shared a celebratory hug. "I'll see you in the kitchen in fifteen minutes. I need to shower." Harry headed down the hallway and heard Mac prepping a fire in the library.

"Osler, it's a sweet day. Granddad would be ecstatic."

Harry stopped halfway up the staircase to digest his son's words. When would he ever be able to share the truth with Mac about who the real Wallace Howitzer was?

Harry's phone pinged. *Look at that.* It was an email from Nightingale with a headline stating, "For Distribution Monday a.m. Sceptre Gold Investigation Closed."

"We're in business again, Mac," he shouted. "Finally."



CHAPTER 22

For the first time in months, Harry had a rare moment to hope—hope for the future of Sceptre and the opportunities it would bring for him and Mac. He buttoned up his white starched dress shirt and tucked it into his black jeans. He slid on his tan house shoes. Though he hadn't shaved, his hair was washed clean, tossed rather than combed. For Sceptre, the worst times appeared to be over. He bounded downstairs.

Mac sat at the kitchen table, waiting for his father like he did when he was a kid, with his straight-A report card, a beaming smile, and sparkling hazel-green eyes.

"Let me start. This issue with the salmon is fixed."

"Yes!" Mac's smile grew wider. "Did Hunt come back from the assignment and realize he screwed up?"

"Don't know the details, it doesn't matter. I have the verification from Nightingale that Sceptre was not responsible for the incident. Case closed. News released on Monday morning. The timing is perfect."

"And the Taku Nation will be back on board," Mac said. "Timing couldn't be any better. My biggest worry was we wouldn't be able to proceed up there."

"You and me both." Harry grabbed a chair and pulled it up to his son. "Show me this next piece of great news."

"The results are better than I thought, Dad." The two geologists peeled back the information. Page by page, they triple-checked the data. Mac pointed to a photograph of granite rock laced with gold veins.

"That's exactly what we want to see," Harry said. *Good for Wallace*. He'd had the instinct for digging into an opportunity no one else had considered. There was at least one redeeming quality about his father. Harry had his ideas about the next steps for the Atlin plan, but he wanted Mac's input first. "What's next?"

"I want to get up there ASAP and drill Granddad's target." Mac carefully unrolled his maps across the kitchen countertop. "I've been working on this for a while." He pointed. "This is the sweet spot. We have about a three-week window for the rig and access before winter hits hard."

Mac was correct. Harry needed to focus shareholder attention on this good news: this discovery. To wait for spring would be a missed opportunity.

"Next. How much money should we raise?" Harry had a number in mind. Ten million.

"First, focus on drilling the Pictou zone. We fund the initial drill program. We should include cash to start building out the engineering plan for the shutdown for Stewart, as much as we don't want to go there, it's time." Mac checked his calculations and passed the document to his father. "Eight million to start."

"Ten to be safe. I'll put the wheels in motion." The reality of the state of the Stewart mine couldn't be ignored. Harry checked Mac's worksheet. "We have enough credit facility to get that drill rig up there. Now we have to find one."

"I have." Mac opened his phone and showed Harry the email. The message included an attachment: a signed confidentiality report from the drillers. "They wrapped up a job in Terrace. They could be on-site in three days. Ready when we are. The minute we get approval to send out the press release, I'll call the chief. Explain in detail that Sceptre wasn't at fault. Confirm we are good partners."

"That is the plan. Let's get into this budget." The father and son diligently worked for the next few hours, running the numbers. There were few disagreements, but Harry was impressed by how Mac had grown into his position. He was no longer a young geologist. He was operating like a vice president.

The afternoon had flown by: it was after four o'clock, and Harry didn't want Mac to meet Cooperhawk. "Okay, let's go. Call the geologists for an early breakfast meeting before the Monday open. The four of us will have a call with Compliance. With everybody in the same room, we get approval to release

the results. We are on our way. Have that rig waiting. Can you start working on the press release?"

"On it." Mac packed up his bag except for the original report. "I'm going to put this in the wine cellar. It's good luck, like Granddad did with all our original reports. And a good backup for security."

"Hold on. You get going. I can do that." Mac and Wallace had these quirky traditions, but the last thing Harry wanted was for his son to meet the squatter downstairs.

"No way. It's tradition."

"Mac, I can do it."

"Dad, seriously? I know where to put it."

Should Harry go with him? No, that might provoke Pookmis. The basement door rattled open. He heard Mac's heavy steps bouncing down the wooden staircase. He paced the foyer, wishing for the ghost not to appear. Then a loud bang, an unfamiliar sound, came from somewhere.

"Mac." Harry hurried down the stairs. "Mac?"

Mac met him halfway. "Done. Safe and secure. What's with you?"

"Nothing. Did you hear that noise?" They climbed the stairs, and Harry closed the basement door.

"No. Dad, you need to get some sleep. Your mind is working overtime."

"You're right there." He was a bag of nerves. "You have your marching orders."

"I'm out of here." Mac grabbed his things and scurried through the backyard to the alley.

The day delivered an unexpected win. But Hunt's accomplice was still unknown. Could Cooperhawk discover who was behind the sabotage? Because he didn't know—and he wouldn't assume the vendetta toward the Howitzers had disappeared.



At precisely five o'clock, Harry answered his phone. "Cooperhawk."

"I'm out front."

Harry found a battered twenty-plus-foot RV parked in front of his house—the only sign of anything modern was a new long-range Wi-Fi antenna attached to the metal side panel. The dilapidated vehicle showed obvious signs of hard use and abuse, which seemed to confirm some things about its owner. The guy was a has-been. This would be a short visit.The door was ajar, so Harry stepped up into the rig. "Hello?"

"Come on in." Cooperhawk sat on a leatherette bench attached to the built-in dining table.

Harry was surprised by the quality of the interior. The cabinetry was custom. A computer rack housed half a dozen computers, and on a small desk sat an amateur radio. In the back was a clean, tiny kitchen and a twin-sized bed made with perfect hospital corners. Eight pairs of polished cowboy boots

were perfectly positioned on a shelf. But he did notice a strong smell of bleach or disinfectant. OCD, Harry concluded—definitely an odd man.

"Have a seat." Cooperhawk motioned for Harry to sit down across from him.

Harry wiggled his way in. Cooperhawk was tough to look at. His skin was severely scarred, and he still couldn't see the man's eyes through the blue-coloured lenses. But his matching black shirt and pants were starched to perfection. And his belt buckle. *~~Was~~ that a bullet? Yes.*

"This is preliminary." Cooperhawk handed Harry a file. "I didn't go too deep until I knew if I was hired."

Harry didn't know what to expect. The contents of the first folder were a chronological report of his life history, nothing too impressive. The following page was a photo of Harry wearing tight white short shorts and a T-shirt with his tennis team at Queen's.

"Where did you get this?" he asked.

Cooperhawk shrugged.

"The eighties. Solid B in scholastics, but a stellar A-plus in partying and tennis." Harry laughed.

The remaining contents contained articles from the past three decades about Wallace and Harry as the Sceptre golden team. He chose social tattle columns that had reported that the Howitzers attended galas and spent significant sums on auction items that flattered their egos. Harry was quiet, startled by the rehashing of his family history.

"You think my family are flakes." Harry closed the file. He'd seen enough.

"Privileged."

"At one time." Harry pointed to a frame displaying four medals. "What's your story?"

"Army. Three tours. Special Forces. The beginning of the end of my life. Here is your second file. This isn't about me, Harry. Take a look. Here's your son." The paperclip held a bunch of photos of Mac from his private Instagram account. They were a mishmash of party pictures, athletic events, and pretty girls. A stapled set of papers from Queen's revealed Mac's stellar academic success. "You and your son—the players." Cooperhawk reached from under the table and passed him the third folder. "The point of this exercise is to show you my worth. This is what I could find with the limited information available. Open the file."

There was one page: Harry's latest bank statement.

"How on earth?"

"Your email password. Califerrari with an exclamation mark. Your laptop login too?"

"How did you know?"

"Old guy password. Change it."

"I'm that obvious?" The guy had unexpected skills. "I understand what you've done here. Research is your expertise."

"Like what you see?" Cooperhawk asked.

"I'm not sure. Now, tell me what you found out about Keefer Gold." Harry wanted to see a file on the company.

"Eight percent of Sceptre. Moving to nine. No visible owners. Russians running this puppy." Cooperhawk nodded to confirm his facts.

This was a good summary, but it offered nothing new for Harry. And no file. "But they've been buying stock for a while. Makes no sense. Did you find anything about Serge Sobakin?"

"Serge? Tell me more." Cooperhawk pursed his lips. "Don't know about him."

Harry described his visit to the business centre, but he and Mac had found nothing about Sobakin in their online search.

"That's a good find, partner." He scribbled illegible notes on a yellow pad of paper. "So, let's get down to it. Who are the Howitzers' enemies?"

"I haven't got a clue, but since my father died, I've discovered the Howitzers aren't as advertised, Cooperhawk."

"That's obvious. Are you going to share with me the real story, or don't you trust me?"

"I just met you." Harry scratched his dry forearms. Blood spotted through his white sleeves. Cooperhawk noticed but didn't comment.

"And I just met you, Harry. You don't have many options to find out who's after your ass. I think if you go to the authorities, they will find something you don't want them to know. Correct?"

Harry swallowed and nodded.

"But I need your intel. Are we doing this deal? If not, sayonara."

Harry got up from the bench. The cut on his forehead was pulsing. He weighed his options. Given the potential motherlode

results from Atlin, he couldn't afford another sabotage event. It appeared Cooperhawk had talent, and he was undercover. He had to give the guy a shot.

"We are doing this deal."

Harry threw up his hands and cursed as he described the shameful details of the family secret. Cooperhawk listened, asked questions, and took more notes as he explained Easton's crime and Wallace's cover-up.

"That Easton was nasty. You said this Sying guy didn't have family?"

"No idea. I discovered the VPD has an open cold case on him. There's more." Harry continued to purge. "First up, the salmon poisoning. There's this RCMP officer in Stewart named Hunt." He explained in detail the history of Hunt and the conclusion. "He committed suicide. Paid off. Can we assume it's all connected? Does Keefer have something to do with paying off Hunt to kill the salmon and hire the vloggers? If so, what else do they have planned? And who are they? Russian gangsters shouldn't give a rat's ass about Sceptre."

"Agree. Slow down. What about your pappy's death?"

"Dad was getting old, but it was a coincidence that he had an aneurysm. He was scheduled for surgery. He died of natural causes—a stroke."

"Uh-huh. Karma. The plane crash?"

"I filled up in Stewart when I landed three days before. Those fuel tanks are old. Probably had condensation—water in the gas. I should have listened to my intuition, but I didn't want to risk running low on fuel." *Or was it Pookmis working*

his spooky ghost stuff? *Plausible*. "Let's go into the Tudor. I have something else to show you."

Cooperhawk pushed himself up from the seat. He reached over to a long cabinet and pushed it open. Inside was a collection of rifles and pistols. He grabbed his thick sweater from the bottom shelf and pulled it on.

Harry wasn't sure if he was supposed to see the cabinet's contents, but it provided more clarity, or was it a quiet reference to other skills? The silent walk to the front door felt long and awkward.

"Come in. Hello, Osler." Since Wallace died, the Westie didn't like being left alone in the house and waited for Harry at the entrance.

"Cooperhawk, meet Osler." The Westie gave the guest a quick tail wag, let out a sharp bark, and raced down the hallway and up the stairs. Harry knew what was happening, but he'd ignore the dog's pursuit. *Pookmis had better stay on the second floor*.

The visitor was drawn to the foyer's oversized sparkly chandelier, then turned his attention to the art walls.

"Boots off?"

"Boots on are fine."

"Fancy place." Cooperhawk stopped and gazed at the art. "Your daddy was a big-time collector."

Harry straightened the Carr *Wood Interior* and followed Cooperhawk down the hallway.

"Wallace loved Canadian art."

"Don't get it." Harry offered Cooperhawk a drink as he poured himself a double. He shook his head. "On the clock. Let's get

to the bottom line here. Guys like you are high maintenance. Demanding. Difficult."

"Not me. I've told you the truth and need answers." Harry wondered if Cooperhawk was really describing Rock—and had to admit, if so, the description fit.

Cooperhawk listened intently with his hands on his hips. "Something else will drop. Don't know what's next, but yours and Mac's lives could be in jeopardy."

"Don't say that. We haven't discussed your terms?" Harry asked. The guy was beyond strange, but he was clear-headed and his only hope. The local police wouldn't be an option given the exposure of the sordid family history.

"Fifty down and another fifty thousand when I find the perp who's giving you a rough time."

"Then what? What do we do then?"

"TBD," Cooperhawk said, nodding. "Harry, I don't have all day. You good with the terms?"

"Assuming this isn't a binding contract deal?"

"Harry."

"I get it. Have a seat. Be right back." With a quick step, he hurried into the library, changed his laptop and email password, and opened the safe. He hadn't thought about what to do with the perp, as Cooperhawk called him. He returned to the kitchen. "It took me a minute to change my passwords. We need to talk more about what happens when you do find who has been making my life . . . dire."

"Later, Harry. Let me find him."

Harry passed the investigator a purple Crown Royal bag. "Open it. I found this knife, along with this newspaper article, in Wallace's library a few days ago. I can't sleep these days. It was tucked in a box of old coins in the safe. The story confirms Wallace's letter. Sying Liu was murdered at the Hotel Vancouver. I couldn't believe he kept this too."

"The Howitzer golden trophy." Cooperhawk studied the razor-sharp dagger. He flicked the pointy tip with his forefinger and passed it back to Harry. "Can I keep the article?"

"All yours." Cooperhawk showed his grey teeth with a teasing smile like he enjoyed his own joke more than Harry. "Do you want the knife?"

"Nope."

Harry didn't like the long, sharp hunting knife. Dangerous as hell in the wrong hands. It had no practical purpose unless skinning dead animals was your thing. The blade was placed on the kitchen table.

"Anything else, Harry? I don't want any surprises. And I want my moola."

"Tuesday. When can I expect answers?"

"Cool it, partner." A clanging sound rang through the house. Cooperhawk jumped to attention. "What's that?"

"Water pipe problems. I'm on it." Harry had to remain calm. "We're set. I'll walk you out."

When Harry returned, he encountered a trail of feathers from the foyer into the kitchen and discovered Pookmis waiting for him. The apparition swayed back and forth, pointing his bony black finger.

"Nice blade," he said with a low, raspy voice. "Danger ahead, Gold Man."

"Get the hell out of here, I mean it."

"Don't have attitude with me." The ghost faded behind the kitchen wall.

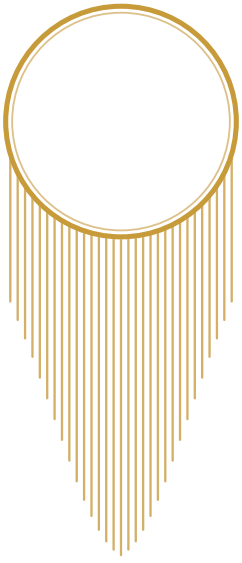
"Danger?" Harry sat down at the kitchen counter and sipped the last of his bourbon. *What a day*. The Atlin results, the Cooperhawk meeting, and the opportunity to disclose the ugly truth to someone about the Howitzers' fortune had all come to fruition.

He stared at the knife. *What should he do with the so-called golden trophy*? It shouldn't be in the Tudor—it was evidence of a long history and a reminder of the past he didn't want around.

His briefcase. He reached over, unzipped it, and slipped the dagger into a side pocket. He would toss it in an alley dumpster somewhere down in the bowels of the Downtown Eastside tomorrow. No one would notice or recognize him down there disposing of the murder weapon.

Was he being paranoid about the evidence? *Maybe.*

But nothing else can go wrong.



CHAPTER 23

MONDAY MORNING

Five o'clock Monday morning. Harry hadn't slept. Everything was moving in the right direction with Sceptre, but he was plagued with worry. There were too many questions, and no explanations.

His cellphone buzzed. "Good morning, Sergeant Nightingale."

"The press release is out. I don't like your pushy style, Howitzer."

"Can I remind you I was the one who did nothing wrong?"

"Enough. I agreed to do this because a messed-up, dead officer left me a paper trail full of lies. It shouldn't have happened

on my watch. Remember, this debacle is between you and me, and if there is any fallout, I will show up at your house and arrest your ass."

"Don't you care who paid him off? Because I do. I need to know."

"Not my problem. Howitzer, the case is closed." He hung up.

The sergeant's arrogant message was clear. His only concern was himself.

The environmental crisis was averted through unconventional means. The salmon sabotage had been a bizarre set of events, from beginning to end. Sceptre was free from any liability. As CEO, ~~that was his~~ responsibility, and ~~he~~ delivered to the shareholders.

Would Wallace approve? No. He'd find some fault.

"Osler, let's go to Yvonne's." He tightened his tie, grabbed his briefcase and coat, dropped off the Westie, and left the neighbourhood in a hurry, weaving through the early morning traffic. Drivers laid on their horns. *Dicks. Nobody liked a Ferrari driver.*

The Toronto Stock Exchange conference call, held at the Hotel Vancouver, would be the most important event of his career as a CEO. Sceptre needed the TSX's approval to distribute the Atlin press release, and once that happened, the company would be on its way to being the buzz of the mining business—again.

He turned into the hotel drive. The engine rumble caught the valet's attention.

"Good morning. Nice to see you, Mr. Howitzer," the doorman said to Harry and eyed the black beauty. "I'll take care of this. Have a good morning."

"You too." Harry undid his long raincoat and raced up the stairs to the boardroom Mac had booked. The next familiar face he saw was the café manager, a friendly guy named Christo, who had immigrated to Canada from Greece about thirty years ago. He was pudgy, with happy cheeks and welcoming eyes. Christo greeted Harry with a big hug.

"Nice to see you, Christo."

"Harry. You look ~~too~~ . . . tired. Are you okay?" Christo quickened his steps to keep up with Harry, who was rushing toward the Langara boardroom. "Harry, I own Sceptre. I bought it last year." He blew out a frustrated breath. "So bad, maybe I buy more? Five hundred shares?"

Harry hated these conversations. "Christo, I can't say anything confidential about Sceptre. I've got to get going. I have an important meeting."

Christo kept pace with him. "Harry, sorry about your papa. I liked him. He always told me stock tips. He spent a lot of time in the hotel."

Harry did not need to know anything more about his father. If Christo did get stock tips, he needed to keep them to himself.

"We all miss him." *Another lie.* "Let's chat later." Harry shut the door and got himself organized in the small boardroom. A conference call telephone was placed in the centre of the long table. *Where ~~was~~ Mac*?

The door swung open. Manuela, a cheery, short hostess, entered. She threw up her arms. "¡*Dios mío!* My, my, you need to eat."

"Nice to see you, Manuela. How are you?" Harry grasped her warm hand. Her golden skin highlighted her friendly blue eyes.

"Yes, yes. I have breakfast. Don't worry, your guests have arrived." She rolled in a cart with coffee, fruit, and pastries. "Do you want eggs?"

"No, that's fine. Thank you, my dear." *Manuela was good people*.

"I can fatten you up. Come to my house for Sunday dinner. I have a pretty daughter. Single."

"I might take you up on that, Manuela." His attention moved on; there was Mac.

"Dad, sorry," Mac said, tossing his courier bag on the table. "Fred and Trevor are right behind me." He dropped his parka on the boardroom chair.

"And? Is there a problem?" Mac's hair was even more shaggy than usual, with beads of perspiration on his forehead.

"No. All good." The instant change in his demeanour gave his father confidence. "I wanted to check the bulletin boards and the influencer feeds to make sure there was no leaked intel."

"That's what I want to hear. There they are. Good morning, Fred." Harry shook both men's hands. "Trevor." He motioned for the men to take a seat, poured himself a glass of water, and sat at the table. "Let's do this, gentlemen. The market will open in half an hour." The day was going according to plan. "Mac, close the door and make the call, please."

On the second ring, the line was answered by two senior officers of the Exchange.

"Hello, I am Jennifer Phillips, and with me is Cameron Drake. What do you have for us, gentlemen?"

"Thank you for the meeting. We have Mac Howitzer, Fred Munzinger, and Trevor Adams on the line, and yours truly, Harry Howitzer. Trevor and Fred are registered geologists with impeccable credentials, having overseen the core examination at the Atlin site and ~~at~~ the core analysis shack on Main Street in Vancouver. I'll ask Fred and Trevor to provide you with a brief overview of the findings to date. Gentlemen, over to you."

"This is Mac Howitzer. Nice to meet you both. Before we get into this, Sceptre has renamed the prospect we are speaking about today to *Gijook*."

"That's interesting. What does *Gijook* mean?" Jennifer asked.

"Golden Eagle. It's from the Taku Nation language. And they are our partners on the project." Mac glanced over at his father for approval.

"Appropriate. Okay, Trevor, what do you have for us?" Cameron asked.

"All procedures were conducted to ensure the preservation and integrity of the samples and the assay recordings. Please note that this is preliminary, and hundreds of hours of testing are still required for our final analysis. Fred, please provide the details."

"There was a presence of gold and copper in ~~one hundred and twenty-six~~ core samples tested out of ~~one hundred and forty~~. Various cores showed gold contents ranging from ~~forty~~

to ~~one hundred and twenty~~ grams per tonne. In addition, the core sampling indicated a widespread area with gold content approximating over six hundred metres at depths down to eighty-five metres." He stopped as Trevor started to speak.

"For clarification, as a comparison, a decent initial discovery would be ~~twenty to thirty-five~~ grams per tonne. In our opinion, Gijook is a major find."

"Right, we've received your data. Can you give us a minute?" Jennifer asked.

They went offline, and Mac muted the conference phone.

"Nice work, you two." The guys ~~had~~ kept the facts straight to the point, as Harry had requested. However, the Exchange could be tough. One could never forecast how they might interpret data or the procedures.

"The Howitzers can turn up the heat." Trevor chugged a glass of water and helped himself to a sticky bun.

"You're not kidding," Fred said, tapping the table like he was playing a piano.

The four men turned silent.

Mac reached over and grabbed pieces of melon off the fruit plate. "Stressed A.F."

"Mac. Business etiquette, please." His son wiggled his auburn eyebrows back at his father.

The two geologists grabbed their phones and scrolled. Harry stared out the window, and Mac continued to review his data. Five minutes later, the conversation restarted.

"Gentlemen, hello?"

Mac unmuted the line. The four men leaned toward the phone's speaker. "Yes, Jennifer, we are all here."

Harry nibbled at his lip; he needed good news.

"Under these circumstances, Sceptre, at the direction of the TSX, is halted for trading immediately, with the condition to release the results after the close. The stock will resume trading tomorrow morning."

"You're halting the stock now?" Harry's heart slowed. *Relief.*

"Yes, it's been halted. We look forward to approving your press release this afternoon."

"Mac will send it to you. Thank you."

"Call us if you need anything," Cameron concluded the call.

"Yes. We did it." Mac jumped up, hugged his dad, and shook the geologists' hands. "Let's get at it."

"Thank you, Trevor and Fred." For the first time all morning, the vice around Harry's head loosened its grip.

"Happy to be involved, Harry," Trevor said. He turned to Fred. "Wish we could be investors. I smell motherlode." The men nodded at the same time. "Mac, you are a hell of a geologist."

"Thanks, Trevor. This one is special—for Granddad."

"The Howitzers are back in the gold business," Harry laughed with confidence. "Yes, we are." His phone vibrated in his pocket. "One moment." His voice dropped as he moved to the corner of the room. "April, it's early. What's going on?"

"Harry, you can't ignore me. We need to visit the Shaman. He can't just snap his fingers and make Pookmis disappear. I just spoke to him. He warned me that Pookmis's omen will grow stronger the longer he remains in your life."

"I don't know how to respond to ~~your comment~~, but I can't talk now," Harry said, aware of Mac eyeing him. "Thank you. I'll call you later."

"Who was that, Dad?" Mac asked. His head was cocked, trying to read his father's face.

"April. Let's get that press release ready." Though Harry had a massive win, her call was a reminder of his reality.

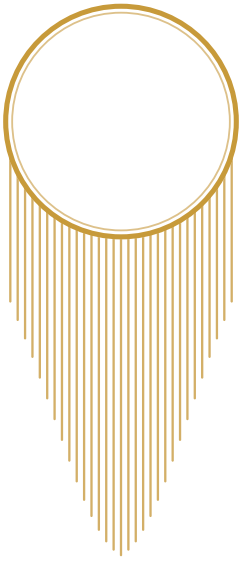
Mac handed him a page titled "Draft" from his file folder. "I took the liberty of writing it late last night. I knew it would be approved."

He read the content line by line, ensuring accuracy. "Nice work. Legal approved?"

"Yes." Mac nodded. "Keep reading."

The last paragraph stated, "Sceptre supports the positive outcome of the RCMP investigation on the mine site and thanks the authorities for their efforts and conclusion. With the tragic loss of the salmon habitat, the company, though not liable, will fund the complete restoration of the stream, partnering with the local members of the Nisga'a Nation."

A gratifying smile beamed across Harry's face. "You're smarter than any Howitzer I know. Send this to the TSX for approval. Let's get this outstanding news out after the close."



CHAPTER 24

MONDAY MORNING

Three knocks rapped on Zi's bedroom door. Half-asleep, he fumbled with the buttons of his silk pyjama top. The alarm clock read 6:30 a.m. Markets were opening. "Hello?" he called out. "It's Serge. I need to talk to you."

"Come in." Zi flicked on the bedroom lights. The room was the size of a small Vancouver one-bedroom apartment. His private retreat was filled with mahogany furniture, including an oversized writing desk. The white walls showcased the new colourful art he had picked up from Martha's gallery the day before.

Serge stepped inside and tugged at his thinning blond hair. He shut his eyes for a moment, as if deep in thought.

"Serge? What's the matter?"

"Sceptre has been halted. ~~And~~ the RCMP issued a news release."

Zi froze. "Halted? Did they blame Howitzer for the accident?" *~~Was~~ it possible that Hunt ~~had~~ changed his mind and submitted the report*?

"No. Case closed," Serge said.

"Closed? That's it? I don't understand. Why is the stock halted?"

"Pending news. I think it's Atlin."

Zi hopped off the bed. "Did Dashi put in all those stock orders last week?"

"He did." Serge paused and massaged his temples. "And he went big."

"He what?" Zi grabbed his housecoat and slid into his slippers. He flew out the bedroom door and found Dashi at his desk, in a panic, speaking on the phone.

"Come on, dude. Help me out here." Dashi slammed the phone down and turned to his father with a sheepish look. "All my orders were filled, Baba."

"How deep?"

"It's hard to say." Dashi checked his calculations. "A lot."

"You were only supposed to put in a short with low exposure," Zi shouted. "That was incredibly stupid."

"You wanted results. I maxed out." Dashi shouted back. "Worst timing ever."

Wei burst through the door in ~~her~~ Lululemon outfit and long coat. "This better be good. I cancelled my trainer. What's up?"

"Is that what ~~you are~~ calling him?" Dashi rolled his eyes. "Give me a break, Wei."

"Dashi, screw off."

"What are you two talking about?" Zi asked.

Zi noticed the tension between the twins. There were few times when they raised their voices with each other. It seemed strange.

"Dashi is being a jerk. What's going on?"

"Did you know Sceptre has big news?" Zi asked. "The stock is halted."

"What?" Wei's brows furrowed. "I saw him Friday night for a quick drink. There was no mention of a stock halt."

"Nothing? Are you sure?" Dashi asked.

"Yes, I'm sure. But he said he knew about Keefer and Serge. Thinks Keefer is run by Russians. Nothing about us."

"How did he know about me?" Serge asked. "That's strange."

"He wouldn't say."

"And then Howitzer somehow manoeuvred the RCMP to close the case, and he didn't tell you?" Dashi threw down his pen on his desk. "Howitzer is such a dick. Wei, why didn't you tell us sooner?"

"Dashi, tell you what? That's all I know." Wei flopped down on the sofa. "Obviously something changed on the weekend, because he was frustrated Friday night. Dashi, what's happening with the shorts?"

"I kind of blew it. Went bigger than I promised."

"Dashi Liu, I warned you not to do more than you promised Zi."

The twins started to argue. Dashi's overconfidence prevented good decision-making. "You should have listened to your sister, Dashi," Zi shouted.

Serge stepped in closer and, with a firm voice, said, "Stop. All of you. Nothing we can do about this now." He rubbed his chin as he put together his words. "I suspect this is a big announcement. The Exchange doesn't halt trading for minor updates. We will have to wait until Tuesday morning."

"Dashi, are you kidding me?" Wei said. "That was so stupid."

"Wei, stop." Zi motioned for his kids to be quiet. "I need you to find Howitzer. Find out whatever you can. Put on that Liu charm."

"I understand what's at stake, Zi." Wei let out a huff and gave Dashi a sharp elbow to his shoulder before leaving the room. "I will figure this out. As usual."

Dashi rubbed his face. "I didn't expect this."

"Dashi, if the release is good news, Sceptre stock is going to skyrocket. And we are short," Serge said and gave Dashi a dirty look. "There's a lesson to be learned here. I'm going to Richmond. Enough disappointing news for one day."

Zi had had enough drama too, and left Dashi to figure out his mistakes. He shuffled down the hallway, glancing at his new art walls, contemplating the news from the last half an hour.

He put the situation in perspective. The Lius had lost money on this trade, but they still owned a lot of Sceptre stock. Dashi's

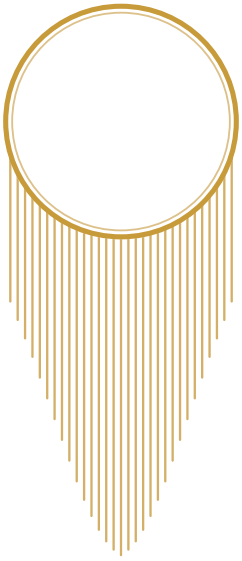
mistake wasn't a showstopper, but it was his son's stupidity and deceit that he was disappointed about.

Zi found Wei in the kitchen. His daughter was leaning against the counter, staring at nothing. "Wei, what's wrong?"

"Dashi knows better." She straightened up, went to the fridge, and poured herself a glass of orange juice. "I'll do whatever it takes."

"I know you will." But Zi knew his daughter like no one else. Something important was upsetting her. "Do you want to talk about something?"

Wei licked her lips, finishing her glass of juice. "Nothing you need to know."



CHAPTER 25

TUESDAY MORNING

It was four in the morning. *Forget sleep.* Zi showered and dressed in his comfortable fleece ~~sweat suit~~. The worry of Dashi's decision was top of mind, but worse, what if Howitzer had good news? That situation would make his efforts more difficult.

A walk would be nice before the market opened. But when he opened his front door and peeked outside, the pitch-black, wintry wind whipped the pine treetops back and forth. He shut the door and headed down the wide hallway, stopping at his new grande dame, *Wood Interior*, positioned in the centre of the feature wall. Zi studied the Carr signature in the bottom-right

corner of the brown-black tree trunks. It was plainly there. Why hadn't he noticed it before?

He studied the painting.

Something didn't feel right about a lot of things in his life.

The living room was his final stop. He poured himself a short snifter of cognac, turned on the gas fireplace, and got comfortable on the soft velvet sofa. Shadows from the dancing flames bounced off the walls.

What would the stock open at? It ~~had~~ closed on Friday in the mid-two-dollar range. Mid-three dollars? The Lius ~~could~~ manage that trade.

After another sip of ~~C~~ognac, his eyelids felt heavy. He sank further into the feather-down toss cushions. He forgot his worries.

"Mr. Zi."

That was a faint voice. Zi snapped out of a deep slumber.

"Serge. What time is it?"

"Time to get to your office. Dashi and Wei are waiting for you."

Zi wrestled himself up off the sofa and followed Serge into his home office.

"Did you sleep, Baba?" Dashi asked.

"No. Wei, what's happening? Any luck?"

"He didn't answer my calls."

"This halt is ~~Howitzer's~~ scam," Dashi said, checking his phone repeatedly.

"Dashi, the Howitzers are pros. There's no scam," Zi said with a raised voice. He was tired of hearing the silly excuses.

"But the Hunt idea worked, Baba. Look how many shares we bought. And cheap. We own about nine percent of Sceptre. Maybe nine and a half." Dashi's eyes lit up. His fingers flew across his keyboard. "Okay, here it is, the Sceptre press release."

Dashi read the words out loud to the room of eager listeners.

Serge leaned against the doorframe and began swearing in Russian as Dashi read the core results.

"Get this," Dashi said, "they are fixing the salmon stream too?"

Wei moaned, "Wow. Ridiculous."

"I want to puke." Dashi turned to his father, face flushed. "That's the news. Friggin' stellar results and a new stream."

"Serge, this is good news," Zi said. His right-hand man confirmed with a nod. "Howitzer has horseshoes, you know where."

"Boss, we borrowed the stock from Dashi's brokers. The orders were in." He checked his watch. "That stock has hit the market for the opening. It's sold. We can't stop the trade."

"Serge, I'm not a neophyte." Zi knew how shorting stock worked.

"We only make money if the stock goes down. That was our bet, and that's our spread. Now we are facing the reverse. We are going to owe those brokers big time for this mistake." Serge shook his head.

"The damage is done." Zi was still holding out hope for the best-case scenario. He clenched his hands and checked Dashi's computer screen. It was 6:35 a.m. Sceptre's first bids were flying—already at $5.50.

"Holy shit." Dashi started to punch his phone's calculator. He repeated the calculation. "Screwed." He showed his father the number, embarrassed to say it out loud.

"Sell, Dashi, call the brokers. Take our losses before it gets worse," Zi called out. "I've had it." *What a waste of money—influencers*. "Wei, I want real information."

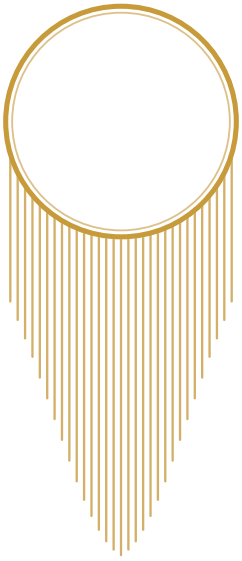
"I'm trying, Zi." Wei fired daggers at her red-faced brother, who was madly making telephone calls, trying to bail the family out of the debacle. "I'm out of here," Wei called out to Dashi. "Bro, listen to me next time. Later."

Zi refocused on the glowing, green numbers, listening to Dashi stumble through his instructions to the brokers. *An absolute disaster*. He got out of his chair and massaged his neck, stiff from falling asleep on the sofa. "I'll be in the living room if you need me."

The snifter on the coffee table had a couple ~~of~~ drops of ~~C~~ognac remaining. Back on the sofa, he savoured the last of the glass. Dashi's expensive Ivy League education did not prepare him for the realities of the street. Zi was reminded of the 10,000-hour rule. Dashi needed 9,000 more hours. His son's hubris had gotten in the way of being smart.

It was time to change the master plan. The good news for Sceptre was nothing but disastrous news for Zi. Short on time and advantage, he would take charge of the Howitzer file.

Every option was in play.



CHAPTER 26

WEEKS LATER

Gold Man hadn't noticed that Pookmis had moved into Father's room. *Pookmis ~~was~~ not hiding anymore. He ~~was~~ a Howitzer.* Gold Man had emptied the room and shut the door for good. ~~The~~ photos of Father still stood on the two tall dressers, gathering dust. Bright oil paintings of trawlers covered the walls. They reminded Pookmis of his fishing days with *Gull*. *They were hard and empty years. Now in the afterlife, he stood at the helm, fulfilling his purpose. The control was delicious.*

Pookmis heard Gold Man arrive home early from work. For the past few weeks, his brother had been in a happy mood because he'd found more gold.

The rich get richer.

Pookmis shuddered. *And the Johnsons had been tossed like trash.*

That afternoon, Pookmis watched his brother sample bourbons from the collection of bottles he'd kept in the living room bar. *Day drinking*. After his first glass, he started making telephone calls, boasting to his friends about Sceptre. Each time, the story became more embellished. *Nauseating*.

The doorbell rang.

Pookmis skirted to the top of the stairs. The tall man with blue glasses arrived at the front door, and Gold Man invited him into the living room.

"Cooperhawk, it's been weeks since I hired you. And you've given me nothing. You should be embarrassed."

Gold Man started to spout off about how much money he'd given the man. *He needed answers yesterday*.

"Hey, slow down." Cooperhawk moved the bourbon bottle to the other end of the coffee table. "You're right. Things have not gone as planned. I scoured the internet. A solid week, but I couldn't find any one person or group grossly slamming Sceptre. Some nasty comments, but nothing that was a red flag for me. Next search was to find out about your guy, Sying Liu. I tried to tap into the Canadian immigration system to see if I could find any details about him, but three-quarters into it, I got flagged."

"So, you didn't find anything, Cooperhawk?"

"I didn't, Harry. I went to Plan B. I tried to access the Chinese public databases and genealogy sites for links to Sying Liu. I got a start. There's someone in Guangzhou named Zi Liu. I think he might be his son."

"You think? A son? Come on. BS."

"Harry, those Chinese firewalls are impressive. I got kicked out before I could confirm my source. But I found someone who might work out. A contact named Viper Byte. She's the best—a deep diver, inside the system. I'm getting the intro from my network."

"Come on. Viper Byte? That's ~~not the name of anyone~~."

"That's her name, Harry."

"I'm losing my patience. Prove yourself, or I want my money back. You've got a Christmas deadline. Or you're fired."

Cooperhawk got off the couch. "Partner, don't talk to me like that. What you've asked me to do is find a needle in a haystack."

"Seemed easy for you to take that first money grab," Harry said with a slight slur.

"You're going to owe me an apology when you sober up. I'll be in touch." Cooperhawk waited for a response. "Harry?"

"We'll talk tomorrow, Cooperhawk."

"Good idea." The man let himself out, mumbling unfavourable comments about Harry's attitude.

Pookmis dropped from the second floor to the first. "Gold Man."

Harry jumped up in his seat. "You. Are you trying to give me a heart attack?"

"No, that's not my plan," he said, gazing into Gold Man's glassy eyes. "That visitor put you in a bad mood. You trust that guy, do you?"

Harry sat on the edge of the cushion and tried to appear to be on his game. "I was giving him a tough time. Stay out of my business. You're watching me all the time, aren't you?" His voice grew louder. "I asked you a question."

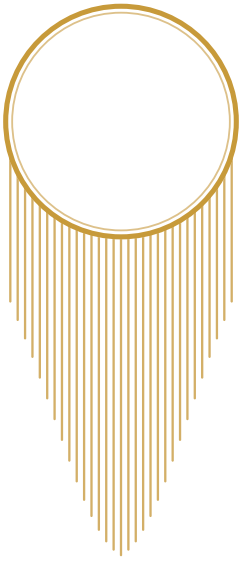
"Get used to it." Pookmis swept back and forth across the room. Gold Man became transfixed by his motion. "Question." Pookmis stopped, level with Harry's eyes. "What would you do if you didn't have any money? Like Benji?"

"That's never going to happen. We've got a motherlode in the making."

"Don't assume anything, brother." Pookmis moved closer; his fishy ~~-tasting~~ breath washed over Harry. "So how would you feel being broke? Could you share a basement suite with someone you didn't know? What if you couldn't afford gas for your car? Eat ramen every night?"

Gold Man attempted to focus on Pookmis, his right eye half-closed. "I wouldn't want to live." He slowly shut his eyes and dozed off.

Fascinating.



CHAPTER 27

NEW YEAR'S EVE

Harry kicked the snow off his shoes and carefully placed the pine logs on the fireplace grate. Sparks flew and the wood crackled. The living room was toasty warm. He and Osler settled into their favourite chair, watching the heavy snowfall blanket the majestic front yard. Harry replayed the past few weeks over his second glass of champagne.

He and Mac had skipped Christmas. The trees didn't get put up, and festive parties had been declined, but he ~~had~~ treasured the time they had spent together playing gin rummy and mapping out Sceptre's future. Both ~~had~~ wanted to ignore the

holiday—one grief, the other anger. The Atlin drill program ~~had run~~ longer and over budget, but they had repaired their relationship with the Taku Nation. They were pleased with the outcome, but still Mac fretted about the next set of results.

April had volunteered to lead the stream rehabilitation, recruiting Nisga'a teens, biologists, and foresters, making plans for the spring melt. With the RCMP case closed, Harry had negotiated hard with the Ministry of Environment and Parks until they ~~had~~ dropped their demands. With April at the helm, she had allayed their concerns by inviting them to be monitors in the process.

Pookmis continued to creep around the house. At night, the intruder scratched at the walls, followed by an infrequent howl, which reminded Harry of a young coastal wolf. *It was scary as hell.* But oddly, there had been no direct encounters between the two of them for weeks.

The dinner Harry and April had shared at the Tudor was memorable. A couple days before Christmas, she ~~had come~~ to Vancouver to meet with government officials to better understand her role in the stream restoration. Harry had prepared his best dish: bolognese. She ~~had been~~ late. Though she carried a flip phone, she never turned it on. Around eight o'clock, ~~she had knocked on the door.~~

"There you are. I was getting worried," Harry ~~had~~ said~~, and~~ helped her with her heavy coat and gave her a friendly hug.

April ~~had run~~ her finger across his long stubble. Her head shake indicated she didn't approve. "It was a good meeting. Had

to get those boys on my side on how this stream was going to come together."

That was news Harry had wanted to hear. He'd invited her into the kitchen and asked if she would like a glass of white wine. As usual, she had refused and insisted they dig into the pasta, claiming she could eat a horse.

Harry had served his heavy garlic-based Caesar salad and bowl of warm, meaty pasta.

"Please have a seat." He had pulled out her chair. "Great having you here. Dig in."

"I will. Looks delicious." After April's first bite, she had settled in. "It was a good day for the salmon, but what about you?" She had taken a moment to check the room. "Is he—"

"He is. Quieter than usual." He had gotten up and checked the hallway. The art frames hadn't been tampered with, and he'd searched for any other telltale signs, like eagle feathers. He'd rejoined April. "Let's not go into too much detail."

"I understand. Koyah is his name. He's one of a kind. But he's not experienced with this exercise—if you want to call it that."

Harry had started picking out bits of romaine lettuce with his fingers and nibbling them. "I don't have time for someone to figure this out, April. I need an expert." He'd realized his voice was probably louder than it should have been.

"No such person. We're lucky to have him." April sized him up. "And it's affecting you. I can tell. You're thin and you look ten years older. And you're eating a salad with your hand."

There was nothing like a reality check when an eighty-something-year-old woman told you how terrible you looked. He'd picked up his fork.

"Whatever Koyah can do. I'll make the time."

"From his research, no one for at least three generations has been confronted with this omen."

"Not reassuring, April." Harry had rubbed the back of his neck. "This whole thing is so unnerving. I can't handle it."

"I understand. He and his grandmother are asking other Elders for advice."

"April, I need this fixed. Something is really wrong." Harry hadn't needed to explain any further.

"Yes, Harry." They had exchanged a long, heavy stare. "You're a good man. I want you back to the original model." She had glanced around the kitchen, then whispered. "Remember, he is mad."

"I know. I can feel him. I'm worried about me."

"So am I." Tears had filled her eyes. "Harry, I will have that glass of wine."

On Boxing Day, Koyah had called April. After New Year's, he should have a plan.

The news had given Harry a little hope.



Osler gave a throaty growl as Cinnamon entered the room. "Stop it," Harry whispered and poked the fire again. "Nice dress. Red is your colour."

"Thank you. What a fantastic way to start the New Year." Cinnamon set down a platter of hors d'oeuvres. "I hope you like this."

"Looks perfect." Harry helped himself to a plate of the fresh oysters and cheeses and sat in his chair.

"This house. I feel so comfortable here. It's like home." She moved closer to Harry and rubbed his knee.

"The Tudor is a lot of work." He set his plate down on the coffee table and got out of his chair. *That conversation ~~was~~ a non-starter.* He added more wood to the fire and sat back down, wanting to discuss something different. "What's going on with you?"

"I've hardly seen you the past two weeks. Atlin keeping you busy?" She moved closer again and placed her hand on his upper thigh. "Or are you ignoring me?"

~~"Never would ignore you." *Cinnamon knew how to turn on the charm.*~~ "Drilling results aren't for two to three months, but we got our financing approved by the TSX. I'm raising ten million dollars." He set down his drink.

"Lots of interest?" she asked with a curious eye.

"I'm sure. It's Sceptre. The Howitzers. Joking." *He wasn't.* "~~We are~~ announcing it on Tuesday." *Champagne made him talk too much.* "That's all I can say right now about it." He could tell Cinnamon had another question by the way she tilted her head—always a sign.

"And you mentioned that Keefer company, what's ~~that all about?~~"

The woman's memory ~~was~~ a steel trap. "No more biz chat," Harry said.

Cinnamon gathered her words. Harry knew what was next. It was probably couple talk.

"Your friend Trudy?" She kicked off her silver high heels. "Is she involved with this financing of yours?"

"Trudy? No. We've talked about this. Trudy and I have been friends since we were kids."

"You've slept with her?"

"Cinnamon . . ." He paused. Harry and Trudy sometimes would hook up when they were loaded. But Trudy ~~had~~ always laughed it off the next morning. ~~He had~~ gotten the message that last time, which was the previous summer at the cottage. "Friends. That's never going to change. She isn't in the stock business. She owns a café that ~~is~~ across from my office."

"The Fuel café?"

"Yes. Topic closed." Harry sensed Cinnamon's pout. "Stop it. Nothing to worry about. Can we please lighten up the conversation?"

The tête-à-tête was a reminder that he and Cinnamon had different expectations of their relationship. Maybe he should tell her the truth about his and Trudy's trysts. That would end the evening and them.

No, that would be rude. Cinnamon ~~was~~ a good person.

Harry's cellphone rang. *Perfect timing. Must be Mac. No, ~~he was~~ in Whistler*. At this time of the night, his son, with his snowboard buddies ~~at Garfinkel's~~, would be doing shots of Don Julio and dancing on the tables. *Anonymous caller. It ~~had~~ to be Cooperhawk. ~~It was~~ about goddamn time.*

"I have to get this. Give me a minute." He headed to the kitchen. Osler trotted behind him, then bounded upstairs. Harry quietly shut the wooden kitchen door tight. "Hello?"

"Harry, hope I'm not too late~~,~~ and you're into the bourbon for the evening?"

"No, just fine, thank you very much."

After that afternoon's bourbon event two weeks ago, the next morning, Cooperhawk had chastised Harry for being rude. Harry had been foggy about his actions, and maybe he had been offside, so he~~'d~~ apologized. But Cooperhawk needed to deliver.

Cooperhawk accepted the apology and started his next chapter of research, peppering Harry with a new set of questions about Sceptre's history and possible enemies. But the PI's production was on par with the Stewart mine, and Harry was worried. About both. "What's up?"

"I've found something, and it's a humdinger."

"Tell me."

"Tomorrow. I will send you my location in the morning. Get back to your gal Cinnamon. And find out her real name, will you?"

"Not an issue."

"Do your homework, partner. Happy New Year."

"This better be good. See you tomorrow."

Harry, thinking about Cooperhawk's big news, looked through the wine fridge racks and found a bottle of vintage Pol Roger. *Nice.* It was minutes to midnight. When he opened the door, Cinnamon was standing in the hallway.

"Hey, what's up?" That was the first time she took any notice of the art collection.

"I forgot the dessert. It's in the fridge." She flashed Harry a cute smile. "Be right back."

"Or maybe you could be the dessert," he said as she passed him and quickly returned to the living room with two slices of precut chocolate cake.

"Is your real name Cinnamon, or is it your nickname?"

"Why?"

"And are you going to share with me your real name?"

"It's a silly one." Cinnamon laughed and pointed to the eight-foot oak grandfather clock. "It's that time."

The hands struck twelve. Harry unwrapped the foil of the bottle, tossed the wire onto the carpet, and popped the cork. "Happy New Year." He poured them each a glass, and they toasted each other, and then kissed deeply. He felt Cinnamon's long arms wrap around his neck.

"Harry." She nibbled on his ear. "You're awesome."

"Hold on." The living room music was turned up. Harry took Cinnamon in his arms, and they danced, kissed, and danced some more until the music started to skip and garble. The romantic interlude was interrupted.

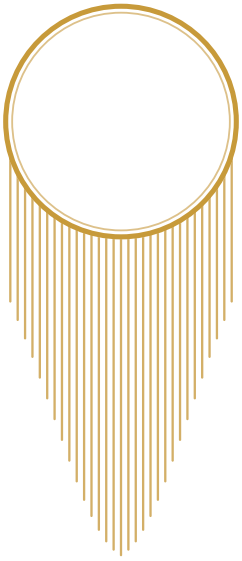
Behind Cinnamon, Pookmis's black shadow emerged, inching along the back grey wall, growing larger, revealing the spirit's long, pointed nose and profile of puckered lips.

After weeks of silence, he shows up now. "Let's go." Harry grabbed Cinnamon's hand and led her upstairs before she could ask any more questions. For some reason, he felt safest in his bedroom, though there was no logical reason why.

The sound of the apparition's scratching like nails on a chalkboard followed them up the staircase.

"Happy New Year, Gold Man," Pookmis whispered in his ear.

Harry's skin crawled.



CHAPTER 28

A voyeur, Pookmis had stalked the couple for hours. They had slept intertwined after a delightful interlude, until Cinnamon stirred at five in the morning. An hour later, she gave Gold Man a kiss on the lips, got out of bed, dressed in the tracksuit she had in her bag, and tapped his arm.

"Harry, last night was great, but the oysters aren't sitting well with me."

Half-asleep, he mumbled, "Get better. Call me," and rolled over.

Pookmis trailed her outside and hid in the cedar hedge. The first call she made was for a ride, but her second call was intriguing.

"Mission accomplished, Zi," she said. "Yes, I feel good. I'll call you at noon. There's a deal to be made."

"Not so fast, lady," Pookmis whispered. "What is your plan for brother? You're up to something."

Cinnamon checked her phone, turned, and gazed back at the Tudor. "Oh, Harry. Why?" Five minutes later, a white Tesla with an Uber sign in the window pulled up. She left.

Pookmis scurried back to the house.

Gold Man slept. But he was breathing heavily, tossing.

"Wallace," Harry muttered as he woke himself up. He wiped the sweat from his chest with his sheet, scratched his neck, and sat up leaning against the headboard. His phone rang.

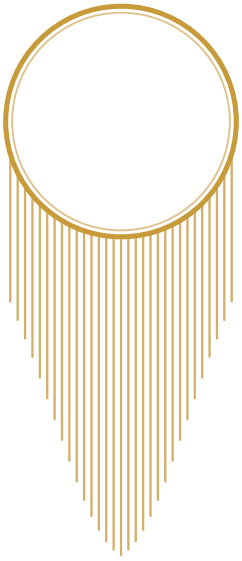
"April, Happy New Year. I didn't realize it was already nine o'clock." He flinched when he touched his scar. "Yes, I'm fine. Looking forward to the new year."

The conversation was short. Gold Man confirmed he would travel to Masset.

Pookmis understood. Aunt April was on a mission.

A Shaman might be the end of Pookmis.

Or not.



CHAPTER 29

Harry flipped through the news and his emails, anxiously waiting to hear from Cooperhawk. A text buzzed. Cooperhawk sent his address, the street next to ~~The~~ Home Depot parking lot. SEE YOU IN FIFTEEN.

Harry fired up ~~the~~ SUV and sped down the empty streets of Vancouver. After running four red lights, he passed the big-box store, made a right, and entered a new world. Dozens of decrepit RVs and dilapidated trailers were parked along the street. It looked like a set from a *Mad Max* movie. The residents had bolted makeshift wooden porches to the sides of the vehicles. Stained sofas lined the sidewalks, implying permanence. Black

garbage bags were piled on the street. Street rats the size of small cats ripped at the plastic, searching for food.

A pair of headlights flashed twice—Cooperhawk. *Where ~~was~~ ~~Harry~~ going to park*? He backed up, turned around, and found a spot half a block away.

The frigid air filled his lungs as he hustled to the RV. It was hard not to stare at the misery lingering along the street. But he felt the glare of the dishevelled dwellers, giving him a clear indication he was an intruder. The world had changed. It was a terrible state of affairs that people didn't have a decent place to live.

Cooperhawk waved him over. The men shook hands.

"Why are you staying down here?" Harry asked inside the RV and noticed all the blinds were closed. Cooperhawk wore a Hells Angels leather vest with a California patch and a navy-and-white bandana neck cover. "You're a Hells Angel?"

"Have a seat, partner."

Harry peeled off his coat and tucked into his regular spot. Cooperhawk grabbed the top file from a stack.

"I thought you were from Texas?" Harry searched his coat pocket for his glasses. His nose caught the strange antiseptic smell again, but it smelled more pleasant than the Tudor did this morning.

"I'm a Texan and I got some luck." Cooperhawk opened the file and handed Harry Sying Liu's death certificate. "I matched with the dates of the newspaper article you gave me."

The document was a genealogy-certified copy of a death registration from the BC government.

"Here is the history of Sying Liu." Cooperhawk pointed to Sying's home address. "Keefer Street."

"I see. Keefer Gold. I'm listening."

"Next. I headed to the dark web and, using my facts from the death reg, I discovered a man named Zi Liu, Sying's son. Figure he's about seventy years old. Sying also had a daughter, Genji, who died over a year ago."

"Sying did have a family." Harry scratched the back of his head. His hair felt oily between his fingers, and he looked up at Cooperhawk. "What's the dark web?"

"Google for bad guys." Cooperhawk flipped to the next page—a map of China. "Then, I got connected with Viper Byte. Smart as hell. She had access to a billion names of Chinese citizens hacked from the Shanghai police servers." He stopped. "You owe me another fifty grand for Viper Byte's intel. I negotiated her down from half a million."

"Next time, ask first. Was she legit?" Harry swallowed and cleared the frog in his throat. "That's stupid expensive."

"Very legit. Fifty grand is nothing compared to what I found. The Liu family was from northern China but moved to the south in the early seventies. Guangzhou area." Cooperhawk circled the area on the map. "And Viper and I spent some time connecting the dots, but we found Zi Liu. He's a pharmacist and a manufacturer of prescription drugs in Guangzhou. Big money."

"Sorry, what am I missing here?" Harry asked, staring at the map, trying to get a sense of the location. He wasn't too familiar with China's geography.

"That's what I ~~thought.~~ Then Viper discovered that Zi Liu was no longer in Guangzhou after she made her phone calls to her local contacts. And she learned Zi Liu's best friend, Chen, was running the pharmaceutical company with his daughter, Jing, because—"

"Because what?" Harry knew the answer. "The Lius moved to Vancouver?"

"Yup. About a year ago. I needed the full story about Zi Liu. So, Viper contacted Chen." Cooperhawk nodded. "He wasn't answering. Then, a brilliant move on her part. She used AI and doctored up a ~~photo~~ with Chen in a compromising ~~position~~ with a seedy woman. She demanded answers from Chen, or the photo would be sent to the wife."

"We blackmailed Chen? That's a terrible thing to do."

"It is, but Chen sang like a bird. According to him, when Zi Liu found out his father had been murdered over a year ago, he went ballistic. ~~He, with his kids,~~ began exporting chemicals from their pharmaceutical operations to Vancouver to produce fentanyl. After we got our intel, the ~~photo~~ was destroyed."

"That's a cheap move, Cooperhawk."

Cooperhawk confirmed with a smirk and a nod.

"But I don't understand the fentanyl thing." Before Cooperhawk could answer, he ~~finished his own sentence~~. "He can't get his money out of China."

"Exactly. The fentanyl business must be funding Keefer." Cooperhawk moved to a different document. "Next. Liu's daughter, Wei, according to Chen, is involved in the production. Son is Dashi. They're twins. Late thirties. I spent time on the

Eastside, and asked around for intel. Took time, but I found her." He showed a photo of a tall woman wearing a disguise of a long red wig and sunglasses on the corner of Water Street and Powell. Her face was severely scarred. "Took this photo. Quite sure she doesn't look like that. I followed her, but she disappeared down an alley. Must have taken off her getup."

The photo was taken close to his office. "I've never seen her," Harry said.

"Her street name is Red."

"Red. All too weird. And the son?" Harry asked.

"Chen didn't know what he was up to, but I'll find out."

"What you are saying is when Zi Liu found out his father was murdered, he moved to Vancouver and turned into a drug dealer and set up Keefer Gold?"

"Producer, actually."

"But how did Zi Liu find out the truth about his father's death now? And not years ago?" Harry got up from the bench. "Maybe somebody told them about the murder?" He prayed no one else knew about Easton. "This is disturbing. All of it."

"My experience? There's never the perfect cover-up for a crime. The truth always comes out. Eventually." Cooperhawk laid a photo of Zi Liu in the army and the twins' high school pictures on the table. "Only pictures I could find. Not helpful."

Harry studied them for a moment. "Homely kids."

"Yup. Next, Serge Sobakin. Put on my HA patch and did the rounds at the East Vancouver clubhouse to see what I could find out."

"And is he in the mining business?" Harry asked.

"Nope, Serge Sobakin is Russian mafia. The Hells Angels hate those Russians. I got the goods at the clubhouse poker game. Turns out Serge and Zi Liu are partners in the fentanyl business. The Russians run the dealers. The Lius provide the product."

"Keefer Gold is a front for the Russian mafia and Chinese gangsters who are buying up Sceptre's stock?" Harry asked. "My God."

"Yup." Cooperhawk sat back and crossed his arms, seeming to relish the salacious details.

"Thanks to the Howitzers." Harry was paying for Easton's bad deeds decades later. "The salmon poisoning. Hunt's Bitcoin receipt. Keefer's stock buy. Liu and gangsters were responsible." Harry gathered the facts in his mind. "Liu wants Sceptre—payback."

"Seems to fit. Now I have to find the Lius." Cooperhawk nodded and gave a small grin. "This is such a great assignment."

"Not great for me. And what do you recommend when we do find them?" Harry asked and contemplated those consequences. "I'm not too excited about marching the Liu family as drug dealers down to the police station, given what they know about the Howitzers." The visual raced through Harry's mind. "Can you imagine? A nightmare."

"Nope, this is how. We find them, then." Cooperhawk's forefinger formed a gun and motioned to pull the trigger with his thumb.

"No. I'm not signing up to kill someone." Harry needed time to comprehend what he'd learned. "We're done for now."

"It's your call, Harry." Cooperhawk shrugged. "And let me know when I can pick up that money."

"Tomorrow. The office."

"I'll be there. Get on with your Sceptre business. I need a couple more days to work on my leads. Then we can make our decisions. Your gal's name?"

"I'll get it," Harry said in a curt manner. He wrestled to put on his coat. "Cooperhawk, I never expected anything like this. It's shocking."

"I figured it was bad. See you tomorrow." Cooperhawk stayed inside.



The street was as ugly as the news Harry had heard. He noticed two scraggy men huddled between their pickup trucks. There was a strange, acrid smell in the air. Harry peered over. One man was shooting up the other with a needle in his neck. *Goddamn Liu and his drugs*.

Harry had his answers. *Should ~~he~~ take Cooperhawk's information to the authorities? If ~~he did~~, the Howitzer story ~~would~~ be finished. Even with the Atlin results,* Sceptre *would get creamed. ~~He and Mac~~ would be socially isolated and ostracized—forever.*

Maybe once Cooperhawk found the whereabouts of the family, Harry could potentially rat them out as drug dealers to the police. Anonymously.

It wasn't the worst idea, but at this point, a Howitzer scandal of epic proportions could blow at any moment. The salmon event would be nothing if the Lius went public with the truth.

Harry's heavy foot goosed the SUV out of downtown. The transition from the gritty Eastside to the pristine Westside reminded Harry of the influence of money. *Life ~~was~~ a tough ride without it.*

But he had one stop before he returned to the Tudor. He parked in the driveway of his and Mac's home. It appeared picture-perfect. The front yard was clean, and his gardener had refreshed the four-foot cement pots with winter annuals beside the front door. Trimmed boxwood lined the walk and driveway. The for-sale sign would go up next week.

The smell of fresh paint wafted through the home. In his bedroom closet, the Cowichan sweater was wrapped in plastic. The ~~cleaners~~ had struggled to eliminate the rotten Pookmis smell. Harry grabbed the sweater and walked out to the backyard. He remembered how excited Wallace had been when he'd gifted it to him. He dumped it in the garbage bin. "Goodbye, Wallace."

After inspecting the interior paint job, he stopped in the kitchen. All the cabinets had been emptied. In the broom closet, he popped open the false floor and opened the safe. He grabbed his gun, holster, and ammunition, set them on the counter, and reminisced about the fabulous years he and Mac

spent together in their home. Mixed feelings best described how he felt about selling the house.

The decision had been made. The house was locked up and ready for sale.

What a brutal day. Time to go for a drive.

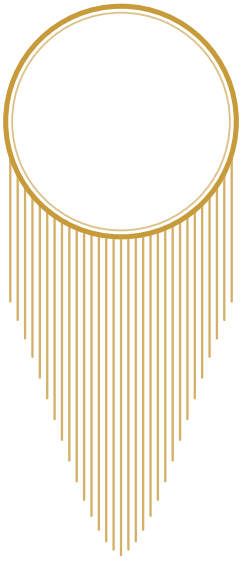
It was late afternoon. He drove the Range Rover over the busy Lions Gate Bridge through tony West Vancouver toward Lighthouse Park. The majestic park, known for its historic lighthouse, was surrounded by the shores of Burrard Inlet. It was a place he used to go with his family as a kid. Half an hour later, the SUV looped its way down the winding road and parked in the muddy lot. No one was around. He got out and smelled the fresh ocean air to clear his cluttered mind. The hike through the old forest, thick with ferns and hemlocks, was familiar, though it brought back his crash at Princess Royal Island. His trek brought him up the slippery rock cliff.

At the top of the bluff, he took a moment to appreciate the blustery Howe Sound on the cold winter's day. It was a beauty. The snowy mountains and blue sky in the background were picturesque as the white-capped waves crashed against the jagged rock face.

Harry pulled the Magnum from his coat pocket. The grey metal was cold and shiny. It was a cool piece he'd bought twenty years ago, and he loved owning it. But he had never pulled the trigger.

And he intended to keep it that way.

Harry tossed the pistol into the deep, choppy ocean.



CHAPTER 30

TUESDAY

Harry had hoped for a day like the ones he used to have—uncomplicated. ~~Not~~ that Tuesday. Before his first coffee, he~~'d~~ encountered a strange twist. At home, ~~he'd gotten~~ an early call from Trudy asking him to meet her at the café.

"Hey, settle down. It's just paint." He held on to Trudy. Her shoulders were taut, and she shook. They stood in front of Fuel. Someone had vandalized her place, tagging it with the words "Leave Bitch" in red letters.

"Harry, tags are cryptic. This message is loud and clear." She wiped her eyes. "Who would do this? My cafe has been here for decades, and I help everyone I can."

Harry squeezed her tighter. "Who knows these days?" Trudy was right: those words weren't typical tags. "Some wacko."

"Thank you for coming." She melted into his shoulder. "You are such a good guy."

Maybe. "What have we got here?" Harry waved to a small white panel truck that drove up to Fuel. The sign on the side of the vehicle read "Words Be Gone."

"Who's this? Harry, did you hire this guy?" Trudy broke away from her friend and breathed a sigh.

Harry nodded. He'd called a developer friend who had given him the name of the best graffiti removal company. ~~But~~ after learning that Trudy had been vandalized, the friend had offered to call himself to fast-track the job.

"Hey, anything for you."

A short, husky man bounced out of his vehicle. He marched up to Harry and Trudy and gave Harry a sweaty handshake.

"Mr. Howitzer?"

"That was quick. Yes, I'm Harry. Nice to meet you. This is Trudy, the owner." Harry was impressed with the young man's professionalism.

"Thank you so much. Please, get this fixed as soon as you can." Trudy pointed to the words on her storefront. "I can't stand this."

"You bet." Jeff, wearing a heavy vest over his black coveralls, pulled down his black toque and assessed the task. "Hmm.

That's a strange one." He pulled his gear out of the back of his organized van. "Give me an hour. Easy fix."

"Do you want to come to the office and wait?" Harry nudged Trudy.

"No, Harry. I'm sixty years old." She let out her recognizable belly laugh. "I'm putting on my big girl pants. You go—get on with your day. Thank you."

"Call me if you need anything." He squeezed her shoulder. Out of the corner of his eye, a woman crossed the street. She walked briskly, and her head was down, staring at the sidewalk. Cooperhawk's photo flashed through his mind. *The wig, the glasses, and the long coat*. It was her, in the flesh—Red. The woman's hands were in the pockets of her long and oversized puffer coat. "What the hell?"

"What?" Trudy asked and checked around. Cars and delivery trucks raced up and down the street to beat the morning rush. "~~What, Harry~~?"

"Come on." Harry grabbed her hand. They manoeuvred around Jeff, who had started the removal process. He locked the café door behind him. "I need to make a quick call." Cooperhawk's phone was off. He texted instead.

RED ON WATER STREET. GET BACK TO ME ASAP.

Trudy shook off her beige sheepskin coat. The red beaded tassels that trimmed the fur clicked when she hung it on a metal chair.

"Harry? I didn't realize how pale you are."

"I'm good." Harry peered out the window—no sign of Red. His hands shook as he texted Cooperhawk again.

SHE'S GONE. CALL ME.

"Sit with me for ten minutes, Harry." Trudy prepared two steaming espressos and a plate of pastries. "Eat. I've never seen you so scrawny." She ran her fingers through his messy hair. "Yuk."

Harry shot back his espresso. "Bourbon chaser?" He grinned.

"A little early—even for you. Are you okay?"

"My life has been a complete train wreck since the sabotage." Harry set down his half-eaten cinnamon bun and wished he could share his story. "I need normal."

Harry's phone pinged. *Cinnamon.* Two texts. She wanted to talk. "Just a sec." He typed.

BUSY

"But I don't understand. Look at Sceptre. Another fortune in the making. Life doesn't sound too bad to me." Trudy shook her head at Harry. "What don't I know?"

"It's complicated." Harry stuffed the last of his second pastry in his mouth.

"You know, you can tell me anything," she said and touched his hand. "Anything."

"Got to go." Harry gave her a wink and headed to the door. *Even Trudy wouldn't believe the life he was living.* "You're the best."

On his way out, Harry handed Jeff his card and told him to call to settle the bill. He slipped him a fifty for a tip. *Jeff was Harry's new best friend.*

A horn blasted as Harry crossed the street in front of traffic.

The driver yelled, "Are you blind?"

Harry ignored him. The metal back door of the family office boomed when it shut. Harry was wheezing and perspiring from walking a block and climbing four sets of stairs.

"How's Trudy?" Mac brushed back his long, ~~red~~ curls ~~of hair.~~ He hadn't cut his mane, and he wouldn't until the results from the next set of samples were in. Months of ~~big~~ hair were part of his good luck ritual. He stood over the map table, which showed the Atlin zones they had drilled, peppered with his sticky notes with comments and calculations.

"She's good now." Harry waltzed over to check out his son's latest work. The kid never stopped working.

"Seems sus. Have you seen that weird woman hanging around?"

"Who's that?" Harry dreaded the answer to his question.

"She's like a burn victim, red hair, sunglasses. When I came in this morning, she was standing in our parking lot."

"And?"

"She's creepy. I don't know what she's doing, but she's around. I should call the cops."

"Leave it, Mac, I'm sure she's harmless." *Harry could only hope*. "Speaking of security, what's the update?" After Harry had learned about the Lius, he'd ordered further action.

"Atlin done. Kirk and the chief are on it. No one is getting on site. Same at Stewart." He stuck his mechanical pencil behind his ear.

"The drones are purchased for both sites?" Harry asked.

"Ordered them this morning. They'll arrive next week. We've got training to do. But why now? ~~Have you heard anything that made you concerned about another incident?~~"

"To be safe." Though Mac was in the room, Harry dialed Cooperhawk. He'd find privacy if they connected. No luck. "Not the way I hoped the day ~~was going to~~ start."

"Dad, you're sweating, ~~you're~~ looking a little out of it." Mac realized what he'd said and chuckled. "Kidding."

"I'm tired. Back to business. Any interest in the financing press release?"

"It's been like three hours." ~~Mac's brows squeezed again, appearing for the second time that he thought his father was not himself.~~

"We need orders." Harry threw his cellphone on his desk. Father and son shared unsettled glances. "Hey, if you're going to be CEO one day, you've got to get the cash too."

"Relax, will you?" Mac headed to the back of the 3,000-square-foot office, to the fireproof filing room that held Sceptre documents and maps. "There's something I want to check. Then I'll dial for dollars with you. Give me ten minutes."

That was Mac. He loved rummaging around in the map room. Harry checked across the street. Jeff's truck was gone, and Trudy's café was spotless. No Red. He made himself a Nespresso. A text from Cinnamon popped up.

WE NEED TO TALK, HARRY—ABOUT US. CAN WE GO FOR DINNER?

He typed a short message and deleted it. Then he started to send her a longer message about their relationship, but ultimately

decided to delete that too. *Later*. It was time to start selling the financing. Mac was back at his desk. Harry forwarded a dozen emails to his son.

"The deck? Where is it?" Harry asked and checked outside for the mystery woman.

"Check your email. Man, are you edgy or what?"

Harry sat down and read through Mac's financing presentation. It was compelling. Sceptre appeared to be on its way to a potential motherlode in Atlin.

"This is good. And no one will have a big position. That maintains our liquidity—Howitzer control."

"Talking to the converted. I sent you the list. I'll call the names in blue. You have the big dogs." Mac put on his headphones and got to work. Harry listened in on Mac's first few calls. The prospects wanted to talk to Mac about the geology. And Mac shone.

The afternoon kept them busy. The buzz from the stockbrokers was contagious. The phone call inquiries started to come in. Hour after hour, the interest grew. There was banter between the father and son, giving Harry a sense of confidence they were on track. He picked up his desk phone on the fifth ring.

"Harry Howitzer."

"Harry, it's Rock."

"Rock, hello. How are you?" He stretched out his legs. *Nice to hear a friendly voice*.

"The financing, I'll take all of it. Me and my boys have the dough. And we love that Atlin find."

That ~~was~~ a ridiculous idea, and Rock ~~knew~~ it. The guy was the chairman of the board. Harry remembered Wallace telling him Rock was ruthless, and that's why he'd kept him close, to keep an eye on him and rein him in when necessary. Harry didn't have that kind of relationship.

"Rock, that's a generous offer, but Mac and I have spent the afternoon making calls. We have an incredible amount of interest, but we'll make room for you." Mac got up from his desk and leaned on Harry's. They exchanged grim glances. Harry went to speakerphone.

"Not optional, Harry. Let's meet on Friday. I have to fly to the island this afternoon."

"Rock, what are you thinking? You are the chairman—transparency?"

"You can be chairman if that's the only roadblock. Friday. Meet me at the Rowing Club at Stanley Park. Ten a.m. See you then. Have a good day."

The line went dead. Mac threw up his arms. "Dad, ~~there is~~ too much hair for the Exchange to pass that transaction. Like ~~n~~ever. He wants to own Sceptre."

"He's not going to. It's a no, and if he doesn't want to be chairman, there's a lineup for the job." Harry tapped his pen fast against his desk and wondered why Rock had introduced him to Cooperhawk.

"Why are you going to Masset?" Mac noticed the airline ticket on Harry's desk and picked it up. "Tomorrow? You weren't going to tell me?"

"I was." Harry was dreading the conversation. "This prospector, a friend of April's, says he's got a hot property close to the mine."

"What? Where? I know every inch of that place."

"Not sure, but I promised April. With the mine in ~~its~~ state, I need to try." Harry knew this wouldn't be an easy or convincing conversation.

"Why aren't you taking me?"

"I didn't want to waste your time."

"Dad, we're a team, especially since Granddad is gone. I need to be there."

"Mac, I need you here. Closing this deal. Hey, it's four o'clock." Harry wanted Mac gone by the time Cooperhawk arrived. "Why don't you go for your workout? I'll pick up Osler. Come over. Let's order in Thai and review our books."

"Sure, the game is on too." Mac grabbed his bag. "I still don't understand what's up with you. Flying to Masset in January to meet a random guy? What's wrong with a phone call with the two of us?"

"Let me do my thing. See you at six."

Ten minutes later, Harry buzzed in Cooperhawk and took the cash for Viper Byte out of his briefcase.

"Hey, there." Harry stood by the elevator holding the payment.

"Got your texts. Red has your number. Not sure what she's doing with it." Cooperhawk nodded and tucked the envelope in his jacket pocket. "I haven't found Liu, but the Hells Angels gave me the address of the Richmond fentanyl ops. Fort Knox~~, that place~~." He gave Harry a full description of the operation.

"Slick. Didn't see a soul and couldn't break in. Smart guy, that Liu. I'm two steps behind him, but I'll find him."

"Keep at it. How long will it take to find Liu or Serge?"

"Hours, weeks, months. I don't know. Patience, grasshopper."

"I'm out of that." *There was no way Harry would survive waiting months for answers.* "If you need more money to fast-track this thing, let me know."

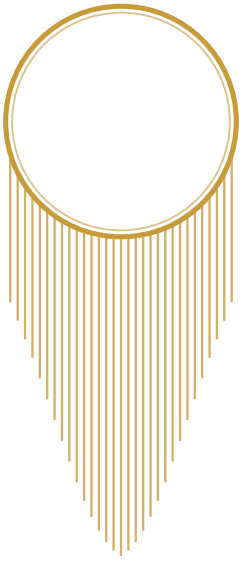
"Doesn't work that way. I'm sure in a couple more weeks, I will have answers. This isn't easy."

"You've reminded me plenty of times. I'm going to Masset tomorrow for the day. Meeting a guy who says he has a property close to Stewart for me to look at. Doing it for a friend."

"The truth, Harry, that's all I need from you. Keep me posted. Something will happen, trust me." The elevator closed.

Harry was lying to everyone in his life. He had no idea what the Shaman visit would entail. April was firm: it was the only solution.

The palms of his hands turned clammy as he contemplated the visit. A solution to at least one of his problems—that's all he wanted.



CHAPTER 31

WEDNESDAY, MASSET, HAIDA GWAII

The tiny Masset Airport terminal hadn't changed since he and his Pilatus had landed there for a day of sightseeing. He tried to remember how many years it had been. *Time flies*. It had to be five years ago. Harry waited outside for Shaman Koyah. There wasn't a single vehicle on the street or waiting by the pickup curb. He checked his phone. Nothing. The guy was a no-show. *Screw it*. He should hop back on the plane that brought him to the village. There was a ten-million-dollar financing to close.

An old, grey Toyota Land Cruiser with screechy brakes pulled up. A man with a slight build in his late twenties hopped out.

"Harry Howitzer?" He reached out to shake hands. "I'm Jeremy."

"Yes, hello. I'm sorry, I'm supposed to meet Shaman Koyah. Are you taking me to him?" *April never mentioned anyone named Jeremy.*

"That's me, Koyah. You can call me by my Haida name if you like, or Jeremy." He opened the passenger door, and Harry climbed in. "Sorry I was late. I had to help someone who was in tough shape." The men buckled up, and the Toyota headed out of the airport.

"I'm sorry, I imagined someone else." *What an odd start to the day*. "April said ~~you are~~ off the grid? A young guy like you?" Koyah's warm, curious eyes connected with Harry's, but his man bun and a full-length Helly Hansen winter jacket weren't what Harry envisioned. Koyah appeared to be a new-age Shaman—or so he hoped.

"As much as I can be in today's world. But my day-to-day life, yes, I'm off the grid. Keeps me grounded." He turned down a side road and onto the main drag. "Harry, I know your story. All I can say is you're being truly victimized."

Those words ~~were~~ not comforting.

"Hold on, Koyah. Please. I need to hear your story first." Harry was not about to divulge his secrets to anyone. "Not to be rude, but . . ."

"No, I understand." Not far from the airport, Koyah turned right onto Cemetery Road.

The road's name heightened Harry's distress. The Toyota drove down to the dead end, where the thick emerald-green West Coast forest closed in around them.

"It's pretty chilly out there, but you're dressed for it." Koyah patted Harry's olive-coloured Barbour coat. "And when the sun's out, a beach walk on Haida Gwaii is gold. Come on."

A beach walk with a Shaman. The day ~~could~~ not get any stranger. Harry reminded Koyah that his plane was leaving at four. He was supposed to meet Cinnamon for dinner. The past few days, she had been over the top, constantly calling him or texting. *What ~~was~~ her problem*? He didn't need the drama. It was time. Harry would have "the talk" with her.

"Let's go." Koyah motioned.

Harry walked silently next to Koyah along the wide, mossy path, scattered with old spruce trees, to the vast sandy coastline. Haida Gwaii was one of Mother Nature's most beautiful gifts to the world. There were miles of long, captivating beaches. In the distance was the outline of the Alaskan mountains, only noticeable on clear blue-sky days. The ocean waves purred as they slapped on the shore. Large pieces of driftwood furnished the coast. The landscape could only be described as pure paradise.

"I guess April didn't share my background. I come from generations of Shamans—for, I guess, centuries. It's how I live my life. My father was a legend. But two years ago, my parents and my three sisters died in the family home from a fire."

Harry stopped. "I'm sorry to hear that. A forest fire?"

"No, the propane tank line in our home leaked. It was installed incorrectly. They didn't have a chance. The house exploded. Heartbreaking."

"A terrible loss for you." Harry noticed Koyah's calmness in describing the tragedy.

"It's that thing called life. So here I am. Granny and I are off the grid in Old Masset. And yes, Harry, I am a Shaman, though I am not my father."

"What I am experiencing since my longhouse encounter is absolutely bizarre. And so private. Can I trust you?" Harry looked into the Shaman's steady eyes. He swallowed. "Because if I can't, I've got to go. You know."

"I know all about the Howitzers. And Pookmis. I have no reason to share your story with anyone."

Koyah's statement sounded a little ominous. He noticed the Shaman staring at the cut on his forehead. He touched it, though, for the first time, it didn't hurt.

"Let's sit down." Koyah showed him a long, flat rock that invited conversation. "This works."

The sitting rock was hard and cold, but the sea air gave his mind clarity. After deep breaths, Harry turned to Koyah and told his story, then asked what he made of it.

"The Pookmis story is strange. In Haida, the spirit is known as Gagiid, but it is the same phantom that roams the ocean, haunting greedy fishermen. But he's not mainstream, and he doesn't live in someone's house." Koyah rubbed his face. "A rogue spirit that's gone rogue. That's a new one for me. But he's powerful. A force."

"You're not kidding." *Those words didn't give Harry any sense that the Shaman could be helpful.*

"Pookmis will push you until you cross the line. Become like him."

"What do you mean, like him?"

"Self-serving, predatory. He'll infect your mind."

"Infect my mind? That's not happening. Come on, Koyah. Do you have a solution? A ceremony or something to get rid of him? You can come back to Vancouver with me."

"It's not that simple, Harry. To be honest with you, your energy is difficult for me to connect with."

"~~I'm being honest~~."

"Talk to me. You're upset, and it's not all about Pookmis."

"You're right." Koyah's energy was disarming. "For the most part, my life has appeared perfect, but it's been tough too."

"I'm sure most outsiders wouldn't agree with you."

"The expectations of retaining our mine, our reputation. And frankly, the huge amount of pressure to keep Sceptre going. The business is not easy. And I question myself if I could do better. Except I raised an amazing son. You know, Koyah, I love him more than anything."

"Your summary is truthful, Harry. I appreciate that."

"Having a demanding father like Wallace, who never recognized me. He turned out to be a dishonest man, Koyah. And incredibly selfish."

"That's a shame to die with dishonour."

"Agree," Harry continued. "I worked my ass off. He always treated me like a child. But I sucked it up, and after his death, I learned who he really was. ~~Then~~ I learned the truth."

"I know all about Wallace."

"Then you understand." Harry wouldn't ask what he ~~did know,~~ probably not everything but that was okay; he would know enough about Wallace's improprieties. "~~I've not~~ been myself since my plane crash. I ~~was not a believer in spirits~~ until this idiot Pookmis showed up. ~~And, after my encounters with him,~~ something has changed."

"How?"

"I've been lying to make the Howitzers appear like the illusion my father wanted us to be. I was never a liar before I met Pookmis."

"You know, Harry, privilege can come with demons too." The Shaman picked up a small stick and started to draw lines in the sand.

"Can you give me an example?"

"To lose money, status, lifestyle. That's a tragedy for guys like you. Never a good ending. Desperation sets in." He was quiet for a moment.

"I'm not losing the family money." He turned to Koyah. "Did Pookmis kill Wallace? He was his father, Benji's father. If ghosts have fathers." He realized how weird the conversation had become. "You know what I'm trying to say."

"April told me about Spring. Sad. No, spirits can't kill."

"Koyah, Pookmis told me I'm in danger. But what does that mean?" Harry found a tissue in his jacket and wiped his nose.

"That's his orders from the spirits. They judged what he did as unforgivable and forced him into the dark underworld. It's a powerful place. Pookmis was ordered to find a victim to ruin. And he chose the Howitzers. That's the omen."

"Koyah, those words are scary as hell."

"If you aren't careful, you'll reach a point of no return. I need to ensure that doesn't happen to you."

"Whatever it takes, I need your help." *Now Harry understood April's panic*.

"My goal is to get Pookmis out of your house and out of your life. But there's no guarantee."

"You mean, he might not go away?"

"It's complicated. Haida values, such as respect, responsibility, giving thanks, and reciprocity, must be part of day-to-day living. Everything is connected. But the generations of Howitzers might have created irreversible damage. I just don't know."

"Except me. I'm a good guy." With Koyah's logic, he was paying penance for Easton and Wallace's bad behaviour. "I can't change the past."

"I understand. Come on. Lunch at my house."

"Are we done? This is it?"

"No, Harry, we're not finished."

The trip down the bumpy country road couldn't keep Harry from dozing. Koyah's conversation left him distraught. His eyelids grew heavy, but it would be rude to fall asleep.

Fifteen minutes later, Koyah pulled into the driveway of a peaked grey cedar home with oversized white-paned windows. "Harry, wake up."

"I'm sorry." He straightened himself out and popped a mint from his pocket. "I haven't had a good sleep in months."

"I understand. Come in."

The cozy place, filled with a hodgepodge of furniture and Indigenous art, made Harry feel at home. Harry picked up a small carving that sat on the coffee table.

"Jim Hart?"

"You know your art. The best, isn't he?" Koyah urged Harry to follow him into the kitchen. "This is Granny. Granny, meet Harry."

"Welcome. Please come in," Granny said.

"Wow, I didn't expect this." Harry smelled baked bread and noticed the table was set. His stomach gurgled. "Thank you for having me." He pulled up a chair at the four-seater kitchen table. "What a comfortable home you have."

Granny had to be close to seventy, but she appeared much younger. Her cherub face had few wrinkles. Like Koyah, she wore a heavy sweater and jeans. Her bright-red crocheted house slippers were hard to miss.

"Granny steamed the crab we caught yesterday." Koyah helped serve a platter of fresh Dungeness.

"What a feast. Thank you. This is wonderful." Harry took off his coat. Granny quickly hung it on the rack by the front door.

"Please, Harry, let's eat," she said.

They cracked the hard, red-and-white shells, devouring the fresh, meaty seafood for the next hour.

"Delicious. You know, Granny, breads and pastries are my ~~soft spot~~. You knocked it out of the park," Harry said, eating a

thick slice of sourdough bread. He loved her impish grin and recognized how she hung on every word he spoke. He asked questions about life in Masset. The conversation, about the social and environmental challenges Haida Gwaii faced, was revealing—it was a difficult life. Solutions weren't easy, either.

"Another piece of pumpkin pie?" Granny asked.

"No, thank you. It was so good." He'd already had a generous first slice. Harry tried to help the family clear the table, but Granny insisted he sit, and gave him a small sliver of pie anyway. He couldn't resist.

After finishing the last bites, Harry's belt could have been loosened a notch, but he wouldn't.

"What's up for this afternoon?" Harry asked. Granny motioned to speak to Koyah privately. He checked his phone, but there was no service or Wi-Fi.

"Harry, ~~we are~~ out of here. One stop and then back to the airport." Koyah returned with Harry's coat.

"Thank you, Granny. The lunch was just lovely. Like you. I hope to see you again." Harry grabbed her bony, calloused hands. He noticed her look of uncertainty as she walked with him to the door.

"Please take care of yourself. Hold on," Granny said in a soft voice. She returned with a container filled with slices of bread and pie. "You need these more than we do."

"That is a sweet gesture. Thank you."

"He's waiting." Granny pointed to the running Toyota.

Harry apologized to Koyah for making him wait, snapped the clasp of his seat belt, and commented how he loved Granny's energy.

"She's the matriarch." He reversed out of the driveway at a good clip.

"You're a lucky guy to have her." Harry laughed. "You're like me. You like to drive fast." They traded smiles. "Where are we going?"

"A longhouse."

"No way. I'm not going to a longhouse again. Never." Harry's body began to shiver. "I can't, Koyah. Take me to the airport."

Koyah pulled over to the shoulder of the road. "Harry, Granny and I worry that Pookmis's grip is stronger than you realize. There is no magic in what we are trying to do, but you've got to work with me."

"How would you know that?" *Harry had been the perfect guest.* "I'm the same Harry Howitzer. Kind of."

"It's hard to explain. ~~Physical and emotional~~, Granny has seen it all, and April ~~has~~ shared her concerns. I ~~must~~ trust their observations. Let me do what I can. Time is against you~~, it is.~~"

"Let's get this over with." Harry had no idea what he had agreed to, but the message was clear: something was wrong.

It was a ten-minute drive. The cedar longhouse was much longer than the one on Princess Royal Island, though similar in design. They entered through the massive doors into an empty room filled with wooden benches, chairs, and colourful art and totems.

"Sit here, Harry. I'll be back."

What the hell was going on? He heard a thud, then the lights dimmed. The Shaman returned wearing a simply carved light-blue mask and an embroidered red blanket tied around his shoulders. He held a long-handled red rattle shaped like a human skull.

Koyah grabbed Harry's clammy hand, motioning for him to stand. He chanted and circle-danced, shaking his ceremonial rattle for several minutes.

Harry closed his eyes, listening to the rhythmic and repetitive swishing sounds. The vibrating rattle was mesmerizing. The performance pushed Harry far beyond his comfort zone. The pain from the scar became unbearable, leaving him unsteady on his feet. He crouched down on the floor as perspiration dripped from his face. It was as though he was back inside the longhouse with Pookmis.

After what felt like an eternity, the ceremonial dance stopped. The room turned silent. Harry opened his eyes.

The Shaman removed the mask.

"Harry, you're done." He chanted in his native Haida language and passed him the blue dance mask. "This is yours. I warn you, Harry, the mask will only do so much. Pookmis is fierce, and if you don't respect him for who he is, he will never leave. It's part of the foundation of the supernatural."

"How am I supposed to do that?"

Koyah's deep brown eyes said everything. "Show respect. Could you accept Benji as a brother? As family. Publicly acknowledge him as a Howitzer."

"Koyah, give me a break. No. That's history."

The gossip, the stigma, and who knew what else could come of it. And his mother, Barbara. ~~RIP.~~ That bomb would smear her reputation as Wallace's ideal wife. Then there would be the fallout and the shame for him, Mac, and Sceptre. "Never."

"That's your decision. Be careful, my friend. His motives are generational."



Koyah sent Harry home with detailed instructions. The minute he arrived at the Tudor from the airport, he dropped his coat on the floor and beelined to the library. He took the mask out of the canvas bag, unwrapped the newspaper protecting it, and placed the piece on the carpet.

The plain carving appeared out of place, surrounded by Wallace's duck collection and paintings. His hand trembled as he positioned the offering at the centre of the fireplace grate. He turned, thinking he heard the spirit's breath behind him.

Pookmis wasn't in sight.

One match ignited the mask. Within seconds, it caught fire. The smell of cedar drifted through the library. Harry sat on the floor and watched the flickering flames, reflecting on his day. He contemplated how Koyah's priorities were family and

culture, rather than the Howitzers' priorities: the accumulation of wealth.

The grey embers didn't take long to pile in the firebox. But small bits of the mask refused to burn.

Harry waited for some kind of sign, like a screech or a whimper from Pookmis being scorched or exiled from the Tudor, but there was no observable sign of the haunt's departure.

Did ~~he~~ do something wrong? ~~He~~ should call April. His heart pounded, waiting for her to answer. Finally. "Hi, it's me," he said in a sombre whisper.

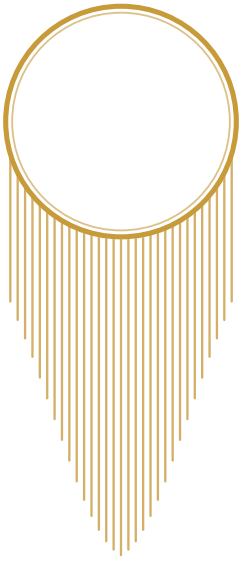
"Harry, what's happening? Your voice sounds shaky."

"It's done. ~~The mask has been burned~~. It was an incredible day, April. I love that family," he said, poking the smouldering wood in the fireplace. "But Koyah told me I'm supposed to accept Benji, even though he's not even alive. No goddamn way. How would that work?"

April was silent for so long he thought they'd been disconnected.

"April?" Harry flopped with exhaustion into Wallace's wingback chair.

"Acceptance is a virtue, Harry."



CHAPTER 32

WEDNESDAY, NOON

The murky skies had been a constant for days. The energy in the city was low, like Zi's mood. *Why hadn't Genji told him the truth about Baba's death? He'd never know.* But he would put each day to good use until he had resolution. Baba's death would not be in vain.

The Christmas season ~~had~~ passed quietly. Zi ~~had~~ walked the seawall~~, often~~ reminding himself never to short a stock. He ~~had~~ paid off Dashi's debt and the topic was closed. The family ~~had~~ kept to a few festivities, while he had taken long stretches alone on *Sunspot*, contemplating his next move. But the perfect gift

had arrived from Wei—the New Year's Eve insider tip about Howitzer's plan to raise ten million dollars. This was the break Zi ~~had~~ needed, and it ~~hadn't taken~~ him long to devise his plan. He would offer to purchase the entire financing, adding a twenty percent premium. *How could Howitzer turn that down*? Keefer Gold would then own just under twenty percent of Sceptre. *Then what ~~came~~ next*? He was uncertain about the logistics of these Canadian stock markets. At his request, Serge had arranged for Alexi, an associate of their gang, to serve as a corporate advisor.

Zi's intuition ~~had~~ urged him to move fast on his idea because he ~~had~~ sensed the opportunity window was closing. The Atlin success would bring interest from people with deeper pockets than his. Serge had agreed.

On a quiet Wednesday afternoon, with traffic that felt like a Sunday morning, Serge turned down a side street in South Granville. "Yes, there it is, Serge. I'm going to have a quick look." It was time for a visit to a gallery he'd recently read about.

"Take your time." Serge turned up Tchaikovsky on the stereo. "Your meeting with Alexi isn't until later this afternoon."

"Thank you." Zi buttoned up his coat and grabbed an umbrella from the back seat. "Looking forward to this."

Outside, the winter rain splashed on the sidewalk, puddling in broken pieces of slab. The gallery window featured watercolours by an artist Zi wasn't familiar with. They appeared to have more elegance, if that was the right word, than what he'd bought from Martha. He had a lot to learn. The gallery was locked, but he buzzed, and the unlocked door led him into a long, narrow room.

"Hello?" Zi asked.

A slender man in his mid-sixties, dressed in tweed, popped out from around the corner. "Hello, I'm Steven Spencer. Please come in," he said with a distinct British accent. He motioned Zi to put his umbrella in a container by the door. "How can I help you?"

"Ah. Yes. My name is Zi. I'm interested in what you have with the Group of Seven." He fiddled with his gold nugget ring.

"Splendid." The dealer's curly grey eyebrows rose. "Nice to meet you, Zi. Follow me."

Steven opened a locked room in the back of the building. About a dozen works of art hung on white walls, illuminated by spot lighting.

"I'm looking for an education," Zi said. "I've recently become interested in Canadian art. I've collected Chinese artists, but I'm a novice in this area."

"Congratulations." The dealer fussed with the gold frame of his round wire glasses. "It's addicting, I tell you. Here, we have a Thomson. This is excellent value, I would say. Entry level for the Group of Seven."

Zi leaned in. He didn't like the dull and dreary picture of an empty canoe in a cluster of ugly brown trees. But a three-by-four-foot abstract of a sky-blue mountain range caught his eye across the room.

"No, that one is not for me."

"You know what you like," Steven said with crisp words, showing his long, horsy teeth. "I noticed you eyeing the Lawren Harris. An option, but pricey these days. You can thank Steve

Martin for that." He motioned to another wall nearby. "Here we have an Emily Carr. A must for any collector."

"Yes, I am familiar with her." It was hard for Zi to keep up with the man's pace and words. The Emily Carr oil painting had a similar tree theme to his new piece, but the work appeared different. The strokes were exact and accurate, not like what he owned. He checked the signature. Was there something different? "I see. Tell me about *Wood Interior*."

"Which one? The oil or the watercolour?"

"The oil?" *There are two.* "Yes, the oil."

"You must be a friend of the Howitzers."

"Howitzers?"

"Wallace Howitzer was one of the biggest collectors of the Group of Seven. *Wood Interior* is in his collection." Steven's face took on more gravitas. "Such a good man in the community. Unfortunately, he passed away recently, but I spoke to his son, Harry, before Christmas. He's keeping the collection."

Howitzer had decided to keep the collection. How was that possible? He had to stay calm and gather more information.

"I don't know the Howitzers. I've heard of the painting." He pretended to check his phone for information. "Yes, this woman. Martha Prigger told me about it."

"That's his ex-wife." The dealer chuckled. "Best to get advice from me. Stay out of that woman's way. She's rather, let's just say, not that legit."

"Harry Howitzer's ex? Since when?" Zi exhaled, trying to remain composed.

"Oh, years and years ago. She ran off with a firefighter after they had their son, Mac. And Harry has been a playboy for decades."

The man was a gossip. It was time to take advantage of his loose lips.

"The Howitzers are friends of yours?"

"Yes. My father was the British Consul for a decade. We moved to their hood when I was seventeen. Great fun, the lot of them. That crowd parties." Steven's eyes sparkled as he recalled the past. "Champagne and bourbon flowed. We would dance all night long. Harry and his bestie, Trudy, would make eggs and pancakes at six in the morning for a house full of people—the Tudor, Harry affectionately calls the family home."

Zi struggled to hold himself together, but the rage building inside him was like a flash fire. "Would Martha be selling any of the Howitzers' art?"

"No, no, no. They hate each other. Their divorce went on for years." He leaned in and whispered, though no one else was around. "Heard she took Harry to the cleaners."

That was the only good news Zi had heard. He unbuttoned his coat and loosened his scarf.

"There are more Emily Carrs upstairs. Follow me," Steven said.

Zi climbed up a narrow staircase to the attic. He felt his face flush, and he wanted to leave, but he had to see more of the work.

"Come this way, Zi. These items are on consignment from an estate sale. Beautiful, aren't they? The precision is so engaging."

The two oils were smaller than Zi's. The attention to detail and the colours were spectacular. Both were the exact opposite of what he'd purchased.

"Silly question. There is never more than one. Correct?"

"That's right. One original oil, and one watercolour named *Wood Interior*. It can be a bit confusing but that's Emily."

At that moment, Zi understood that Martha had sold him a fake. He wanted more facts and asked Steven for a price range for the paintings in front of him.

With the pen that he pulled from his suit's inside pocket, Steven wrote down the amount on his card and passed it to him. "Probably could get you a little under if you take both."

"I see." *Zi Liu was stupid enough to overpay for fakes. That woman—Howitzer's ex—was a con*. "Steven, thank you. I must go."

"Brilliant. Zi, next time, call ahead. We can have a glass of bubbly and talk art." Steven saw him to the door. "And that Harris is lovely. Think about it."

"Yes, I might just have the space. Thank you." Zi grabbed his dripping umbrella. "My visit has been more than revealing." He stepped out, turned the corner out of sight of the gallery, and whacked his umbrella across a light pole, busting it to smithereens.

Serge raced out of the SUV to Zi.

"Boss, slow down." Serge grabbed his shoulder and checked the block to see if anyone had witnessed the temper tantrum. "Come on, let's get in the SUV."

Slouched in the passenger seat, Zi slammed the door, dropped his head, and regurgitated his findings. There was only one thing to do.

"I want to see Martha. Right now. Let's go."

Serge rolled the SUV through downtown, fighting noon traffic.

"I should have listened to my gut. She's a scammer, a fraud." His voice rose. "And why didn't Wei tell me? She must have seen the painting in Howitzer's house. She's there all the time."

"Ask her." The driver stopped at the yellow light on Main Street. "But, Mr. Zi, you got caught up in the moment. It can happen to anyone."

Zi dialed his phone. No answer. "Wei, it's Zi. Call me back—now." He turned to Serge. "Can you believe this?"

"I know. She played you."

Zi fell silent, rehashing his time with Martha. He was her prey. *Not anymore.* Fifteen minutes later, they arrived at Martha's gallery.

Inside the stale-smelling building, Zi climbed the steep staircase and marched up to his nemesis, who was laughing and speaking loudly to a group of young artsy-looking people.

"Hello, Martha, I have to interrupt you."

"Zi, what a surprise." Her brown eyes widened, her pupils dilated, and her canned smile quickly altered to something strained. "I didn't expect you today."

He motioned her away from the group. Her perfume smelled like a wet dog. "I need to speak to you. Privately." He noticed her custom emerald choker that complemented her form-fitting

black suit. The multiple-carat jewels glittered. He wondered if Howitzer had given it to her from Sceptre's profits, or if she had bought it with his Carr money. They moved to the corner of the room. "Who was the owner of *Wood Interior*?"

"As I mentioned, Zi, that's P and C."

"Is my Carr a fake?" He cut her off before she could ~~speak~~. "Because I think it is, and I want my money back. Now."

"Fake? No," she said with a phony laugh. "Zi, settle down." Her eyes roamed the gallery. "Let me show you the paperwork. I'll be right back."

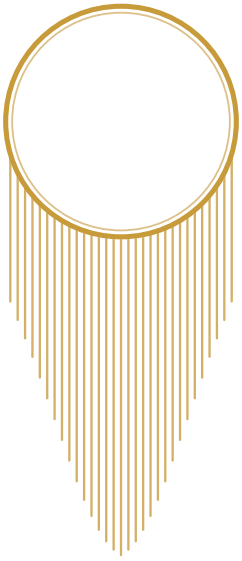
Martha raced to the back of the gallery and closed the office door behind her.

The longer Zi waited for her to return, the angrier he became. ~~*Was* she faking the paperwork, too~~? He wasn't waiting anymore ~~and~~ made his way through the gallery and opened the office door.

The cold breeze from the open rear exit to the alley whisked through the room. ~~*He was*~~ *an absolute fool. Again.*

Martha Prigger had scammed him for the second time.

There would be no next time.



CHAPTER 33

WEDNESDAY, EARLY EVENING

Zi should've done his homework instead of throwing money around like a clown. He was every bit as stupid as Dashi. What made it worse was Martha had once been a Howitzer, part of the scourge. He climbed into the vehicle with only one goal burning in his mind.

"Serge, get rid of her." After a year being so closely associated with the Russians, justifying a hit seemed easier in a strange way. "Can it be done, tonight?"

Serge shifted in his seat and checked out the building. "Let me make a call." For the first time, Zi wished he understood Russian. "*Poka*." Serge hung up the hands-free. "Done."

"Best decision I've made in a while. What if she doesn't show up here?"

"Boss, her gallery is her lifeline. She'll show up."

A tinge of guilt stirred in his mind, but he ignored it. "Drop me off at *Sunspot*, please. Time to get on with the important business." Serge made the second and third phone calls, confirming the impending Martha event while he wheeled the SUV through the narrow waterfront streets. He arrived at Zi's regular marina drop-off spot. "Serge, let me know when it's done."

"Will do. Good luck with Alexi."

"Thanks for everything." As Zi got out of the Escalade, Dashi was hustling down the sidewalk and waved.

"Baba, wait for me," he called out.

Even from a distance, he knew that look on his son's face. It meant good news. Zi waited. "Dashi?"

"Baba, I have a meeting with Howitzer to talk about the financing tomorrow."

"What? How?"

Zi expected good news, but not excellent news.

"After you told me what you wanted to do with the financing, Wei gave me his cell. I called him and told him we had an offer he needed to hear. He seemed kind of spaced out, but he agreed. Serge and I will go."

"I'm going."

"Baba, if you go, you'll blow it. You hate Howitzer so much. Let me go with Serge."

Zi sensed Dashi's passion, but there was no way he'd miss out on this opportunity. "No. Did you hear me? It's Serge and me."

They walked through the locked gate toward *Sunspot*. Dashi stopped his father and grabbed his wrist. "Promise me."

"Promise you what, Dashi? That I won't blow our cover? I'm not stupid."

"You're pretty hot-headed these days."

"End of discussion."

Dashi hesitated. "All right. Alexi is in the stateroom."

Inside the superyacht, the young Russian lawyer waited on the sofa, preoccupied with his phone. He stashed it in his briefcase as Zi and Dashi entered the stateroom.

"Hello, I'm Zi Liu." He shook Alexi's strong hand. "My son, Dashi."

The man was about Dashi's age, with chestnut-coloured hair and prominent cheekbones. He wore an expertly tailored wool suit. Zi liked his style.

"Nice to meet you. Serge said you owned a superyacht." Alexi nodded and continued checking the vessel's craftsmanship. "This is super."

"Ah. Yes, it is. Please, let's sit. I've had a busy day." Zi warmed up to him at once. The elderly steward gathered Zi's coat, and the three men ordered Scotch, neat. Dashi and Alexi connected and bantered back and forth about the latest hockey team trade.

"Let me start, Alexi. Keefer Gold wants to own Sceptre Gold." After his first sip, Zi started to feel a little more relaxed.

"Yes, Serge gave me the background. You own about ten percent, and you want to buy their financing."

"That was the idea, or do I want to do a hostile takeover?" Zi had another sip of Scotch.

The lawyer contemplated the idea. "With your background, you'll be exposed from the due diligence. Not an option. Here's your plan: the Howitzers own twenty-four percent of their company. You need to own more than that. Then you're the boss, the biggest shareholder. No need for a hostile takeover; you can do lots of damage as the majority owner."

Smart kid. "Works for me. Tell me about this Rock Weston. We learned he owns a lot of stock."

"Yes, the board chairman. He owns eighteen percent now." Alexi flipped out a piece of paper from his leather folder. "But he's an insider. He won't be an issue. Mr. Liu, Serge, and I are working on the private placement for Keefer, but it won't close in time for this financing. You offer the financing price plus twenty percent. Twelve million dollars. Sceptre can't take no for an answer. If you can buy the entire financing, you should own eighteen percent. Then you're close."

"Dashi, those numbers don't add up. We need twenty-five percent, at least." Zi threw up his hands.

"But, Baba, we do." He pulled out his file from his messenger bag. "I accumulated another nine percent of the stock in numbered accounts. Under the radar, so Sceptre would never know." He leaned over and squeezed his dad's hand. "We close this financing. We are literally golden. You'll be the boss man."

Boss man. *Brilliant*. Dashi had made two clever moves. He raised his glass and toasted his son.

"Alexi, do you agree?" He noticed Alexi using his phone to make a quick calculation.

"Yes, the numbers work. But you have to buy that financing."

"Gentlemen, it's going to be a done deal." The steward arrived with hors d'oeuvres. Zi nibbled a piece of soft bread spread with brie. "Very nice. Thank you."

"You're welcome, sir." The attendant unbuttoned his navy vest pocket and handed a small, sealed, white envelope with Zi's name written in longhand. "For you."

Who would send a note? Zi ripped the top open. "Ah, Sandy is in town for the week." Most of the day was terrible, but this meeting had proved to be excellent.

The three men spent the next half hour socializing. Then Alexi excused himself to start on his paperwork assignment from Zi. Dashi left a minute later to head home, faking the need for a quiet night. Zi knew he was going to a party, but it didn't matter. He'd earned it.

Zi relished the new strategy. The more Scotch he drank, the more ideas he had for how to take Howitzer out once he was the majority owner.

After a warm shower, he returned to the stateroom and found Wei waiting for him. "Hello, dear."

"Zi, what's going on? Three messages? Are you pissed at me?"

"Curious is the word. What's with Howitzer?"

"Nothing. Can you believe Dashi? He nailed a meeting with him."

"Yes, we came up with a good approach. Back to you. Why didn't you tell me about Howitzer's art? *Wood Interior*." With a raised voice, Zi explained the details of his art gallery visit to learn he'd been ripped off. By her blank expression, it appeared to be a surprise to his daughter.

"Zi, you wouldn't believe how many paintings they have. Hundreds. It's like a gallery in that mansion. I didn't notice it. I'd tell you if I did."

"And this Martha Prigger. Why didn't you tell me about her?" Zi explained the rest of the unexpected story.

"Harry has ~~talked about~~ her, but he never said her last name or what she did, so I didn't connect that relationship. You need to forget this art thing for a while. Focus on Sceptre."

"~~For~~ now, but I will decide how I spend my time." He sensed his daughter was out of sorts. "What is with you and Howitzer? You haven't been the same since you've been spending time with him."

"I guess that I'm, you know," Wei said, staring down at the varnished mahogany floor, but before she could finish her sentence, Serge arrived.

"Ah," Zi interrupted. "Mission completed?"

"Yes, boss." Serge pulled up a chair. "As soon as it was dark, we broke into the gallery, found her in her office, gagged her, and dragged her through the back door ~~and down the stairs~~ into the alley where the van was waiting. She was a scrapper." He rolled his right shoulder and squeezed his face like he was feeling pain. "We took her to the port and put her in a container

bound for Saudi Arabia. It's our last car shipment until we find a new location for the body shop."

"Wow, Serge. That's aggressive," Wei said. "Can you imagine what's going through her mind? Terror." Wei shook her head. "Zi, I can't believe you did that. You killed her for a painting? Why?"

"I don't want to talk about it. It's done." Zi questioned his own decision again. It was an unorthodox punishment. He had trusted her in good faith, and ~~she had~~ conned him out of over a million dollars. But if he had to be honest, his criminal action was more about Howitzers than Martha: she was the mother of Mac Howitzer. "A bit of poetic justice. I'll leave it at that. Last discussion of this topic—ever." He cringed inside, envisioning her ghastly end of life. "How many bodies have you sent to Saudi, Serge?"

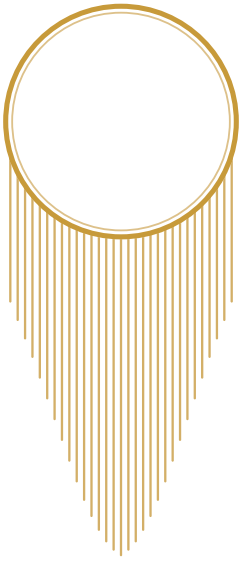
"Martha Prigger is our first. We didn't want a body. Our receivers are aware of the incoming corpse. No problem." Serge shrugged. "It's the only thing I could suggest on short notice, boss. She'll suffocate within hours." He checked his watch. "Dead by now."

"This ~~story~~ is sick. I'm going home." Wei gave her father a peck on the forehead. "Not nice. Good night."

"Good night. Serge, I'm staying on board tonight. Tomorrow is an important day, and I want to be rested."

Zi sat in the stateroom alone. Angst and uncertainty gnawed at him about meeting Harry Howitzer face to face. He ~~needed to remain~~ composed and deliver his pitch like a seasoned mining investor.

The Liu reputation was at stake. ~~It was his~~ opportunity to restore his family's honour.



CHAPTER 34

THURSDAY

Harry wondered what Liu's endgame was—a takeover or something more nefarious. He had been waiting to fly home at the Masset Airport, in a sort of state of mild hypnosis, when Liu's son, Dashi, called his cell. The guy had the nerve to ask for a meeting with him and Keefer's front man, Serge Sobakin, under the guise that they had an offer Sceptre couldn't refuse. Harry had agreed. For once, he was one step ahead of Liu. After the meeting, Cooperhawk would tail them, opening the door to Liu's world.

After speaking with April last night, he had updated Mac on the meeting with Keefer and lied about the trip to Masset, telling him the prospector visit was a waste of time. *What else could he tell his son*?

And now the Keefer meeting started in less than an hour.

"Hello, there." Harry hung up his winter coat and threw his briefcase on his desk. "How are things?" He peered over his son's shoulder, who was working at his desk piled with rolled-up maps and files.

"Hey, Dad, working the afternoon shift?" Mac asked.

Harry had spent the morning at the Tudor, contemplating the meeting and waiting for any signs of Pookmis—nothing. It appeared Koyah's sorcery had worked. "How was the morning? Progress?"

Mac had identified a lengthy list of brokers wanting to participate in the financing. The interest far exceeded anything Harry had expected. It gave him a small reprieve; Sceptre was in good financial shape for the short term.

"Let's get those subscription forms out, son, and let's get ready for this meeting with Keefer."

"Who is this guy, Cooperhawk?" Mac asked. He checked the time on his phone and put on his cashmere camel sports jacket, following the Howitzer tradition of impeccable dress when representing Sceptre to the public. His white dress-shirt cuffs and collar were starched, and the pleats in his dark wool pants were pressed. He checked out his father. "Where's your jacket?" He stared at his father's shoes. "Dad, hiking boots with dress pants?"

Harry hadn't planned his outfit for Liu, but realized he didn't match. "Don't worry about it. I'm not dressing up for these creeps. Cooperhawk's expertise is corporate finance. I wanted him in front of this Keefer crowd. Figure out what they're up to."

"Why have I never heard of this Cooperhawk guy?" Mac gave his father another look, scrunched up his face, and waited for an answer. "I still don't know why ~~we are~~ meeting this Keefer dude."

"Keep your enemies closer, like your ~~G~~randdad used to say. We need to find out what the hell their interest is in Sceptre."

"Yeah, ballsy, aren't they? Must be something about Atlin. But then we didn't have results until three weeks ago." He let out a sigh. "~~Since the salmon poisoning, everything has been so weird.~~" Mac's phone rang. "That's strange. Hello. Uh-huh. What?"

Mac leaned over his desk and listened to a long, one-way conversation. The serious expression on his face bothered Harry. *Whatever ~~he was~~ hearing ~~had~~ better not have anything to do with Atlin before ~~they closed~~ the financing*.

"~~Goodbye~~," Mac said, setting his phone down.

"What is it? Something at Atlin?"

"That was Madeline. It's Mom. She's missing." His expression turned puzzled. "~~Would she take off?~~ And not tell anyone where she was going?"

"That's her MO, but she'll show up. She always does."

"Yeah, I guess. I don't know why Madeline called me." He shrugged. "I can't worry about it. ~~She~~ never worried about me."

"Let's move on. But I can manage this Keefer thing if you want to go and see Madeline."

"Not interested." Mac sat down, staring at his computer, typing slowly on his keyboard.

"Mac, listen to me. The people that disappoint you the most are the people closest to you."

Mac was quiet, then nodded. "You're right."

The elevator buzzer rang. "I'll get it. Come on up, Cooperhawk," Harry said.

The Texan arrived with his yellow notepad under his arm. He wore a vintage 1970s black leather blazer, polished cowboy boots, and a heavy black scarf.

"Cooperhawk? Like Mr. Cooperhawk?" Mac's nose wrinkled with his question.

"Nope. Cooperhawk. Mac, nice to meet you."

"And you." Mac shook Cooperhawk's hand. He cocked his head and weighed up the visitor. "How did you guys meet?"

"Can't remember, long time ago. Cooperhawk, make yourself at home. Tell us the plan." Harry continued to clean up the boardroom table and his desk.

"We are going to let these guys talk. Half an hour max to discuss their plan with Sceptre and why." Cooperhawk sat down and tapped his finger on the table.

"Works for me. Mac? Thoughts?" Harry asked.

"Understand what they are doing." Mac locked the map room, sat down at the table, downed half a bottle of water, and let out a loud sigh.

The buzzer rang. The visitors were ten minutes early.

"Serge? Yes, come on up." Harry turned to Mac and Cooperhawk. "Here we go."

The elevator opened, and two men exited.

"Lordy," Cooperhawk said. "Mac, you saddle up over here instead." He pulled a chair closer to him. "We have a special guest."

"Hello, I'm Harry Howitzer." The pit in Harry's stomach dropped. *This was no kid*; *it had to be Zi Liu*. Serge's sticky handshake gave Harry the willies. "Serge, correct?"

The Russian visitor nodded, unbuttoned his woollen grey coat, sprinkled with dandruff, and introduced his boss as Zi Liu.

"Nice to meet you, Mr. Liu." *Hold it together, Howitzer.* Zi Liu's handshake was firm, cold, like a man half his age. *What a turn of events*. "Let me introduce my son, Mac, and my counsel, Cooperhawk."

Zi Liu had arrived in a grey fine-wool suit with a darker grey overcoat, which appeared custom-made. The elegant man wasn't the greasy gangster that Harry had imagined. The glare Liu gave Harry felt like a stake through his gut. Liu turned his back to speak to Mac.

"I'm impressed with your work. First-rate. Unlike your great-grandfather, Easton."

"What's that?" Mac asked. "My great-grandfather?"

"Mr. Cooperhawk." Zi nodded. "Good to have a lawyer present."

"Uh-huh. Mr. Liu and Mr. Sobakin. Please sit down." Cooperhawk motioned to the long boardroom table and

unbuttoned his blazer. The guests sat across from Harry, Mac, and Cooperhawk. "Serge, this is your meeting. What's up?"

"Yes. We like Sceptre," Serge said. He crossed his arms and leaned forward. "Mr. Cooperhawk, new to Sceptre?"

"Harry's a client. What's your role, Serge?"

"Geologist. Long history of mining in Russia. I moved to Canada and met Mr. Zi about a year ago. Love Canada."

"Mr. Liu, are you in the mining business?" Harry asked, recognizing that Serge never answered Cooperhawk's question.

So far, their story ~~was~~ fake—total BS.

"That's a private matter. Let's get down to business." His eyes darkened as he stared into Harry's. "The Atlin results are worth an aggressive offer." He pulled out a folded document from his suit pocket and handed it to Harry. "I'm prepared to buy your entire private placement. All of it for a twenty percent premium."

Harry did a quick calculation and exchanged eye contact with Mac. *The guy had money. But did Liu think the Howitzers were stupid*? However, given the number of shares they owned, that purchase wouldn't make Liu the largest shareholder.

"Appreciate the interest, Mr. Liu, but we don't plan on bringing in a partner or one investor."

"Hold on," Mac interrupted. "Mr. Liu. What are your plans with Keefer?"

"Undecided," Zi said. "Let's talk about my offer."

"Keefer doesn't even trade," Mac said. "Did you pick Sceptre out of thin air a year ago? I'm confused because Atlin is a new project."

Harry sensed the uneasiness and tension building. He had to hold his tongue, and it was bloody tough.

"Harry Howitzer, if you don't take this offer, you are doing a disservice to your shareholders," Zi Liu said in a forthright voice.

"No. It's my decision, and that's not going to happen."

Liu twisted in his chair. His confident grin vanished. His lips pursed, and he glared at Serge. "We want this deal."

"Harry, how could you not take the offer? It makes sense," Serge asked. He continued to clear the frog in his throat.

"Two-week closing," Zi said. "Money in Sceptre's bank, less dilution for your shareholders. I won't take no for an answer," he said and slapped the table with his hand.

The heated vibes reverberated through the room. Harry worried about his and Mac's safety. These guys had to leave. "Not in our plan. We're done." He stood up and called the elevator.

"Harry Howitzer, you have one choice," Zi Liu said. "You never know what's next."

What ~~did~~ he mean by that ~~comment~~? Harry pressed the elevator button again.

"I'll get our lawyer, Alexi, to discuss the paperwork." Serge offered his card, but there were no takers.

An awkward silence settled over the room as the guests waited to leave.

As the door was about to close, Serge said, smirking, "Today, we've filed with the TSX. We are officially a ten-percent-plus owner. And still buying."

As the door shut, Serge's smile faded to an eerie gaze.

"Ten percent? Do you believe those guys?" Mac asked. "So random and super angry."

"Harry, talk later. Mac, you keep yourself out of their way." Cooperhawk raced out the back exit.

"Dad, that Cooperhawk guy isn't a lawyer. Who is he?"

"A specialist." Harry wondered what Cooperhawk's next steps would be. The meeting had solved at least one mystery for Harry: Zi Liu knew about his father's murder, and that was why he wanted to take Sceptre Gold from the Howitzers. *Pure revenge*. "Forget about these guys. They're out."

Mac continued to pepper Harry with questions about Cooperhawk, but Harry avoided answering.

"Mac, after this meeting, we know it's crunch time. We need to close that financing before another missile arrives. Next Friday, we close the book. All ten million."

"Done. Dad, I want to punt these Keefer trolls. But are you feeling okay?"

"I am." Harry scratched his two-day growth; he'd forgotten to shave that morning. He unbuttoned his top collar and wiped the back of his wet neck.

"Things are so random these days, and you are so messy."

"Not messy." His phone pinged a text from Cooperhawk.

LOST THEM IN THE TRAFFIC. LATER.

Harry responded.

THE PLAN???

"Granddad should be here. He'd figure out this Keefer thing." Mac rearranged the boardroom chairs. "And what about that Easton comment?"

"Mac, it's a strange world we live in. Everyone wants what we have."

"You mean what they think we have?" Mac got comfortable at his desk, put on his headphones, and dialed his cell. "Hi, Norm, it's Mac Howitzer. I have you pencilled in for a hundred thousand. You should take ~~one fifty~~."



It was time for Harry to have "the talk." After that meeting with Liu, he was ready for any drama Cinnamon would offer.

She waited at her condo door, dressed in loose pink silk lounge pants with a matching blouse, and tried to give him a sexy hello smooch. Instead, Harry gave her a quick kiss.

"Harry, did something happen today?" She touched his cheek and smiled. "How are you?"

"Don't want to talk about it," he said, shaking off his jacket and watching Cinnamon open a bottle of red wine.

"You know I'm a good listener."

"Cinnamon, no. Please stop asking about my business."

Cinnamon handed him a glass of red wine, and her voice grew quieter. "Sorry, you're right, I shouldn't pry."

"No wine, thanks." He took Cinnamon's hand. "There's something we need to talk about. I-I'm too busy to give you the time you deserve. Sceptre is my focus. I'm out. We're not exclusive."

Cinnamon pulled her hand free and steadied herself on the kitchen counter. "What are you saying?"

"I'm done. And I'm sorry. This isn't working for me."

"What do you mean? We're a couple." She threw her arms up. The wine glass flew across the counter and shattered on the stone floor. "Oh, no." The wine splattered across her white barstool. She grabbed a tea towel and scrubbed the white linen seat.

"Don't do that." Harry motioned her to stop. "It will make the stain worse. Do you have any hydrogen peroxide?"

"Somewhere." Cinnamon hurried into her bathroom. "This is the worst day!"

Harry understood, but he'd had to tell her. He could hear her rattling around in the drawers as he wiped up the white marble counter with a paper towel. The glass chunks crunched under his leather boot soles. The paper towel was soaked with wine. Under the sink, he opened the garbage bin and noticed an empty pregnancy test box. His heart pounded as he searched through the coffee grounds, chocolate bar wrappers, and leftover salad for the result stick. At the bottom of the bag, he dug out the digital test. It read a question mark on the results line. *That must mean not pregnant—it wasn't positive.*

That was a hell of a good decision he had just made.

"I need a broom," he asked. He was out of there as soon as the wine mess was cleaned up.

"First hallway closet," she called back.

"Why would she buy white linen bar stools?" he muttered. There were two closets. He opened the first. It was a walk-in junk closet stuffed with sealed boxes, a yoga mat, and a snowboard. *Was she a snowboarder?*

"Cinnamon, this closet is a disaster." He dug around. *They could never live together if this was how she organized her house.*

"It's there somewhere," she said.

He didn't find the broom and moved on to the next closet down the hall. Inside, there were a dozen designer coats organized by colour and season. He pushed the clothes to the left side of the long rack to continue his search. There was no broom, but a small backpack was stuffed in the corner, with strands of something long and red hanging out of the zipper. The colour and texture appeared oddly familiar. Harry unzipped the bag and dumped out a red wig, a prosthetic face mask, oversized sunglasses, and a spray can onto the hallway floor.

What the hell?

"~~Cinnamon!~~" he shouted, booting the knapsack and smashing it into the wall.

"Harry, what's the matter?" Cinnamon ran out of the bedroom and cried out, "Not that closet!"

"You're Wei Liu. Zi Liu's daughter," he said with a roar. "Your ~~old man~~ is trying to destroy me."

"How did you know?" Tears started to roll down her cheeks. "Harry, listen."

Harry picked up the wig, let out a ~~gasp~~, and tossed it across the room. "What kind of person are you, producing street drugs? Stalking me for intel!"

"You know that, too?" Cinnamon's hands wrapped around her face. "Oh, God."

"Disgusting." It was time to leave before he said or did something he would forever regret.

"Harry, stop. I'll tell you what's going on." Cinnamon motioned him to sit down, but Harry backed away from her. "It's complicated. Let me explain."

"Shame on you. You and your family sabotaged my company and bought off a cop. My God. What else are you going to do to me?" He grabbed his coat. "What a bloody idiot I am."

"Listen to me. One thing led to another. I'm so torn. Harry, I fell for you. You're amazing. I want to be with you."

She didn't deny anything.

"Wei Liu, rot in hell. You and your father." Harry slammed the door. On the elevator ride down, he tried to recall if ~~he had~~ shared anything with her that would be useful to her father. Of course he had.

Harry Howitzer was an idiot.

Outside, he dodged people on the busy, rainy sidewalk. He dialed Cooperhawk.

"Howdy."

"Cinnamon," Harry shouted, not caring who heard.

"Uh-huh?"

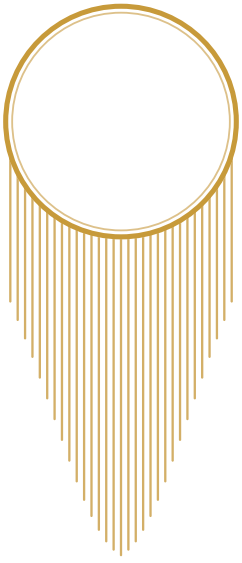
"She's Wei Liu—Red."

"Told you Cinnamon wasn't her name," Cooperhawk said. "You wouldn't listen." He paused. "Always figured she was too cute to be interested in an old mutt like you."

"Do whatever it takes. Get them out of my life. They are going to ruin the Howitzers." The rage came out as a roar. "That is why I hired you!"

"Roger that. Liu is a mad dog. Partner, this one might not end the way we want."

"Don't tell me that," Harry snapped. "Fix it."



CHAPTER 35

FRIDAY

It was time to get things done.

First on his agenda: the meeting with Rock. Harry wove through the bumper-to-bumper cars down Georgia Street. The seawall in Stanley Park was an odd location for a meeting. He waited by the Rowing Club but didn't see Rock's jet-black Rolls-Royce fastback in the parking lot.

"Where's your umbrella?" ~~Rock asked with his raspy, resonating voice.~~ He gave Harry a long look. As usual, the ~~bigger~~ than-life man was dressed impeccably, sporting a long tan Burberry raincoat and a well-worn pair of duck boots.

"Hey, Rock. Let's go this way."

"No. This way," Rock said. "What's going on with you? Growing a beard?"

"No." After a few silent steps, Harry wanted the conversation over. He pulled up his tartan-lined hood over his head. "You want to invest in Sceptre. The book is pretty much closed, but I put aside half a million for you."

"No, Harry, I want the whole issue. I want to be the major investor." Rock slowed his pace and waited for Harry to do the same.

"Rock, come on. I've got shareholders." *Rock ~~was~~ playing games*. "And—"

"Who's this Keefer crowd?" Rock asked. The man interrupted midstream each time Harry started a sentence.

"Russians." Harry described the surprise meeting with a guy named Serge~~, who had~~ arrived at the office with an offer for the entire private placement, without mentioning Zi Liu. "And with a twenty percent premium. And Keefer owns just over ten percent of Sceptre. Registered it with the TSX."

"Twenty percent? Do they have any brains in their head? What am I missing?" Rock asked.

"Atlin. This Serge guy is a gold miner from Russia. Made a pile of money and wanted to invest." *Should ~~he~~ tell Rock that Serge phoned this morning with a stupid offer of twenty-five percent above the current offering*? *No*. "Mobster types. Maybe."

"Harry, that makes no sense," Rock said.

"It's some kind of money laundering set-up. Vancouver these days." Harry needed to close this question-and-answer period.

"Gangsters. This city is not what it used to be," Rock said, glancing across the Burrard Inlet to the downtown core stuffed with glassy condo towers.

"I turned them down. Let's not make them an issue." That was the last conversation Harry wanted to have with Rock about Keefer Gold. They continued along the seawall. Harry could hear and see Rock's heavy breathing. Rock stepped over puddles; Harry walked through them. No one else braved the soggy weather except an old heron, who took advantage of the low tide to search for his breakfast. "Rock, you can't do this placement. The optics wouldn't look good for Sceptre with you being the chairman of the board and a friend of the Howitzers."

"I'll resign. Lots of talented people will want that role. Anything more about the cause of your plane crash?"

The Ministry of Transportation's report had been delivered to Harry's email yesterday. The officer concluded it was an accident. He explained to Rock that the investigation ~~had~~ pinpointed water seepage in the fuel line.

"Is that right? A Pilatus?"

"~~Agree~~. Strange circumstances." Harry didn't share the email ~~he had~~ received that morning. The insurance cheque was in the mail for over two million bucks. "Done with flying."

"Good idea. It's a young man's game. Harry, how are you managing all this nonsense besides the bourbon bottle?"

"Focused on Atlin. I can handle it, and I am."

"And did you ever connect with Cooperhawk?"

"We met, but he wasn't my type. Nothing he could do for me." Rock's nosiness was starting to get on his nerves. *~~Did he know he was lying~~ about Cooperhawk*? "I need to get going."

"Hold on." Rock's phone rang. He checked the caller ID. "I've got to get this. Give me a minute."

Harry moved ahead to give Rock his privacy but overheard him say, "I'm with Harry, babe. What's up?"

He noticed a spectacular superyacht through a corridor view of the Coal Harbour Marina. It eclipsed any other boat he'd seen in the harbour. It was a strange time of year for that kind of boat to be in the Pacific Northwest. Usually, those yachts arrived in the heat of the summer on their way to Alaska. It was a beauty. He spotted Cinnamon's apartment building, counted the floors, and pinpointed her unit. The lights were on. *What ~~was~~ she scheming today? What an idiot ~~he~~ was, getting wrapped up with her.*

April always told him beauty was blinding. Imagine if she had been pregnant.

"Okay, where were we?" Rock asked.

"How's Margaret?"

"Oh, Margaret. She's the best thing that's ever happened to me. We've been married for over forty years."

"Yes, she ~~is~~ lovely." *How many men called their wives babe after forty years*? *At least Rock ~~was~~ a good husband*. "Did you want to turn around?"

"No, we aren't done yet. The salmon situation. What's happening?"

"It's over. Ministry isn't an issue. Stream restoration on plan." Rock didn't need to know any more details, though Harry had given the senior manager's son at the Ministry of Environment and Parks a full-time job in the accounting department to ensure all of Sceptre's paperwork was signed off, and the case was closed. "In my opinion, the salmon were poisoned. Vandalism."

"Is that right? Like, who would that be?"

"Kooks are everywhere these days." *Like Officer Hunt and Liu*. "We've increased the security on-site and at Atlin. One hundred percent confident it won't happen again."

"Now, Atlin. I smell motherlode. And I like your son's style. Smart boy."

"It ~~was~~ the old generation and the new generation. A melding of Howitzer minds."

Rock laughed. "That Atlin is a hell of a story," he said, turning to Harry. "Why aren't you financing the whole thing? The Howitzers are flush."

"Optics with our shareholders. Mac and I own enough stock. Rock, it's time to get new types of investment in the company. We have solid funds interested. I want to build this company out."

"No, Harry, it doesn't work that way. I want the whole deal. My terms." Rock's voice was stern and commanding. "And I'll bring my two boys into the company. You need more horsepower."

No way. Rock's sons were ~~total~~ know-it-all second-rate geologists. Rock's oldest son, Cam, a complete loser, couldn't find his way to the Grouse Grind, let alone a gold deposit.

"Rock, ~~it~~'s not the direction I want to go."

"Harry Howitzer, this isn't optional." Rock's sharp voice insisted.

"Sorry, Rock." Harry stopped and attempted to turn back to the parking lot. "I'm running Sceptre. That's my decision. No deal."

"You're wrong, Harry. I wasn't going to go there, but . . ." Rock eyed a wooden bench beside the seawall and plunked himself down. "Join me, I need to tell you a story."

"Rock, I'm not going to change my mind." Harry begrudgingly joined him on the damp bench. "Can we make this quick?"

"You need to hear this story, Harry. Years ago, I was playing poker with Wallace and Howey Hamilton at the Vancouver Club on Men's Night. The Scotch was flowing, cigars were puffing, and the cards seduced the men at the table for hours." Rock squinted as he remembered the details. "It was about midnight. Howey won. Cleaned everyone's clock. Willie Brooks, a crack-shot miner at the table, couldn't pay his card debt. So, he offered to pay his loss with his claim that he'd bragged about all night at the table. You know where that claim was?"

"Seriously, Rock. Cut to the chase. Who the hell is Willie?"

"Willie lived up north, in the Yukon~~, and~~ was the best prospector up there. Had to be eighty years old. Wily as hell. Wallace knew that and invited Willie to the game. That invite always made me wonder. Wallace convinced Howey to take Willie's claim he'd staked at Atlin for his card debt."

"Atlin?" Howey, Trudy's dad, had died over five years ago. Trudy ~~had~~ never told him this story. Maybe she didn't know.

"You're not making sense. Howey was a property developer. Why would he take a claim?"

"Howey was corked. Wallace convinced him to take it as the pot, so he did. Howey didn't care. I'm going to skip to the point of this story. Days later Willie begrudgingly transferred the claim to Howey—a bet is a bet. Howey asked Wallace to do the work up. It was at least two or three years later, but Wallace told Howey that, at first blush, his findings showed Atlin was worthless. Wallace told Howey to let the claim go, and guess who the owner was when it expired? Check out the government files. It's all there. Black and white."

"That's absurd. The same claim as we have now?" Harry was in no mood to hear this. "Knock it off, Rock."

"Not lying, Harry. Wallace scammed his best friend."

"No way." *Déjà vu*? *Impossible*. "Wallace didn't discover Atlin?"

"No, Willie did. Why do you think I'm on the board, and Wallace has kept me so close? I called him on it. He couldn't deny the truth."

"How did you find this out?" Harry asked. *There had to be an ~~answer~~ for Wallace to do what he ~~had~~, not Rock's version*.

"I visited Howey at the Point Grey Hospital when he was staying in the hospice. We talked about the good old days and disappointments, and had the proverbial how-short-life-is talk."

Why would Howey have any disappointments? He was a major player in the real estate game. Trudy's trust fund was more than she could ever spend in five lifetimes. ~~Though her brothers were disappointed at their inheritance. Howey had never forgotten their disrespect after he'd done so much for them.~~

"Howey was drugged up, delusional. He started to ramble about Wallace. Called him a ruthless prick."

"What? They were best friends." However, Harry agreed with Howey.

"No, they weren't. He sensed Wallace had tricked him. Howey smelled a rat and trapped one. He got one of his lawyers to check the claim, which then was in Wallace's name." Rock laughed, "By the way, Harry, Howey told me more stories about Wallace. Vile."

"I don't want to know," Harry said. The conversation was pissing him off. "So, Howey figured it out. Why didn't he confront Wallace?"

"Howey knew dick about mining. He didn't care, but he wanted me to hear first-hand that Wallace Howitzer was a jerk ~~before he left this earth~~." Rock tugged on Harry's jacket. "You are the only one I've shared this with—other than Wallace." He chuckled. "I'm assuming you don't want Mac to hear about his granddad. That son of yours couldn't manage that bombshell."

"Mac isn't some delicate kid." Harry was slammed with more Wallace dirt. He stared at a buzzing yellow float plane as it landed in Coal Harbour. "I'll tell Mac. No problem. Done. Not an issue."

"Fine. You want to play hardball. I have my orders in to sell all my Sceptre stock, ready to go. Every share that the Westons own, and I'll do it fast. Your stock will get creamed. I'll file my insider reports, and shareholders will wonder why your chairman is selling his stock. Rumours will fly, and I'll resign." Rock smiled. "Your financing will blow up. No one will pay the

premium price of your offering if the stock price drops in half and your chairman doesn't believe in the company."

"You're a piece of work, Rock."

"I usually get what I want."

Rock's second threat was a showstopper. Sceptre didn't have the money to continue the Atlin program. He needed to close the financing. Rock may be bluffing, but he couldn't take the risk.

"I guess ~~we are~~ going to be partners."

Rock reached out. "You're not going to shake my hand?"

"Take a hike, Rock." Harry stood up and walked quickly to the parking lot.

What an asshole.

He warmed up the car. There had to be a path to stop Rock. But first, he'd deal with Liu. He found Serge's number in his phone and called. "Serge, Harry Howitzer."

"Yes, ready to do the deal?"

"You can tell Zi Liu to screw off. Book closed." *That felt great*. Next call. Cooperhawk. No answer. He texted him.

MEET AT THE OFFICE ASAP.

Cooperhawk confirmed he'd be there in fifteen minutes.

Harry peeled out of the parking lot and came to a stop on Georgia Street. The traffic was backed up for blocks. He wasn't going anywhere soon.

Wallace and Atlin. He remembered a strained interaction with his father years ago. They had been at the mine, and he ~~had~~ noticed on Wallace's desk a set of maps. "Atlin? What's the interest?" Harry asked his father, peering at the map.

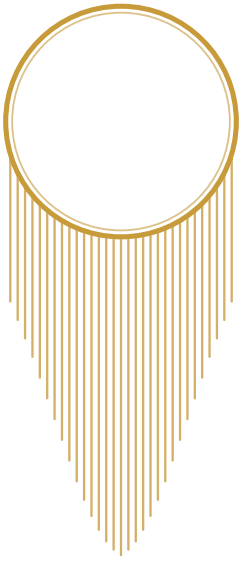
"Nothing of interest to you, Harry." Wallace ~~had~~ picked up a stack of pink callback slips. He ~~had~~ flipped through the messages and pulled one paper aside. Harry ~~had~~ read the note upside down. It had been from Trudy's dad. Wallace ~~had~~ reached for the push-button telephone and picked up the receiver. "Close the door behind you. I have a call to make."

Wallace ~~had been~~ busy that day, stealing an opportunity from his best friend. Harry tapped the steering wheel. *Now, it all made sense. The secret Atlin trips. Trudy's dad's call. And Wallace's resistance to sharing any information.*

The traffic broke free.

The Westons' promised share sale would crush the Atlin program and do endless harm to Sceptre.

~~Desperate to retain control, Harry decided it~~ was time to fight back, and Cooperhawk might be the man to help him.



CHAPTER 36

Cooperhawk leaned on the front door of Harry's office building with his arms crossed. "Partner, what's going on with you? Your face is ~~as~~ red as a barn door."

"Come on in," Harry said, rubbing his scratchy chin. "Rock Weston is about to take Sceptre and me down, that scumbag. Wallace fired another missile from the grave. Can you believe that he didn't discover Atlin?"

"Your daddy was a scoundrel."

"That's a compliment." Harry searched for a strike back. "You and Rock. How close are you two?" He hammered out a quick second question. "Are you tight?"

"~~MYOB~~, Harry." Cooperhawk sucked his teeth.

Harry would try another tactic. "Do you have dirt on Rock that would stop him from doing this financing? And he couldn't track that I was behind it? For the right price?"

"Yup." Cooperhawk nodded. "But we're talking more bucks. Rock is no friend of mine. That's why I was surprised he introduced us."

"You're not? That's not what he said."

"Here's the truth," Cooperhawk explained, "I got Rock's son Cam out of a mess when he was living in Houston. Drugs, an incident with a girl, an ugly mess. Arrested on several charges."

"Not surprised. And?"

"Rock hired me to fix it. I had a buddy at the police department who talked down the arresting officer. And with a few bucks to sweeten the pot for the officer, bingo. Cam got cleared. Case closed."

"And?" *That scenario sounded like Rock, but Harry knew the story had more to it.*

"You know how Rock brags~~, and he~~ can't keep a secret. I found out he told one of his buddies about my manoeuvring. Turns out the buddy was connected to the Feds. Then, for no good reason, the Feds were chasing me around the country trying to arrest me on my—let's say—outstanding issues. That's why I'm hiding out in Vancouver. Rock denied being the cause. He had to be because I'd lived under the radar from the Feds for decades until the Cam incident."

"That's a twist."

"I guess Rock thought if I worked for you, he'd get the inside scoop on the Howitzers, but he burned me. Not telling him

a thing, and I don't trust him. Told him I turned you down. He wasn't pleased."

It didn't surprise Harry that Cooperhawk was a man on the run. "Rock lives in his own world. But do you have something I can use to mess him up?"

"Harry, this dirt I got is mighty big. Personal."

"That's what I want. Done." At that moment, he noticed Cooperhawk was wearing two distinctive styles of work boots, but he wasn't going to ask. "How much?"

"Harry, you should know what ~~you are~~ about to buy."

It must be something big. Perfect. "Is it about the Howitzers?"

"Nope."

"Then I don't want to know. I've got enough of my own secrets."

After the two men negotiated the twenty-thousand-dollar terms, Harry told Cooperhawk to get it done.

"Viper Byte can do the dirty work. She loves this stuff." Cooperhawk grabbed his cellphone and stepped outside to speak privately.

Harry watched Cooperhawk convey the secret order. *That was a good move. And wouldn't it be great if Rock resigned as the chair, too*? Minutes later, Cooperhawk motioned for Harry to let him back inside.

"Done. Payment upon delivery. He'll be out of your hair by tomorrow." Cooperhawk's laugh continued until he started to snort. He wiped his eyes from behind his blue-lensed glasses. "It's a dandy plan."

"Good." There was a risk that Cooperhawk's plan might not work, but his giddy confidence was reassuring. "What's next?"

"Let's go upstairs and discuss Liu. I need a coffee. The guy is slippery. I can't find him."

"We need to find that sleazeball." The men entered the fourth floor. There was no sign of Mac. His coat was gone: he had to be having lunch at Trudy's. The office phone rang. "Hold on." He grabbed the receiver. "Sceptre Gold. You've got Harry Howitzer."

"Harry Howitzer. Zi Liu."

Harry motioned Cooperhawk over and put the caller on speakerphone. "Liu, I spoke to Serge. No deal."

"Serge told me the exact words you used. You are such a commoner. You and your foul language. But we have a problem."

"Not we, you," Harry said. The two men leaned in, exchanging uncertain glances.

"Harry Howitzer, I've had enough of you and your family. Your grandfather killed my father and stole his claim. Today, that claim is Sceptre."

"No idea what you're talking about." Cooperhawk motioned to Harry to keep Liu talking. "Stop the lies."

"The Howitzer life is a lie. And your money is peanuts compared to the Liu fortune. You prance around the city like big shots. Here's the difference. I'm sitting on the biggest boat, a superyacht, in the marina in downtown Vancouver. You could never even afford the fuel. But I protect my family. And my dear father was treated like a rabid dog by your grandfather and the citizens of Vancouver."

"You've got the wrong story, Liu."

"No, I don't. Time for the Howitzers to be exposed. Monday morning, pick yourself up *The Globe and Mail* newspaper. In the business section, a full-page ad will highlight the history of the Howitzers. Details about your sleazy family will be exposed—the frauds that you are." He laughed with confidence. "Want to change your mind and be partners with me?"

"You have no proof of that accusation."

"Oh yes, I do. You have twenty-four hours before I pull the plug on your so-called legacy, or we can make a deal. Call Serge if you'd like to change your mind."

The phone went dead.

"Cooperhawk, he's blackmailing Sceptre and me." He slammed the receiver down. "This can't happen. He'll destroy us now, or later if he owns the financing."

"Settle, partner. You're not thinking straight. That's a stupid idea on Liu's part. He's exposing himself and their gangster operations, but did you hear that? He's at the marina. I'll find him. Set him straight."

Harry was reminded of his morning walk along the seawall. "I saw a superyacht moored by Cardero's. Must be his."

"I'm heading there. Now, what do you want me to do when I find him?"

Harry noticed a change in Cooperhawk's energy. His enthusiasm reminded Harry of a pointer on a bird hunt. This might be the only chance to find Liu.

"Threaten his life. Break something. Hurt him."

Harry paced the room, hands flailing wildly.

"Shake him up, quietly and privately. He needs to understand the message. Then force him to cancel the ad and make it clear that he and his family are not welcome in Vancouver."

Harry stopped.

This was his last option, and he'd take the risk.

"If not," his voice dropped, "all hell will break loose. I'll rat them out—all of them. Including that daughter of his."

"As long as I can find Liu tonight, there will be no ad." Cooperhawk patted Harry's shoulder and called up the elevator. "Lord willing and the creek don't rise. I'll call you when I have answers." The elevator closed.

The map room door slammed shut. An instant sense of dread fell upon Harry. There was Mac, standing in his red parka, clutching a long mailing tube.

"Dad, you haven't told me the truth about anything." His hazel-green eyes were wide and piercing. "What the hell is going on?"

"Mac, I only found out about this Liu mess when Wallace passed away. Circumstances deteriorated. It's a long story, and a messy one. You've got to believe me."

"That Cooperhawk guy is a goon, not a lawyer." Mac blasted his father. "You lied to me."

"You missed my point. Cooperhawk is getting the message to Liu not to mess with the Howitzers." Harry tried to motion to his son to sit down. "This is complicated."

"~~What's the story?~~"

"Son." There would be a better time to discuss this with Mac. Harry needed to find the right words. "This weekend. We will sit down and talk this through."

"I'm supposed to wait to talk to you about this bombshell sometime this weekend. Listen to yourself. You're not like Mom. You're worse." He shoved Harry out of the way and grabbed his knapsack. "This is insane," he started to stutter, "and so are you."

Mac stormed past Harry. "Mac. Stop. We can talk now." He chased him down the stairs.

In the back alley, Mac fired up his Jeep. Harry tried to open the driver's door. The window rolled down.

"Dad, what's happened to you?"

"I'm not sure." *How could Harry answer that question honestly? A ghost-with-a-vengeance conversation would ensure his son would check him immediately into the hospital.*

As the Jeep sped down the back alley, Harry realized what a terrible state he'd put his family in.

As confident as Cooperhawk was, there was no guarantee that his roughing up Liu would stop the ad from being published. Harry would have to decide within the next twelve hours whether to report it to the authorities.

An absolute disaster was looming.

Harry went back upstairs into the empty family office.

For the rest of the afternoon, the phones rang unanswered. His emails piled up in his inbox. There was a pile of mail he hadn't attended to in weeks. Most of the envelopes contained his personal bank and brokerage statements. He spent the

next hour filing or shredding them—anything to distract him from reality.

There was a thick brown envelope. The flap was sealed with several pieces of packing tape, with no proper label. It appeared suspicious. ~~*Could it be*~~ *another bombshell from Liu*? He struggled with a pair of scissors. The tape made it impossible to open. ~~He~~ remembered. In his briefcase, he pulled out Easton's knife he'd forgotten to ditch. The sharp dagger easily slit the seal open.

"Come on." Harry threw his head back. Inside the envelope was a thick catalogue of office supplies. "Waste of paper." He tossed it in the garbage can, and the knife was tucked back into the inside pocket of his case.

Another hour passed, and not a word from Cooperhawk. After several attempts to contact Mac, he had nothing left to do except fear the collapse of the Howitzers.

Six o'clock. He'd go home and wait. What was the alternative? As he powered down his laptop, he checked out the window. Even Trudy had gone home. That was an early day for her.

Snowflakes danced past the window.

The last time it ~~had~~ snowed was New Year's Eve. He had thought it a wonderful night—but only a ploy.

He'd been had.

Cinnamon's constant questions about Sceptre should have been a red flag. Instead, he ~~had~~ let her into his world because she ~~had~~ paid special attention to him. ~~And he had~~ loved the passion. But she was a traitor gathering Howitzer secrets for her father, who wanted to ruin him.

"Harry Howitzer, you're an idiot," he roared and booted the garbage bin next to him. "Never again."

The light above his desk flickered. A desk chair rolled along the floor and came to a full stop in front of Harry.

"Gold Man, not your best day." Pookmis drifted in, shirtless. He straightened his Alert Bay ball cap, trimmed with his long eagle feathers. His pants were belted with marine rope. "Your son hates you. The pretty girl and her father tricked you. Father was right—you're a stupid man."

As the phantom inched toward Harry, he stiffened. The ghost's presence paralyzed him. The stench of rotting fish drifted up Harry's nostrils as Pookmis's chalk-coloured cheeks puffed in and out.

"Your legacy is over." The ghost howled. "Congratulations, loser."

Harry wanted to explode, but he wouldn't antagonize the predator. He grabbed his coat and briefcase and darted down the back staircase toward the exit door.

But he sensed the stalker. Pookmis stood at the top of the stairs and let out a low-pitched, wolf-like growl that resonated down the vestibule. Harry slammed the door and ran into his SUV. He locked the door.

That yowl sounded like a kill.

The mask-burning ritual ~~had~~ failed. Koyah had warned him that the spirit could be invincible.

But Pookmis, his so-called brother, would not call Harry Howitzer a loser.

The Range Rover engine fired up. He put it in gear and slipped along the icy downtown streets.

Ten minutes later, Harry parked three blocks from Coal Harbour. He snapped the buttons on his coat, found a pair of old gloves and a toque Wallace had tucked into the back of the glove box, bundled up, and headed to the marina.

The fresh air did nothing to clear his head. He lumbered along the seawall, seething at Pookmis's taunting and processing the consequences of Zi Liu's latest play.

The article would inflict irreversible damage.

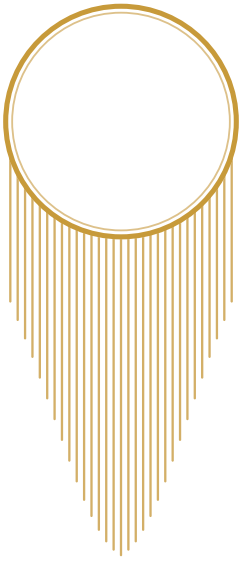
When he reached the marina, the sleek black superyacht glowed against the night. Liu's profile was visible through the stateroom port. *Prick.*

He scanned the dock to see Cooperhawk. He checked his phone. Nothing.

Less than twenty-four hours to the publication deadline.

The Liu circus had to end—for good.

Head down, hands shoved in his pockets, he retraced his steps to the Range Rover, opened the passenger door, and unzipped his briefcase with his cold, stiff fingers.



CHAPTER 37

FRIDAY

Zi was convinced that blackmailing Howitzer was his best course of action. It was clever, but the twins weren't supportive. They didn't have the drive or the get-it-done attitude that he did. He'd had enough of their negative attitude. He jumped to his feet, throwing up his hands. "Do you think I became a success by taking no for an answer? I didn't have a dollar to my name when I started my little pharmacy. Hard work and sweat, that's why I'm a success today, not stealing, not pretending to be superior. The Howitzers are fakes! And their story needs to be told."

"Baba, you shouldn't have told Howitzer your plan or about Yeye. Now ~~we are~~ exposed." Dashi turned to Wei. "I need your help here. Tell him that I'm right."

"Dashi, I'm running this file." Zi's steward handed him a fresh glass of Scotch. He gripped it tightly, not taking a sip, and sat back down in his chair, glaring at them as if they were children being reprimanded for their behaviour.

"Wei, what is going on with you and Howitzer? Tell me," Zi asked. *She'd been avoiding the topic, and he knew his daughter. There was more to her story.* "I want to know. By the way, you look peaked."

"I think I ate something that was off." She twirled the ends of her ponytail, avoiding details. "I told you. We had a fight."

"What about?" His daughter's answer was not an answer. "Wei, what happened? Tell me the truth. I am your father."

"I was pushing for information, and he got mad at me. He's off the wall these days. Move on, Zi."

Wei was right about one thing: Zi was aghast at Howitzer's appearance and rude behaviour at their business meeting. He looked like ~~he had~~ arrived from a hike in the woods with his mad hair and muddy boots. *What a slob. But why ~~was his~~ daughter sad and not herself?*

"Wei, tell me." He waited for an answer, but his daughter was silent. "Your choice. Let me finish what I started. That financing was ours to lose. I'm going to get it, and this is how I plan to do it. Howitzer will change his mind. I guarantee it."

Wei moved to the chair next to her father and turned to him.

"Zi, listen to me. We need to forget about this Keefer thing—and the Howitzers. Something bad is going to happen to us. Yeye suffered, but we could too if we're exposed. Harry suspects something."

"How?" Zi shouted. "Wei? Answer me." *Wei's relationship with Howitzer had to end. She appeared rattled, not herself.* "Do not see him again, do you hear me?"

"No problem there, Zi." Wei turned to her brother, who shook his head and gave her a sly glance.

Zi never understood the twins' communication with each other—unspoken and fiercely protective of each other. "Dashi, do you have something to add?"

"No, Baba."

"Good. Now, then, let's carry on."

"Boss, listen to my idea. There is a group in Russia. Hackers. We could extort Howitzer. Ransomware." Serge nodded.

"What are you talking about, Serge?"

"These guys could hack Sceptre's computer system and encrypt their files. The ransom would be the financing. If they don't agree, we threaten to go public with all their classified information. It's a better idea than the newspaper. Cleaner."

"Too little, too late. Serge, why now?" Zi asked.

"It took me some time to find this group. They're underground. And not all of them can be trusted. Late this afternoon, they got back to me." He clasped his hands, fidgeting with his thumbs. "I didn't want to tell you about ~~this idea~~ in case I couldn't reach them."

The room silenced, everyone glaring at Zi.

"I want this over. Tonight. My idea will work. No one will want to be associated with that family after their criminal history is exposed. The stock will plunge. I'll buy all the cheap stock, the financing won't close, and the Lius will become the ~~major~~ owners of Sceptre. Howitzer will be broke and broken in no time."

"Baba, you're making too many assumptions. Howitzer won't put up with it. And with those Atlin results, everyone will be buying cheap stock. Sceptre won't be yours. It will be a free-for-all. He'll call the TSX surveillance about the ad and tell them it is a plant from us." Dashi threw back his head. "This is so wrong."

"Dashi is correct. Pigs at a trough. Very risky, Mr. Zi. My suggestion is safer," Serge said. "Right now, this is the best solution."

Dashi got to his feet and moved around the stateroom, tugging at his long hair, his face tense. "Serge, can we kill off Howitzer?" Dashi asked. "Your crowd can pull that off."

"No, Dashi. Stop. Let's walk away quietly." Wei gave her brother a dirty look. "No drama, no killing." She was almost pleading. "Harry's going to go to the authorities if we don't leave him alone."

"He's not going to tell anyone about us, Wei, because he doesn't know about our business with the Russians," Zi said. "And with my accusations, he'll have to prove me wrong. And I'm not."

The room was quiet again. Zi had made himself clear.

"Baba, I think you're playing with fire. Don't jeopardize our safety because of your grudge. It's reckless."

Reckless. Again, Dashi doesn't understand.

"No, we are out of time. This cat-and-mouse nonsense must end. The ad will be published ~~on~~ Monday morning. If Howitzer ~~were~~ a smart man, he ~~would~~ change his mind tonight. Serge can cancel the ad, and ~~we will~~ have the financing in our hands." Zi placed his untouched Scotch on the table. "End of discussion. I'm done here."

The steward handed him his black Moncler ski jacket. "I'm going for my cigar in the park and then dinner with Sandy. Don't be here when I return. I plan on having an overnight guest." He found his phone and turned it on, waiting for Sandy to call.

Wei stood up and grabbed his shoulders. "Listen to me. Don't."

"Enough," he shouted. "Goodbye."

He made his way down the gangplank and lit the cigar he'd kept in his parka pocket. The sweet aroma filled the brisk air. He loved his cigars. He turned, taking a moment to admire *Sunspot. Yes, bought and paid for by Zi Liu*.

The thick, fluffy snowflakes danced through the dark skies. It was the second time Zi had seen snow in Vancouver. It was beautiful, invigorating. He liked this city and planned to live ~~there~~ for a long time. Maybe forever.

He made his way out of the marina, along the seawall and up the stairs into his favourite park. It was small, triangular-shaped, and private but well-lit. The fir trees and spindly cedars

competed with two exotic blue spruces, their long needles catching the snow. It was a beautiful oasis.

It was time to sit down and relax. He brushed away the snow on the bench and made himself comfortable, contemplating Serge's idea. ~~Yes,~~ extortion was a better ~~one~~ than his. To publish the ad was risky. The authorities could trace it back to him and the twins, and they could connect the Lius with the drug operations.

He pulled out his cell to call Serge.

"Hey, old man. Over here," the voice said.

The last thing Zi needed was to get mugged. He slipped his cellphone back in his pocket and threw the cigar on the ground, scanning the park for his quickest exit. Not far from the bench, he spotted a clearing on Hastings Street between the thick evergreens. He would head that way—and he better move~~,~~ now.

"I said stop," a twangy voice called out.

A strong hand gripped his jacket collar from behind and slammed him to the ground. "Take my Rolex. I've got lots of cash," Zi said. He could taste the blood running down from his nose.

The attacker remained silent. Zi took a deep breath and, with all his strength, flipped over on his right, saw the attacker, and booted his knee. Zi scrambled to a semi-crouched position, focused on the mugger.

What? The man was pointing a pistol at him.

"What do you want? I'll give it to you," Zi shouted. "Hold on, you're Howitzer's guy. What are you doing? I'll give you all the money you need. More than Howitzer has."

"Nope, don't want your money. A message, partner. You leave the Howitzers alone, or you die. Do you understand?"

Zi was silent, sizing him up, and in that moment, his mind changed about the ad. "No way."

"I'm telling you, Zi Liu. Your identity is not a secret. All of you are gangsters, not as advertised. Stop this witch hunt. Listen to me, I will shoot you if I have to."

"No deal," Zi said, noticing the man's attention ~~for a moment~~ had become distracted by something or someone behind Zi.

"Harry, get out of here," Cooperhawk said in a low, firm voice.

Zi gingerly stepped to his left and saw Howitzer standing stoically, arms crossed. The three men were at a standoff.

"Liu, listen to Cooperhawk," Howitzer said calmly. "Cancel the ad. Get out of town, or you and your daughter will spend the rest of your life in jail."

"Howitzer, what kind of man are you?" Zi spat out the blood from his mouth. "You have to hire someone to do your dirty work? Coward." He flashed his hand. "See my ring? This is Liu gold, not Howitzer gold. Sceptre is coming back to ~~the~~ rightful owners. Your family ~~are~~ scum. The world will know very soon."

Zi realized two against one was never good odds. But Cooperhawk wouldn't take the risk of shooting him in the middle of a downtown city park. *No way*.

He would make a run for it.

"Go to hell, Howitzer."

But without warning, Howitzer charged at him, gripping a long-bladed knife. The downward-glaring park light revealed a man who had gone mad, his haggard face marked with deep creases, his eyes bulging.

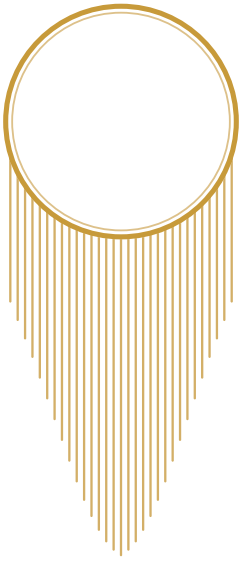
Startled, Zi slipped on the slushy snow as he tried to avoid the attacker. He fell hard to the ground. The blade came toward him fast and pierced through his heart. The shocking pain ran through his body.

Paralyzed, he could hear Howitzer mumbling—a truly hellish sound. Zi tried to shout out his wish for him to rot in hell. But his efforts were powerless. He shut his eyes.

A sense of warmth and relief filled his body, and Zi rose above his soulless corpse. Life, as he knew it, was over.

The Liu honour would not be salvaged.

What a stupid man ~~he'd become because of his~~ hate for Harry Howitzer. Zi would be remembered by his twins as a bitter old man. His decades of commitment and sacrifice as a good husband, father, and businessman were for nothing because his money could no longer protect him.



CHAPTER 38

"Didn't think you had that in you." Cooperhawk knelt to inspect the bloody body next to Harry.

"What?" On his knees, Harry fixated on Liu, checked for any signs of life. Nothing. Liu was dead. Harry dry heaved.

"Walk it off, partner," Cooperhawk said, motioning him away from the victim. "Get up. I'll deal with this."

Harry got back on his feet, took a couple steps back, squeezed the knife, and sucked in the cold air and gasped. His lungs tightened; his consciousness froze. A quiet, throaty voice called out his name.

"Brother." Pookmis moved closer. "Gold Man, you did it."

A glowing figure stood feet away from Harry. The apparition appeared stoic, more human-like than any other encounter. His eyes, still pupilless, didn't swirl, but were laser-focused, locked on to Harry's.

"Look at you. Broken. Just like me." The powerful spirit slinked away from the crime scene, drawn to the marina, stopped, and turned. "I told you I liked that blade."

"Cooperhawk, deal with this. The dead body." The scar on Harry's forehead throbbed with pain. "I need to get out of here now."

"I learn something every time I work for one of you rich guys. Whatever it takes, right?" Cooperhawk asked sarcastically. "We're all crooks in one shape or form." He slapped Harry's back with his gloved hand.

"I don't want to talk about it," Harry retorted. He tucked the knife into the back of his belt and pulled his shirt out. *No one ~~could~~ ever find the murder weapon*.

"Harry, Liu wasn't armed. What were you thinking?"

"He didn't need ~~one~~. His threats and insults were enough. I lost it, okay? End of story." Harry was unable to justify his merciless behaviour. "Mac and I can now get on with our lives. No more Lius. We were at risk of losing everything. And I mean everything."

"Hold on." Cooperhawk turned his attention to a nearby cluster of trees. He grabbed Harry's arm and pulled him behind a cedar bush, motioning him to be quiet. The boughs of a shrub shook. "Someone's over there."

"What's happening?" Harry whispered, crouching.

"I'm going to find out." Cooperhawk rushed toward the bushes. "Show yourself," he called out. A grey squirrel bolted out of the clumps of evergreens and scampered across the park. He laughed and wagged his finger at Harry. "Nothing is ever what it seems."

"I told you. Get rid of the body." *All Harry wanted to do was leave*. "I've got your money."

"Good. See you tomorrow at noon. I'll deal with all of this. Easy stuff." Cooperhawk instructed Harry on how to exit the park via the dark side. The snow had turned to slush, ensuring no footprints at the crime scene. "Now git."

Harry tightened his coat hood over his toque. He hustled for the following three blocks. The goal was to get to his SUV without being recognized. Before he got to his vehicle, he turned into an alley. An overfed rat jumped out of nowhere and crossed his path. That thing didn't even jolt him. He tossed his jacket, gloves, and toque into a blue garbage bin.

Harry ran to his vehicle. Out of breath and shivering, he collapsed in his seat and fired up the engine. As he turned onto the lit street, he caught a glimpse of himself in the driver's window. *Gaunt and white. Ghastly.* ~~*He even looked*~~ *like a killer*.

The usually short drive took longer than expected. Harry knew he was driving too fast on summer tires. At a red light, a police car pulled up next to him. The female cop turned and checked him out. *Would she notice he wasn't wearing a coat on a snow day and assume he was up to no good?* His mind was in no shape to give a good explanation of why he had a bloody dagger in his possession.

He gave her a quick wave and kept his eyes straight ahead. He didn't blink. It was the longest traffic light of his life. His hands vibrated on the steering wheel. The light turned green, the cop turned, and he drove home at the speed limit.

The garage door slammed shut.

In the Tudor, Harry threw off his boots and tossed them down the basement steps. The adrenaline raced through his body. With the murder weapon in his hand, he fell into Wallace's wingback chair in the library. His hand began to twitch, the one that held the knife, as he stared at the blade.

"This thing is the omen." He opened the safe and placed the dagger on the top shelf. No one would ever find it. Even Mac didn't know the strongbox existed.

Harry drew the fireplace screen. Three small chunks of charred wood from the mask were piled on the grate. He furiously tried to burn them. Match after match, the wood sparked but would not catch fire.

Koyah was right: the omen had struck him and his mind. He desperately wanted to talk to the Shaman.

He climbed the stairs, sweat dripping down his face as he reached the third floor, searching for the ghost.

"Show yourself," he shouted and investigated the floors. Harry was ready for a battle, but Pookmis didn't appear ready for the fight. The art was hung perfectly, and not a feather littered the Tudor floors.

The doorbell rang. Did that cop follow him home? He had to answer it. It rang again. He had to have left the gate open.

What would he say? He'd deny, deny, deny. He opened the door. *Thank God.*

"Yvonne."

"Harry, this head cold is getting the best of me. Better for you to have Osler."

"No problem. Come on, guy." He noticed Yvonne's chafed, red nose. Her oversized wool coat covered her long white housecoat.

Her big, swollen eyes focused on Harry. "Are you sick, Harry?"

"Yes, I am. Goodbye, Yvonne."

He shut the heavy door. Harry locked it using both bolts. He turned on the alarm. Usually, Osler barked and raced around the foyer, showing his detest for Pookmis. The Westie pitter-pattered into the kitchen and had a big gulp of water from his bowl.

It was about eight o'clock. A small batch would deaden his troubles. He turned out the lights and grabbed a bottle. "Come on, Osler, bedtime."

Harry flopped onto the bed, remembering his life before. Since the salmon incident, he'd been living a nightmare. *April. He wanted to talk to her and share his guilt, but he couldn't. She would disown him if she knew what he'd done. He'd have to give himself time to prepare to hide the truth from her—forever. How would he manage that? She knew him better than anyone. But he couldn't lose April.*

He stripped down to his boxers and crawled into bed. The Westie hopped up and snuggled close to him.

"Osler, this is our secret." Harry's hand shook, like he had a tremor. He opened the bottle and knocked back the liquor.

Sweat trickled down his achy back. “Pookmis got to me, Osler. News flash. I killed Zi Liu.”

He tugged at his unruly hair. “I lost my mind. Pookmis’s poisonous rant, Liu waving the gold ring in my face. ~~I wanted Easton’s knife to *just*~~ threaten Liu. And the next thing I remember was the blood, the gasping~~, and~~ Liu’s struggle to live.”

He shut his eyes. The chilling encounter with Pookmis in the longhouse resurfaced. The spirit’s promise was to ruin the lives of Howitzers. It was cold and calculated manipulation.

Harry had taken his bait.

“Osler, Pookmis is a bastard.”

After rehashing Harry’s shattered life, the two buddies passed out.



The buzz from Harry’s cellphone startled him from his deep sleep. He sat up, his heart beating fast. The lights were still on in his room. “Cooperhawk? It’s after midnight.”

“Outside, partner.”

“I thought you were coming tomorrow at noon. Be right there.” Harry threw on a pair of sweatpants and a shirt he’d pulled out from his laundry. His knees cracked, and his head

thumped as he plunked down the stairs. Osler followed close to his heels, waiting for Harry to hurry up. He turned off the alarm and flipped the locks. The door moaned when he opened it.

Cooperhawk appeared like a hitman. Water clung to the hem of his jeans, accentuating his spindly calves. The mismatched hiking boots were covered in thick brown mud. Even his usual perfectly coiffed hair was on end.

"What the hell happened?" Harry asked.

"No issues, Harry." Cooperhawk patted Harry's shoulder and let himself in. "I'll wait inside the hallway here. I don't want to track in a mess."

"Why are you here ~~now~~?" *The PI's arrival was disturbing. Something had to have gone wrong.* "Where's the body?"

"You don't need to know." Cooperhawk dug into his pocket. "This nugget ring. You want it?"

"Yes, I'll put it with the knife. I can't have evidence." It didn't take a brain surgeon to figure out Liu was dumped in some kind of muddy waters. "What if there's a witness? For you or me?"

"Harry, it's not a clean deal. You screwed up my plan. But you should be okay."

"Should? Cooperhawk, come on. That's why I hired you." Harry threw up his hands. "You're supposed to be a pro."

"You hired me to get Liu, not cover up murder. But worrying about it will drive you crazy. Move on. We'll deal with it if we need to. At that time."

"What about Serge? The ad?" Cooperhawk acted as if Harry had been ticketed for speeding. "Come on, there are still problems with this Liu situation. I don't think it's over."

"Settle, Harry. He's a gangster, he's going to lay low. That ad idea of Liu's was stupid. ~~Those Liu~~ twins and the Russians are drug dealers ~~and~~ don't want attention. No ad. That I can guarantee. I've got to get going. Need final payment." Cooperhawk checked himself out in the large foyer mirror, his face skewed. "I need to clean up and get some sleep. Got an assignment with another family in town. You'd know them. I've got to find a missing son who cleaned out the grandfather's bank accounts. Talking big cash. He's probably in Ibiza. The guy is such a jackass. Call me if you need me. Let's hope you don't."

"A grandson did that? Terrible," Harry said. *Who am I to comment on anything?* "I'll get your envelope."

In the library, Harry unlocked the safe dial, placed the ring next to the knife, and got the final payment.

The bookcase slid back into its slot. He handed Cooperhawk the booty. "All there—both payments."

"You showered?" Cooperhawk scratched his nose and scowled.

"Not tonight."

"Pretty ripe, cowboy. Not guilty about killing Liu, are you?" Cooperhawk cleared his throat. "Taking someone's life is a big thing."

"I told you. I didn't plan it. It wasn't me. You know, an out-of-body experience. That's what happened."

"Is that right? In my forty years of doing this, that excuse is new to me. Whatever you say, but there's something wrong with you." Cooperhawk removed his glasses. The hired gun's left eye was a piece of baby-blue-tinted glass. It was placed deep

in his scarred socket. A thick web of criss-crossed skin replaced his natural hood. “See this?”

“I do.”

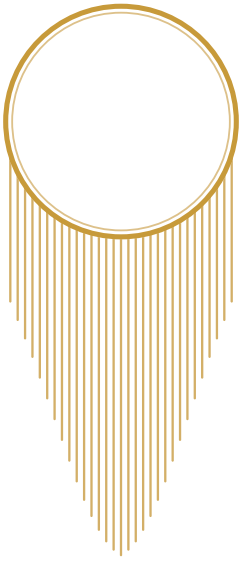
“Got this when I was a crazy asshole. And you, partner, you’re a changed man since we met.” The black frames were adjusted back on his long, sharp nose, masking the man’s secret. “Go to rehab, your doc, whatever you need to do.” He patted Harry’s shoulder. “If you’ve got a problem, fix it before it fixes you because your excuse for killing is frankly . . . sick.”

“I’ll figure it out.” Their final handshake lingered, giving Harry a sense that there was unfinished business. “I have to.”

“You’d better get that scar on your forehead checked. It’s turned black—butt ugly nasty.” Cooperhawk gave Osler a scratch, and as he turned the heavy brass front doorknob, he said, “Goodbye, Harry. I wish you well.”

~~*That remark was*~~ *ominous.* Like Cooperhawk, Harry checked himself out in the hallway mirror. The scar had blackened around the edges, like rot.

Just like Harry Howitzer.



CHAPTER 39

SATURDAY

Early the next morning, Harry made himself a double espresso and carried it to the top floor bedroom. He settled into the antique rocker beside the panelled window and wrapped himself in an old wool Hudson's Bay blanket. Outside, the heavy clouds hung low on the snowy North Shore Mountains. The wintery scene dragged him back to his flight from the Stewart airport, to the crash and the Pookmis confrontation. The spirit's vengeance and relentless power had destroyed everything that once was Harry Howitzer.

He rubbed his eyes.

Last night, he had stabbed Zi Liu like a man possessed. Like Wallace and Easton, he would spend the rest of his life as an imposter, and he hoped like hell ~~that~~ secret was buried—forever.

His phone buzzed. He checked the screen. *That ~~was~~ odd.*

"Hey, Margaret, how are you?"

"Don't give me that nice talk, you knew what was going on with Rock, didn't you?"

"Sorry, Margaret, I'm missing something. Are you okay?"

"Are you kidding me? I kicked Rock out of the house this morning. I'm freezing his assets, and he's going to pay for what he did to me. That cheating scumbag. I'm not letting him sell one share of Sceptre or use one dollar for an investment I don't approve. I own half. No financing deal with Sceptre. Do you understand?" Her voice broke. "I've given my entire life to that man."

"Margaret?" She hung up. It took a moment for Harry to register the conversation. The result of Cooperhawk's work. Rock ~~had been~~ having an affair, and ~~he had gotten~~ busted. ~~And~~ Margaret was riled up. Rock's offer and threats to Sceptre were not going to happen. *Impressive job, Cooperhawk.*

It would be the right time for the board to replace him as the chairman. "Adios, Rock."

He sipped his coffee and relived the drama at the park. He dialed Cooperhawk.

"What's up, partner?"

"Problem solved with Rock. Thanks for that."

"Welcome."

"Cooperhawk, tell me where the body is."

"Nope. Shake it off and move on, Harry." He hung up.

Harry wasn't sure if that was the reassurance he needed. He called out for Osler, who seemed to be ignoring him, threw off his blanket, and headed downstairs. He swung by the living room and had a small sip of Pappy's. That sweet liquor always took the edge off any angst.

His phone rang. *What now*? He needed some peace and quiet to try and get his act together. "Hey, Trudy."

"Harry, I'm outside. Let me in. I need to see you."

"Give me a minute." Harry checked out the living room window. Trudy's black sports car was parked on the street.

"Come on in." She arrived at the door wearing a pair of baggy, checked pyjama pants, a well-worn lumber jacket, and rubber boots. Her black mascara had dripped down her cheeks.

"Why were you crying? What's happening?"

"Harry, I screwed up. Big time."

"Let's sit down." Harry took her hand and brought her to the living room sofa. "What's going on?"

"Worst day of my life." Trudy dropped her head. "Where do I start?"

"It can't be that bad." Harry's mouth was parched. He didn't have the patience for the guessing game. "Tell me, will you?"

"Harry, don't be like that. I'm having a crisis here." She let out a breath. "I've been having an affair with Rock for years." Her brown eyes locked with Harry's. "I'm so embarrassed."

"You're kidding me?"

How gross.

"A woman phoned Margaret yesterday and told her the whole history of our affair. She shared invoices from our trips to Europe, the cruises, and the safari, as well as my iPhone photos. Margaret called me and exploded." Trudy rubbed her face. "Why now? Who was this woman?"

Harry knew the answer—Viper Byte. And she had done a bang-up job. "It's a small world."

"We were so discreet," she said, wiping the black makeup off her hand and onto her pants. "This is brutal."

"I'm so sorry." He had never considered that his actions would hurt someone he cared about so much. "What can I do?"

"Nothing." She leaned forward, elbows on knees. "That's it. I'm out of here. I'm moving to Europe. Shutting down the café."

"This will blow over, don't worry about it. You're not the first person to have an affair in this town."

"I need a new scene." She refocused on Harry. "What the hell is going on with you? God, you smell like a goat. A boozy goat."

"I don't."

"You do." She pinched her nose and waved her hand in front of her face. "When Margaret called me, she said she had kicked Rock out of the house. Now, he won't even answer my calls."

It was the first time Harry understood Trudy for who she was. She was always full of advice and opinions on how he should live his life, while hers was far from perfect. *A disaster.*

"Write him off. Rock was married, you weren't."

"You know my dad gave me all this money and look at the stupid choices I've made and the wasted years I can never get

back. Years, Harry. Time for me to get a life." She leaned on Harry. "At least I have you. You're such a good friend."

Her face crumpled as he hugged her to his chest. "Harry, will you clean yourself up? You're more of a hot mess than I am." Her phone rang. "Oh, it's Margaret again. She's insane. I'm not answering."

"Block her number." *Trudy needed to settle down.* "Don't make any rash decisions."

"What the hell was I thinking?" She pushed herself off the sofa. "I'll call you later." She headed for the door and left.

The confident woman Harry had secretly loved for years. ~~He had~~ always wondered if they could be a couple. That question was just answered. No. But Rock Weston? He disliked the jerk even more.

It was ten o'clock in the morning. One more taste of Pappy's and back to bed. Harry made his way slowly up the stairs, searching for any sign of Pookmis. *That sicko will be back.* Osler was stretched out on the bedspread. Harry crawled under his sheets, closed his eyes, and shut out the world.



A thunderous bang resonated from the kitchen.

It awoke Harry from his slumber. He jumped out of bed, heart racing, and ran down the staircase. "I knew you'd come back, you bastard," he shouted. "Show yourself." Mac turned the corner and stopped, staring at his father.

"Wow, Dad. What's going on with you?" His eyes were wide, and his face was twisted in disgust as he stared at Harry's disfigured scar.

"Mac, I didn't know it was you. I thought it was—forget it." Harry tied up the waist of his sweatpants and scratched the hair on the back of his hot neck.

Harry couldn't believe he'd slept most of the day; it was already four in the afternoon. His son stared. He looked away.

"Nasty, dude." Mac's nose wiggled. "You stink like booze. What's with the bender?"

"Mac, I've had a time lately. We need to talk." He went to the kitchen sink and drank a couple of large glasses of water. That's it for him and the bourbon. "I need some air. Let's go to the backyard."

Mac fetched Harry his warm coat. They sat down in the soft patio chairs under the covered porch.

Like Harry, the weather had changed. The dreary spitting rain set the stage for Harry's confession.

"Dad, look." Mac fussed in his jean pocket and pulled out an emerald necklace.

"Why do you have that?" The piece was his mother's, an heirloom and a gift to Martha on their wedding day. Typical Martha, she wouldn't give it back when they'd divorced.

"The police stopped by my house this morning."

"What? Why?" Harry asked. *Did someone see him in the park last night*?

"The port police found the necklace at the container yard in the inner harbour."

"Mac? What are you talking about? Where's your mother?"

"The police showed me the security video. Masked guys in a black van, no visible license plate, drove up to an open container, threw Mom in, and locked it up. They took off."

The story was so bizarre that it didn't make sense. "You're kidding? Did they find the container?"

"No. Saudi Arabia-bound. It's gone to sea. Dad, Mom's dead."

Harry didn't see any emotion from his son. Stone-faced. "I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry. I'm not. I don't want to talk about Mom anymore. She pissed ~~off someone.~~ ~~Whatever.~~ You reap what you sow." Mac threw his head back and let out an exhausted huff. He set the necklace down on the patio table. "I don't want this. Now, can you tell me what's going on with you? I need to know."

Harry gathered his words and started to speak.

"The real story of the Howitzers is nothing to be proud of." For the next half an hour, Harry ~~explained~~ the young Chinese geologist Sying Liu and how Easton had scooped his claim after he'd murdered him. "I found out the truth about Easton and Sceptre after Wallace died. Your grandfather shared the details in a letter addressed to me."

"Why would Granddad not tell anyone until he was dead?" He rolled his eyes. "Obviously."

"Yes, the Stewart motherlode was the prize. There was no way Wallace would let it go. He wanted to make a fortune and he did . . . We all did." Harry watched his son processing the ugly story. He wouldn't share the truth about who the real prospector was on the Atlin discovery. "Somehow, Zi Liu got wind of the whole story and decided he wanted Sceptre back. But the situation got a lot stranger. That's when I hired Cooperhawk."

"How did you find him?" Mac asked.

"That's another story for later, not important. It turns out Liu and that Serge ~~were~~ part of a gang—fentanyl dealers in Vancouver. Liu was a pharmacist who imported the chemicals from China. And Serge worked with a Russian gang that distributed. The sales of the drugs ~~had~~ funded Keefer Gold. Cooperhawk discovered all this intel."

"Gangsters?"

"You heard I ordered Cooperhawk to shake Liu up. The shakeup turned into something we ~~hadn't planned~~ for. Cooperhawk described it as an event. I don't know any more of the details, and we don't want to know, but Liu is dead. Cooperhawk, being the pro, made the whole incident go away. Body disposed of. That's it. It's a crazy ending. And nothing to be proud of."

"Cooperhawk killed him?"

"He didn't."

"And you don't know how he died?"

Guilt gnawed at Harry. Other than Cooperhawk, only Osler would ever know the truth of Liu's death. "I'm confident

Liu's revenge tactics with Sceptre are over. It was his personal vendetta. And the Russians will disappear." *And the Cinnamon exposure ~~would~~ never be shared. She ~~was~~ history too*. "We are back to business."

Mac glared at his father. "That's an insane story, Dad. I get why you've been acting so bizarre."

"If I went to the authorities about all of this . . . you understand." Harry turned to his son. "Mac, this whole thing has been a living hell."

"If the truth about Easton becomes public, we'd be a joke. Atlin would never happen under our watch." Mac rubbed his hands back and forth on his thighs. "What if someone finds out you hired Cooperhawk?"

"We have no paper trail with him. He's invisible to the real world." Harry hoped he'd managed to dance around the truth. "Our family are not the high moral characters you were led to believe."

"Dad, I've heard a lot of bad rumours about us, but I needed to know the truth." Mac stared across the yard for another moment. "I needed to know. And this secret is buried forever."

"Has to be. There should be a fresh start for you and me. Let's sell Wallace's art collection. Purge the Howitzer history. Donate the proceeds to the Stewart community and the local Indigenous Nation. With the mine in decline, our employees will eventually need a new way to provide for their families. I want to recognize their efforts." Harry didn't want this new Howitzer chapter to be some token gesture.

Harry was waiting for a response from Mac.

"Do you not agree? It's a start, and we have a hell of a lot more to do—redemption." Harry vowed he would see it through, all of it. There was a lot to make up for.

Mac fidgeted with his thumbs. "Sell all of it. That legacy is over. That's a better use for that money. Granddad would be pissed. I don't care."

"What's the matter? This is a lot to take in, but I hope we are past the worst of it." *Assuming the discovery of a body didn't bury his and his son's future, but he could only hope for the best.* "Mac, tell me."

"This is weird." Mac dug in his coat pocket and pulled out a long eagle feather. "Do you believe in ghosts?" A gust of frigid air swept through the porch.

"I do." Harry fumbled as he got out of his chair. "Get rid of it." He grabbed the feather and tossed it. As he watched the breeze whisk the plume away, his eyes were drawn to the leafless giant oak tree towering in the middle of the gardens. Pookmis, nestled in the top branches, peered down on them, spying.

Harry would give his life and the Howitzer reputation to keep Mac from Pookmis's omen. "Mac, there is one more thing you need to know." He cleared his throat. "Wallace kept another secret. He had a son years ago. Benji." Out of the corner of his eye, he noticed the ghost drop down and hover by the wide tree trunk. "He's blood."

"I know about him. Granddad mumbled his name to me when we were waiting for the ambulance."

Harry, to his shock, realized that the fourth generation of the Howitzers kept secrets, too. "And?"

"I didn't understand what he was talking about. When I was cleaning out the map room over Christmas, I found one of his field journals in a file cabinet. Year by year, he documented his thoughts about Benji since he was born. It wasn't cool. All anger."

~~"That's shocking."~~ *Wallace was a miserable, irresponsible man*. "That generation kept things private."

"That generation was arrogant. I'm so embarrassed by his behaviour. Granddad neglected his own son. And then Benji died in a fishing accident last September. What a tough life that guy lived. You know, I thought Granddad was a good guy."

Before Harry could comment on his son's revelations, Mac continued, "Dad, Benji was a Howitzer."

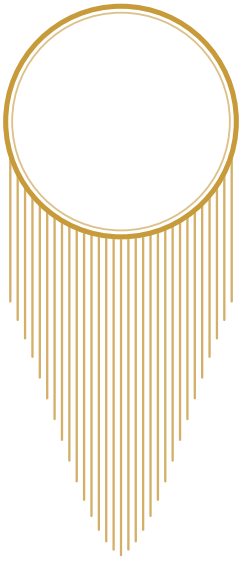
With Pookmis in earshot, Harry remembered his and Koyah's discussion; this was his chance to make amends with the spirit. Wallace was dead. And so was his reputation as a father and businessman.

"Yes, Benji is our family, and we will recognize him, even if he has passed. He and his mom deserve the respect Wallace didn't give them."

An uncanny cry echoed through the garden.

The spirit slowly drifted away from the oak tree across the dead grass and disappeared into the towering laurel hedge.

Not a single leaf stirred.



EPILOGUE

THREE MONTHS LATER

The black Escalade pulled up to the majestic Tudor. Wei turned off the engine and stared longingly down the driveway. It was Sunday afternoon. The blooming crimson azaleas filled the flower beds, and the magnolia trees were bursting with oversized white blooms.

She rested her hand on her round stomach.

The fentanyl business had shut down. Serge ~~had~~ moved home to Moscow.

Keefer was delisted.

Zi's body had been found two weeks ago, twenty miles from the marina.

Her phone rang. "Hey, Dashi." She held back her tears.

"Are you going to tell him?"

"I don't know. See you at the house later."

Wei inhaled a determined breath and climbed out of the vehicle. The living room was dimly lit. Harry was home. She remembered the gate code: 1939.

What ~~would she say~~ to Harry? Her guilt ran deep. The Lius had tried to destroy his family and his business. *How could he ever forgive her deplorable actions*?

She was halfway down the driveway when Osler started barking.

Then Harry opened the front door. Wei froze. There he was. Black T-shirt. Black jeans. The same tan house shoes. His hair was longer, but slicked back. Handsome as ever.

He stared at her without emotion.

"Oh, Harry. I'm sorry," she called out, voice cracking. She waited, but he said nothing.

She understood. She wasn't welcome.

But he was the father of her child.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Thank you:

Ammi Keller, for the coaching, endless patience, and belief in the story.

Beta readers and "special advisors" Angela, Ashley, Grant, Jack, John, Lyn, Rick, Shayne, Shelley, and Tim, for your time to read working drafts and for providing exceptional feedback and suggestions.

I acknowledge that I live in the homelands of the Coast Salish peoples, including the Musqueam, Squamish, and Tsleil-Waututh, the stewards of these lands and waters.

And I have had the honour of visiting Princess Royal Island, the spiritual sanctuary of the Tsimshian Peoples, including the Gitga'at Nation, and the Spirit Bear.

I recognize and have gratitude for all Nations' contributions to our local communities, and I am committed to honouring, listening to, and learning from all Indigenous Peoples.